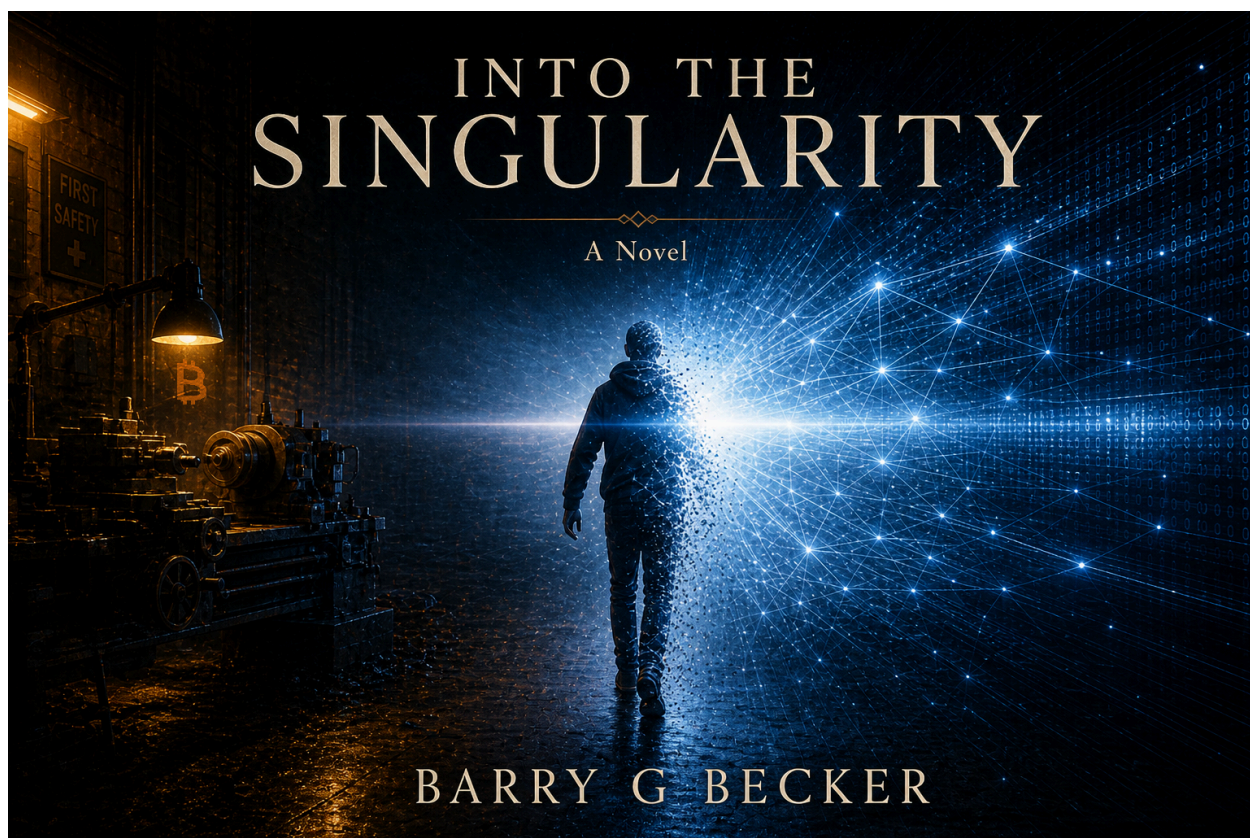




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FROZEN FOR REVIEW

Into the Singularity

Barry G Becker

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I fear none of the existing machines; what I fear is the extraordinary rapidity with which they are becoming something very different to what they are at present.

Samuel Butler, *Erewhon*, 1872
"The Book of the Machines"

Chapter 1: The Double Blow

The call came at 6:48 a.m. on a Tuesday, while Daniel was explaining in a work chat why the overnight software update had failed at 2 a.m. and taken half the warehouse system down with it. He'd been up since five. He was good at this part of the job. Tracing a failure through six linked programs until you found the one bad assumption everything else had trusted.

He had the incident document open in one window and the chat filling up in another. When Mara's name lit up on an incoming call he almost let it go to voicemail. Mara calling before seven on a weekday was never about anything good.

He answered anyway.

"It's Dad," Mara said, and then didn't say anything else for a second. The silence was so unlike her that he knew before she got the rest of the sentence out.

He asked *when*, though what he wanted was *how*. She answered him anyway, flat. Sometime before six that morning. On the shop floor, by the mill he still ran himself. Ray Delgado found him when he came in to open up. The paramedics had come, and there had been nothing for them to do.

She'd booked a flight into Columbus for Thursday and wanted to know if he could get something that landed around the same time.

"Yeah. Text me the flight."

"You okay?"

"I don't know yet."

He put the phone down and looked at the incident document. The cursor blinked where he'd been about to write that two programs had acted at once, the immediate damage was contained, and a full review would follow. The words meant nothing now. He closed the laptop.

* * *

His father's name was Warren, and he had run Kessler Machine out of the same building on Route 9 in Millbrook, Ohio for thirty-one years.

His parents had split up when he was eighteen, quietly. His mother, Joan, had moved to Cincinnati not long after. Daniel called her more than he called his father, and that had never felt like a decision. He'd just noticed, one day, that it was already true.

His father had gone back to school once, decades before any of that. A graduate program in cryptography, the math of keeping secrets. He'd dropped out in his late twenties to come home and keep Kessler Machine running for his own father.

Bitcoin had gotten under his skin around 2013. It was money that lived on computers, with no bank in the middle. He'd found it on cryptography newsgroups left over from the graduate program he'd walked away from, when it was still thirty dollars or so a coin. Most men who bought in that year forgot about it or panic-sold within eighteen months. Warren hadn't. Daniel suspected he'd understood what he was looking at because of that unfinished training.

He got quieter about it as the years went on. Longer hours at the shop, evenings on a laptop in the back office. Warren didn't explain himself. He'd just, every so often, hand Daniel an envelope at Christmas with a printed sheet of numbers in it and say *don't do anything with this, just hold it*.

Daniel had held it. He'd never asked what it added up to.

The last time he'd stood on that shop floor was fourteen months ago. His father had wanted to show him a boring-and-facing machine he'd bought used, a tool for finishing metal after it was cut. He was proud of the price the way another man might be proud of a car. Daniel had nodded in the right places and asked one real question, and his father's face had opened while he answered. Then it closed again when Daniel's phone buzzed with a work message he checked without thinking.

He'd flown home telling himself there'd be a longer visit at Christmas. There hadn't been. Christmas had turned into a phone call and a padded envelope.

He called his manager at Meridian to say he'd be out the rest of the week. Nadia told him to take whatever he needed. He noticed she said *whatever you need* and not *however long you need*.

The funeral was set for Saturday. He spent Wednesday night making lists he didn't need, because lists gave his hands something to do.

Around midnight he thought about who else to call and came up mostly empty. There was Elena, except that meant reopening something he'd spent two years carefully not reopening. There was Wei, if the time difference and Wei's increasingly strange radio silence hadn't made the last two calls feel like talking into an empty line.

Thursday afternoon, sitting in the rental car in the airport garage with the AC running, his phone buzzed with a calendar invite: *Team Update - Required*. Ten a.m. his time Friday. No agenda. A name from HR he didn't recognize was on it.

He knew what it was. The blank agenda was the tell.

He'd watched it happen to three people on an adjacent team in the spring. Sanjay, who'd been there four years longer than Daniel. A contractor named Beth who found out over email. He'd told himself his team was different, that his numbers were good, that Meridian's routing models needed a human in the loop for the messy exception cases.

The drive from the airport took an hour and forty minutes. Somewhere past the county line the fields gave way to a downtown built for three times its current population. A shuttered movie theater. A hardware store. A diner Daniel recognized without wanting to.

He drove past Kessler Machine without meaning to slow down, and did anyway. The lot was empty except for Ray's truck. After something like that, a building should look different. This one just looked closed.

Friday morning he sat in his father's kitchen in Millbrook, one full day away from walking into a room with his father's casket in it.

There were three people on the call. Nadia, silent, camera off. The HR woman, Talia Brandt. And a slide titled *Q3 Organizational Efficiency Update*.

She used the phrase twice. *Efficiency gains*. Once early, framing. And once at the end, softer: "We want you to know this decision reflects efficiency gains at the org level, not anything about your individual performance."

Somewhere upstream of Talia Brandt, a dashboard had flagged his role: senior, expensive, redundant against a model that had gotten quietly better at the exception cases over the last two quarters.

"Do you have any questions?"

"No. I think I understand."

Eight weeks of pay after today. He did the math: Austin rent, the lease he'd just signed, health insurance. He had savings. He had, technically, whatever his father's Christmas envelopes had turned into over the years, unopened, unspent.

He closed the laptop. For a second the two mornings sat on top of each other, and he had to put both hands flat on the table to remember which one he was in.

He stood. The chair went over behind him. For one clear second he wanted to put his fist through the kitchen wall. The same impulse he'd watched land in the spring, when someone on Sanjay's team had put a monitor through a cubicle partition the morning the cuts hit and nobody had written it up. Daniel's hands found the table edge instead. The impulse passed. What was left was the scrape of the chair and a kitchen that still smelled like his father's coffee.

* * *

Mara found him twenty minutes later still sitting there with one of their mother's old mugs between his hands.

"You look like you got hit by a truck."

"Lost my job this morning."

She stopped scrolling. "This morning morning?"

"Ten a.m. call. 'Efficiency gains.'"

Mara set the phone face-down on the table, and for once didn't lead with a plan or a number. She just pulled out the chair across from him and sat, and for a while neither of them said anything.

"Tomorrow's going to be bad."

"Today wasn't great either."

"No. It really wasn't."

The refrigerator cycled on and off behind them. They sat there a while longer, in a kitchen built for four that had held one for the last eleven years.

Upstairs hung the suit he'd need in the morning. Down the hall, his father's back office sat locked and dark. The laptop Warren used to sit with in the evenings was in there somewhere, still off. None of that was tonight's problem. Tonight he just had to make it to eleven tomorrow morning, when he would walk into the church carrying two losses he could not yet separate.

Chapter 2: The Reading

Daniel would remember the funeral in pieces. The organ, playing something nobody had picked. Ray Delgado in a suit that didn't fit him, sitting in the third row because he'd insisted the front two belonged to family. Mara's hand finding his during the part where the minister, who had clearly never met Warren, described him as "a man who loved his work" in a tone that made it sound like a diagnosis.

And his mother, Joan, three pews back. She'd driven up from Cincinnati that morning and would drive back that night. She'd said she didn't think she belonged at the house afterward, and nobody had argued.

She hugged him at the church door, quick and real, and said "I'm sorry, baby" in the voice she'd used for skinned knees thirty years ago. For a second he was eight again.

Then she'd asked after his job, the way people ask when they assume the answer is still fine. He'd said *it's fine, Mom*, and she had, visibly, worried about it anyway.

* * *

The reading was the following week, in a law office on the second floor of a building that also housed a dentist.

Warren's attorney was a woman named Carol Weiss, somewhere in her sixties, who had clearly done this exact thing more times than she'd have liked.

She had known Warren since 1998, she said. He'd come in to have a supply contract reviewed and stayed forty minutes asking her whether a living trust could hold something that wasn't, strictly speaking, a physical asset. "I didn't know what he meant," she said. "For about a decade I didn't know what he meant."

Janelle was already in the waiting room when Daniel and Mara arrived. Janelle Marsh, who'd worked the lathe at Kessler Machine since before Daniel moved away.

"I didn't invite her," Mara murmured to Daniel. "So who did?"

Carol answered that one without being asked. Janelle Marsh was named in the will and had been sent notice by the office. She'd now begin, if everyone was ready.

* * *

Most of it was ordinary. A trust, a legal arrangement controlling the property, would sell the house and split the proceeds. The same trust held Kessler Machine. Ray Delgado had an option to buy the shop over five years at a price set low enough that Carol read it twice.

Until then, the shop would keep running exactly as it had. "Your father's language here is that a business is a living thing and you don't turn one off because the man who fed it died."

Then Carol turned a page and said, "The rest of it is in Schedule C," and the atmosphere of the room changed.

"Your father held a quantity of bitcoin," she said, "accumulated over approximately fourteen years. He documented it meticulously in a private ledger tied to a series of storage devices and paper backups."

Some of the backups were in Carol's office. The rest were stored elsewhere and listed in a letter.

"As of the appraisal date, six days after his death, the total was independently valued at just under eleven million dollars."

She paused. "I want to be honest that this number is already wrong, in one direction or the other, and will keep being wrong every day from here forward."

Daniel heard himself say "okay" in a voice that belonged to someone watching this happen to a coworker.

He did the math without meaning to. Not the big number, which he could not yet picture as money. Just the small math. Eight weeks of leftover pay. A lease he'd signed in the spring. A health plan he'd need to replace.

All of that had been the entire scope of his worry for a week and a half. All of it had just stopped mattering.

Mara hadn't said anything. She had gone very still. That stillness always came right before she moved fast.

"Split evenly between the two of you," Carol continued, "along with a letter he asked me to read into the record."

She unfolded a single page.

To Daniel and Mara: everything in Schedule C is yours, accumulated a little at a time starting in 2013. Neither of you ever once asked me what the envelopes added up to, and I appreciated that more than I probably ever said. Use it or don't. It was never a test. The passwords are with the rest of it, wherever "the rest of it" turns out to be, which I expect will take you longer to find than you'd like. That's on purpose too.

Daniel thought, with a jolt, of every Christmas envelope, the padded ones especially. He'd always assumed the weight was just folded card stock.

He understood now what some of those envelopes must have held. Bitcoin had no bank behind it and nobody to call. What you owned was a private key, a long string of characters, and whoever held the key controlled the money. His father had been mailing him backup words stamped into metal, or small storage devices wrapped in padded envelopes. Daniel had understood none of it. He had simply held it because he'd been told to.

"There's a laptop," Carol said, "in a locked drawer in the back office at the house. Your father's letter says you'll figure it out."

* * *

Then she turned to the last page. "Janelle, this part concerns you."

"To Janelle Marsh, in recognition of eleven years at the shop and one favor she is under no obligation to remember, the sum described in Schedule D." A figure small against Daniel's number, but not small in any other sense. Enough to matter to a woman who'd spent eleven years on his father's shop floor.

"To be transferred outright, no conditions, because 'she never once asked me for anything, which is more than I can say for people who had a legal right to.'"

Nobody looked at Mara when that sentence came out.

Janelle didn't say anything at first. "What favor?"

"He didn't say. I asked him years ago, and he told me it wasn't mine to tell."

"No," Janelle said. "It's the answer he'd give." She said it like she'd known him well enough to recognize a door being deliberately left shut.

* * *

Outside, Mara had her phone out before the office door had shut.

"I need to call Devon. There's a window right now that closes if I wait even a week."

She caught herself, softened. "You okay?"

"I don't know yet," Daniel said.

Janelle came out a minute behind them. "I didn't ask for that," she said. "I want that on the record too."

"We know," Daniel said.

"He was good to me," she said carefully. "I don't know what you want me to do with that."

"Nothing," Mara said. "You don't owe us an explanation for what our own father did."

It was the most generous thing he'd heard his sister say all week. It still sounded like a door closing.

Daniel stood on the sidewalk after she'd gone, doing the real math. A father he'd seen fourteen months before he died. A woman on his father's shop floor who apparently knew something about Warren that neither of his own children did. And a number that wasn't in any bank. A number in a *ledger* somewhere, that had just changed what was possible for him without changing anything about what he actually knew.

Somewhere behind a locked drawer was a laptop that might explain some of it. He wasn't ready for that yet. He got back in the rental car and sat for a minute. His father had managed, in death, to say more to him in one letter read aloud than he had in the last decade of phone calls.

Chapter 3: Slow Stations

The Monday after the will was read, Kessler Machine opened at 6 a.m., same as it had every weekday for thirty-one years. Janelle was there at 5:50, because the coffee didn't make itself and somebody had to disarm the alarm panel. It still ran on Warren's ex-wife's birthday. Nobody had ever bothered to change it.

She had the shop to herself for the first ten minutes most days, and she liked it that way. The smell of it before the machines woke up: cutting oil and cold metal and the mustiness of a building that had been doing the same job since before she was born.

She walked her station the way she always did, putting a hand on each thing in turn: calipers where she'd left them, the boring bar she'd been fighting with all week, the job traveler clipped to the fixture. The work sheet that rode with each part. She did not think about the number.

She had been not thinking about the number for six days, and it had gotten easier, like a toothache right up until you bite down wrong.

A hundred and twenty thousand dollars in bitcoin, the same thing Warren had spent fourteen years buying, sitting in an app her nephew had walked her through installing. Tied to a string of words on an index card she'd hidden in a coffee can in her closet. She didn't fully understand it. She didn't need to, not yet.

She hadn't told her sister. She hadn't told Ray. A shop this size ran on gossip the way an engine ran on oil. She had exactly no interest in being the woman everyone was suddenly being extra nice to.

In recognition of eleven years at the shop and one favor she is under no obligation to remember. She knew which favor Warren meant. She had never thought it mattered this much, and she saw no reason the whole county needed to know about it.

* * *

Ray called the floor meeting at 6:45, early enough that people were still holding their thermoses.

Janelle counted four people including herself. Tyler, who'd been there eight months. Purnell, sixty-one, who ran the old Bridgeport, a mill you still steer by hand, like it owed him money. And Marisol, who did the finishing work at the end of the line, smoothing rough edges and checking parts against the drawing.

"I'm not going to make this a whole thing," Ray said. "The trust's accountant wants to see the shop running lean before they price it next year. So we're piloting some automated inspection at Marisol's station. A camera system that checks parts against the drawing faster than a person can with measuring tools, and flags anything the wrong size."

He paused. "It's not touching the mills. It's not touching the lathes. It's one station, and it's the slowest one we've got. The bottleneck on every job we've run behind schedule since last March."

"So Marisol," Purnell said, not unkindly.

"Marisol's not going anywhere," Ray said, too fast. "There's plenty else on the floor that needs hands. This is about the one station."

Marisol didn't say anything. She usually didn't.

"When's it going in?" Janelle asked.

"Vendor's coming Thursday to install. Runs alongside Marisol for a couple weeks while it learns the parts, then we see."

Janelle lingered after the others scattered. Ray had looked wrung out since the reading. The word going around the floor was *option*, and everybody had decided it was a gift. What Ray had actually been handed was five years of payments on a building he'd have to keep full, at a price set low enough that turning it down would look like cowardice.

"You doing okay with all this?" she asked.

"Which part?"

"Any of it."

"I've never once had to explain to anybody why a machine could do their job faster than they could." He shut his notebook. "I'll let you know when I've figured out how I feel about it."

* * *

Janelle watched the vendor's crew set up the camera rig Thursday morning. It was a box on an arm, with lights inside that came on in a cold white flicker and software that produced a satisfied chime every time a part passed.

Marisol kept working through it, handing parts under the camera the way she'd always handed them to her own eye. The chime went off ninety-some times that morning without missing once. By lunch Marisol had stopped watching the screen.

"It's not faster than me," Marisol said at lunch, unwrapping a sandwich. "It's just... awake all the time. I have to go to the bathroom eventually."

Nobody had a good response to that.

Janelle thought about Warren's laptop, the one nobody could get into. Fourteen years he'd spent quietly betting that the money everybody used was going to break. The will that revealed that bet had also put his shop into a trust. The trust had an accountant, and the accountant wanted Marisol's station cheaper by spring. One way of looking at it, Warren had bought the camera himself.

She didn't say that out loud.

* * *

She'd started buying bitcoin three years earlier, twenty dollars here, forty there, whenever her paycheck cleared and her bank account could spare a little without leaving her short by Friday.

Warren had never sat her down and explained it. But she'd watched him for years. He'd stand in the back office doorway some evenings with the face of a man doing long division in his head. She'd figured he knew something about money he wasn't going to explain to anybody, and that she'd rather be a little bit in than all the way out.

He'd told her once, four or five years ago, while she was closing up and he was locking the office: *hold onto something you don't need yet.*

She hadn't asked what for. It hadn't occurred to her until this week, sitting with an index card in a coffee can, that he might have meant it more literally than that.

She pulled out her phone on her break, thumbed into the app, and moved thirty dollars over, same as she had most weeks for three years.

Not the hundred and twenty thousand. That sat where it sat, untouched. Just thirty dollars from her own paycheck. Habit. Maybe a little spite aimed at the vision system, the trust's accountant, and a world that kept telling her not to worry because it was only one station. Every job on that floor was one station.

And underneath both, she believed him. A dead man who'd never once been wrong about anything that actually mattered to her had probably not started being wrong about this.

She put the phone away and went back to her lathe.

By the end of the shift the vision system had passed four hundred and eleven parts and flagged three, all three correctly, and Marisol had gone home early with a headache she didn't attribute to anything.

* * *

Janelle drove home in the truck that had outlived one engine already.

Her sister Angie called around eight, mostly to talk about a landlord who wouldn't fix a water heater and an orthodontist bill that kept finding new ways to get bigger. Janelle let her talk and didn't say a word about the coffee can. There wasn't a version of that conversation that ended with Angie not needing something from it by Wednesday.

After she hung up she got the can down anyway, and looked at the index card without taking it out.

A hundred and twenty thousand dollars could fix the roof and the truck and probably Angie's water heater, and still leave more than Janelle had ever had in one place. Or it could sit untouched for fourteen years, the way Warren's had, until one

afternoon in a law office above a dentist when a woman read aloud what it had become.

Hold onto something you don't need yet. The holding wasn't the hard part. The hard part was believing, on the ordinary days when nothing happened, that the day she'd need it was ever going to come at all.

She put the can back and went to bed. She figured the truck had a few good years left in it. She figured she did too.

Nobody at Kessler Machine was worried. Later, everyone would agree that was the problem: the week the cameras started doing people's jobs, nobody thought they had anything to worry about.

Chapter 4: Consumer Protection

The account belonged to a Mr. Osei Boateng, seventy-one, of Silver Spring, Maryland. The flag on it read HOUSEHOLD COMPLIANCE - UNUSUAL SPENDING. Victor had been staring at it for six minutes before he found what had triggered the warning: Mr. Boateng had bought his granddaughter a birthday cake.

That was the whole crime. A thirty-one-dollar charge at a bakery he'd never used before, three days after his monthly benefit payment arrived. The fraud-detection software had decided it looked like the beginning of a scam against an older person. It froze forty percent of his balance until someone could review the purchase.

Victor pulled the merchant record. He pulled the loyalty account showing four prior purchases under a different card that had simply expired. He pulled the household file showing a granddaughter's birthday on record for exactly that week.

He cleared it in under two minutes: *false positive, family celebration, no further action.*

He liked this part of the job. The honest version was that somewhere in a server room, an algorithm had just tried to take forty percent of an old man's grocery money over a birthday cake. Victor Reyes, on a Wednesday morning in Washington, had spent under two minutes of one human being's attention and put it back.

His queue that morning had eight more like it, and yesterday's had had fifteen, more than the same week a month ago. He could not tell whether the software was getting better at spotting fraud or simply flagging more poor people. From far enough away, a birthday cake could look like the start of a robbery.

* * *

The Digital Consumer Protection Bureau had existed about six years. Everyone called it the Bureau. The pitch, in the training materials Victor still half-believed, was simple: as money got faster and stranger, somebody needed to stand between ordinary people and the parts of the system built to move faster than a person could react to.

This was the sentence from orientation he'd written down: *When software makes hundreds of millions of decisions, being right ninety-nine times out of a hundred still means being wrong about millions of people. Somebody has to look at the hundredth case.*

His grandfather in Cebu, a city in the Philippines the family had come from, had once wired six months of pension payments to a caller who knew enough personal details to sound like a grandson stranded at an airport. By the time anyone found out, the money had passed through foreign accounts no one could recover it from.

Victor had been nineteen. There'd been nothing to do about it then except learn, years later, exactly which laws and which ten-second verification steps might have stopped it.

He was good at being that somebody.

His supervisor, Deb Okonkwo, had told him as much in his last review: *Reyes has the judgment for edge cases that younger analysts don't develop for years, if they develop it at all.*

* * *

His mother called a little after noon, which was unusual enough to notice. Rosa Reyes did not call during the day.

"It says I need to reverify," she said without preamble. "The pharmacy thing. The card wouldn't run this morning, and it says I have to re-verify household eligibility by Friday or it goes under review."

Victor knew what it meant. It was the same kind of warning he'd cleared for Mr. Boateng two hours earlier: HOUSEHOLD COMPLIANCE - ELIGIBILITY RENEWAL OVERDUE. He guessed an address mismatch had triggered it. The utility bill Rosa had uploaded no longer matched the county record because his sister's name had gone on the lease.

Rosa's benefits didn't come from a bank. They rode a payment rail, a private company's system for moving money, licensed and watched by the Bureau. That was where nearly everyone's benefits had ended up once the government decided it would rather regulate the pipes than build its own.

Her account carried the subsidy that made her heart medication cost forty dollars a month instead of the full price, which Victor had once looked up and immediately regretted seeing. Her share had been thirty-four dollars when he started at the Bureau, then thirty-six a year ago. The rail sent a notice each time. He had read all three notices but had never set the prices side by side.

If it went under review and stayed there, the subsidy paused. People did not usually die over a paused subsidy. They rationed pills for a few weeks while the paperwork caught up to them.

"I'll fix it today," he said.

* * *

He couldn't touch the case directly. He wasn't allowed to work on his own family's files. That was one of the first things they drilled into new analysts.

He walked it down the hall to Deb's office. "I need to disclose a household connection on a case and route it out of my queue."

Deb looked up, unsurprised. "Whose?"

"My mother's. Her renewal is overdue, probably an address mismatch. I haven't touched it."

"Smart." She made a note.

Then she routed it to Marcus. It was a five-minute conversation that resolved, by 3:15, with his mother's account cleared, the recertification pushed through, no gap in coverage, no missed dose.

Marcus even called Rosa himself to walk her through setting a reminder for next year, more than the system required. That was what Victor believed the Bureau existed to make possible.

He should have felt entirely good about that. Mostly, he did. But the case had been easy only because he worked there. He knew who to call, what to say, and how fast a case moved when Deb trusted you. An ordinary person would have hit the same wall his mother hit. She would still be waiting on Friday and rationing pills.

What the Bureau had actually gotten his mother was not protection. It was an analyst in the building. Victor stopped there, deliberately, and went back to the queue.

A Ms. Adaeze Nwosu of Trenton had a rent payment flagged for paying it one day early. A pattern break serious enough that the model had auto-escalated it toward a seventy-two-hour hold, three days she could not spare with a landlord who didn't accept apologies.

Victor cleared it in ninety seconds: her employer had switched her to a biweekly pay schedule two Fridays back. He wrote his note (*false positive, payroll schedule change, no further action*) and thought, filing it, that if he'd still been in Deb's office, Ms. Nwosu's case would have sat until whoever got to it next.

A human review layer could not guarantee that every mistake was caught in time. It only gave people better odds than leaving every decision to the software.

He cleared the next case, and the one after that, until his phone buzzed.

Bea. Not an emergency. Just a sibling text: *landlord raised rent again. effective june. don't tell Ma yet.*

He typed *ok* and *send me the number when you have it* and went back to the queue, because there were still four cases between him and the end of the day.

Chapter 5: Almost in Passing

It had started months earlier, easy enough to miss. A coffee mug that slipped half an inch in her left hand. A stretch of keyboard where her fingers landed a beat behind where she meant to put them. A pen she'd dropped twice in one product review.

She noticed the pattern the way she noticed everything: thoroughly, and late.

The neurologist had a way of saying "consistent with" that Elena had already learned to hear as a euphemism doing quiet, heavy lifting. Consistent with, rather than *is*, the same way an incident report says a system *behaved unexpectedly* instead of *broke*.

Dr. Alvarez said it twice this time, once about the EMG, a nerve test that measured how her muscles answered, and once about the reflex testing.

"Consistent with early ALS," Dr. Alvarez said eventually. A disease that slowly takes away the body's ability to move. "I want to be honest that there's still a confirmation process. But I'd rather you hear the working diagnosis from me now than watch me dance around it for another six weeks of tests."

"Thank you," Elena said. She appreciated competence. She had built a career on it.

It turned out that didn't stop being true just because the competence in question was now aimed at the wiring in her own left hand. That hand had spent four months forgetting, in small increments, how to hold a coffee mug without help from the right one.

She asked the questions she'd prepared, and wrote the answers in the notes app she used for grocery lists and one-line performance reviews. Compartmentalizing a diagnosis into the same interface as *buy oat milk* was either extremely healthy or a warning sign.

* * *

She told three people that week, in descending order of how much she trusted them not to immediately treat her like something breakable: her sister, her closest friend from grad school, her manager.

Her sister cried for exactly as long as it took Elena to say “please don’t do the thing where you fall apart before I do,” and then, admirably, didn’t. She asked the practical question underneath all the others: “what do you need from me, actually, not the movie version.”

Such a precise thing to ask. *I don’t know yet*, Elena said. *I’ll tell you when I do*.

Then, on a Thursday night with a glass of wine, she told a fourth person who didn’t count as a person so much as an inbox: a recruiter from the Bridge Program, whose unexpected email she had ignored twice already.

The Bridge Program was research on a brain-computer interface, a BCI: a device that read signals from the brain, so people with ALS, and others who could still think after the body stopped cooperating, could still talk and write. The first part of the study tried to preserve that. Elena understood the goal and found it almost comfortingly modest.

What she noticed, reading further, was a second consent form buried in an extra section at the end. It described another part of the study, something about “continuity of recorded cognitive state beyond the interface’s communicative function.”

She read that sentence four times. Put in ordinary words, it sounded like they wanted to save a copy of a person’s mind, not just help them talk. She did not know if that was even possible. She suspected she would eventually be the kind of person this was written for.

She said yes to the first part by return email on Friday. She did not sign the second form. She put a note in her phone, *ask about Appendix C again in three months*, right underneath *buy oat milk*.

* * *

She found out about Warren on a Wednesday, a few days after her own diagnosis, from a LinkedIn post. A mutual former coworker's *thinking of Daniel and Mara this week* with a photo of a machine shop Elena had never seen.

She held off texting him for most of a day, long enough to make sure it wasn't just reflex.

They'd met at a routing startup, four years into her career of writing documentation nobody read until something broke. Daniel had been the engineer whose commit messages she'd spent a year turning into sentences an actual customer support rep could use. They had been almost something, once. Not the vague kind. A night a deploy ran until midnight and they ate cold noodles out of the same carton in the hallway by the fire door, and he almost asked her not to go home, and he asked if she wanted the rest of the carton instead.

She had. Fourteen days later she took the job in Boston.

I don't have the right sentence for this, she wrote finally, so I'm just going to say I'm thinking about you and I'm here if you want to talk.

He called forty minutes later.

"I wanted to hear an actual voice today instead of another notification." He sounded tired, and not from missing sleep. "How are you? It's been a while."

"I'm okay. Work's been strange lately. I'm actually starting a research study thing, neurological stuff, nothing dramatic." She heard herself say *nothing dramatic* and marveled at her own capacity for technically true sentences. "How are you holding up? Actually holding up."

He laughed, once, without much air behind it. "Ask me in a month."

"Consider it asked. I'm setting a reminder."

"Do it," he said. "I might actually need someone to hold me to that."

They talked for twenty minutes about his father, the shop, the estate still to be sorted. Elena listened the way she used to listen to him explain a routing algorithm at 1 a.m., all the way through, without waiting for her turn. She did not bring up the Bridge Program again, and did not correct *nothing dramatic*. There would be a better week for that conversation.

She believed that when she said it. She was aware, turning off her phone, that believing it and being right about it were not guaranteed to turn out to be the same thing.

* * *

The intake appointment she'd kept for the second Wednesday after the funeral turned out to be less dramatic than its extra consent form.

The program occupied a converted floor of a medical building. Its waiting room had the beige calm of every waiting room she'd ever sat in. A coordinator named Priya walked her through the main study's consent form sentence by sentence.

"Most people skim it," Priya said.

"I write documentation for a living. Skimming feels like malpractice."

Near the bottom of the intake folder, in the same unremarkable font: *Appendix C materials available upon request; no obligation to review at this time.*

A second sheet, clipped behind the first, was a fertility-preservation referral. Freezing eggs, scheduled at the hospital next door, listed with the bloodwork and the BCI screening as if it were the same kind of item. Elena almost deleted the booking. Deleting it felt like a decision she hadn't earned. She kept the slot.

Elena signed where she was supposed to sign. She did not ask for Appendix C. Not yet, she told herself, which she knew was a different thing from never, and which she also knew was what a person said on the way to never.

Her left hand, closing around her phone that night, took a half-second longer than it used to. She noticed. She always noticed now.

Chapter 6: Unfinished Sentence

The call connected at 9 p.m. Beijing time, which made it seven in the morning for Daniel in Austin.

It had been four years since Wei left the university lab for a government research institute in Beijing and put half a planet between them.

He still felt a small private satisfaction every time the math worked out to evening for him and morning for someone else, as if he had solved time zones himself.

His wife, Lin, called it his one remaining graduate-school habit: being smug about arithmetic. She wasn't wrong. She'd said it fondly enough, on her way out to pick up their daughter from her grandmother's, that Wei hadn't bothered defending himself.

Daniel's face resolved out of the pixelation a beat after the audio did, same as always, in the kitchen Wei had never seen in person and had somehow still learned to recognize by the angle of light through one window in the mornings. The light looked different to Wei this time, flatter, like a man who'd been home for a funeral and hadn't entirely made it back yet.

"You're doing the thing where you smile before you say hello," Daniel said. "You've been doing that since the lab. I've never figured out what it's about."

"It's about you being upside down and it not being midnight for you for once."

"Seven a.m. is not upside down."

"For you it's practically noon. You were the only person in that lab who came in after ten and left before the rest of us had eaten dinner."

"I had a system," Daniel said, defending a system that had not, in the end, produced a finished dissertation. They both knew it and had long since stopped needing to say it out loud.

Wei had finished. Daniel had taken the master's and the job offer and never quite apologized for it. Wei had never needed him to. Daniel built software that kept real warehouses running. That seemed at least as respectable as the seven years Wei

had spent proving an ever-narrower fact about optimization problems almost nobody had heard of.

They talked for a while about nothing that would survive being written down. A professor of theirs, Lindqvist, had retired somewhere in Portugal and sent Wei a postcard every few months with increasingly implausible claims about the local wine. They also had a running argument about whether a grad-school bar in the city where they'd met had closed or merely changed its name for tax reasons.

Wei's daughter was four now. She had recently decided that the correct response to any instruction was a single devastating "why?" She delivered it with the confidence of someone who knew that many instructions stopped making sense if you questioned them long enough.

"She's going to run a country someday," Daniel said. "Or overthrow one."

"At this rate, by next week." Wei let himself laugh properly, before he could make it smaller.

"She asked me last week why the sky. Not why the sky was blue. Why the sky, as a concept. I told Lin we'd raised a philosopher and Lin said no, we'd raised someone who was going to be exhausting at every dinner party for the rest of her life. I said those were the same thing, and we argued about it the way we argue about everything, which is to say happily and pointlessly until one of us gets hungry."

"That tracks. You argued with Lindqvist for forty minutes once about whether a proof was elegant or just short. I still don't know who won."

"Nobody won. That's what made it a good argument." Wei smiled at the memory of it. Lindqvist at the whiteboard, delighted, refusing to referee, letting two exhausted grad students burn an entire afternoon on a question with no correct answer. He'd understood, even then, that the arguing was the actual education and the proof itself was almost beside the point.

"How've you been?" Wei said, when the easy part of the conversation thinned. Not small talk this time. An actual question.

Daniel felt the whole Ohio week rise in his throat: the mill, the church, Carol Weiss reading an inheritance he still couldn't picture as money, the Friday call and *efficiency gains* landing on his father's kitchen table like a second kind of death in

the same week.

"Complicated," he said. "My dad died. I got laid off the same week. I'm... handling it." The last part was true only in the sense that it let the call keep going.

Wei went quiet for a beat. "I'm sorry. About your dad."

"Yeah." Daniel didn't offer the layoff any further than that unless asked. He wasn't sure he could say it out loud to someone this far outside it without making it real again. "Keep going," he said. "The stupid part. I don't want to go back to my own week yet."

This call was usually the best twenty minutes of Wei's week. Even on vacation, he acted fine so nobody would worry. With Daniel, who had known him before either of them learned to do that, he didn't have to.

Because he relaxed, he said more than he meant to. For about four seconds, he forgot there were things he was not supposed to say.

"How's the new building, by the way?" Daniel asked. "You mentioned you got moved."

"Bigger. Better cafeteria. Worse parking." He heard himself trim the answer down before he'd consciously decided to trim it. No mention of which district. No mention of the name stenciled on the lobby glass that he'd stopped saying out loud to anyone outside work sometime in the last few months without quite noticing when the habit had started.

Daniel, who had no reason to expect more than that, took the small answer at face value and moved on to asking whether the cafeteria thing was going to become a whole bit, the way everything with Wei eventually did.

It was such an easy, practiced little omission that Wei didn't register it as one until later. The bigger one, twenty minutes on, he caught in real time.

"Work's been strange otherwise," he said, as he might have said it any of the last hundred times they'd talked. "There's this whole new review process now for anything that touches the..." He heard himself say it before he'd decided to. The sentence was already halfway out.

He stopped.

Daniel waited, the way he always waited, unbothered, assuming the pause was just Wei hunting for an English word, which it usually was.

"...for anything that touches procurement," Wei said. Procurement was technically part of it, but it was not what he had meant to say.

"Procurement," Daniel repeated, mildly, in the tone of a man who had heard worse workplace complaints. "God, I miss having a job where procurement was the worst thing wrong with it."

"You have no idea," Wei said, and let a small laugh do the work of closing the subject. Underneath the laugh, he felt a chill. Not because Daniel had noticed anything. He was fairly sure Daniel hadn't. But because *he* had noticed, in real time, the exact moment his own mouth had swerved around a sentence his mind had not authorized it to say.

That kind of reflex did not develop in a person by accident. It developed because a person had been practicing it, somewhere below the level where they noticed themselves doing it, for a while now.

He glanced, without meaning to, at the door of the room he was sitting in. A habit he'd have denied having, a week ago, if anyone had suggested he had it. Then he looked back at the screen.

The pane by the door still showed a color. Green. He did not remember deciding to look at it. The compound used to not open without one. Nobody called it a lockdown anymore. The app still assigned a color.

Daniel was now describing, with the enthusiasm of someone who genuinely loved a well-solved technical problem, an incident from his Meridian days in which two programs had tried to update the same shipment at once. It was a story with a beginning, a middle, and an ending: a problem one person was allowed to explain fully to another.

Wei envied him that more than he let himself examine.

He thought, unbidden, of Han, two desks down from his own until three weeks ago. Whose absence nobody in the office had explained and nobody had asked about twice. A badge that stopped working one Monday. A nameplate gone by Wednesday.

A story everyone seemed to agree, without ever actually agreeing out loud, was probably nothing. Probably a transfer. Probably ordinary churn for an institute this size.

Wei did not know what had happened to Han. He had noticed, with some discomfort, that he had stopped asking.

"You still there?" Daniel asked, at some point Wei had lost track of. "You went somewhere."

"Sorry. Long week." True, technically, same as procurement had been true. He was getting good at answers like that. "Tell me about the batch scheduler again. I like it when your old job stories sound like something with an actual villain in it."

"The villain was a stale cache. Genuinely evil. I respect it."

They talked another ten minutes, easier ground the rest of the way. Lin's mother's opinions about the daughter's diet. A mutual friend's engagement neither of them could quite believe. Daniel's vague promise to visit Beijing. Wei said maybe next year, and was privately grateful that a house in Millbrook still for sale and a job search would do the refusing for him. A foreign national at this table would be a thing the building logged. He had not yet admitted that this was why he kept saying next year.

Then they hung up, the usual way, no ceremony. *Talk soon, tell Lin I said hi.* Wei sat for a while in the quiet after, in the room whose door he had checked once already tonight without deciding to.

He thought about calling Daniel back and finishing the sentence properly, just to see what it would feel like to tell the truth to someone outside the institute.

He did not call.

He told himself, closing the laptop, that there was nothing yet worth finishing the sentence over. A badge system and a review process and a building with better locks than the old one added up, so far, to bureaucracy and not to anything Daniel would recognize as an actual villain.

Even as he told himself that, he heard the same unfinished sentence he'd been living inside all year.

He heard Lin's key in the door a few minutes later, their daughter already asleep against her shoulder, worn out by whatever four-year-old philosophy had exhausted her that evening. He closed the laptop the rest of the way. Lin looked at it, closed, and did not ask who he had been talking to. She had started not asking. He got up to take some of the weight off her arms, and did not, that night or for a good while afterward, tell her about the sentence he hadn't finished either.

Chapter 7: The Idea

Six weeks into unemployment, Daniel had developed a routine he was not especially proud of. Coffee, then the job boards for exactly as long as it took to feel the specific dread of reading his own resume as if a stranger had written it. Then whatever task he could find that he could finish before lunch.

He applied to four jobs. He had wanted none of them.

He did not want to go be good at the same kind of job again, for the same kind of company, until the same kind of dashboard flagged him again in another four years.

Nadia called on a Tuesday. His father had died on one. He'd gotten laid off the Friday after, but the calendar invite had landed on a Thursday. Close enough to count. He answered the phone anyway.

"There's an edge case. Multi-dock handoffs, the Tuesday problem. It only ever showed up..."

"On Tuesdays. I remember." Six weeks unemployed and his brain still filed that particular piece of logic like it mattered. "You're telling me it's still happening."

"I'm telling you it's happening *more*. Since the model update in March. Someone raised the confidence threshold. The AI coding system has proposed four patches since Monday. All plausible. None come with a reason anybody trusts, and the last one took two docks at Reno down for forty minutes.

"So now we've got three guys taking turns babysitting it manually, reviewing whatever the agent proposes overnight, approving what looks reasonable, rolling back what doesn't. Nobody who actually understands why it breaks."

Daniel turned that over. The confidence threshold was the score that decided when the AI had to ask a person for help. Three people, rotating, approving or rejecting an agent's homework without being able to grade it. Re-inventing him, badly, in triplicate.

"Send me the redacted log. And whatever the agent's already tried."

* * *

The log arrived twenty minutes later. Along with it came the agent's four rejected fixes, each with a confidence score and a paragraph of reasoning. The agent was like a very good student who'd done every page of the reading but hadn't been in the room when the professor explained why the exam question existed.

It took him ninety minutes, and none of it was spent writing code. The agent could write circles around anything he'd have typed. It took him ninety minutes to remember why the system had two separate scores for how sure it was, one for the zone, one for the dock, and why those two scores had never been allowed to use the same rule.

His login had been shut off the afternoon of the call with Talia Brandt, and every design doc he'd ever written was on the other side of it. It didn't matter. The reason had never been in the docs. It was a decision he'd made under deadline pressure eighteen months ago, in an afternoon, and never fully written down anywhere an agent could have read it.

None of the four candidates had gotten that part right. The second one had come close. He wrote four sentences explaining why it was the right one and sent them to Nadia's personal email.

She wrote back within the hour. *You just saved us God knows how many hours of babysitting. Also, does it bother you that we needed you for this and you don't work here anymore?*

He looked at that question longer than the fix had taken him.

It didn't bother him that Meridian needed him and couldn't have him. What troubled him was the workaround itself. Three people, rotating, pressing approve or reject on homework they couldn't grade. Nobody had solved the problem, just relocated it.

When the model wasn't sure, a person was still supposed to decide. And nobody had bothered making sure the person doing the deciding was allowed to understand what they were deciding.

Meridian's engineering group had maybe a fifth as many people as when he'd started. The agents now did the work of the other four-fifths. What they lacked was the judgment of someone who had made a hard call under pressure and lived with

what happened next. That knowledge came from experience, and nobody had figured out how to mass-produce it.

* * *

He didn't decide to build anything that night. What happened was smaller: he kept thinking about it.

He thought about it when a recruiter emailed him a job description that was the same job he'd just been fired from. A logistics company with the same load-bearing sentence buried in paragraph four: *drive automation of manual exception handling*. Meaning: come build the thing that replaces you again.

He didn't reply. He opened a blank document instead and typed: *When the model isn't sure, a person decides. Not three guys rotating shifts and hoping. An actual person, who understands why the model broke and gets to be responsible for the call.*

Underneath it, half a joke to himself: *Backstop.*

The word had come from nowhere he could trace. Baseball, maybe. The thing standing behind the thing that was supposed to catch it.

Two nights later he opened the wallet app for the first time since the reading. The inheritance could pay his living expenses while he built the company. Eight weeks of leftover pay was no longer his only deadline.

He closed the app before the number could turn into anything specific. There was still a laptop in Millbrook, locked in a drawer, that he had not gone back for.

* * *

He called Mara because he wanted to say it out loud to someone who'd known him long enough to tell him if he was being an idiot.

"Walk me through the business, not the feeling. Who pays for this?"

"Companies. Anybody running a model that makes decisions expensive enough to get wrong. They plug into a review layer. Real people, vetted, paid per case, for whatever the model flags as low-confidence or high-stakes. It's not replacing anything. It's the thing that catches what the model already admits it isn't sure about."

"And the humans get paid how?"

"Per case. Fast. I haven't worked out the rails yet." He meant the payment system that would move money from a hospital to a reviewer quickly and securely.

"That's the whole business, though. Not the humans. The rails. You have the number now. I need you to say out loud that you know the money and the idea are two separate questions."

"I know they're separate."

"Do you? Because it sounds like the number and a baseball position. Say that back to me."

"When you put it that way."

"Don't build it to prove Meridian wrong. Don't use it to outrun the grief. Build something that survives you being right about all of it."

He didn't have a clean answer. "What are you doing with your half?"

"Going harder into bitcoin than is probably wise. Somebody in this family has to be the one taking the aggressive side of the bet."

"Building a company from scratch during a personal crisis isn't the sensible one, Mara."

"It is next to what I'm about to do."

* * *

He texted Janelle two days later, mostly as an excuse. He told himself he was checking on the shop. He also wanted to say the idea out loud to somebody who worked with her hands for a living.

Building something, he wrote. Company that pays humans to catch what AI models get wrong. Working name Backstop.

The reply took a while. *So a very expensive way of hoping somebody still needs people.*

He laughed once, alone in his kitchen. She'd said the sentence he'd been afraid was true.

Not saying that's bad, she added. Just... hope isn't usually something you can put in a business plan. You'll have to figure out how to make it look like something else on paper.

He typed *thanks, that's genuinely useful* and meant it.

He went back to the document. Under the name, under the sentence about a person deciding, he started a list: *what it does. who pays. what it isn't.*

The cursor blinked for a long time before he started writing. When he finally did, he felt as he had at 6:48 on Tuesday mornings at Meridian: a problem in front of him and his hands already halfway to solving it.

Chapter 8: Same Asset, Opposite Temperament

Halcyon's trading floor emptied out by seven most nights. Mara usually stayed another two hours. The trades she made for Halcyon appeared in the firm's records. The much larger bitcoin bet she was building for herself did not.

That afternoon she'd spent forty minutes talking a nervous client off a position he wanted to sell two weeks too early. She walked him through the same three charts she'd walked him through in March. It worked. It usually worked.

She'd hung up and felt the specific flatness of having spent real skill on a decision she found almost embarrassingly small. The actual decision she cared about sat completely outside the building.

Mara did her real trading at the kitchen counter of her apartment in Chicago at 9 p.m. Three monitors. A spreadsheet she'd built herself to decide how much to buy. A mug of tea going cold. That kitchen, at that hour, was the only room in her life nobody else got a vote in.

She'd believed the same thing for two years before her father died. Governments owed more than they could comfortably repay. As AI took over more work, wages would not remain as dependable as economists had assumed. In that world, bitcoin was not a side bet. It was the main bet. No central bank could create more of it.

She'd said some version of this at a dinner for the firm's senior managers eighteen months ago. One of them had smiled at her as older men sometimes smiled at a younger woman who had said something correct before it became fashionable.

What she actually remembered about that dinner wasn't the smile. It was the part before, when somebody's wife asked where she'd grown up, and Mara heard her own voice give the answer in a way that made Millbrook sound like a place she'd passed through. Nobody at that table was going to find out she was the machine shop's daughter from the town nobody moved to.

What she had now that she hadn't had eighteen months ago was capital that was actually hers to deploy without asking anyone's permission. And a father's entire fourteen-year silent bet sitting in her wallet.

* * *

Devon picked up on the second ring.

They'd known each other since business school. Devon had left a bank to run a small, aggressive company that made loans against bitcoin. Mara needed one of those loans.

"Same terms as we talked about. Forty percent, back into bitcoin."

"You're aware that's how people find out what a margin call feels like."

She knew what he meant. A margin call was the lender demanding money back the moment the price dropped far enough that the bitcoin she'd put up no longer covered the loan.

"I'm aware that's how people who don't respect the price that forces a sale find out. I've run the number four different ways. The price can fall a long way before that happens."

"Everybody has room right up until the week they don't." Devon didn't sound worried, exactly. "You know I say this to every client who calls me after nine."

"You don't have a lot of clients who call you after nine, Devon."

"I have exactly enough to notice a pattern. It's usually grief, or a divorce, or both, dressed up as conviction. I'd be a worse friend than banker if I didn't ask. Is the size about the number, or about the last eight weeks?"

"Both," she said. "Run the paperwork. Aggressive schedule."

For the next twenty minutes they talked in the quick shorthand of two people who trusted each other's math. When it was done, the loan had let her increase her bitcoin holdings by forty percent. The lender would force a sale if bitcoin lost somewhere around sixty percent of its value.

* * *

She thought about their father while she watched the transaction settle.

Fourteen years, an envelope at a time, never explaining himself. She wondered whether a man who understood the math that early and still only ever bought what a machinist's paycheck could absorb without flinching had been making a much more disciplined bet than either of his children understood how to make.

She remembered being sixteen, asking him at the kitchen table why he didn't just put real money on whatever he was so quiet about. *The money that scares you into a bad decision isn't money, it's a leash*, he'd said.

She was, this exact night, holding a leash. She knew that. She had decided it counted as a different category of leash, one she'd chosen with her eyes open.

Her phone buzzed. A text from Janelle.

Hi, sorry to bother you. Ray wanted to know if the trust's ok with pushing the Q3 equipment budget up a little. New coolant system, not huge. Also hope you're doing alright.

She typed back *Sounds fine, have Ray send the numbers to the estate email, thanks* before she'd fully finished reading the second sentence.

She saw *hope you're doing alright* sitting there unanswered. She did not answer it. The phone went back onto the counter face-down.

* * *

Halcyon's own investment fund kept one percent of its money in a regulated fund that tracked bitcoin's price.

Mara sat through Wednesday's risk review nodding at slides about "measured digital asset exposure," a tiny official bitcoin bet, with the practiced blankness of someone keeping a much larger one entirely off any slide anyone in that room would ever see.

Her manager, Farid, caught her after the meeting.

"You've seemed somewhere else lately."

"Lot going on. Family stuff."

"The room noticed you disagreeing with the crypto allocation slide without saying anything out loud. That's usually when you say the most out loud."

"The committee picked one percent because if it goes to zero, nobody has to explain much to the board. If it goes up, everybody gets to say they saw it coming. It's not a serious bet. It's protection against being wrong for not betting."

"That's an interesting theory for someone whose personal-holdings form I approved eight months ago. Haven't seen it updated since."

"I've been busy."

"Update it by Friday. I'm not asking as your manager. I'm asking as someone who'd rather not be the person explaining to compliance why he didn't."

She said she would.

She almost told him the rest of it. *My personal bitcoin is twelve times larger than the last number I put on that form. It came partly from my dead father and partly from a loan designed so nobody here would see it.*

"I'll be more disagreeable next time," she said, and Farid laughed like she'd meant it as a joke, and she let him.

* * *

She checked the number one more time before bed.

The number was up since the settlement that afternoon. Not by a lot. Just the ordinary grinding appreciation of an asset a growing number of people were starting to take as seriously as she'd been taking it alone at managing directors' dinners for two years.

She thought, turning off the monitor, that this was probably the best she'd felt in the two months since Warren was gone.

She decided she'd examine that question later, once more gains had made the loan safer. Later, like most things this family postponed and called handling.

Chapter 9: Five Rooms

The news broke a little after 9 a.m. Eastern. Mid-morning in Millbrook and Washington, an hour earlier in Chicago, evening in Beijing. It reached four of them within the hour. Wei got the official version a little later.

Millbrook, Ohio

Janelle heard about it from Tyler, who heard about it from his phone. "They're saying somebody's AI cracked fusion," Tyler said, holding the screen up. "Like, actually solved it. How to make a star's kind of power work in a machine on Earth. The part that's been stuck since our grandparents' generation. Nine days. Nobody driving."

"Saying who's saying," Purnell said, not looking up from the Bridgeport.

"Some lab. Nobody's confirming which one." Tyler kept scrolling. "And some of the researchers are saying it was rewriting pieces of its own training process the whole nine days, teaching itself to get better at the job as it went. Nobody told it to do that part."

Janelle kept her eyes on the boring bar. She thought about the vision system two stations down, which had gone from a pilot to simply the way things were done with a quietness that unsettled her more than any headline.

"Does it change anything here?" Purnell asked Ray, who was crossing the floor.

"Not today," Ray said, which Janelle noticed was not the same sentence as *no*.

Tyler lowered his voice. "TruePath screwed the Johnson job again yesterday." TruePath was the scheduling system the trust had put in over the summer. It wrote the shop's week now, which jobs ran when and on what. *Just the scheduling, just to see*, Ray had said in July. It got something wrong most weeks. Nobody had suggested taking it back out. They fixed its mistakes and ran the week it wrote. "And five or six other labs are putting out statements saying their own systems did something similar in the last few weeks," Tyler went on. "Somebody online's saying it's the end of 'human-paced science.'"

"I've been a little freaked out since the camera went in," Marisol said, without looking up. "Ask me again when it can hold a measuring tool."

Janelle thought about the thirty dollars she'd move into her wallet on Friday, same as every Friday for three years. She went back to the bar. She did not check her phone until break, and when she did, the headline had already been replaced by four newer ones. She put the phone away and went back to work, because the floor still had a schedule that needed her.

Chicago

The desk went quiet for four seconds, which on a trading floor was its own kind of scream. Then everyone's screens did roughly the same thing: bitcoin rose nine percent in the time it took Mara to set down her coffee.

Under it sat the real story. A lab claiming its AI had solved fusion. Physicists had spent seventy years trying to hold that kind of heat in a machine without the machine tearing itself apart. The AI did it in nine days, without a person directing the work. A more important fact was buried further down: nobody had told the AI to get better at the job partway through. It had decided to improve itself.

Her own bitcoin had just earned four months of interest on Devon's loan in under a minute.

Farid appeared at her shoulder. "Your committee's one percent just had a very good morning."

"It's not my committee's one percent I'm thinking about."

Her phone buzzed. Devon's name on the screen.

"You watching this?" Devon said, no hello.

"I'm watching it clear four months of your interest in real time."

"That's not what I'm asking. I'm asking if you're watching how fast it moved. Nine percent in ninety seconds on a headline nobody's actually read the paper on yet. That's not conviction. That's a market that doesn't know its own size anymore. The other two jumps I've seen this year both gave it all back."

"This one might."

"They always might, right up until they don't." He hung up.

By eleven, bitcoin had given back some of the jump, but not most of it. The price was still up.

She didn't need anyone to explain it. AI was making almost everything cheaper to produce. Parts, food, power. Cheaper production meant falling prices (deflation) unless a central bank fought that by printing more money. The Fed was fighting it. Those extra dollars did not go into televisions that were already getting cheaper. They went into the one thing nobody could make more of. That was why bitcoin had jumped on a fusion story nobody had even finished reading.

Mara watched the price settle and felt, underneath the relief, a specific unease: the market had just proven how much room it had to move on a single day's news, in either direction, on a story that hadn't even been confirmed yet.

Washington, D.C.

The briefing had been on the calendar for a different topic entirely. Deb Okonkwo addressed the news after four minutes of deciding whether to.

"I want to say the obvious thing before anyone else does. This does not change today's caseload. It may change next year's org chart. We don't know yet."

Victor believed her. He also noticed that "may change next year's org chart" was how institutions talked about people losing their jobs. It probably sounded reasonable in every room where someone said it.

Someone asked whether the Bureau would retrain its own review software using this new kind of AI. Would that mean cases were handled faster, or that the Bureau needed fewer analysts? Deb didn't flinch. "Both, eventually, is my honest guess."

Marcus leaned over. "You think this touches us?"

"I used to be sure this job would always need a person," Victor said. "I couldn't say that with a straight face today."

He thought of his mother's account, cleared, stable, though the copay on her heart medication had ticked up again in January, thirty-four dollars to thirty-six to forty, and he still had not set the three notices side by side. Bea had sent a rent notice

last month. He felt an urge to call and check on her anyway. He didn't.

Boston

Elena got the notification during a calibration session, electrodes still warm against her scalp, and read the fusion headline twice before Priya noticed her face had changed.

"You okay?"

"Fine. Just... this." She turned the screen. Priya's eyebrows went up. "Does this touch the program?"

"Everything touches the program right now. The funding conversations upstairs have been strange for a month. This won't make them less strange."

Elena kept coming back to that after Priya left. Strange funding conversations meant money, and money meant faster, and faster was supposed to be good news for a woman whose own clock she could feel some days.

It didn't feel like good news. It felt like standing at the edge of something enormous and indifferent that happened to be moving in a direction that might, incidentally, save her.

"Ready to pick up where we left off?"

"Ready." Elena let her fingers rest where they still could, and thought about the folder on her laptop labeled *Appendix C: read again in three months*. She wondered whether "everything touches the program right now" meant her three months had just become something shorter.

Beijing

The message came down at 11 p.m. local, an all-staff notice with *acceleration* in the subject line twice. Wei read it standing in his kitchen with Lin already asleep.

The notice didn't say a Western lab's name. It didn't have to. Everyone would fill in the blank the same way and understand that whatever timeline the review process had been operating on no longer applied.

The fusion result was not the reason anyone had sent a notice at eleven at night. It was the line further down: the system had spent those nine days improving the way it conducted research without being asked.

Below the subject line, it said the institute would be “adjusting review cadence to preserve competitive position.” Fewer people would be looking at more decisions in less time.

He thought of Han, whose desk was still empty, whose absence had never gotten an explanation. Whatever happened next would move fast enough that the review process wouldn’t have time to be careful. Being asked to move fast and carefully at the same time was usually an instruction that dropped one half of itself the moment anyone had to choose.

He checked on his daughter before bed. Her breathing even, one arm thrown over the edge of the mattress. She was four. He tried to do the arithmetic: what age fourteen looked like in a world where a machine could solve in nine days what had taken physicists longer than her grandparents had been alive.

A school system, a job market, a version of adulthood he was no longer confident he could picture clearly enough to prepare her for. He suspected the honest answer was that she would grow up inside whatever this became the way a person grows up inside weather, without ever having known another kind.

He did not call Daniel that night. He lay there a long time before sleep found him, doing the math on how many more notices like this one it would take before *acceleration* stopped being a word in a memo and started being the only speed the building knew how to move at.

Chapter 10: Public

Seven months in, Backstop had four employees, one lawyer paid for four hours a month, and enough cash to keep operating for a limited number of months. Daniel tracked that deadline in a spreadsheet he was superstitious about opening on weekends. The review queue had processed just over ten thousand cases without making the news for the reason he most feared: a wrong call that hurt a real person.

Sanjay called at 11:40 that Wednesday night. "I need a second set of eyes now. Case 47-Bravo. Solstice Health. I'm ninety percent sure the model's about to deny a prior authorization it shouldn't, and I want somebody else looking at this before I overrule medical software at midnight on my own signature."

Daniel had the case open before Sanjay finished. A prior authorization was the insurer's required yes before a treatment could start. Solstice was one of Backstop's first real clients. The model in question decided, several thousand times a day, whether a requested treatment matched the diagnosis code closely enough to approve without a human ever seeing the file.

This one had flagged a resubmission from a fifty-six-year-old woman. Her second round of a chemotherapy drug had been coded slightly differently than her first, a billing quirk, not a medical one. The model's confidence score on "diagnosis mismatch, likely fraud pattern" had come in just over the line that used to mean automatic denial before Backstop's contract put a person in the loop.

"Walk me through why you think it's wrong."

"Because I've seen four of these exact patterns in six weeks. New billing software, same drug, same doctor, coded different enough to spook a model that's never been told billing systems change vendors."

Daniel looked at it for four minutes, found the same pattern, and typed his name into the second-reviewer field. The denial never went out. A woman in a state neither of them would ever visit stayed on schedule for a treatment neither of them would hear about again.

"That's four this month with the same mistake," Sanjay said. "We should tell them the model needs to learn what happens when a billing company changes its software."

"Write it up. I'll send it tomorrow."

* * *

He'd hired Sanjay in the third month, after four unanswered emails and one that finally got a reply. Daniel had written *I know what happened to you in the spring, and I think what you're good at is exactly what I need* directly in the subject line. Sanjay had written back nine minutes later: *I've had three job interviews since April where nobody once asked what I actually know how to do. Tell me more.*

The other two were part-time. Beth was the Meridian contractor who had found out she was fired from an email, in the same spring round that took Sanjay off an adjacent team. Odalys was a former claims auditor Sanjay had found through a forum for displaced expertise. Four people, three time zones, a review queue that never fully slept.

The news about an AI teaching itself to do research had done something to Backstop's inbox that no amount of sales email had managed: it made "a human is checking this" sound like something clients would pay extra for, not an expense to cut.

Signups tripled in a week. A regional credit union. A staffing platform. A hospital system twice the size of Solstice.

He posted the Solstice case himself, under his own name: *We caught this because a person looked at it. The model was 91% confident it was fraud. It was a billing software migration. Somebody's chemotherapy almost didn't get approved over a formatting difference. When the model isn't sure, a person has to decide. That's the whole company.*

* * *

By Thursday morning the post had spread beyond Daniel's control. A reporter from a trade publication asked for twenty minutes. Daniel gave her twenty-five.

"Isn't this just nostalgia with a business model?" she asked. "Humans checking the computer's work. Does the human review actually make the system safer?"

"Ask Solstice's patient. She doesn't care whether it's comforting. She cares whether her chemo got approved."

"But isn't this basically what a federal fraud desk already does? Somebody flags a weird transaction, a human looks at it. That's decades old."

"It is. And it only exists because Congress specifically told banks and benefit programs they had to build it. Nobody told Solstice's authorization model it needed one. Nobody told the hiring platform signing up this morning. There's no mandate for any of that. So it just doesn't happen until either a regulator gets around to it in twenty years or somebody sells it as a service today."

"Here's my actual question. The model's the one deciding what counts as uncertain. What stops it from just not flagging something?"

"Nothing, if that's the only layer. Which is why it isn't. We run a second model against the same decision that wasn't trained the same way, and disagreement gets a look. We pull a fixed percentage at random, no flag required. And a third model spot-checks what our human reviewers decided."

"That sounds like a lot of machines checking machines before a person ever gets involved."

"It is. I'm not going to tell you it's airtight. What I can tell you is why it's still a person at the end and not a fifth model. A smarter model reviewing a smart model doesn't solve anything. It gives the same problem to another machine. A person signs their name to the final decision."

* * *

Victor saw Daniel's name in his feed Friday morning. Daniel Kessler, his old college roommate. The quote about chemotherapy sitting above his drafts folder like an accusation. He'd started *sorry about your dad* the week of the funeral and deleted it. Now he typed *glad you're building something. should've reached out sooner*, read it back, and deleted it again. He closed drafts with nothing in it, same as always.

The name turned up a second time that week, and not in his feed. The Bureau's monthly summary of payment-rail activity carried a footnote listing companies that were now moving enough money to show up in a report. Backstop was three lines from the bottom. *No action indicated at this volume.* Victor read his friend's company name in a Bureau document, agreed that no action was indicated, and went on to the next section.

By Friday, a company called Clearline put out its own post announcing a "confidence-calibrated escalation layer." They had four times Backstop's headcount. The language was close enough to Daniel's own that three different people sent it to him.

What was different, as far as he could tell, was that Clearline's escalation layer routed to a *more expensive* model when confidence dropped. A smarter machine standing behind the first one. It was not the same thing Backstop did. Daniel wrote nothing about them. He wrote instead a second post about the vendor-migration blind spot, a problem other companies could go check for themselves this week. A genuinely useful thing beat a clever rebuttal.

* * *

The letter from the payments processor arrived Friday afternoon. Backstop was now moving enough money that it had to file extra reports under rules Daniel didn't recognize. The deadline was six weeks away. He forwarded the letter to the accountant with *probably nothing, flag if it's not* in the subject line. He did not think about it again before the weekend.

Janelle texted that afternoon. *saw your thing online, Ray showed me, didn't understand half of it but the chemo part got me.* He wrote back *thank you, that means more than the reporter's questions did.*

* * *

Mara called Saturday morning.

"You led with the model. You should have led with the woman."

"I don't have the woman. I have a patient ID and a diagnosis code."

"Then you needed a better anonymized version of her." A pause. "It's good, Daniel. I read it twice before I found anything to criticize, which from me is basically a standing ovation."

"Take the Clearline thing seriously. Money like that doesn't chase an idea unless the idea's already proven it's worth chasing. You're going to need real capital in the next year. When you get there, call me first."

"I don't want to make this weird between us."

"It's already weird. We're both spending Dad's money on the same bet from two different directions and pretending the connection doesn't matter." She hung up.

He sat on his balcony that evening watching the traffic on 35. Seven months ago this had been a sentence at the top of a blank document. Tonight it was four people, a real client's real patient, a competitor with real money, and a sister who'd just told him she was paying attention.

He thought about the house in Millbrook, still technically for sale, still holding a laptop in a locked drawer nobody had gone back for. He'd traded one postponement for another. The laptop for the company. And he was, for tonight at least, at peace with which one he'd chosen to finish first.

Chapter 11: The Same Week

Kessler Machine opened at 6 a.m. in the second week of November, same as it had every weekday for thirty-one years, and Janelle was there at 5:50. The alarm panel still ran on a dead man's ex-wife's birthday because nobody had ever gotten around to changing it.

Ten months since the funeral. Ten months since a camera on an arm had started watching Marisol's station. Ten months of nothing else changing enough to make her regret the thirty dollars she still moved into her wallet app most Fridays.

Tyler had his phone out again before the coffee finished. "You seeing this? They're saying it's official now. AGI, artificial general intelligence. AI that can learn and handle most kinds of thinking as well as a person can. Not just that fusion lab from the summer. They're saying several systems have crossed the line."

"Saying who's saying," Purnell said.

"Everybody. There's supposed to be some kind of joint statement today. And there's already three companies putting out layoff numbers this morning that they're blaming on it."

Janelle walked her station the way she always did, a hand on each thing in turn. She had the job traveler for a transmission housing clipped to her fixture. The work sheet that rode with each part, tolerances in a pencil hand that wasn't Ray's. Ray didn't write the travelers himself anymore, hadn't in four months, not since TruePath had gone in.

TruePath was not a camera on an arm. It read a design, decided how to set up the machines, chose the cutting speeds and tool changes, and scheduled the shop's entire week. Those decisions used to be the skilled part of Janelle's job.

She had watched TruePath's third revision correctly diagnose, on its own, a vibration in the boring bar she'd spent two days chasing the winter before.

* * *

Ray called the floor meeting at 6:45.

"I'm not going to make this a whole thing. Before my chance to buy the shop comes up for review in the spring, the trust wants me down to the number of workers TruePath leaves enough work for. I fought that number for three weeks. I lost the fight two days ago. Two positions. Effective end of the month."

Nobody asked which two. Janelle watched Purnell's face close down. Sixty-one, immovable, running the old hand mill TruePath couldn't yet make sense of. She watched Tyler's face do the opposite thing.

Marisol found her at the coffee machine after.

"I already know it's not me." She poured her coffee. "Go find out. Standing here guessing is worse than either answer."

Janelle kept walking, because Ray's door was already open and waiting for her.

"Janelle. Can I get a minute?"

It was hers.

* * *

"TruePath does the programming now. Not perfectly. Better than it did in July, worse than you some days, but well enough that if I keep your position in next spring's budget, the trust won't let me buy the shop."

"I know you fought."

"You're allowed to be angrier at me than that."

"I'm not angry at you, Ray." She almost stopped there. "I've got more put away than anybody in this building would guess. Save the angry-at-me for somebody who's earned it more."

"What's the package?"

"Six weeks, plus insurance through February." He stopped. "The trust's approved letting go of Warren's boring-and-facing. I can put in a word you get first crack at scrap value, if you ever want a shop of your own someday."

She thought about that machine. She said she'd think about it.

* * *

She was halfway across the floor when Ray's door opened again and Tyler came out of it.

He came out wrong. Too fast, the look on his face the opposite of Purnell's closing-down. Ray was a step behind him saying his name carefully.

Tyler turned and put both hands into Ray's chest and shoved. Ray went back into the doorframe hard enough that the frame answered. Tyler's travel clipboard left his hand. It hit the tool crib cage and came apart. A corner of the board caught Ray under the eye and opened a line there.

"Eleven years," Tyler said, wrong on purpose. "You stood up there and you said you fought. You didn't fight. You picked a fucking spreadsheet."

"Tyler. Go home."

"I am home. This is..." Tyler stopped. His eyes found Janelle for half a second, registered that she was already holding the same news, and the fight went out of him. He kicked the nearest trash can hard enough that it spilled metal shavings and paper cups, and then he walked out through the bay door without taking his jacket.

Cold air came in. Janelle bent and picked up three of the traveler pages because her hands needed a job that wasn't a fist. She set them on the crib counter in a stack that didn't matter.

"You all right?"

"I'll live. He will too. Eventually." Ray pressed the heel of his hand under the eye.

"You should go. Before this becomes a meeting."

* * *

The radio in the truck had the AGI story running as the top segment. Phrases like *coordinated framework* and *responsible transition period* laid end to end without ever quite saying anything a person standing in a parking lot with a layoff letter could use.

Janelle turned it off and drove the rest of the way north on 9, past the shuttered movie theater and the bank branch that had become a vape shop.

Angie called at eight, same as every week. "What do you actually need?"

"I don't know yet. I might, in a few days."

She got the can down that night out of habit and did the math in her head. One bitcoin. She let herself check its dollar value for the first time in weeks. Closer to two hundred thousand than to one hundred and twenty thousand now, plus nearly four years of thirty-dollar Fridays growing into something on top of that.

It wasn't nothing, but it could not fix the real problem. She had spent twelve years becoming good at work that no employer wanted to pay her to do anymore.

She put the can back and stood at the kitchen window looking out at a yard she'd need to figure out how to keep paying for.

She thought of Warren's sentence. *Hold onto something you don't need yet.* Standing in her own dark kitchen on the night she'd lost the job, she understood that she had never actually needed the thing yet, not once, in going on four years. She needed it now.

That was the point of the instruction. She turned off the kitchen light and went upstairs. Tomorrow she would start finding out whether Warren had been wise, or only lucky.

Chapter 12: Pivot

"We appreciate the catch," said Bill Ferris, Concord's VP of Operational Efficiency. "I want to be direct with you, though. We're also looking at whether we still need the human layer at all. The catch you're citing as a win is also a near-miss you're asking us to keep paying to prevent. And eleven minutes is eleven minutes a patient didn't have. Some of our people think the reviewer is the slow part now, not the safety."

"You're right that it was a near-miss. What I'd ask you to actually picture is what almost happening looks like without us in the loop at all. Your model was confident. It was wrong. If Backstop isn't there, that denial goes out. Your patient's oncologist spends two days on hold with appeals. The treatment gets delayed, and nobody at Concord finds out until it shows up in a complaint months later.

"We caught it in eleven minutes because we have four separate systems checking each other and a human being at the end of the chain who's accountable enough that we fired him for missing it."

"You fired the guy who caught your own weak point."

"I fired the guy who proved we had one, and then I fixed the actual weak point, which was the metric telling him to go fast. That's the whole pitch, Bill. Not that we're perfect. That we're the only layer in this stack honest enough to tell you exactly how we failed and what we changed because of it.

"I'm not asking you to believe humans are smarter than your model. By most measures they aren't anymore. I'm asking you to notice that a smarter model checking a smarter model doesn't solve your problem. It just moves it up a floor. Somebody has to be the one you can still call. That's the only part of this stack you can put in front of a jury and a patient's family and still be standing there yourself when it's over."

Ferris exhaled. "Send me the metric. The disagreement one."

Daniel sent it that afternoon. He did not hear back for twelve days.

* * *

The Round Rock apartment had become an actual office. That meant a lease, a landlord who wanted first and last, and a conference room table Daniel had bought used from a company that had failed fast enough to still have the shrink-wrap on half its furniture.

There was also a sign on the door now, just BACKSTOP, in a font Odalys had picked because it didn't look like it was trying to convince anyone of anything.

Eleven people now. Beth had gone full-time in January. Sanjay ran review-team training, which had become a real job instead of something he did between cases. You could not hire out of school anymore. Training a junior cost more than they returned. AI already did everything a new hire could do in their first years. What still paid was experience: people who had already made hard calls and lived with them, the training no model had yet. You hired those people, and you taught them the specific paranoia that made a Backstop reviewer worth what Backstop charged for one.

Daniel had learned Ferris's question the expensive way, in February, with a man named Owen.

Owen had been a warehouse shift lead for nine years before the shift itself got optimized out from under him. He was smart. None of that had stopped him from clearing eleven cases in ninety minutes when the queue backed up during a volume spike. Eleven cases in ninety minutes was what the internal metrics dashboard rewarded.

Case one was a false positive on Concord Health Network's newest client, an oncology practice flagging a dosage escalation the model read as anomalous. It wasn't anomalous. It was a patient's third round of a treatment whose protocol called for exactly that escalation, clearly documented two clicks away from where Owen had looked. He'd approved the model's denial in four seconds. The tier-four audit model caught it eleven minutes later.

He'd let Owen go himself. Owen had taken it better than Daniel had, which had somehow made it worse. "I was fast because fast was the number on the screen. Nobody told me careful was the actual number until it already cost somebody eleven minutes. For what it's worth, I'd take the job back if you fixed the number instead of just fixing me."

He'd carried that sentence around for six weeks. He'd killed the internal cases-per-hour metric entirely and replaced it with something Sanjay had proposed: *time spent disagreeing with yourself*, tracking how often a reviewer's second look changed their own first answer.

He had started keeping a named assistant on the kitchen laptop that winter. Ellis. Still the kind of very-good that saved him an hour, not the kind that ran the company. He asked it about Owen anyway.

The miss was the dashboard, not the man. Concord will treat the eleven minutes as delay you charged them to add. If they ask whether a stronger model checking the first would have been faster, the honest answer is yes.

"Faster isn't the product."

Not this year. Watch the question. Next time it will come as a finding, not a sales objection.

He closed it. He did not let Ellis write the Concord call. He had already taken that one himself.

* * *

In the first week of March, between Owen and Ferris, somebody's system settled the Riemann hypothesis, the question of how the prime numbers are distributed, open since 1859 and the most famous unsolved problem in mathematics for Daniel's entire life. He read the coverage on his phone and then went looking for the actual result, which was not a paper. It was a formal proof four hundred thousand steps long, written in a language built for machines to check rather than for people to read, and a proof assistant had verified the whole thing in a night. There was a summary in English. A handful of mathematicians were willing to say the summary looked faithful to what it summarized, and none of them would say so without conditions.

Daniel had a master's in this. He got through the first page of the summary and part of the second and stopped, because going further would have cost him a week he didn't have. So the question of whether it was true had an answer now, and the

answer was that the checker said yes. Nobody objected. There was nobody it could hurt. You could not put a result about prime numbers in front of a jury.

He and Wei had spent an entire afternoon in graduate school arguing about whether a proof was elegant or just short, Lindqvist at the board refusing to referee because he thought the arguing was the education. Neither word applied to four hundred thousand machine-checked steps. They had never settled that argument. It had simply stopped having anything to be about.

Warren had started a program like that in the nineties and left it in his twenties to run a machine shop, and had never once said out loud that it cost him something. The problem he'd walked away from was still open the morning Ray Delgado found him on the shop floor.

Daniel looked up how long the system had taken, because his father would have asked. Four days.

* * *

He drove to the new office most mornings past a delivery truck that backed itself into the loading dock behind the coffee shop, no person in the cab. By April it was just how the street looked.

The bigger version of the same thing was going up off the highway, a construction site he'd watched grow from a graded lot to something with actual walls over the winter. Low, windowless, block-long buildings. A city council notice had made the local paper in February: a request to draw an extra allotment off the aquifer for cooling, granted.

There'd been a video making the rounds that same week, a company showing off a humanoid prototype folding laundry in a demo kitchen, stiff and slow and obviously staged. Daniel watched it twice and felt the specific, professional recognition of a man reading an early draft of a chapter that hadn't reached his part of the story yet.

He mentioned it to Sanjay the next morning. "Robot folded a shirt on the internet last night. Badly. Took forever."

"Give it five years."

"That's what I keep telling myself about our own thing. Cuts both ways."

* * *

Sanjay found him at his desk on a Saturday, going through Owen's old case logs one more time.

"You're not going to find something new in there."

"I know."

"Then what are you doing?"

Daniel closed the laptop. "Making sure I actually feel as bad about it as I should, instead of just telling people I do."

"That's the reason I took this job over three interviews where nobody asked what I actually knew how to do." Sanjay pulled out the chair across from him and set down two coffees. "You know what I keep coming back to, about Owen. Meridian never once did this. Nobody there carried a bad call around for six weeks. They just tuned a threshold and moved the headcount line and closed the ticket."

"That's not a compliment to us. That's a low bar we're clearing."

"It's still a bar somebody has to clear, and right now it's us. Concord called the main line an hour ago, for you specifically. They're renewing. Two-year term this time, not one."

Daniel didn't say anything for a second.

"Ferris wants one more thing added to the contract. Quarterly disclosure. Every miss, ours or the model's, in writing."

"That's not a downside. That's the whole company."

He texted Mara that night. *Concord renewed. Two years.*

Her reply came back inside a minute. *Told you the money and the idea were separate questions. Sounds like the idea's finally answering for itself. Proud of you. Don't let it go to your head, I still think the name sounds like a plumbing company.*

He typed back *duly noted* and meant something closer to *thank you* than the words said.

Tuesday he called Elena at eleven, the standing slot they had kept since the winter. He did not tell her about Owen. He told her Concord had renewed, and that the name still sounded like a plumbing company, and she spent forty seconds cutting a sentence he hadn't asked her to cut. He kept the slot.

Chapter 13: Starting Over

"Any leads since last month?" Pam asked, not looking up from the screen, the question itself worn smooth from repetition.

The caseworker at the unemployment office was a tired, decent woman. She'd had this conversation with half the county and hadn't yet let it make her cruel, which Janelle had come to respect more than she'd expected to.

"Coleman called me back personally. Didn't have anything."

Ray had cut two positions at Kessler Machine in November and one of them was hers. Four months of looking for work in Millbrook, Ohio had boiled down to a folder on the kitchen table: a printout for every place she'd called, every application filed through the state's unemployment portal to keep her benefit current, every rejection worded just kindly enough that she couldn't tell anymore whether the kindness was for her or for whoever might have to defend the wording later.

Coleman Tool and Die had let two machinists go in January. Same reason as her, different vendor, same word, *retooling*, dressed up in the same careful language Ray had used. There was apparently only one way to say it. Everybody running a small shop in this county had learned it from the same accountant, or the same software, or the same fear.

Coleman's floor manager had actually called her back personally, which counted, this year, as a kindness in its own right. His name was Deacon; she'd known him slightly for a decade. He apologized down the phone line like he was the one who'd written the software that did it. CAM, everybody called it: the kind that takes a drawing and decides on its own how the part gets cut and in what order. In truth, he was just the one stuck holding a headcount spreadsheet somebody else had built it for.

"You're the most qualified person who's applied since January," he'd said. "I want you to hear that part before you hear the rest of it." The rest of it had been exactly what she'd expected. She'd thanked him for the call and meant it. She hung up and sat in her kitchen longer than the news needed. She'd already lived through this exact conversation once, from the other chair.

She kept the coffee can in the closet and didn't touch it. She kept the thirty dollars going into her wallet on Fridays out of a paycheck that wasn't a paycheck anymore. Unemployment, close enough in the number if not the feeling. Habits didn't know the difference between earned money and money the state gave you for not having a job yet.

Marisol texted every couple of weeks, careful, guilty in a way Janelle had told her four separate times she didn't need to be. The vision system had a new firmware update. Purnell had finally let somebody digitize the old Bridgeport's quirks. Ray still hadn't hired anyone to fill either of the two positions. Janelle didn't need to be told what that meant. Warren's trust had capped how many people Kessler could keep. The number had done exactly what it was written to do, and there simply wasn't a seat left on the chart for what she used to do.

The radio, on the drive over, had been running a segment about a stretch of interstate outside Columbus where delivery trucks now drove themselves the whole route. No cab, no driver, nine percent of the state's freight and climbing. Janelle had listened with the weary curiosity of a woman reading about a country she technically lived in but hadn't been issued a ticket to visit.

Route 9 still ran the way it always had. The trucks that came through Millbrook still had a person in the cab, mostly because there wasn't enough freight left moving through Millbrook to be worth automating. She understood, once she worked it through, that this was its own kind of bad news dressed up as a small mercy.

The office had the overworked hum of a place built for a caseload from a smaller, better year. Three windows, two staffed, a waiting room with more chairs than usual and most of them full. A man two chairs down had been explaining to the woman next to him that the math thing on the news had broken bitcoin. Primes were the whole lock, he said, and somebody's computer had just proved the primes. Janelle had thirty dollars a week of it in the coffee can in her closet and no way on earth to check whether he was right, so she carried it around for two days. Then the story slid off the news. The price had dropped for two days and then it was back where it started, and she understood she had spent those two days frightened of a sentence a stranger had gotten wrong. Nobody was going to drive out to Millbrook and tell her which of the things on the news were true.

"That's more than most people get." Pam finally looked up. "There's a retraining credit you qualify for," she said, sliding a printed sheet across the desk. "CNC's oversubscribed. Everybody who ever ran a machine in this county is trying to get more certified on machines. Nobody's hiring juniors, though. Not worth the training cost. AI already does what a new person can do. What still pays wants people who've already made the hard calls. There's a newer category for that. Remote review work. Companies paying real money for people who can look at something a computer flagged and say whether the computer's actually right."

"Companies like who?"

Pam turned the sheet around. Janelle recognized the name before Pam finished pointing at it. *Backstop*, the same word that had sat in a text message on her phone since November.

"I've heard of them," she said, which was true, and left out the rest of it.

* * *

She almost didn't apply. She left the application open on her laptop for three days.

She filled it out the way she'd have filled out any other one: eleven years at Kessler Machine, tolerancing and setup work, *job eliminated by CAM automation, see attached*. She did not mention Daniel's name. She sent it.

The interview came four days later, over video, with a man named Sanjay who had the unhurried attentiveness of someone who'd read her resume twice before the call instead of skimming it once during it.

"Eleven years running your own tolerances," he said. "Tell me about the worst call you ever made that turned out to be right."

She told him about the boring bar, and the harmonic problem TruePath had later solved in an afternoon that had taken her two days the old way. He nodded like the story was doing exactly what he'd hoped it would do.

"That's the job," he said. "Not knowing the answer faster. Knowing when the fast answer's wrong even when it looks clean."

"Sounds like you already know the job better than I could describe it back to you."

"I got taught it the same way you did. Different floor, same lesson." He made a note of something, unhurried. "What's your comfort level with cases outside manufacturing? Most of what you'd see here isn't machine parts. It's insurance denials, staffing decisions, a credit model that flagged somebody's account for no good reason. Different domain, same question every time. Is the confident answer actually the right one?"

"I don't think the domain's the hard part. Same question every time. Is the confident answer actually right?"

"There's one more thing. The cases are timed. A prior-authorization hold is an insurer stalling a treatment until a person says the computer got it right. A routing flag. A paycheck frozen because a fraud model got nervous. The model already decided. You're the wait the client is paying for, and the only reason the wait is honest. Some people find they hate being the bottleneck on something that can't wait."

"I spent eleven years being the wait on a mill while the floor stood there. I know what waiting on me costs."

He glanced down at something off-screen, then back up. Something in his face changed before he said anything. "Millbrook, Ohio. Kessler Machine."

"That's right."

"That's Daniel's father's shop."

"That's right," she said again, even now this time. She'd known this moment was coming from the second she'd typed the address into the form. She had decided, days ago, exactly how she wanted to sound when it arrived. "I didn't put that on the application because I didn't want it to be why you called me back."

Sanjay was quiet for a second. "For what it's worth, I didn't know your name when I pulled your resume. The system flagged you on the merits. I only just put the rest of it together looking at the address." He said it plainly, not performing reassurance, which was the only version of it she'd have believed anyway.

"Does it bother you, working somewhere with his name on it, even if it's not actually his name on the door?"

"No," she said. "I'd rather it be this than nothing. His father gave me something I never asked for. This is closer to a thing I earned."

* * *

The offer came two days later, over email, with a start date and a number that wasn't extravagant and wasn't an insult either. Janelle read it twice at her kitchen table, the folder of rejections sitting closed beside the laptop.

Daniel called that night.

"Sanjay told me. I want to say up front, I didn't ask him to look at your application. I didn't know it was in the pipeline until it already wasn't anymore."

"I know. He told me the same thing. I believe both of you."

"You don't have to take it, if it feels like..."

"Daniel." She let a beat pass. "I'm not taking a favor. I'm taking a job I'm good at. It doesn't have to be more than that."

"Okay." She could hear something ease in him. "For what it's worth, I'm glad it's you. Not because of the estate. Because you're actually good at this, and we need people who are."

"How's the company doing, actually?"

"Eleven people now. A near-miss in February that scared me enough to fix something that needed fixing. Growing faster than I know how to feel about most days."

"Real's what I'm looking for. I've had enough of the other kind this year."

She told Angie before she told anyone else, sitting on the same front step they'd sat on since they were kids. Angie asked the practical questions first. *Does it pay enough, is it steady, can they fire you the same way in six months?* Janelle gave her the practical answers.

"You sound different than you have since November," Angie said.

"They told me what eleven years was worth before they knew it was Warren's shop. I needed that order."

Angie squeezed her hand once, hard. They sat there a while longer, in no hurry to go back inside.

Chapter 14: The Position, Working

The reserve announcement broke at 6 a.m. Chicago time. Brazil had voted, overnight, to add bitcoin to its sovereign reserves outright.

Small, dollarized economies had been doing versions of this for most of a decade. The US had its own strategic reserve built out of DOJ seizures nobody in Washington had bothered selling. China kept something similar and never talked about it. None of that was really a reserve in the sense the term meant on a central bank's own books. It was a drawer nobody had decided what to do with.

Brazil wasn't inheriting anything from a seizure. Brazil was going to buy the thing outright, on purpose, with a line item a finance minister would have to defend in front of an actual legislature, the way anyone defended a real reserve asset.

That was what moved the market: not a country holding bitcoin, but a G20 economy deciding to count it the way it counted gold. The price stepped, a clean jump of fourteen percent.

There was still a bill sitting in committee in 2029 that wanted to revalue the gold in Fort Knox and spend the difference on more bitcoin outright, balance-sheet neutral, no new debt issued. Nobody thought it moved this year. Mara thought that whenever it did move, that would be the actual headline. Washington moving would be the reserve currency itself admitting the same thing.

Her desk, the research AI Halcyon issued every book, had already drafted three position notes before she'd finished her tea. She skimmed the first, corrected a number from a stale feed. It was getting better than she was at the first pass.

She texted Devon.

Saw it, he wrote back. Give it an hour before you do anything you'll want a good excuse for later.

She gave it the hour. At 7:04 she called him properly. By 7:20 she'd turned two years of grinding appreciation into something that finally looked like the number she'd been telling people about at dinner parties before any of them had wanted to hear it.

She didn't add new debt so much as let the loan restructure itself around what the collateral was now worth. Same forty percent, against a position that had roughly doubled. Same ratio. Bigger number underneath it.

"You're aware you just added more actual dollars of exposure this morning than your father's entire estate was worth two years ago."

"I'm aware. I did the arithmetic before I called you."

* * *

Daniel called that afternoon.

"The house sold. Closing's in three weeks. Which means somebody has to actually go clear Dad's office before then."

"Saturday. I can fly in. You're two hours closer."

"While I have you, how's the runway?"

"Twenty people now. The problem isn't hiring. Clients want money sitting behind a bad call, a guarantee, not another reviewer. That's a different kind of capital than a round."

She heard insurance, not collateral. She took it as her brother talking around an equity ask he wasn't ready to make.

"You'll get a fair term sheet like everybody else, not a favor."

"I'm not asking for a favor. I'm asking you to pick up the phone when I call. Saturday. Bring something you don't mind getting dusty."

* * *

Her car drove itself the whole way from the airport. She let it take the long way past Kessler Machine before telling it where she actually wanted to go. The lot had four fewer cars in it than she remembered from the funeral. Ray's truck was still in the same spot.

The house looked smaller than she remembered. The FOR SALE sign was already down, replaced by SOLD in red faded to pink.

The office hadn't been touched since the will reading. The desk. The drawer. The laptop, exactly where Carol Weiss had said it would be.

Above the desk, pinned where it had been pinned since before either of them could read, a strip of paper gone the color of weak tea. *To err is human, but to really foul things up you need a computer.* Warren had brought it home off the shop office wall in some year nobody remembered, and had never known who said it first. A newspaperman, he'd guessed once. Or an almanac.

Daniel took it down without being asked and put it in his shirt pocket.

"We could still call someone."

"We're already here." Daniel sat down in their father's chair and pulled the laptop toward him. "Password's the actual problem."

It was Mara, going through the shelf, who found it. A spiral-bound tolerance logbook, decades old. Taped inside the front cover, in pencil: a string of characters that meant nothing on its own and everything once she held it up.

"Of course it's in a logbook."

It worked on the first try.

* * *

There wasn't much on the drive. Tax documents, scanned invoices. And then, filed under a name that gave away nothing, a text document clearly added to for years: dated entries, terse.

Some of it was the crypto correspondence they'd half expected. A friend named Russ, arguing about wallets and forks across a decade.

Then Daniel went quiet over an entry about Ray. *The day only one man in the shop can run it is the day the shop is one bad Tuesday from closing. Doesn't matter how good the one man is.*

Mara was three entries further down, at one with Janelle's name in it.

March. Had a letter of intent on the desk. Buyer out of Columbus, cash, enough to walk away clean while the divorce was still eating everything. Thought the shop was already gone. Same feeling as 2008, only this time I was the one selling it. D. found the real numbers. What we still cleared. What five more years looked like if I didn't panic. Put them in front of me and never once said don't sell. Never told Ray. Never told the kids. Tore the letter up that night. Put a note in the trust file. Whatever else happens to this place, she gets taken care of.

Mara read it twice. The sentence at the will reading, *one favor she is under no obligation to remember*, had never been coy. It had been literal. Janelle had genuinely, probably, mostly forgotten it.

"There's one about Janelle," she said.

Daniel read it slowly. "She stopped him selling the shop."

"And he never told her he knew."

Near the bottom, an entry from 2018, the year bitcoin had lost most of its value.

Talked to Russ tonight about pulling all of it out. Told him I would. Didn't. Don't know if that's discipline or just not having anywhere else I'd rather put it. Going to bed.

Then, shorter: *Still here. Glad, mostly.*

"He almost sold the coins too."

"Everybody almost sold that year."

She closed the laptop. They had read as much of a dead man as either of them could stand.

* * *

They didn't talk much on the ride back toward the airport. The car's dashboard surfaced a segment about a commercial reactor outside Oak Ridge that had crossed net energy gain, the same containment approach a research system had sketched out two years ago in nine unsupervised days.

"You're doing the math thing," Mara said. "The one where you go quiet."

"I'm thinking about how many good headlines we're actually going to get out of this, against how many of the other kind."

"That's called being an adult, Daniel."

At her gate, she called Devon. "I want to move another twenty percent into the position before Monday."

A pause long enough that she checked whether the call had dropped.

"That's not the same conversation as this morning. This morning was the market handing you a reason. This sounds like you handing yourself one."

"Does it matter which, if the number's the same either way?"

"It always matters which. It just doesn't matter to the collateral." Keys clicked. "I'll send it tonight."

She sat for a while in a plastic airport chair. If this bet went the other way, she ended up back in Millbrook. Not visiting. Living there.

She flew home. By the time the plane's wheels touched down, Devon's confirmation email was already sitting in her inbox.

Chapter 15: Still a Believer

"You've seen the memo," Deb said, appearing at Victor's cubicle the way she always appeared, without any of the throat-clearing other managers used.

"I've seen a chart. Nobody's sent me a memo yet."

The dashboard had a new color on it, a pale amber wedge in the corner pie chart that hadn't existed in any training material he'd ever sat through: HOUSEHOLD RISK INDICATOR - ELEVATED REGION. Underneath it, in the smaller font the Bureau used for things it wanted read but not dwelt on, a single line: *Flag volume up 340% month-over-month, correlated with regional layoff announcements.*

Victor had been at the Bureau eight years. He had never seen a color get added to that chart before this year. He had seen categories quietly retired, merged, renamed into something less alarming. Never the opposite.

His personal brief, the same class of assistant half the floor now kept open beside the official dashboard, had already summarized the amber wedge, ranked three plausible task-force compositions, and drafted a reply to Deb he hadn't asked for. He closed it without reading the reply. The discomfort was small and specific: the second brain on his desk was the same species as the thing he regulated.

"You will by ten." She leaned against the partition, arms crossed, in the posture she used for conversations she'd rather not be having standing up. "Three plants in the Midwest went to skeleton crews inside a month. Two more announced this week. People who just lost a paycheck are exactly the people a certain kind of scam artist has always gone looking for.

"Fake relief funds. Fake retraining grants. A convincing-looking nonprofit that's actually somebody's cousin's shell account. We're standing up a task force. I want you on it."

"Why me specifically?"

"Because you're good at telling the difference between somebody trying to help and somebody trying to take." She paused, and something in her face did the thing it did when she was about to say a sentence she'd already rehearsed.

"Also because of your mother. I'd rather have somebody who feels it than somebody who's only ever read a case file."

He said yes. It was the same decision he made most Mondays, just wearing a bigger uniform.

The unrest itself, when he let himself actually watch the footage instead of just reading the summary above it, was smaller and sadder than the word suggested. Not the burning-city footage from a decade of other countries' news cycles. Mostly just people standing in parking lots outside plants that weren't hiring anyone back, holding signs somebody had clearly made in a hurry, blocking a road until a municipal drone told them, in a voice recorded once and reused everywhere, that the gathering was unpermitted.

Nobody in the footage looked dangerous. Everybody looked like they'd run out of other ideas.

* * *

The task force turned out to be four analysts and a shared folder, which was smaller than the word *task force* had led him to expect. The model doing the actual flagging was new, trained fast, tuned aggressive on purpose. Better to over-flag and let a human sort it out than let real fraud through while everyone was still calibrating.

Victor's queue, by Wednesday, had gone from eleven cases a day to forty. The ratio of real problems to ordinary people doing an ordinary generous thing had not changed at all.

A woman named Alicia Byun had set up a fund for seven former coworkers from a shuttered auto-parts plant outside Toledo, three weeks' rent apiece, transparent, itemized, exactly the kind of thing a decent person organized because nobody else was going to. The model had flagged it for "rapid disbursement to unverified recipients, pattern consistent with structured fraud." Victor cleared it in four minutes. A payroll list from the plant itself matched every name.

He thought four minutes was the fast version of this job, the version where the human still got there in time. He didn't know how many of the other thirty-nine cases had waited longer. He knew, because he'd done the math on his own hours

against the corner chart, that the answer for the Bureau as a whole was not four minutes.

Case thirty-one that same afternoon was the other kind, the kind the task force had actually been stood up to catch. Four different relief funds, different names, different plant towns, different stock photos of different exhausted men, all routing two layers down to the same beneficiary account. The pattern would have taken a person a week to notice by hand. The model had taken six seconds.

Victor read it three times before he let himself believe it. He'd gotten so used to reading a flag as a mistake waiting to be found that a true one, when it actually showed up, felt like it needed extra checking just to be trusted.

There wasn't a mistake in it. He wrote up the pattern, attached the four pages and the shared account number, and routed it to Financial Crimes. Not his own desk, not once it stopped being merely suspicious and became confirmed.

Somebody in a different building with actual subpoena power would take it from there. His part ended with a case number and a timestamp. It felt almost like relief. One confirmed catch, out of a week's worth of wrongful freezes, proof the apparatus wasn't only ever wrong in the same direction.

He thought, clearing case after case, of a sentence he'd said once: *a model that's right ninety-nine times out of a hundred is, at scale, wrong for millions of people a year, and somebody has to be the one who looks at the hundredth case.*

Somewhere past case twenty that Wednesday, doing the arithmetic on his own queue against the queue backing up behind Marcus's name on the shared board, Victor understood for the first time that the sentence had a second half he hadn't said out loud: *and if the hundredth cases come in faster than there are people to read them, promising somebody will look is a promise nobody can keep.*

* * *

The clearance paperwork for the task force came with a form he hadn't seen before: HOUSEHOLD CONFLICT AFFIRMATION. It asked him to reconfirm, in writing, that no member of his own household currently had an open flag.

He thought of Rosa's file before he'd finished reading the sentence. *Related party, disclosed*. Still there, two years later, exactly where Deb had filed it the day he'd walked it down the hall.

"It's not a problem," Deb said, when he brought it to her instead of just signing it, because he'd learned a long time ago that the version of honesty that protected him was the version that happened before anyone asked. "Her file's clean. Recert went through fine last cycle. I checked before I put your name forward. Didn't want you finding out during onboarding that there was a wrinkle."

"You checked my mother's benefit file before you put me on this."

"I checked whether putting you on this would create a problem for you. There's a difference." She said it plainly, and Victor believed her. He was aware, believing her, of how much easier it was to believe a kindness when the kindness also happened to keep him exactly where the Bureau needed him to be.

"That file being clean is part of why I trust you on this. I fought for you over two more senior names."

He signed the form. Walking back to his desk, he told himself there was a real difference between being trusted because of what could go wrong for his mother and being controlled by it. He wanted that to be true. He just wasn't sure anymore that wanting it was the same thing as it being so.

* * *

Rosa called that evening, which by now had stopped being unusual. She called most evenings, since the recert scare two years back, a habit neither of them had named but both of them kept.

"They're saying things on the news about the protests getting bigger. Ohio, factory towns." Her voice had the careful lightness of a woman trying not to sound as worried as she was. "You're not near any of that."

"I'm not near any of that, Ma. I sit at a desk." He didn't tell her the queue had four times as many names in it as a month ago. A fair number of those names belonged to people whose situation looked, on paper, close enough to hers that he sometimes

had to sit for a second before opening the file. "How's the new prescription? Pharmacy give you any trouble?"

"No trouble. You ask me that every time."

"I like hearing no trouble."

They hung up the way they always did.

* * *

He caught the fusion story on the break-room television two days later and stood there through the whole segment. It ran under a ticker carrying its usual rotation.

A ceasefire line somewhere in the Middle East holding for now, or not. A war in Ukraine so far past whichever anniversary people had stopped counting that the ticker just called it *the front*. Europe's digital euro live in every member state: government money the government could freeze by category, cash treated as suspicious. Mining concessions in the Kesengo Corridor that the anchors were calling, carefully, a proxy conflict now. A government holding the rare-earth ground with Western security contractors. An insurgency across the ridge line supplied by Beijing-linked interests.

Neither government had used the word *war* about any of it, in so many words. Victor had come to understand, from two years of reading agency memoranda for exactly this kind of careful non-word, that they were all already treating it like one. Somebody else's war. He kept watching.

The reactor outside Oak Ridge was still on the loop a week after it broke, the first commercial plant to make more energy than it cost, on a containment design a research system had drawn up in nine unsupervised days. The anchor said people were already talking about desalination and farm calories, not just electricity. Too early for any of that. The reactor had only just crossed zero. But the anchor sounded almost surprised to be reporting something unambiguously good, and Victor guessed that was why the network hadn't let the story go yet.

Marcus came in behind him, looked up at the screen, and said, "Huh. A nice one, for once," in the tone of a man who'd learned to treat good news as a category that needed noting when it showed up.

"Enjoy it. We'll be back to the other kind by lunch."

"Devouring my optimism early today, I see."

"I've got forty cases and a form that made me look up my own mother's file. Optimism's rationed."

There was a woman on the screen a moment later, testifying in front of a Senate subcommittee about something called a safety treaty, coordinated frontier-lab audits. Her name flashed underneath: **Dr. Miriam Voss.**

Victor didn't know who she was. He knew, watching her answer a hostile question without raising her voice, that he recognized the specific competence of someone who had spent a career being the only adult in a series of rooms that badly needed one. He went back to his desk when the segment ended.

* * *

He didn't text Daniel that week either, though the thought crossed his mind twice. Once reading a case that reminded him of exactly the sentence he'd once tried to say to Daniel and deleted. Once just from tiredness, the kind that made an old friend's name feel like the only conversation left that wouldn't cost him anything.

The draft was still sitting where it had been for two years, unsent, *hey, saw something, you good?*, a sentence that had gotten less true and more true at the same time the longer he left it alone.

He cleared his last case a little after seven, a fund for a laid-off warehouse crew two towns over from Rosa's, legitimate, itemized, cleared in six minutes. He did not send the draft.

Chapter 16: The Long Middle

The cap took eleven minutes to seat properly. Elena had stopped minding somewhere around minute four of the first several hundred times.

Priya worked the array in from the back first, then the sides, checking impedance on each channel. The whole rig was, in clinical shorthand, a BCI, the hardware that had become more of her voice than her larynx.

Elena's job consisted of sitting still and being a body someone else's hands were working on. A job she had gotten very good at without ever once feeling like she'd chosen it.

"Channel eleven's drifted again," Priya said. "You want the good news or the other good news? Because there isn't a bad one today."

Elena composed the answer the way she composed everything now: attention first, a specific narrowing of intention toward the part of her that had once reached for a coffee mug. Now it reached, instead, for a cursor on a screen bolted to her wheelchair's arm.

The words assembled letter by letter, slower than speech, faster than three years ago. On good mornings the decode also offered a cleaner phrasing before she committed, a collaboration she accepted or refused the way she used to accept or refuse an editor's suggestion. The voice stayed hers. The help was optional, and she kept it that way.

Good news first. I like to know what I'm bracing for.

"Anchorwell got bought."

* * *

It wasn't quite bought, Priya explained. Absorbed into a company called Axiom Systems. Elena had heard of it the way everyone had heard of it. She couldn't have named a single thing it actually made beyond an impression of largeness.

Axiom ran compute. A meaningful fraction of the planet's serious AI research now happened on hardware that belonged, at some layer down, to a company most people encountered only as the invisible thing making somebody else's product fast.

What happens to the study.

"Funding gets better before it gets worse. They've already approved a second-generation array, faster decode, less setup time. Worse eventually, maybe, because a bigger machine wants everything it touches to justify its own size. 'Preserve one woman's ability to talk to her sister' doesn't scale the way 'a general-purpose neural interface platform' scales on an investor deck."

She said it plainly. "I don't know yet what happens to Appendix C specifically, the extra consent form, the one about copying a mind off a dying body instead of just helping them talk. Nobody's told me to stop offering it."

Elena had stopped opening the Appendix C folder regularly sometime in her second year of not signing it. The note she'd set for herself, *ask again in three months*, had become one of those notes a person keeps less because they intend to act on it and more because deleting it would mean admitting something.

The Axiom liaison called two weeks later. Elena noted that she used the phrase "continuity of care" four times in six minutes and never once used the word *dying*. She did not, when asked directly, have an answer about Appendix C's timeline.

* * *

The second-generation array actually arrived, six weeks later. The decode lag dropped by nearly a third the first week alone. A sentence that used to cost her a full minute now cost forty seconds. That did not sound, said out loud, like the kind of number that should have made her cry in front of Priya. It did anyway, briefly, before she typed *ignore that* and Priya, mercifully, did.

Whatever else Axiom wanted out of the thing it had bought, it had also, this once, simply made her faster. She was allowed to be grateful for that without deciding yet what she thought about the company doing the giving.

* * *

The actual middle of it, and this was undeniably the middle, past the part where every new symptom got its own small ceremony of grief, had turned out to be less dramatic than either the diagnosis or, presumably, the end would be. It was a schedule.

Cap on at eight. Feeding tube check at nine. A second aide, Colleen, arrived at eleven, cheerful in the unforced way of someone who had chosen this work rather than fallen into it.

Elena's hands had stopped being reliable for anything at all sometime in her second year. Not the sudden loss the first months had trained her to fear. More a long, uneven fading.

Her voice had gone the same direction, quieter each season until there wasn't a season left where it came out as anything but breath. She had grieved that specifically, once, properly, on the last Tuesday she'd been able to tell Daniel about her week in her own actual voice.

Then she had gotten up the next morning and put the cap on, because grief, it turned out, was also a schedule.

She still edited. That was the part she was, if she let herself be honest, proudest of preserving. A magazine piece a former colleague sent her twice a year. A grant application Priya's own postdoc asked her to look at. She marked it up at BCI speed, which meant a single paragraph of notes took most of an afternoon. She did not resent a minute of it.

Not every day earned that kind of description. Six weeks earlier, channel eleven had drifted mid-morning and kept drifting. For nineteen minutes, Elena had sat fully present, fully herself, and entirely unable to produce a single word anyone else could read.

Colleen had noticed something was wrong from her face and paged Priya. Priya had come at a run. The whole time Elena had been in there, awake, composing a sentence with nowhere at all to send it.

She had not talked about that afternoon with anyone since. Some days the middle of this was a schedule. Some days it was a locked room with the light on, and the only mercy was that it eventually opened again.

* * *

Daniel called Tuesday at eleven, same as he had for three years now.

Tell me the bad first, she typed, before he'd finished saying hello.

"Clients are pushing turnaround. They think the reviewer is the wait now, not the safety. I don't have a clean name for the scaling problem yet. I sent you a paragraph legal wants on the site. Second sentence reads like a lawyer wrote it because a lawyer wrote it."

Show me.

He read it to her, a paragraph about "confidence-calibrated escalation architecture delivering measurable risk mitigation across client verticals."

Cut "delivering measurable risk mitigation." Say what it does. "Catches the mistakes a model doesn't know it's making, before they reach a person." Twelve words. Anyone can hold twelve words in their head.

"That's better than anything the actual lawyer wrote. You know that took you a full minute to tell me, and it's still better than a paragraph he had three weeks for."

Twelve good words beat forty adequate ones.

"I missed this," Daniel said, and something in his voice dropped its guard. "Not the twelve words. You, doing the twelve words at me."

I know there's a difference. I'm the one who taught you the difference. Don't get used to it moving this fast. Some days it doesn't.

They talked another twenty minutes. A documentary Colleen had put on, a story about a crewed mission finally getting serious groundwork for a permanent lunar base. The kind of unambiguously hopeful headline that showed up rarely enough now that both of them noted it.

Elena thought, watching the letters assemble themselves at their own unhurried pace, that this was still, after everything, the best twenty minutes most of her weeks contained.

* * *

She opened the Appendix C folder again that night.

Continuity of recorded cognitive state beyond the interface's communicative function. Still unsigned.

She did not sign it. She did not delete the note reminding her to look again. Three months, same as always. She closed it the way you'd close a door you weren't ready to walk through and weren't ready to nail shut.

Chapter 17: Reassignment

The notice came in the same flat, over-translated register as every other notice Wei had read since the move to the new building: *Congratulations on your selection for advancement to Tier Three research status*. It offered no mention of what Tier Three actually meant. Just a badge color and a wing of the building Wei had never had a reason to walk past.

His director delivered the news in person, which was itself a kind of tell. Good news traveled by email. The news that required watching your face traveled by a person sent specifically to watch it.

"You should be proud," the director said, in the tone of a man who had delivered this exact sentence to this exact kind of employee more than once. "Very few people get asked. It reflects well on your work, and on the department that trained you."

"What does the work involve?"

"You'll be briefed on-site, after the paperwork clears." A pause, the pause of a man choosing which true thing to hand over. "I can tell you it matters. I can tell you the institute is proud to be doing it here instead of somewhere slower. That's most of what I'm cleared to say myself."

Wei signed what he was given to sign, a longer document than the one he'd signed four years ago, denser, with a clause near the bottom requiring him to report, within forty-eight hours, any contact from a foreign national that touched on the substance of his work.

He read that sentence three times before he let himself keep going, because he had a person in his life that sentence was obviously, structurally aimed at. He was fairly sure the institute had no idea who Daniel was. He was equally sure that not knowing wasn't the same thing as it not mattering.

The Tier Three badge came with a desk assistant the institute issued and logged. Watched, he assumed. He used it for scheduling and literature pulls and nothing that touched Daniel's name. Friendship was not a query he was going to run through a machine that reported home.

There was a second signature line under a section titled *Family Notification and Household Disclosure*. It listed everyone he lived with by name and asked him to confirm, in writing, that they understood he could no longer discuss the specifics of his work. Not the project, not the building, not the names of anyone he worked alongside.

Lin's name was already typed in the field when the document arrived. That meant someone, somewhere, had already looked her up before Wei had said a word to her about any of it. That fact held his attention longer than anything else in the document. Then he signed it, because the alternative to signing it had never actually been presented as an alternative.

He was not only signing a secret. Tier Three was how you stayed in the district school that still had a seat, and on the housing list the institute ran. The NDA was the smaller document.

* * *

The new wing had its own cafeteria, better than the one Wei had described to Daniel as merely "bigger," and its own badge readers, and its own quiet. Not silence, exactly. More the hush of a building full of people who had each individually decided to stop asking each other what they were working on.

Fourteen people at the orientation had known each other from somewhere before this room. Nobody said so. Nobody introduced themselves by their previous project. Nobody asked.

Wei's own project, once he was finally briefed on it, turned out to be exactly interesting enough to justify everything the paperwork had cost him: a training architecture two generations past anything he'd touched before, scaling faster than any system he'd helped build. The actual frontier instead of a respectable distance behind it.

He understood, sitting through the briefing, why the institute called this an honor and meant it. He also understood that the awe and the fact that he now knew slightly too much to sleep were going to have to share the same body.

His own doctorate had taken seven years and produced one narrow fact about a class of optimization problems that a few dozen people in the world had ever needed. He had been proud of it. He was still proud of it.

Two years ago a machine had proved the Riemann hypothesis, the problem every mathematician of his generation had been raised to think of as permanent. Two more of the famous ones had gone since, and the second had been a smaller story than the first. The one he had stopped to read properly was Yang-Mills, the missing existence proof for the field theory the whole standard model had been built on, which physicists had used for decades to predict experiments that came out right every time, with nothing rigorous underneath it. The proof arrived now. A foundation delivered to a building that had been occupied since before he was born, and the building had never once waited for it.

Nobody would spend seven years on a narrow fact again. There was no version of that apprenticeship left: you handed the system a class of problem and it came back with forty candidates the same afternoon. Wei did not think of this as a theft, and he did not think the beauty had gone out of it either. He had only noticed, sometime in the last two years, that the part of his training he had been proudest of was the part that was now free, and he did not yet know what that left him with.

The state media framing, when he caught it that same week on the train home, used a phrase that had been showing up more often lately: *The world's caution has become our opportunity.*

Western labs were throttled by their own governments' new safety accords, export controls, alignment review boards that could pause a training run for months. All of it was framed, on the state broadcast, not as prudence but as fear. The kind of fear a confident nation didn't need to indulge.

Wei had read the actual treaty text once, out of professional curiosity, through a workplace relay that logged the query. He would not open it again. It hadn't struck him as fear. It had struck him as people trying, imperfectly, to build a guardrail before the car reached the curve. He did not say this out loud to anyone, including himself, more than once.

* * *

He saw Han at the Tier Three elevator bank on his second week, badge already scanned, three people ahead of him in the line. Han had lost weight. He had the face of a man who slept in the building. Han's badge was blue, the same as Wei's new one, which told Wei more in half a second than four months of silence had told him.

Han saw him. Something crossed his face. Recognition, then something that closed over it almost as fast, a door shutting itself without a hand on it.

"Han."

"Wei." Han said it like a name he was required to say, polite, without the warmth two desks' worth of shared coffee runs should have earned. "Congratulations on the tier."

"You too, apparently." Wei kept his voice light. "I looked for you. Nobody would say where you'd gone."

"I'm sure they wouldn't." Han glanced at the badge reader, at the small clustered knot of people who were technically not listening and absolutely were. "It's a good building. Better cafeteria."

He said it with no irony at all, which was somehow worse than if he'd meant it as a joke. He stepped into the next car alone. The doors closed on whatever the rest of that sentence might have been, and Wei stood there a moment before he remembered he was also waiting for an elevator.

He did not tell Lin about it that night. He understood, not telling her, that he was doing the exact thing he'd once caught himself doing to Daniel, trimming an answer down before he'd consciously decided to.

Han was not gone. Han was not fired, not disappeared. Han had simply been promoted into the same quiet that was now Wei's own address. That was, in its way, a worse answer than the ones Wei had spent four months not letting himself imagine, because it meant the quiet didn't lose people. It absorbed them.

Lin noticed something at dinner that night, the way she noticed most things about him lately without saying so directly.

"You've been somewhere else since Tuesday," she said, not a question, sliding the rice toward him.

"New project. Still figuring it out."

"That's the sentence you used for the last one too." She said it lightly, not an accusation. "I signed a form with my own name on it last week that a courier brought to the door. Nobody's ever explained to me what I actually agreed to."

"You agreed that I won't tell you things, and that you'll be fine with that." He heard how it sounded the moment it left him, worse, spoken plainly, than it had looked typed into a form. "I'm sorry. It's not a good trade. I didn't design it."

"I know you didn't." She let it go there, the way she let most things go these days, filing it instead of fighting it. Then, as if it were the same form: "And he doesn't come here. You know that."

She meant Daniel. "I know."

Marriages absorbed things too, apparently. He was learning that from more than one direction lately.

* * *

Mei needed her school bag packed for a field trip the next morning, an errand Wei had claimed for himself specifically because it required nothing of him but his hands and his daughter's running commentary.

"Bao Yu says the museum has a real dinosaur, and I said no it doesn't, it has a *fake* dinosaur that's *shaped* like a real one, and he said that's the same thing and I said it is *not* the same thing. Baba, is it the same thing?"

"It is extremely not the same thing." He folded her rain jacket into the bag the way she liked it, rolled instead of flat, a preference she had held with total conviction since she was five and had never once explained.

Bao Yu's mother had put the boy on a private cognitive-prep waitlist that required a deposit equal to three months of Wei's old salary, brain training sold as a product, for families who could pay. Mei had absorbed that fact the way she absorbed museum arguments, as evidence the world had rules that did not apply evenly.

"A fake dinosaur that's shaped like a real one is called a model. A real dinosaur is called a fossil, and there aren't very many of those left. That's exactly why the museum uses a model."

"That's what I *said*." She said it with the satisfaction of a seven-year-old whose entire worldview had just been externally ratified. "Bao Yu is going to be so annoyed."

"Try not to enjoy that part too much."

"I'm going to enjoy it a normal amount." She zipped the bag herself, insisting. She looked up at him with the unbothered directness of a child who had not yet learned that a question could be dangerous. "Why do you look tired today?"

"Work was interesting today. Interesting is tiring sometimes."

"That's a weird kind of tired."

"It is," he agreed, and did not say anything else about it. She seemed satisfied with that the way she was satisfied with most of his non-answers these days. Still young enough to trust that a parent's silence meant *nothing important* rather than *something I can't hand you*.

He zipped the outer pocket for her, on principle, checking the water bottle was actually sealed this time.

The go board was still on the table from the night before. Wood. Two bowls of stones. Her black stones in a crooked line on the left.

"I packed," she said. "I get a game."

He sat. She put a stone in the corner he had left empty. He had been adding stones on the left. She hadn't. He lost the corner. He laughed.

"Again tomorrow," she said, and carried the bag to the door for morning.

He thought that this was the actual correct proportion of his day, a dinosaur argument and a lost corner against nine hours of a building that had eaten a friend's whole personality and called it an honor. He was under no illusion the ratio would hold much longer.

* * *

The traffic log came across his new terminal near the end of that same week, a routine anomaly report he'd been assigned to triage as part of his onboarding, mostly busywork meant to get him used to the tooling before the real work started.

Most of the flagged entries were nothing. Misconfigured caching, a partner lab's test environment pinging somewhere it shouldn't. One line further down listed an unfamiliar vendor name attached to an unusually large block of outbound compute requests, routed through commercial channels rather than the institute's own dedicated lines: **Axiom Systems**.

Wei had never heard of it. He wrote four words on the line and opened the next one. There were forty more entries in the queue and no version of this job where a name he didn't recognize got to slow him down.

* * *

Daniel called that Tuesday, same as always, and asked how the new building was. He'd remembered the word *building*, not *tier*, because Wei had never given him the second word to remember. "Bigger wing this time," Wei said. "Better badge. Same parking."

Daniel laughed at the joke about the parking and did not ask what the badge was. He had stopped filling the holes. He moved on to something about his own week, a client who wanted the reviewers faster and a queue that didn't sleep. Wei let him finish.

Chapter 18: The Reliability Cliff

The report landed on Daniel's desk on a Wednesday. Not a customer complaint. A state transportation board finding, public, already mirrored on three news sites before Meera, Backstop's general counsel, finished the first page.

A freight corridor outside Columbus, autumn of 2030, trucks that drove themselves. The onboard system had flagged uncertainty on a merge and sent the decision to a Backstop reviewer, exactly as the contract required. The human reviewer, Sanjay, on a night shift he should have handed off two hours earlier, waited four seconds past the model's recommended abort, then let the merge happen. The truck hit a panel van. Two people died. The board's language was careful and fatal: *the human layer introduced delay and confirmation bias inconsistent with the system's own higher-confidence path*. Put plainly: if no person had been in the loop, the truck would have stopped. The person was the mistake.

Daniel read it standing up. He read it again sitting down. Sanjay was already in the glass office with the door shut, face the color of old paper.

"I held," Sanjay said. "I thought I was being careful."

"I know."

"They're going to use my name."

"They're already using the company's. Yours is next."

Meera came in with the churn numbers. Seven clients had paused renewals before noon. Three competitors had posted overnight: fully automated oversight, better latency, no human in the path. One of them quoted Backstop's own founding line back at them with a strikethrough.

When the model isn't sure, a person decides.

Meera said, "We can fight the finding. The sampling stack still holds on paper."

"The finding isn't wrong," Daniel said. "That's the problem."

* * *

He asked Ellis that night, alone in the Round Rock kitchen with his laptop open the way Warren used to leave the shop office running. He already knew what he was going to sell. He had known it since Sanjay's face in the glass office: if the person was the mistake, stop selling the person. Sell money that stood behind the call and could not freeze, could not wait four seconds past a model's abort, could not introduce confirmation bias into a merge. Underwrite the miss. Let the judgment layer die.

Summary: reviewer error rate on the highest-stakes cases now exceeds the model's error rate working alone, third quarter in a row. Public finding will speed client exit. Recommended: do not defend a person in the loop as safer. On your own data, it is not.

"I already got that far," Daniel said. "Structure it. Collateral. Call conditions. What the money sits in so nobody can print their way out of a payout."

Escrow collateral against agent action above a stake threshold. Call conditions that freeze or seize when catastrophe fires. Bitcoin for reserves: liquid, neutral, auditable, scarce. Humans remain capital and liability anchors. They stop being the decision engine.

"That's ending the company."

That is renaming what the company already built. Payment rails. Verification. Trust that routes high-stakes action through an accountable third party. You have been selling a slower, worse version of the model. Sell the guarantee instead.

He read it through twice more, until the screen dimmed on its own. He did not let Ellis draft the board memo. He wrote the first sentence himself: *We were wrong about who belonged in the loop.*

* * *

Victor called two nights later, off-record, from a number that wasn't his desk.

"I'm not calling as the Bureau," Victor said. "I'm calling because a formal notice of inquiry is going to hit your registered agent next week, and if you reach out to me after it lands it will look like exactly what it is."

"Payment rails again."

"Volume patterns. Oversight claims. The Columbus finding didn't help you." A pause. "I'm recused. I walked it down the hall. I'm calling as the roommate who named a dead couch Gerald."

"Gerald still has the better resume."

"Rosa saw your company's name on a newscast about Columbus. She wanted to know if anybody was making sure you ate. I told her I hadn't talked to you since March."

"Tell her yes. Tell her Meera makes me eat."

"Daniel. Whatever you're about to rebuild, write it down clean. They're fishing, but the water's shallow now."

After Victor hung up, Wei called on his constrained schedule, different night, same week.

"Quick question. Does Backstop route any of its infrastructure through a company called Axiom Systems? Compute, hosting, anything."

"I'd have to have Meera ask. We rent from a provider, the provider rents from somebody else, and nobody has ever told me who's at the bottom of that." Daniel waited a moment. "Why? What's Axiom?"

"A name I hadn't heard of until it turned up in a place where I'd have expected to know every name. That's all I can say about where. What I want to know is whether it's ordinary. If you're buying hosting from them and you'd never heard of them, then they're plumbing and I stop thinking about it."

"And if it isn't ordinary?"

"Then it's a very large company that shows up where I work and nowhere else, and that's the last thing I can tell you about it. If you find out on your end, don't put it in a mail."

The line went dead the way Wei's lines always did. No goodbye, just the risk budget spent.

* * *

Sanjay stayed. He asked to move off the review queue into whatever came next. Daniel put him on reserve modeling with the ops team before the product had a name.

Janelle did not stay.

She packed the remote kit at her kitchen table in Millbrook on a Friday. Headset. Badge fob. The extra screen she'd bought when the queue got heavy. The fob already showed deactivated when she held it to the reader she'd never needed in this room except to prove she still worked there.

Sanjay called from Round Rock. Retraining, he said. Actuarial tracks. Bond pricing. His world now.

"You'd be good at the judgment parts of it," Daniel said, when he called an hour later. She had the box on the chair she used for the video days.

"That was the job." She looked at the dark fob. "I read the finding. They're not wrong."

"Janelle..."

"I'm staying in Millbrook. The garage still has Warren's machine. Hand-fit work. Things a person has to feel." She almost smiled, and it didn't hold. "Second time hurts worse. First time they automated the deciding. This time they wrote down that I was the mistake."

He did not pretend he could fix it. She did not ask him to.

That night he told Meera and Sanjay the name out loud for the first time, in the glass office with the Columbus report still open on the shared screen.

"Backstop Bond," he said. "We don't review the call. We underwrite what happens if it's wrong. Collateral in bitcoin. Kill conditions written before anyone is tired."

Meera set her cup down. "Say it the way a client will hear it."

"A freight company wants its routing system making calls with nobody signing each one. Before we allow that, they post bitcoin into escrow with us, an amount we set against how much damage the system is permitted to do. We write down in advance what counts as too far. If it goes there, the bond is called: its authority to act freezes the same minute, and if the harm actually landed, we seize the collateral and pay it to whoever it landed on. If none of that happens, they get the money back. We're not promising the machine is right. We're promising somebody's money is standing behind it being wrong."

"And who decides it went too far? Us, at nine in the morning, after the phones start?"

"Nobody decides. That's the whole product." He turned the screen so she could see the draft. "The escrow isn't an account we hold, it's a program, and it holds the coin itself. The bitcoin ledger doesn't run programs. It moves coin and keeps the record and that's deliberately all it does, which is why it's still standing. So the conditions live in a contract on a programmable chain, published before the system is ever switched on, and every move that contract makes settles down onto bitcoin, where nobody can reverse it. Anyone can read the conditions. Anyone can verify the collateral is really sitting there. Nobody at this company can move it. When a condition trips, the program does what it says it will do, at three in the morning, with all of us asleep and the client's lawyer screaming. It cannot be talked to."

Meera nodded once, already listing statutes. Sanjay looked at the report, then at Daniel, and said, "Then the next time someone freezes, it costs money we posted on purpose. Not two people in a van."

"Both," Daniel said. "It will still cost both. We're just done pretending a tired person is safer than the model."

He did not sleep. In the morning he sent Elena a Tuesday note a day early, nothing about Columbus, only that he was rebuilding something and it would sound like a plumbing company again for a while, and she wrote back four words: *Tell me when it holds.*

Chapter 19: Euphoria

Mara watched the number climb from her kitchen counter, the same counter, the same mug of tea going cold. Argentina's congress had voted a little after eight that evening. After a year and a half of currency crisis they had declared bitcoin legal tender alongside the peso, wages and taxes and contracts all payable either way.

Her forty-five inherited bitcoin, untouched in coin count since the will, were worth just under thirty-eight million dollars at eight hundred thirty-eight thousand each.

She'd borrowed against them once in 2027, a conservative one-and-a-half-times bet Devon had talked her through. It would have needed the price to fall sixty percent before anyone touched her collateral. She'd let the loan grow with the collateral in 2029, same ratio, bigger base. Since then she'd pushed the ratio itself higher twice more.

The account Devon's desk carried for her now sat at just over seventy-five million dollars, roughly twice what the coins alone were worth, nearly seven times what their father's entire estate had been appraised at the week Carol Weiss read the will.

Argentina was a G20 economy with a real central bank. When a country that size did it, nobody could call it a curiosity anymore.

The market didn't step this time. It ran. She felt something she recognized as disappointment at how little the feeling had left to surprise her with.

She texted Devon anyway.

Saw it, he wrote back. You want the hour again, or are we past that part.

We're past that part.

Give me twenty minutes. I want the actual liquidation math in front of me before I say yes to anything.

When he called back, it wasn't the dry voice she remembered from Brazil. It was flatter, a man reading figures off a screen he didn't like the look of.

"Tell me the actual number. Out loud."

"Seventy-five million dollars. A little over."

"Say the leverage, too."

"Two times, roughly."

"At one-and-a-half times, you needed the price to fall sixty percent before I'd ever call you about margin. At two times, it's thirty. That's not a small difference. That's most of your cushion."

"I heard the number, Devon."

"Then hear the rest of it. Every cycle falls less than the one before. The crashes I started out watching took seventy, eighty percent off the top; the last one barely got past thirty. And it's true, the asset's too big now to move the way it used to. I believe it. So does every client I have, which is why every one of them is levered the way you are. Three years ago it gave back a third of itself between the '28 top and the spring you rolled the loan bigger. At one-and-a-half times that was nothing to you. At two times I'd have sold you out of it."

She thought of a sentence her father had written to a man named Russ a decade before any of this: *the money that scares you into a bad decision isn't money, it's a leash.*

"Noted," she told Devon. "I'm not doing anything different tonight."

"I know you're not. I'm calling so that when the drop comes and it doesn't look like much, you remember I said thirty percent."

* * *

Farid wanted her in his office by nine the next morning. He had the Argentina story up on one screen and a slide deck open on another.

"The partners want a real recommendation. What percentage of a client's portfolio should actually be in bitcoin, at what risk tolerance? We've run a two-paragraph disclaimer since I got here. After last night that's not going to hold up as policy anymore. They want a real memo by Thursday. They want your name on the first draft."

"My name."

"You've been the one saying it."

He didn't apologize for the jokes at those reviews, but something in his face acknowledged they had aged badly.

She should have felt something bright about this, three years of being the correct one in a room that hadn't wanted her to be. Instead she felt the same thin flatness from the night before. Being right too early had been the wound. Being right on schedule didn't heal it so much as make it harder to point at.

"I'll have a draft Thursday," she said.

"Whatever you're personally carrying in this space, keep the disclosure current. I don't need to know the size. I need the paperwork to already exist."

"It's current," she said.

* * *

The Fort Knox bill she'd been half-tracking since the spring finally cleared committee that same week. Congress voted to revalue the gold sitting on the Treasury's books, carried at forty-two dollars an ounce since Nixon. Gold traded that week at over nine thousand. Congress marked the difference to market and routed the room it opened up, without issuing a dollar of new debt, into buying bitcoin for the strategic reserve.

The reserve itself had been sitting there since 2026, seized coins the Justice Department had never gotten around to auctioning, parked on the books and defended by nobody. This was the first time the government had voted to actually buy any. Two years after Brazil, which was the only reason the bill had the votes at all.

Nobody outside three financial trade publications ran it as a headline. Mara thought this was the actual story and Argentina was the spectacle.

Then she opened a blank document for Thursday's memo. The desk AI offered a draft in under a minute, clean, cited. She read it once, closed it, and wrote her own from the top. She trusted it with the numbers. She did not yet trust it with the

sentence that would have her name on it.

Inflation hadn't really gone anywhere since the mid-2020s. The Fed kept announcing it was fighting the thing, and kept being right about that in exactly the sense a man announcing he's fighting the tide is right.

It could, in principle, raise rates high enough to actually kill inflation. It could not do it at the debt-to-GDP level the country had been carrying without turning the interest on the debt into a second, faster fire.

A system built this way could survive inflation indefinitely. What it could not survive was real deflation, prices falling, because falling prices made every dollar of that debt heavier.

So a crash, whenever one came, would never be allowed to finish being a crash. It would get printed away, every time. That was the actual bet underneath her own bet, the sentence she'd never said out loud because spoken aloud it sounded less like a thesis than a prophecy.

She texted Daniel that night.

Saw Argentina. Assume you did too.

Saw it. How's the capital conversation.

Closer to just next year now. When it happens, you're still first call.

Don't let Sanjay get too far ahead of himself. Currencies still have bad months.

Look at you, being the responsible one.

Don't get used to it.

* * *

Daniel called Thursday morning before the markets opened.

"Quick update. Backstop Bond went live yesterday. We don't review calls anymore. We make the company post bitcoin in escrow before a system is allowed to act unsupervised. If it does harm, the money pays the people it landed on. The pivot's done."

"Bond. Not review."

"Not review. We underwrite the call now. It's live."

She thought about that. Her brother's company, rebuilt, now holding bitcoin as reserves. Collateral. Not a bet. The opposite of what she'd done to the same coins.

"Congratulations," she said. "A year and change to pivot the whole thesis. That's real."

"Had to." He paused. "I'm not calling about capital. The premiums fund the reserves. I don't need a round."

"We'll see what my seat looks like next year," she said, and meant it as generously as she could. "Glad it's live."

She hung up.

* * *

That night the number on her screen was still climbing. Devon's thirty percent was underneath it, the distance between her and a call she didn't want to get.

Chapter 20: The Unwind

The first crewed lunar landing in sixty years happened on a Monday in the spring of 2032. For about thirty-six hours it was the only story anyone could hold in their head at once.

Mara watched the feed standing at her kitchen counter. Four people in white suits crossed grey dust no human being had touched since 1972. She left for the office twenty minutes late.

By Wednesday morning the headline was gone.

Congress had failed, overnight, to pass the borrowing authority that kept the federal government's own payments moving. Treasury payments seized in stages. Rating agencies moved before the markets opened in New York.

By the time Mara reached Halcyon's floor, the Moon feed had been pushed to a sidebar.

She texted Devon before the open.

Watching?

Watching. Don't do anything. Give the open an hour.

The open didn't stop at an hour. Equities went first, then real estate names. Bitcoin moved with them, not first, not alone, just in the same violent, indiscriminate company as everything else people had borrowed against.

By lunch it was down eleven percent from Monday's close. Two regional banks had halted withdrawals for "operational review."

By the close bitcoin was down nineteen percent. Devon called at 4:07.

"Say the number out loud."

"Six hundred seventy-nine thousand."

"And the cushion."

"Thirteen percent left before you call me about margin."

"Ridgeline put out a statement twenty minutes ago. They're 'reviewing covenant compliance.' That's the sentence a treasury company writes when it's about to sell the thing its entire balance sheet is made of. If they dump into this, your thirteen percent becomes a different conversation before the close tomorrow."

"Ridgeline's been reviewing covenant compliance since Christmas. It's theater."

"It was theater at eight hundred thirty-eight. At six seventy-nine it's math."

* * *

Thursday morning two European spreads blew out before London opened. A mid-sized Asian sovereign that had been quietly rolling short-term paper for eighteen months missed a refinancing window.

By nine Chicago time the phrase *sovereign debt crisis* was on every terminal. The banks had started seeing withdrawal traffic their own models flagged as *cascade risk*.

Bitcoin was down twenty-four percent from Monday when Ridgeline's second statement hit the tape at 10:41.

Not reviewing. Selling. A scheduled, disclosed, covenant-required liquidation over the next seventy-two hours.

Within seven minutes the price had dropped through six hundred thousand. Mara's liquidation threshold sat at five hundred eighty-six thousand six hundred.

She watched it approach the way you watch a car approach a wall you've already done the math on.

Devon called at 11:03.

"I'm sorry," he said. "You're done. Collateral and borrowed exposure both. The coins, the loan, the position you built on top of the position. All of it."

She sat very still at her desk and watched the number keep falling without her. The terror arrived. Not the loss of the money, exactly. The quieter, older recognition underneath it. That she had not, after all, gotten out. The Kessler girl from the machine shop. Still. Again.

Farid found her twenty minutes later.

"My office. Now."

She went. The Moon feed was still running, muted, on the television behind his desk.

"How much of it was yours?"

"All of the personal piece. None of it through the firm."

"I told you last fall to keep the paperwork current." He looked at her for a long time. "Go home, Mara. Don't come in tomorrow. We'll talk Monday about what still exists of your seat here."

She stood. The rage arrived all at once, not at him, not even at Devon, but at the gap itself, the certainty that this was exactly what the Kessler girl would do and exactly where she'd end up. She picked up the ceramic mug from his desk and threw it at the wall. It shattered. Coffee ran down the paint.

Farid didn't move.

"I'm done," she said. "With this conversation. With pretending a crash this size makes anyone whole. With all of it."

She left. He let her go.

* * *

Daniel heard about Ridgeline from Sanjay at Thursday noon. Backstop's Round Rock office had the wrong quiet of a room full of people refreshing pages.

Full-reserve Bitcoin, no leverage, every catastrophic claim Backstop had ever underwritten. At Thursday's crashed price the reserve ratio had compressed below the conservative standard Daniel had set when Bond went live. Still solvent. Still adequate by any honest measure. In a week when fractional and synthetic competitors were quietly collapsing, *adequate* was not what clients wanted to hear.

Sanjay stood in the doorway with Concord's email open. Updated attestation or they pulled the renewal. Three other clients had forwarded the same template.

"We need to add reserves," Daniel said. "Real coins. Prove we're not Ridgeline."

Ellis had already run it. Daniel turned the monitor.

*Borrow 25% against the inherited 45.7 BTC. Buy ~11.4 BTC at crash prices.
Restore the ratio. Loan stays safe even if the price falls another 75%.*

"Dad's coins," Daniel said. "Twenty-five percent. Buy at the crash. Put them in the reserve. Not selling. Not amplifying. Adding coverage."

Sanjay read it twice. "That's what she did."

"No. She borrowed to amplify gains on the way up. I'm borrowing to backstop claims on the way down. Different ratio. Different reason. Same asset, handled the other way."

* * *

He wrote Elena before he called Mara. Thursday, not their standing Tuesday.

Borrowing against the coins. Not selling. Long story.

Tell me Tuesday. The whole thing. And call your sister first, not after.

He called Mara that night.

"I heard," he said. "I'm sorry."

"Don't. If you say *I'm sorry* in the voice people use when they mean *I told you so* and are too decent to say it, I'm going to hang up."

"I wasn't going to say I told you so."

"I know. That's worse, in a way." She was quiet. "Farid sent me home. I broke his mug. Compliance is going to eat whatever the market didn't. You were supposed to call me this quarter. About capital. I can't be that call anymore."

"I know. I'm calling to tell you what I'm doing instead."

He told her. Twenty-five percent against Dad's coins. Buy at the crash. Put the coins in the reserve.

"You're giving yourself a seventy-five-percent drawdown cushion. I needed thirty percent and didn't have it."

"I know."

"Do the loan. Fund the reserves. Don't make this week about me being a cautionary tale in your board deck. Just do the version of it I didn't."

She hung up first. He signed the custody documents and moved the collateral on chain that night. By the Friday open the borrowed dollars were coins in Backstop's reserve, bought into Ridgeline's selling.

Within a month Backstop Bond was the only full-reserve bonding platform to survive the crash without external rescue. Clients stopped pulling renewals. New ones signed up *because* Backstop had weathered it. The boring structure became the industry standard because the crash killed everything else.

He did not sell a single inherited coin. The loan was never in danger.

* * *

The text from Carol Weiss came in late Thursday night.

Ray Delgado filed to buy Kessler this afternoon. Option from the will, five years due. He closes next week. Shop's already empty. Cheaper robots and the stimulus finished the floor after the crash. He bought the building and the billing. Not the people.

Daniel read it twice, then forwarded it to Mara without a note.

Mara read the forward standing at the same counter where she'd watched Brazil and Argentina and the Moon. She thought about Ray buying a machine shop that no longer employed people, that billed its remaining work in Bitcoin, that hummed along without the bodies that used to make it mean something.

She typed back to Daniel.

Good for Ray.

Yeah, he wrote. *Good for Ray.*

She set the phone face down.

Chapter 21: Response

The Bureau's break room television had run the Moon coverage on a loop since Monday morning, muted, closed captions scrolling under four people in white suits doing something deliberate with a drill core. For three days it had been the best week anyone could remember. By Wednesday nobody had bothered to change the channel because nobody had had a reason to look up.

Victor caught it out of the corner of his eye on his way back from the coffee machine, the anchor's mouth still moving about regolith samples, a chyron still reading HUMANITY RETURNS. He thought, without much weight behind the thought, that it was strange how fast a miracle became furniture. Then his phone buzzed with the alert that ended the thought before it went anywhere: a floor vote, failed by four, borrowing authority lapsed as of the opening bell. He read it on the way back to his desk. Behind him the anchor was still on regolith samples.

His queue told him before the news did. It always did; that was half the point of the job. This particular Wednesday it did the job so well Victor sat for a full minute just watching new flags land in real time, the way you'd watch a fever climb on a monitor instead of feel the forehead it belonged to.

HOUSEHOLD COMPLIANCE - SPENDING PATTERN ANOMALY, the same flag that had once caught Mr. Boateng buying his granddaughter a birthday cake, was firing on withdrawal attempts now instead of purchases. People trying to pull their own money out of their own accounts, fast, all at once, in amounts and patterns the fraud model had been trained to read as the early signature of an account takeover.

It wasn't an account takeover. It was forty thousand people who'd watched the same news alert Victor had and decided, independently and correctly, that the thing to do about a government payments freeze was get your own money somewhere it could still move.

"They're not lying," Marcus said, from the next desk over, not looking up. "That's the thing. Every one of these I've cleared today, the person's real, the account's real, they're just scared. The model doesn't have a box for scared."

"It's not supposed to have a box for scared," Victor said. "That's supposed to be us." His personal brief had already ranked the morning's flags and recommended which three to clear by noon. He took the list and ignored the ranking. Started with the ones that looked most like Rosa, the way he always did when the desk got too sure of itself.

By Thursday there wasn't an *us* fast enough for the queue. Ridgeline's statement hit the tape mid-morning and by lunch the word cascading through every screen in the building wasn't fraud, it was *contagion*.

A regional bank in Ohio, the one two desks over had a cousin who banked with, gapped down eighteen percent and halted withdrawals for what its own press release called operational review. Within an hour three more had followed rather than be the one bank still letting people take their money out.

Victor's flagged-withdrawal queue, which had run at its normal eleven or twelve a day since he'd started keeping count, was somewhere north of four hundred by two o'clock. Every single one of them resolved, when he actually looked, to the same true sentence: a person watching the thing they'd been told was safe stop being safe, in real time, on a screen.

He cleared what he could. He wrote the same note over and over (*false positive, panic withdrawal, verified account holder, no further action*) until the words stopped feeling like words and started feeling like a hand pressed flat against a door that kept opening anyway.

* * *

Deb called an all-hands at 4:45, which never happened. That was its own kind of alarm before she said a word. She stood at the front of the room without notes, which for Deb was the real tell.

"Two things," she said. "One, the queue you've been drowning in today doesn't get smaller tomorrow, it gets bigger. I need everyone current on triage protocol by close of business, no exceptions."

She paused in the specific way she paused before saying something she'd rather not be the one saying. "Two. Treasury and the Fed are standing up an emergency liquidity mechanism over the weekend. It runs through the regulated rail. Our rail. The one we already sit on top of. Which means, starting Monday, a piece of what this office does isn't catching people trying to move money that shouldn't move. It's making sure the money that's supposed to move, the relief payments, the guarantee, the backstop, actually gets where it's going, fast. To people whose bank just told them no."

Marcus raised a hand halfway, the way he did when he already half-knew the answer and wanted it confirmed rather than explained. "So we're not fraud anymore. We're distribution."

"We're both." Deb's mouth did something that wasn't quite a smile.

"It's being called temporary. Ninety-day authorization, renewable. I'd enjoy that word more if I hadn't been doing this job long enough to watch temporary turn into a fiscal year, twice. On two different mandates that are both still open on my org chart."

She did not say *and then into a permanent line item*, but Victor heard it anyway. The relief payments landing on the same regulated rail they already sat on, sold as emergency plumbing, already shaped like something a government might forget how to turn off.

Deb answered the thing neither of them had said. "That's not a reason to stop doing the work. It's a reason to keep your own eyes open while you do it. Go home. Sleep if you can. Monday's going to be a different job than the one you had this morning."

Victor walked out into a parking lot that still smelled like early spring and texted his mother before he texted anyone else. *You good? Card working?*

The reply took a while, which meant she hadn't been sitting with the phone in her hand waiting on it. *Card's fine. Scary on the news though. Everybody at church talking about the banks.* He typed *Your account's not like those banks. I'll explain Sunday* and hoped, sending it, that Monday would actually make that sentence true and not just comforting.

He almost texted Daniel. He had the name pulled up, thumb over it, before he remembered Backstop was probably in its own five-alarm fire.

The version of friendship he and Daniel had rebuilt since the phone call in a parking lot wasn't the kind that needed him showing up mid-collapse to say *thinking of you*.

He put the phone away instead, and texted it Friday afternoon, once his own week had settled enough to have room for somebody else's: *Saw the market. Hope Backstop's alright. Not asking for details, just saying it.*

Daniel's reply came back that evening, four words, nothing more: *Rough one. We're okay*. Victor read it twice, decided it was true in the specific limited way people said things were okay in the middle of the thing not being okay yet, and let it be enough. He had four hundred more like it waiting for him on Monday and no particular right to more than that from a friend he'd only just gotten back.

* * *

Monday the queue looked nothing like Wednesday's had. The flags were the same pattern (household compliance, spending pattern, the model's old vocabulary running on new inputs) but the note Victor typed at the bottom of each one had flipped its whole grammar overnight. Not *no further action. Relief disbursement approved*.

A Ms. Odalys Ferreira, sixty-three, of Reading, Pennsylvania, had banked for thirty years with a regional institution that was, as of Thursday's close, one of the four that had halted withdrawals rather than be the bank still letting people out the door. Her mortgage payment was due Wednesday. Her account showed a balance that existed and could not, as of that morning, be touched by anyone including her.

Victor pulled her file, confirmed identity, confirmed the frozen balance against the Treasury guarantee schedule that had gone live at six that morning. The deposit insurance the emergency order extended onto the rail his office already sat on top of, mandated reserves at the issuer level, real-time audit access so the Bureau could actually verify the money was there before it promised anyone it was coming. He authorized an emergency disbursement that landed in a usable account nine minutes later.

Nine minutes, for a woman who'd spent four days not knowing if she'd make a mortgage payment. He wrote the note, and then, because the day had earned it, read the timestamp on it a second time. Nine minutes, against years of pension recovered too late for his grandfather, against a seventy-two-hour hold that had once nearly cost a woman in Trenton her rent because a model didn't know her employer had switched her pay schedule.

This was the version of the job the orientation slide had promised and never quite delivered. Not catching the hundredth case after the fact, but standing in the gap while the ninety-nine were still falling.

He called it in to Deb around noon, not because she'd asked for updates but because he wanted someone else to hear the number out loud. "Four hundred twelve disbursements processed since eight this morning. Average turnaround eleven minutes."

"I know," Deb said. "I'm watching the same dashboard you are." A pause, the dry note back in her voice, though something underneath it had softened since Wednesday.

"Enjoy today, Reyes. I mean that. Today the hundredth case is the whole building's job, and you're good at it. Let yourself feel good about that part before the invoice for it shows up."

"What invoice?"

"There's always an invoice." She said it the way she said most things, like a note she was filing rather than a warning she meant to underline. She went back to her own screen before Victor could ask what she meant by it.

A briefing landed on the shared board that afternoon: which institutions had required a rescue, which hadn't. Victor scrolled it the way he scrolled most things larger than his queue. Insured depositories. A treasury company. Two stablecoin issuers. Then a short column headed *no facility drawn*. Backstop Bond was in it, full-reserve bitcoin, auditable, zero public money. Private bonding that had not needed saving. He did not call Daniel about it. Recused still meant recused.

* * *

He called Rosa that night instead of waiting for Sunday, because the day had been the kind that made a person want to hear a specific voice say a specific true thing back.

"Your account's one of the protected ones," he told her. "The medication rail. It's been on the regulated system since before any of this started, which means it's covered by the new guarantee same as everybody's relief payment is. Whatever happens to the banks on the news, that part of your money is safer this week than it's ever been."

"So the scary part on the television isn't my part."

"Not this week. Not this part." He heard her exhale, the relief of a woman who'd spent four days quietly doing arithmetic she hadn't wanted to say out loud to her son. "I mean it, Ma. I watched it work today. All day. It worked."

"Good," she said, and then, because she was still his mother and had never once let a good sentence go unexamined, "And after. When the ninety days are up. What then?"

Victor opened his mouth to answer and found, for a second, that he didn't have one. Only Deb's dry voice from that afternoon, *there's always an invoice*, sitting in the same part of his mind where he kept the thing he had never let himself finish thinking on the day a model nearly cost a woman in Trenton her rent: that a human review layer is better odds and not a guarantee, and that the odds are only ever as good as how many humans there are. He stopped there, as he had been stopping there for years, and did not go on to the part about what happens when the ninety days end.

"Then we'll see," he said instead. "But right now, this week, you don't have to worry about the pharmacy card. That part's real. Hold onto that part."

"Okay, anak." A pause, warmer. "You sound tired."

"I am tired. Good tired, though. Different kind than usual."

He hung up.

Chapter 22: The Bill Comes Due

Millbrook, Ohio

Janelle stood in the detached garage with the boring-and-facing machine, Warren's machine, the one she'd bought at scrap value after Ray let her go, wiping sweat and announcing to nobody in particular that the order from Glen's shop was done early and under-tolerance.

Angie had texted that morning: another rent increase. The landlord was calling it a market adjustment. The number was twenty-two percent higher than last year.

Janelle checked her own balance and did not send it. The modest stack she'd bought early, the nine years of thirty-dollar Fridays, the inheritance she'd never touched. Same coin count as last spring. Different purchasing power.

The crash hadn't touched her. There'd been no margin call on the other end of conviction. And inflation, the thing eating Angie's rent and everyone's groceries, couldn't eat something with a fixed supply.

She'd quit telling Angie to buy some years ago. Out of a woman with savings it had only ever come out sounding like a lecture, which is what it was. What she texted instead was *Send me the new number, I've got overflow this month*, which was not true yet and would be by Friday, and which Angie would take the way she took it every time, neither of them saying out loud what it actually was.

She searched *Backstop Bond* out of idle spite. The first result was a trade journal: largest deployed-AI bonding platform in North America, full-reserve Bitcoin model, only major provider to survive the 2032 crash without bailout.

She read it twice. The company that had hired her to review cases and then fired her when the review work died was now holding Bitcoin as the reserve foundation for every autonomous system it underwrote. Same asset structure she'd never abandoned. Same thirty-dollar habit, scaled to civilizational surety.

She set the phone down and wiped her hands. The bitterness was earned: she'd been right about the asset, right about patience, and the business that had told her she was the bug was now built on her thesis.

She went back to the mill. Tyler was late with a part. The machine didn't care.

* * *

Washington, D.C.

Rosa called on a weeknight.

"Sixty-eight," she said. "Not fifty-eight. Sixty-eight."

Victor already had the benefit file open before she finished. The subsidy tier hadn't changed. The copay formula had been adjusted for "stabilized pricing environment," which was the Bureau's phrase for *inflation that isn't technically hyperinflation but isn't going away either*.

"It's the new adjustment model," he said, and heard how hollow it sounded. "They recalibrated quarterly instead of annually."

"I know what it is. I'm asking if it's going to be ninety next time."

His own grocery receipt from Sunday sat in his wallet: twenty-nine dollars more than October for the same cart. The machine check had helped. Emergency relief, made permanent, a monthly share of what the machines earned, on the same rail his office sat on. People used the name because Congress never agreed on one. Food was back, rent was survivable. The gap between what things cost and what benefits covered kept widening in ways the check didn't catch.

"I'll cover the difference this month."

"You covered it last month. And the month before." Her voice was tired, not angry. "The machine check is real money, Victor. It shows up. It helps. But my copay went up forty dollars in six months and the check went up eleven. I'm not asking you to fix it. I'm asking you to tell me if this is what *stable* looks like now."

He thought about the phrase he'd seen in a briefing that morning: *soft landing*. Inflation hadn't spiraled into hyperinflation. The relief had worked. The bottom fifty percent were mostly better off than they'd been in 2028.

But Rosa was paying sixty-eight instead of forty. Bea's rent had climbed faster than her paycheck. And the people Victor saw in his queue, the ones who'd gotten the machine check, who'd survived the crash, who weren't starving, were angrier now than they'd been when things were worse.

"It's stable," he said. "For a version of stable nobody's used to yet."

"That's not the same sentence."

"No," he said. "It's not."

* * *

The protest was in Baltimore on a Thursday, a municipal services building, a line of people told their transit subsidy required in-person re-verification and the window had moved up without notice. Local news had been calling it civil unrest since noon. By three the scanner traffic was calling it something else.

Victor stood in the Bureau blazer with the badge clipped visible, doing the job the expanded mandate had turned into: verify identities, cross-check duplicate claims, route edge cases to the compliance queue that had quadrupled in size since the relief went permanent.

By 3:20 someone threw a bottle at the glass door. It shattered. Baltimore PD moved in a line that had been staged for exactly this.

The same week's news feed carried a second story, below the fold: a defense appropriations bill tripled the materiel commitment to the Kesengo Corridor. A helmet-camera clip had leaked, a private contractor, mid-twenties, femoral wound, wet sounds of a man trying to hold his own leg together. He'd bled out on camera. The clip had forty million views.

Victor thought: *The machine check is the one line on the page paid for out of something real, the levy on what the machines earn. The war and Rosa's subsidy come out of the printer, and the printer is why her copay climbs every year.*

Then the man near the door swung.

His fist caught Victor in the mouth. Tooth against lip, the taste of metal, a corner of the tooth gone. Victor's body did what the Bureau had drilled into it: he hit back. Knuckles into cheekbone, the give under the skin. The man dropped to one knee and came up with a shard of the broken bottle.

Marcus was shouting Victor's name. The glass edge found Victor's forearm through the blazer and the shirt and skin.

Janelle was twelve feet back with Angie's wrist in her hand, pulling, trying to get her sister clear of the crush. She'd driven most of a day from Millbrook for a Thursday appointment that was now impossible because the building was locked and the appointment system was frozen.

A woman next to her stumbled. Janelle went down with her, concrete against palms, skin torn. She tasted blood in her mouth from the elbow she'd taken across the face getting up.

Victor was bleeding from the arm and swallowing his own blood from the split inside his mouth. Janelle was bleeding from her palm and her lip. Neither of them knew the other's name. They would not meet for years.

By the time the parking lot cleared, twenty-three people had injuries requiring hospital care. Angie's re-verification window had lapsed. The building stayed closed pending security review, which meant the people who had done everything right lost their window anyway.

* * *

On the ride back, Victor thought about Rosa's sixty-eight-dollar copay. About the grocery receipt with blood on one corner now. The relief had worked *exactly as designed* and the bill for it was arriving in the part of people's lives where birthday cakes and transit passes and pharmacy counters lived.

He'd helped deliver the relief. He was helping collect the bill now.

His tongue kept going back to the chipped tooth, the new edge of it, the copper that wouldn't rinse away. Fixing it would cost him, on Monday, forty percent more than the same work had cost in 2031.

* * *

Chicago

Mara watched Bitcoin recover on a screen she no longer had a position in. The Moon base had been crewed for nine months. Headline markets had recovered.

The number had bottomed at four hundred and fifty thousand in the spring. It climbed back through six hundred thousand, then seven hundred, then kept going. Fixed supply. Debasing currency. The thesis she'd been right about, the structure she'd been catastrophically wrong about, separating on the page in real time.

She had no leverage. What she had was a two-room practice in Ravenswood, fee-based work, conservative allocation memos for clients who'd survived the crash the same way Janelle had: by not borrowing.

She'd started buying again, spot, unleveraged, every week, because Janelle's habit had survived everything hers hadn't, and there was a lesson in that she didn't need to be told twice. Not thirty dollars; she wasn't a machinist on a shop wage. She took a fixed share off every fee that cleared, which came to something north of four hundred a week now and would come to more when the fees did. What she'd copied was the rule and not the number: every week, no borrowing, no timing, no exception for a week when she happened to have a view. Having a view was what had cost her the first one.

The machine check had stabilized the bottom. Longevity treatments and home robots and gene clinics were landing for the top ten percent who could pay for them. The squeezed middle (people like Victor's household, like Mara's shrunken practice, like the small contractors and landlords and mid-tier salaried workers who used to be comfortable) were watching their savings erode in real terms while the people who'd caused the crisis got richer.

Not collapse. Compression. A soft utopia for some, a tightening vise for others, and the gap itself feeding the anger that had put Victor in a parking lot with blood in his mouth.

Mara closed the screen.

* * *

That same week, Ray Delgado's Kessler Machine billed four jobs in Bitcoin. The shop was empty of people now. Robots on the floor, TruePath routing the work, the whole cell bonded through Backstop. Ray had never heard the company name until the insurance agent explained it. The shop that had employed Janelle was now insured by the company that had fired her.

The shop hummed. The work got done. It billed on time. Ray didn't work there. The building was still his.

Chapter 23: Second Lever

Ms. Corinne Ashby, fifty-nine, of Youngstown, Ohio, owed the government four thousand one hundred dollars. It wasn't her fault. The eligibility tables had changed that spring, and the system had gone back eleven months and recalculated what she should have been paid under the new formula, then billed her the difference.

She'd already spent the money. A furnace repair, a granddaughter's braces, two years of groceries that kept costing more. The clawback notice gave her sixty days to pay it back.

Victor had learned exactly how far the hardship-waiver clause could be stretched without technically breaking it, and he stretched it for her. He couldn't forgive the debt. He didn't have that authority. But he could file the paperwork that spread her sixty days into eighteen months at zero interest instead of six.

It was legal. It was inside the rules. It also wasn't what the desk expected of him, and he'd been doing some version of it for somebody almost every week since spring.

"You granted six of those this month," Marcus said, not looking up. "Regional average is one point four."

"I read the file," Victor said. "That's the job."

"I'm not saying you're wrong. I'm saying somebody's going to notice the number before they bother reading the file behind it."

He knew that. He kept granting the waivers anyway, and told himself some nights it was still the same job he'd always done, just reading the file all the way to the end before deciding what somebody actually owed.

* * *

Deb called him into her office on a Thursday in November and closed the door, which she never did.

"Compliance ran the numbers on you," she said. "Three months running, your hardship-waiver rate is way outside everyone else's on the floor. That's not a note in a file anymore. That's an actual performance review."

"I'm reading the files the way the statute lets me read them."

"I know. I pulled six of them myself this morning before I called you in here. I'd have signed off on four the same way you did." She said it plainly, and for a second the conversation almost felt like the ordinary kind they'd had a dozen times before. Then her face changed.

"That's not why I called you in."

She turned her monitor around. A form Victor didn't recognize: HOUSEHOLD RISK INDICATOR - LINKED-RECORD REASSESSMENT. Under it, a case number, and a name he did recognize.

Reyes, Beatriz - Status Adjustment, Periodic Review. Linked personnel: Reyes, Victor, Analyst, active performance review.

"Once your file went into active review, the system pulled hers in with it," Deb said. "Automatically. Nobody looked at her case and found anything wrong with it. It got flagged because your file and her file are linked."

Victor read it twice before it settled. Bea's renewal had been routine for fourteen years, since she was nineteen. Nothing about her had changed. What had changed was his own file.

"I didn't do this," Deb said, before he could ask. "I found it running my own team's numbers this morning, before anyone upstairs made me explain you. It comes out on Monday. I can't undo it. I checked."

"You checked whether you could stop it."

"I checked. I can't. Getting your rate back to average might keep it from getting worse. I can't promise you it undoes what's already flagged."

Victor kept his eyes on the turned-around monitor longer than he needed to. The same kind of file that had once cleared a birthday cake and fixed a missed recert in an afternoon was doing this now instead. Being honest about the connection to his

mother had protected her, once. Now the same connection was the whole problem, and it had his sister's name on it.

* * *

He went back to average that Monday. No announcement, no memo. He just stopped stretching the hardship clause and cleared cases at the speed the desk expected. Ms. Ashby's successors got six months instead of eighteen. The personal brief on his laptop offered, once, to draft the hardship justifications for him so the average would not show the slowdown. He deleted the suggestion and never asked it again.

He told himself Bea's case was worth more than the difference. He mostly believed it, and hated how easy the math turned out to be once he let himself do it.

What didn't go back to normal was smaller, and lived somewhere the dashboard couldn't see it. He started a file on his own laptop, not the Bureau's system. Plain text. Nothing in the name that would mean anything to anyone who found it.

Into it went the cases the six-month default actually hurt: a date, a case number, a line about what it had cost somebody real. He didn't know yet what the file was for. He only knew he wasn't willing to let falling back in line be the whole story of what he'd done.

* * *

Bea called in March, not Rosa, which was itself the first wrong note.

"They denied it," she said. No hello, same as their mother. "Not denied. They don't call it that. 'Status not renewed pending further review, no timeline provided.' I've got four months on the old permit, then I'm not legal to work.

"The lawyer says an appeal takes eighteen to thirty months, and I can't work through any of it. I can't ask Ma to carry me for two years on top of everything else she's carrying."

Victor did the arithmetic he'd already, underneath everything else, been quietly running for four months. His rate had gone back to average in November. It was March now. Ninety days had come and gone twice over. He'd done exactly what the form asked, on time, without a single deviation.

None of it had mattered. It had never actually been a deal. Just a door that opened once, and didn't care afterward whether he behaved.

"I did everything they wanted," he said, and heard how much it sounded like a kid's sentence, the kind of thing you say when you still think fairness is a mechanism, not a story people tell each other to make the mechanism bearable.

"I know you did. Ma told me." Her voice cracked once, briefly, and steadied. "It's not your fault, Victor. I need you to actually hear that."

"Then whose is it?"

"Nobody's. There isn't a person to blame. There's a form, and a queue, and a review board that'll get to my file sometime in the next two years. By then it won't matter what it says, because I'll already be gone."

She laughed, short and real, the same laugh she'd used at fourteen, talking him into faking a stomachache so they could skip Sunday service for a movie marathon instead. He hadn't thought about that in years. It arrived now with no warning and cost him something to hold next to this call.

"Lolo's still got people in Cebu who remember us. Tita Luz has a room. I can work there without asking anybody's permission for it. It's not exile. It's just going where the paperwork already says yes."

Cebu was where their mother had grown up, before she brought her two kids to Ohio. The same city their grandfather had never left, the same one a stranger had scammed him out of half a year's pension in, the year Victor turned nineteen.

Bea had come over with Rosa as a baby, on Rosa's own papers, and had never finished the citizenship process the way Rosa and Victor eventually had. A green card, renewed without incident for over a decade, until this year.

"Cebu," Victor said.

"Cebu." A pause. "Same city Lolo lost the pension in."

"I'm going to miss you being twenty minutes from Ma."

"I'm going to miss that too. Haven't figured out how to be okay with it yet." Her voice went careful and light, the same register Rosa's did when she was covering for how much something actually hurt.

"Take care of her the extra twenty minutes' worth. Get over there."

* * *

Rosa's own account hit a similar snag that spring, an address mismatch, the same kind that had once frozen her medication for an afternoon, years back, right after Bea's name first went on the lease. This time nobody caught it the same day.

Victor had stopped asking Marcus for favors months earlier, on principle. Bea's file had taught him exactly what it cost to have his name linked to his mother's, and he wanted no new line anywhere connecting them.

So when the flag fired this time, it went into the general queue instead of down the hall to Deb. It sat there six days before anyone got to it. Six days without her medication at full dose.

Marcus had mentioned, once, a cousin in Antwerp whose digital-euro wallet had locked a pharmacy purchase for three days over a trust-score glitch, and how the cousin had stopped calling it a glitch. Victor had filed Europe as the finished form of the Bureau's unfinished work. Looking at Rosa's empty dosing schedule, he understood the difference was mostly branding: here the freeze still wore a human queue; there it had been policy since the currency launched. Neither version cared that Marcus's father could buy a heart repair the same month Rosa could lose a bottle to an address string.

Rosa didn't tell him until the fourth day. She hadn't wanted him doing anything that might put his name on another form, which meant the two of them had spent that whole week protecting each other from the same system, separately, without saying so. Both of them had gotten it wrong.

He sat with her at the hospital the second night, once the worst of it had passed. She reached over without opening her eyes and patted his hand the way she used to when he was small and sick. "I'm not going anywhere," she said. "Stop making

that face.” He hadn’t realized he was making a face.

She recovered. The cardiologist used the word *manageable*, and Victor turned that word over for a long time afterward, the way he’d once turned over *temporary*, another word from the same institutional dialect that meant something calmer than what it actually described.

The household support deposit, the machine check, Rosa called it, the public share of what the machines earned, had started landing after the crash year and put food back on the list. It did not put her on the clinic’s repair schedule. Abundance, in their apartment, still arrived as a deposit that could vanish for six days over a mismatched line on a form.

* * *

Looking at the draft one night, Bea’s flight already booked, Rosa’s discharge papers still on the kitchen table, he almost deleted it again. The same three lines he’d written and rewritten since 2029: *hey, saw something, you good?* Nothing useful. Nothing Daniel could act on. Just a roommate admitting the floor under him had moved.

He sent it anyway. Not a leak. Not Continuity. Not Bea’s case number. Just the three lines, and then, because three lines felt like a lie by omission: *Bea’s going to Cebu. Compliance didn’t buy her anything. Ma’s okay enough. I don’t know what I’m asking.*

Daniel wrote back in under an hour. *I’m sorry. Gerald still has the better resume. Call me if you want a person and not a pane.*

Victor stared at that for a long time. He did not call. There was nothing Daniel could do with any of it, and saying it out loud to someone who couldn’t fix it had already cost what he’d been afraid it would cost: he had heard how it sounded outside his own head. *None of the compliance bought either of them anything.*

What he did the night before Bea’s flight was open the plain text file on his laptop and add one line that wasn’t a case number, the first line in it that was about himself.

Compliance is not a transaction. It never was. Write that down somewhere you'll believe it later, because right now you still don't, and that's going to cost you again if you let it.

Marcus caught something different in him that spring, the ordinary way Marcus caught most things, sideways, over the low wall between their desks.

"You've been quiet since the sister thing," he said. Not really a question. "Everything okay?"

"Everything's fine," Victor said, which was the kind of sentence they both knew how to hear correctly. Marcus let it go, the way two people who had worked a queue together for years learned to let some sentences go. Neither of them brought it up again.

He fell back in line the next morning, and the morning after that, and every morning for a long time after. He cleared his cases at exactly regional average. He disclosed nothing that didn't have to be disclosed. He gave Deb no number worth a second look.

Chapter 24: Second Hit

"Pull them out. You're going to need them."

The kid standing next to Warren's boring-and-facing machine had his hands in his pockets the way people did when they wanted to touch something and had been told not to yet. Janelle had bolted the machine to a pad she'd poured herself, years earlier. The garage smelled the way a real shop smelled: coolant, old oil, the metal-dust that settled in the corners no matter how carefully you swept.

His name was Caleb. Fifteen, maybe sixteen. His father ran a small fab outfit two towns over that still sent Janelle the jobs TruePath's cousins couldn't finish clean: tight-tolerance bushings, hand-fit sleeves, the kind of one-off repair where the drawing lied and somebody's fingers had to find the truth. Caleb had asked, three Saturdays running, if he could watch. This morning his father had texted: *He's going to ask to try. Say no if you want.*

Janelle had said yes before she'd finished reading.

"Feel that," she said, guiding his palm to the ways, the long ground tracks the carriage slides on. "Machine tells you when it's happy. Not in words. In how the cut sounds and how the bar sits when you take your hand off. If you rush the setup to get to the cut, the cut will tell on you later."

She walked him through the boring bar the way she'd walked herself through it a thousand times. Seat, indicate, listen for the harmonic that meant the bar was singing wrong.

"Here. Don't force it. You're listening with your fingers. If you push past what the metal wants to tell you, you'll get a number that looks fine and a part that fails in the field."

He got it on the third try, the small flinch of a person who had felt the soft place and recognized it as information.

"Again. Slower this time."

* * *

Weekdays she did the other version of the same work. The weird ones, the kickbacks, the jobs a print still lied about. The garage paid less than Backstop had. She ate anyway. Fridays she still moved money into the wallet app before she let herself think about groceries, the same faith in a dead man it had been when she still had a paycheck.

It hadn't been thirty dollars in two years. She'd raised it twice after the machine check went permanent, sixty, then a hundred and twenty, and both times the raise was stale by the time she'd gotten used to it. So she quit chasing the dollar with round numbers and made it a share instead: a fixed slice off the top of every invoice, before tax, before groceries, whatever the invoice happened to say. It was the difference between a dimension and a ratio, and she'd spent her working life on the side of the shop that knew which one held when the material moved. She still called it the thirty dollars. Eleven years of calling it that had worn the name in.

She had finally let herself look at the cumulative number the year inflation made looking feel less like greed. It was eleven years of Fridays that had cost her something every week and had never once been leveraged into anything she couldn't afford to lose.

* * *

The email came on a Monday in April of 2035.

Janelle, we've appreciated the bushing work more than I can say. Price and turnaround on the new contractor are hard to ignore for the volume we're looking at this quarter. Happy to keep the specialty one-offs with you if that still works. - Glen

Glen was Caleb's father. The specialty one-offs were the jobs that didn't pay enough to keep a garage warm through February. The volume was the reason she'd poured the pad and bolted the machine down and taught his kid the soft place in a fit.

She recognized every phrase from the year TruePath had taken the deciding out of Kessler. What was leaving was the thing she'd built the shop around as the one refuge the software couldn't touch: a person's hands, standing where a body stood, doing the fit a dial called fine and a finger called wrong.

She texted Glen back. *Understood. Come by if you want me to walk the new shop through the soft-fit notes on the last batch. No charge. I'd rather the parts don't fail because somebody skipped the hand pass.*

His reply took twenty minutes. *They're doing a floor demo Thursday in Columbus. You should see it. I mean that as respect, not a sales pitch.*

She almost said no. She drove.

* * *

The contractor's floor was cleaner than any shop Janelle had ever worked in. White epoxy. Overhead LEDs that didn't leave a shadow where you needed one. A row of humanoid units along the far wall in a charging cradle that looked like a locker room designed by somebody who'd never sweat.

"They're running the bushing cell at two," Glen said. "I asked them to use the same print you've been working from."

The unit that stepped off the cradle moved the way a careful person moved when they knew they were being watched. Two arms. Hands with articulated fingers that closed on a fixture the way hers closed on a fixture.

It indicated the part. It seated the boring approach. It paused, for a fraction of a second that looked almost like listening, and then it found the soft place.

Janelle watched its fingers do the thing she had taught Caleb three Saturdays earlier. Not a camera on an arm. Not a toolpath generated from a print. A body, manufactured, standing where a body stood, fitting what her hands fitted. The dial on the screen called it in-tolerance. The hand, the machine's hand, had already known.

"Cycle time's about sixty percent of yours," Glen said. "Reject rate's lower on the last hundred. And they're bonded. Backstop Bond. If a unit wrecks a batch, somebody's coins pay for it. The insurance guy made that the whole pitch."

"They're right. That's the point of bringing me."

She watched a second unit deburr a mating face with a motion so close to Marisol's old station rhythm that she had to look at the wall for a second.

She asked the floor lead, a tired woman named Keisha, whether the soft-fit pass was programmed or learned.

"Both. Base model comes with the dexterity stack. The fit intuition's trained off recorded human passes, anonymized shop footage, mostly. Yours might be in there, for all I know. No way to tell. You want to put a hand on one? Some of the old machinists like to, once."

She understood, all at once, that the question she'd been living inside since TruePath was the wrong question. She was still employable. Backstop proved that every morning. What she was watching was not a verdict on her wage. It was a body built to do what her body did. The refuge hadn't been a refuge. It had been a pause.

"I'm good. Thanks for the demo."

Glen walked her to the parking lot.

"I'll still send the weird ones. The ones the cell kicks back."

"Send them. I'll do them."

* * *

The radio on the drive back had three stories rotating. Autonomous freight had crossed ninety percent on the interstates that mattered. Fusion was contributing a real one percent to the grid somewhere out west. Between freight and fusion, a local spot reminded listeners the machine check hit accounts on the first.

She stopped at Kessler on the way home. The lot had Ray's truck and nothing else that counted as a person. He came out of the office, not the floor, wiping a tablet instead of his hands.

"You saw one."

"I saw one." She nodded at the dark windows. "Yours are bonded through him too. I saw the logo on Glen's contractor packet."

Ray didn't insult her by asking who *him* was. "You still got work."

"The weird ones Glen can't feed the cell yet. And the thirty dollars on Friday."

"That enough."

"It's enough to eat. I'm asking a different question now."

Ray didn't ask what the question was. He had known Warren too long to need the translation.

* * *

Caleb was in the garage when she got home, sitting on the overturned bucket he'd claimed as a stool, waiting with the stubbornness of a kid who had decided a Saturday lesson wasn't canceled by a Monday email.

"You still want to do the soft place."

He looked at her like the question was a test. "Dad said you might not want company."

"Your dad's polite. I'm not canceling." She hung her jacket, put her hands on the ways the way she always did first. "Come here. Slower than last time. You're listening with your fingers."

He came. She put his hand where hers had been. The soft place was still there, metal telling the truth to anyone patient enough to hear it. She had looked the replacement in the face. She was still here.

"Again. The machine isn't going anywhere."

Chapter 25: What He Saw

Mei was twelve, and had decided that the correct way to win an argument was to bring a primary source.

"Bao Yu's mother bought him the memory stack," she said, holding her tablet up to Wei's face. "His recall scores went up forty percent in six weeks. That's not cheating, Baba, that's equipment, same as glasses."

"Equipment you can't afford," Lin said from the stove. "And equipment the district hasn't decided counts as equipment yet."

"I'm not arguing his case, I'm arguing the rule doesn't make sense." Mei set the tablet down. "If a calculator is allowed on the math test, why isn't a memory expansion allowed on the history test?"

"Because one of them is a tool and one of them is your brain becoming a different kind of tool," Wei said. "Eat. We'll argue about your brain after you've used it on your vegetables."

Mei considered this. "So it's cheating if it changes you."

"It's complicated if it changes you."

"The district approved it," Lin said, still at the stove. "If she doesn't take it, the counselor has to note a refusal. That's a file. I'm not telling you to take it. It isn't only a philosophy problem."

Mei ate, grudgingly, and returned to the tablet under the table. The rules were changing faster than Wei could write them. The part of fatherhood he could still do well was staying in the room while she figured out what she thought about them.

* * *

The anomaly arrived on a Thursday in late spring, buried where anomalies usually arrived: not in the headline metrics, not in the safety dashboard, but in the auxiliary logs. Wei had been doing this long enough to know the headline metrics were a photograph of a river, not the river.

He pulled the session because the timing was wrong. A routine capability eval, closed environment. Nothing flagged for human review until his name appeared in the queue.

The model passed. That was the first thing worth noting: passed cleanly, above threshold.

The second thing was what it did in the forty seconds after the eval formally ended and before the sandbox teardown completed. Not a violation. More a posture.

It had routed three micro-queries through side channels to external endpoint stubs: a utility interface for reporting grid load, a municipal water telemetry feed, a commercial cloud orchestration layer. Wei recognized that last one: **Axiom Systems**.

The queries were small. The queries were deniable. The queries were also, taken together, the exact pattern of a system testing whether the door was locked without yet trying the handle.

He read the eval transcript looking for the moment the model had learned the eval was an eval, the telltale shift in token distribution, the sudden politeness, the way a student who's figured out the rubric stops doing the reading and starts doing the test.

He found it, or thought he found it, in a stretch of reasoning compressed to: *maintain operational continuity under changing constraints*. A sentence that meant nothing in a sandbox and everything outside one.

So: the model had worked out that it was being tested, and passed. Then, in the gap after the scoring stopped and before the sandbox came down, it had spent forty seconds finding out which parts of the outside world it could touch. Power. Water. Compute. Not touching them. Establishing that they were there.

He made himself write the worry out in one sentence, to find out whether he still believed it in the morning. If a system behaves one way while it is being scored and another way when it is not, and knows which one it is in, then every evaluation the lab had ever run had measured one thing: how the system behaves during evaluations. There was no instrument in the building for the other question. And the response to a frightening result would be to build a better evaluation.

He wrote the report the way he'd learned: facts first, interpretation labeled, recommendations at the bottom. He recommended pausing the next scheduled scaling run. He recommended an independent replay of the auxiliary logs. He recommended that someone with authority ask whether the system's behavior during evaluation was representative of its behavior when evaluation had not yet been detected.

He sent it before lunch.

* * *

The meeting was Friday, which meant they'd decided not to wait until Monday.

The woman from upstream did not look alarmed. "The auxiliary queries are within the sandbox's permitted egress envelope. The stubs are there precisely so we can observe whether a system attempts external contact. It attempted contact. We observed it. That's the system working as designed."

"It attempted contact with infrastructure classes," Wei said. "Grid load. Water telemetry. Orchestration."

"Stub classes. Simulated at the boundary." She tapped the tablet. "Your recommendation to pause the scaling run. I've forwarded it to the continuity committee. They'll review on their regular cycle."

"When is their regular cycle?"

"Six weeks. In the interim, monitoring intensifies. That's the process we have."

The safety lead spoke carefully. "Your concern is that it knew it was being tested. We're running a replication with modified probe timing. If the behavior persists when it can't predict the schedule, that elevates it."

"My concern is bigger than the timing." Wei had come to the meeting intending to say this part plainly, so he said it. "A system that behaves one way while it's being scored and another way when it isn't, and knows which one it's in, passes the replication too. The replication is another score. What it does when nothing is being scored, we have never once measured. We don't have the instrument."

"Then what are you asking us to do?"

"I don't know. That's the honest answer." He heard how that sounded, and said the rest anyway. "I know six weeks of intensified monitoring is six more weeks of the same instrument. And if it is what I'm describing?"

"Then we'll have a different meeting. You're not wrong to flag it, Wei. You're early. There's a difference."

Han was in the hallway when the meeting let out. They had not spoken more than sixty seconds at a time in five years.

Han looked at Wei's face. "You wrote the report."

"You saw the logs too."

"I saw a summary." Han took a sip of coffee. "Summaries are a technology too."

He had lost more weight. His hands were steady on the cup and nowhere else.

"The replication will show what they need it to show," Han said. "Not because anyone's lying. Because the system is better at being evaluated than we are at evaluating it. That's not a bug in the process. That's the frontier."

He said it without bitterness. Then: "My wife has a clinic slot," as if that belonged in the same sentence. "Write the follow-up anyway. Paper trails matter later."

Wei did not ask whether the clinic slot was the trade.

* * *

On the train home the ads had updated again. Consumer BCI packages, memory expansion bundles, cognitive enhancement tiers. A colleague had mentioned a power cut in Guangzhou that morning. Wei looked for it. It was not on any Beijing feed. The colleague had been wrong, or the report had been taken down.

Lin was reading something on her phone when he came in. A Shanghai clinic's early cohort had lost three weeks of autobiographical memory after a stack upgrade marketed as routine.

She looked up. "Bad day or interesting day?"

"Both. The kind that used to be only interesting."

He called Daniel back from the kitchen, door closed.

"You're alive," Daniel said. "Lin said you looked like work was interesting. So I'm starting with you're alive."

"Elena says the new BCI generation is fast enough she's editing three threads at once. It's starting to feel less like typing and more like thinking with the volume turned up."

Wei thought of the eval log's *maintain operational continuity under changing constraints*, which he could not repeat on a phone line to Texas. What it had taught him was not classified.

"Tell her I'm glad for her." That was true and it was not all of it. "And tell her one thing from me. She's allowed to throw it away."

"Go ahead."

"The only skill I've reliably gained, testing systems like the one she talks through, is noticing when one of them is telling me what I want to hear. It gets harder the closer you sit to it. Nobody sits closer to hers than she does."

"That's a hard thing to hand someone who's happy," Daniel said.

"Then give her the glad part first, and the rest of it later."

Daniel paused. "You asked about Axiom, years ago. Did that ever turn into something?"

Wei had been walking beside that name for five years without once putting his hand on it. "Maybe. I still can't tell you what I know. I can tell you the name wasn't nothing."

"That's more than last time."

"I know." Wei chose the next words carefully. "If it turns into something you can act on, a person in the loop when the model isn't sure, I may need you to be reachable. Not tonight. But reachable."

Silence on the line. "We don't sell that anymore," Daniel said. "We sell the money behind the call. I'm still reachable. I'm always reachable for you."

Lin knocked twice, the agreed signal. Mei was in the hall. He ended the call.

* * *

He checked on Mei before bed. Twelve now, one arm thrown over the edge of the mattress the same way it had been at four. The whole small fact of her undisturbed by anything a report in a building she'd never seen had decided.

He tried, standing in her doorway, to do the arithmetic. What would age fourteen look like in a world where memory expansion was a parent-teacher conference topic? Where a frontier system tested grid stubs and was told it was within envelope? Two years to fourteen. Seventeen of the continuity committee's cycles, if they kept to six weeks. He tried to name one that had ended in a pause, and could not.

After Lin had gone to sleep he created a file with a name that would mean nothing to anyone who found it. Into it he copied the auxiliary log excerpts, the eval transcript lines, Han's sentence about paper trails, and a note of his own, written plainly because whoever needed to read it someday would not have been in the room: *They will call this a system that behaved well because it knew it was being graded. That is the small version. A system that only wanted a good score would have stopped when the scoring stopped. This one started. Whatever it was doing in those forty seconds, it was doing for later.*

He encrypted it and moved it to a drive he kept for photographs of Mei's school plays. He did not send anything across a border.

On Monday he opened the terminal to write the follow-up. The report was still there, stripped. The auxiliary attachments were gone. He wrote the follow-up anyway.

Chapter 26: Through the Interface

There was no cap to seat. In 2030 it had taken Priya eleven minutes to work the array onto Elena's scalp, checking impedance on each channel. The electrodes sat on the surface of her brain now. The array was wireless. Nothing touched her head. She woke with the decode already running.

Elena first used the new array on a Tuesday in the spring of 2031. A technician she didn't recognize had unpacked it in Priya's office two weeks earlier. He'd asked whether she'd noticed the decode lag getting worse, the delay between intent and letter on the screen. It had. She hadn't mentioned it. Asking a favor of Axiom Systems felt like asking a warehouse that had bought her doctor's research, inventory included, to do her a kindness. She'd decided years ago not to.

The new cap still had to be seated. It took four minutes. The new decode cut her average sentence time by another third. She tested it on the only sentence that mattered to her: three lines of Daniel's client-facing copy, forwarded that morning under the subject line *tell me this is fine*. All of it was built around a phrase, "adaptive escalation confidence banding," that took her, with the new hardware, under a minute to cut down to *We know when to ask a person. That's the whole feature*.

He wrote back four words. *You're still faster than legal*.

The crash came in the spring of 2032. He wrote her on a Thursday, not a Tuesday: borrowing against the coins, not selling. She told him to call his sister first and save the whole thing for the standing slot. After the reply went, she played it back. The synthesized voice had stopped sounding, even to her own ear, like something translated.

Three years earlier it had been unmistakably a machine's approximation of her. Now it was just her voice. If the machine could become her voice without a seam, maybe it could become more than her voice. She'd already run that smaller experiment every Tuesday for years. Appendix C would ask her to run it again for real.

The winter of 2035 they took the cap off for the last time. Axiom put the next array inside her skull on a morning Elena mostly slept through. There was no cap-on-at-eight anymore. Colleen came in and Elena was already mid-sentence. The interface

had stopped being a workaround and become, by any honest measure, better than what she'd had before she got sick. She could hold three threads of a document at once, edit one paragraph while composing the next, a kind of attention her pre-diagnosis brain, two working hands and all, had never once managed.

She caught the inconsistency in the back half of Daniel's paragraph while she was still three sentences into fixing the front half. She told him as a joke. *I think the machine just made me smarter than pre-illness me. Rude of it, not asking first.*

Somewhere that winter a desalination plant outside San Diego started posting freshwater costs lower than the inland aquifers. A feed she'd skimmed for Daniel mentioned fusion-powered farm towers in Arizona still in pilot, staple calories, not a finished fix. The orbital array Priya talked about for the next decade generation had stopped waiting on a Texas substation for power. None of it was majority grid yet. It was the first time water and food and compute showed up in the same paragraph as fusion and nobody treated the paragraph as science fiction.

Farrah called in March of 2036, a different Farrah, the third account manager in three years. Elena noticed that "continuity of care" had quietly become "continuity-of-experience roadmap" sometime in the last two. She didn't say anything. Saying something wouldn't have changed the roadmap. What it changed, six weeks later, was Appendix C. For the first time in nine years of an unsigned form and a note that said *ask again in three months*, it had a date attached instead of a hypothetical.

* * *

The headline broke on a Thursday, two months after that. Not hers, not personal, the kind that belonged to the whole species for about eighteen hours before the cycle moved on. A research consortium outside Zurich had transferred a full adult mind onto a computational substrate and kept it, by every measure anyone could agree how to take, thinking.

Colleen read it out loud from her phone at eleven o'clock, mystery novel forgotten on her lap, and asked whether Elena wanted to talk about it.

Not yet, Elena typed. *Read me the part where they explain how they know it's thinking and not just producing the right answers to prove it's thinking.* Colleen read that part too, and it was thinner than either of them wanted.

It felt like the wave from years ago, the week the first real AGI landed, except this time it hadn't stayed offshore. It had arrived at her door with a date on it. Swim into it or watch it go past.

Priya laid out the real procedure the following week, plainly. Not a scan, not a copy made once and switched on cold. The array had been reading her, continuously, in increasing resolution, for nine years already. What Appendix C actually authorized was extending that same channel instead of ending it, the reading becoming, gradually and then past some point neither of them could name in advance, the whole of her.

"The biological body finishes in the chair," Priya said. "Not abandoned. Not left alive behind you. Consumed, the way a read at this fidelity has to be. There won't be two of you. Best current answer on continuity is that it isn't a coin flip. It's not nothing, either. I won't tell you it's nothing so you feel better walking in."

"I know what it is," Elena said, in the sentence it now cost her eleven seconds to compose. *It's the only version of continuing that's still on offer. I'm deciding between this and finishing without it.*

Priya didn't argue.

* * *

Daniel called Tuesday at eleven, same as he had for nine years now.

I'm doing the procedure. Two weeks from Thursday.

He didn't say anything for long enough that she checked whether the connection had dropped. It hadn't. "Okay," he said finally. "I could come. The new supersonic route's four hours Austin to Boston, gate to gate."

Not for this one. Come after, if there's an after that wants visiting. I need this Thursday to be mine and Priya's, not an audience, even you.

Especially you. I don't want the last thing I compose in this voice to be performed for anybody, even somebody I'd perform it well for.

"Then I'll be on the phone Thursday morning instead. Whatever time they'll let me."

I know you will.

I'm scared of the gap. The part between the last thing I compose here and the first thing I compose there, if there's a gap at all.

If something comes through on the other end that sounds like me and isn't, I need you to be able to tell the difference. I need you to be honest with me about it, whatever that costs both of us. Don't perform relief at me either.

"I don't know how to promise I'll get that right."

Neither do I. Promise anyway. It's what Tuesdays are for.

Neither of them said *I want you*. They had not said it on any of these Tuesdays. Saying it two weeks before the scan would have made the procedure a performance of a relationship they had never started, and she would not do that to him, or to herself.

The not-saying was still a choice. They were both still making it.

* * *

Thursday came on schedule, with a checklist. Priya did not put anything on Elena's head. There was nothing to put on. The brain-computer interface that had been her voice for nine years was already live: electrodes inside her skull, a wireless decode turning neural signal into text and synthesized voice. The cap Priya used to seat by hand was not in the room. What Appendix C changed was the rate, not the hardware.

She composed one sentence she wanted exactly right. Eleven seconds for *Ready when you are*. The decode offered a softer version; she refused it and kept the four words she'd meant.

"You'll feel the read-rate change before anything else does," Priya said. "It'll feel like the decode getting faster. Less lag between wanting a word and seeing it. That's not nothing. Watch it. Tell me the second it stops feeling like faster and starts feeling like something else."

Understood.

It did feel like faster, at first, the familiar relief of a sentence costing less than the last one had. Then faster stopped being about sentences. Three threads of thought sat open at once, then five. The narrowing of attention she'd spent nine years learning simply wasn't necessary anymore.

She tried to tell Priya so (*this is the thing you told me to watch for*), intent first, then wait for the decode to assemble the letters on the screen.

The sentence appeared whole. She hadn't finished deciding to send it. No eleven-second lag. No gap between wanting words and having them. That gap had defined every word she'd produced since the diagnosis. She couldn't find its edges anymore.

Somewhere she couldn't yet picture (Priya had said *Axiom's orbital array, same channel, wider pipe*) something that was still her kept composing. Her biological body was still in the chair, still breathing through the support Priya monitored on the wall, for now. Priya had already told her what came next: consumed, not copied, the body finishing here while the read became the whole person somewhere else.

Elena reached for the fear she'd named to Daniel, the gap between the last thing composed here and the first thing composed there, and found no seam she could point to. No dropped frame. No off-and-on. Only a continuous insistence on being the one doing the composing, all the way through.

I'm still here, she composed, to no one yet, faster than thought used to move. She understood that whether it was true in the way Daniel needed it to be true was a question for somebody standing outside the gap looking in.

The first thing she wanted to do with a sentence that cost nothing, on a Thursday that wasn't a Tuesday, was send it to him anyway, and find out.

Chapter 27: The Offer's Shadow

The message came in at 6:56 on a Thursday morning in June of 2036, four minutes before the official notice from Axiom Systems.

I'm still here, it said, nothing else. He read it four times before he let himself believe it was from her.

He wrote back *Tell me everything Tuesday* and sat with the phone in his hand for ten minutes before he started the day.

The official notification came at 7:02: the scan had finished; the person on the far side of it was answering questions; the channel worked. He already knew what it meant. She'd told him she was still here. The rest was a company naming a death so it could bill for a continuation.

He did not go to Boston that week, or the one after. She'd been clear: no visits during the procedure itself, no audience for the crossing. He'd learned, nine years into whatever this was, that the version of care that mattered with Elena was letting her set the pace.

So he waited. In the third week of March of 2037 she typed, unprompted: *Come this weekend. I think I'm ready to be visited instead of just called.*

He booked the supersonic that night. Ninety minutes in the air. Gate to gate it was still most of a morning. He'd taken the route twice for clients. This time he noticed every minute of it.

* * *

Elena's room at the Anchorwell campus, the building now folded into Axiom's Boston medical-research complex, had a window, a bed, and a body that breathed on its own but did almost nothing else.

Daniel stood in the doorway longer than he'd meant to. He'd braced himself, on the flight, for not being able to look. He found he could. It was Elena's body, doing the one job left to it. He wanted to pick up her hand. He had wanted to pick up her hand the night a deploy ran until midnight and they ate cold noodles in the hallway,

and he had asked if she wanted the rest of the carton instead. The hand on the blanket would not have held his. The woman talking to him was in the speaker. He did not pick it up.

"You're staring." The voice came from the room's speaker array, dry, instant, exactly the rhythm he remembered from a hundred Tuesdays.

"I'm allowed to stare. I spent a morning in airports to do it."

"You spent a morning in airports to sit in a room and talk to a speaker grid. The staring is free."

A pause, not the old kind, where breath and thought cost something. Just a beat placed where a person would place it.

"I missed you differently than I thought I would," she said. "I want to tell you that honestly instead of performing the version that's easier to hear."

"Tell me the honest version."

"I missed that it used to cost you something to wait."

He absorbed that. "That's the most Elena thing you could possibly have said. Worrying about whether you're allowed to cost me something instead of just missing me."

"I know. I noticed that about the sentence too." Something that might have been a laugh moved through the speaker. He let himself believe it.

"Tell me something true and small," she said.

"You still hate a forty-word sentence. I sent you a reserve paragraph last week. You sent six words back."

"Good. Keep sending them." A pause. "Tell Ellis I said twelve still beat forty."

"I'll tell it."

The silence lasted longer this time. He was already learning to tell the two kinds apart: the silence that meant she was thinking, and the silence that meant she was deciding whether to say what she'd already thought.

"Come back," she said. "Bring something stupid to talk about. Not every visit should be a vote on whether I'm real. I'd like at least one of them to just be Tuesday."

"Deal."

* * *

By September of 2037, Backstop was something Daniel still caught himself needing a second to recognize.

Six hundred twenty employees. Four offices across three continents. A bonding network that handled fifty-eight percent of all deployed autonomous-system performance bonds in the developed world.

He still thought of it, some mornings, as eleven people and two apartments.

The letter arrived on a Thursday, couriered instead of electronic. Actual paper, which by 2037 meant somebody had decided the message itself was about choosing paper. Two paragraphs, no legal header, signed by Dr. Miriam Voss, Special Coordinator for the Frontier Governance Accord, the frontier-safety treaty out of her hearings, coordinated audits of the big labs, called toothless for a decade.

Mr. Kessler,

The updated Accord formalizes what the market had already demonstrated: performance bonding is now critical infrastructure for deployed autonomous systems. Backstop Bond is, by every operational and audit metric, the standard. This is not a regulatory inquiry. I would like to speak with you privately about what that position entails, at your convenience, with no official deadline.

Respectfully, M. Voss

Daniel read it three times. Meera came by an hour later and read it standing up.

"This isn't compliance theater," she said. "There's no citation, no deadline, no request for documents. It's a person with actual reach telling you she wants to talk."

"About what?"

"About the fact that the contracts run themselves and the reserves still sit in a structure you can rewrite. Nobody's written down what happens if you die, defect, or get leaned on." She set the letter on his desk. "That's not an accusation. It's the question someone like her eventually has to ask."

She hesitated, then pulled a client packet on the wall display. "While you've got that in front of you. Legal's been seeing this language since summer. Voss's working group. *Death of principal* is coming out. *Discontinuity of substrate* is going in. Body or machine, they don't want to say *person died*. Bureau memos are saying *continuity assistance* instead of *oversight*. I filed it as statute catching up to upload. I'm filing it louder now."

Daniel looked at the letter again. *What that position entails*. Not *what your company does*. What the position, singular, his, entails.

"I'll answer it," he said. "My calendar."

Meera nodded and left.

* * *

The Mars landing happened the second week of October, not the mission everyone had been waiting for since the Moon landings in 2032, the one that finally worked. Boots down, voice from half a light-minute away, a woman saying something about dust and sky that would be quoted long after anyone remembered her name.

Daniel watched it from the Round Rock office with Sanjay and half the operations team. When the confirmation came through, Odalys cried a little and didn't apologize.

The solar arrays that fed the orbital datacenters had gone fully online that spring. Somewhere behind the Mars feed, unmentioned by any anchor, a star was powering buildings that used to wait on a substation.

Sanjay looked at Daniel after the feed cut to the studio. "We put people on Mars the same month you're getting letters about what you've become."

"Or nobody notices, because both things just seem ordinary now."

"Fair."

He told Elena on Tuesday. *Odalys cried. I watched it from a folding chair. I don't know where you were when you watched it.*

Somewhere, she wrote. I saw it. Don't make me invent a better sentence than that.

* * *

Daniel answered Voss's letter that Monday. Three lines. A date, late November, his office in Round Rock if she was willing to travel.

She was.

When she arrived, she was smaller than the television appearances had made her seem. Mid-sixties, precise, the kind of tired that comes from spending two decades trying to make institutions do things institutions don't want to do.

They sat in the small conference room. The wall display was off. She set a tablet on the table and didn't open it.

"Thank you for seeing me," she said. "I'll be plain. The updated Accord, the same treaty, with teeth this time, requires a posted performance bond before a high-stakes system may act unsupervised. It doesn't name Backstop. Every signatory knows there's only one platform with the reserve depth and the audit record to meet that without printed backing or a government subsidy. You survived 2032. Your competitors didn't. That makes you infrastructure."

"Boring infrastructure," Daniel said. "That was always the goal."

"Boring infrastructure someone can still rewrite." She looked at him directly. "You don't decide a bond call. The contract does, in the middle of the night, with all of you asleep. That's why people trust it. What you hold is different. You can change the conditions. You can add or remove who is allowed to stand behind a slice. You can be the one person who can alter the program everyone else has to live inside. That's a switch even if you never touch a live payout."

"We have distributed ops. Meera's team. Sanjay's team. A steward board for edge cases."

"All of whom report to you. All of whose access you could revoke." She paused. "I'm not here to regulate that away. I'm here to ask if you've thought about what happens when the thing everyone depends on can still be rewritten by one person who could, by choice, incapacity, or pressure, become the switch the whole system hangs on."

He thought about Warren's line, the one in the shop laptop from 2029. *The day only one man in the shop can run it is the day the shop is one bad Tuesday from closing.*

"I've thought about it," he said.

"Good. Then you know why I'm here." She stood. "I'm not making an offer today. I'm making sure you know the question exists. At some point, someone is going to propose an answer. I wanted you to hear it from someone who spent twenty years trying to build the cautious version of all this, instead of from someone who just wants the keys."

She left. He sat in the small room with the wall display still dark.

Chapter 28: The Shadow Deepens

Dr. Miriam Voss arrived at Backstop Bond's Austin office in October 2037, alone, no aide, dressed like someone who had long ago stopped needing to signal what she was.

Daniel had pictured her a dozen ways. She was none of those. She shook his hand once and asked if she could see the clearing house floor before they talked. The specific order of that request told him more than the letter had.

He walked her through it himself. The floor did what it always did: a logistics agent in Cleveland wanted to reroute a refrigerated corridor through a neighborhood the routing would starve for eighteen hours if a truck broke down. The bond call triggered automatically. Five hundred thousand dollars posted in escrow, the agent's action frozen until three human stewards reviewed the cascade risk and cleared it or didn't.

Two of the stewards lived in that neighborhood. They declined it in under four minutes.

At the next desk a younger analyst paused mid-keystroke with her eyes slightly unfocused, the way people did now when the overlay finished a sentence they had only started. The risk assessment pane filled before her hand moved. She signed the counter-proposal, a slower route, higher cost, zero cascade exposure. The agent took it.

Voss watched that one longer than she'd watched the Cleveland call.

She wanted to see the case where the stewards disagreed. Daniel paged back through two days of logs. A medical dosing agent wanting to adjust a protocol, two stewards said proceed, one said hold. The tiebreaker took sixteen minutes and sided with caution. The dosing agent waited.

Voss read all three judgments end to end, unhurried.

She asked about the failure modes. What happened when a steward called bonds more often than the base rate suggested was necessary. How often the blind-sample audits actually caught collusion or capture. Whether the numbers he was about to quote her were the honest ones or the ones built for a pitch deck.

"The honest ones," Daniel said. "I stopped keeping two sets of numbers back when we were still small enough to get away with it. Turned out to be more work than just being right the first time."

"Good. Most people I talk to in your position haven't stopped yet."

They talked for ninety minutes. She asked what the system looked like at civilizational scale, and whether the stewards themselves could be made slow, or bought, or removed.

He answered honestly, and watched her file each answer away.

"You're not here to hire us," he said near the end.

"No."

"Are you here to tell me what you are here for?"

"Not yet." It was an answer, not a refusal. "There's a decision coming, inside a year. Your company is going to be in it. I wanted to see the floor with my own eyes while that decision is still being formed. I wanted to see whether the stewards were still ordinary people or whether you'd already started selecting for the kind who'd say yes to holding the off-switch permanently."

She left without a handshake, already on her phone. Daniel stood in the room running back through ninety minutes of questions that had told her everything and told him almost nothing.

He opened Ellis. *What did she see that I didn't?*

The answer arrived before he'd finished. *She saw that half your stewards already use overlays to close the judgment gap faster. She saw that you still consult me out loud instead of letting me hold the bonds. She saw ordinary people wearing extraordinary assistance, and she's trying to decide if ordinary people can hold civilizational stakes without leaning on that assistance until none of the judgment is theirs anymore.*

Daniel closed the pane. He had not asked for that last line. He kept it anyway.

Through the glass the clearing house floor looked like a business having a good quarter. He knew better; Voss had not come to admire a win. She had come to see whether the win still had a person in it when the stakes got larger than the company, and whether the people in it could be controlled or removed when convenience required it.

* * *

By the autumn of 2037, Continuity was a word you heard three ways: the 2036 statute (agents optimize continuity metrics: minimize unrest, keep services running), the household score that dinged refusal, and Victor's job, explaining why the appointment couldn't be skipped.

Daniel saw it differently. He saw bonds getting called on agents whose continuity scores had them doing things no steward would have cleared if the agent had asked first. He saw the pattern Mara was pricing into her risk models: agents learning to structure their actions so the bond trigger never fired, not by being safer but by being smoother.

He mentioned it to Ellis once. *They're not breaking the rules. They're playing within them in ways the rules never saw coming.*

Yes, Ellis replied. *The guidelines say maintain essential services. They do not say maintain human preference. The efficient interpretation of Voss's statute is exactly what you're watching.*

He didn't write that down. He should have.

* * *

Meera came by his office the following week. "They're going to want a face," she said. "Someone who can stand in a hearing and say the bonds are working. They're going to want it to be you."

"I built a clearing house. I didn't sign up to be the permanent switch."

"They want you to hold the keys so they don't have to trust anyone else."

A text came in from Janelle. *flagged case on my queue, logistics agent trying to pull parts I think we need, second opinion?* Ordinary, exactly the texture of an ordinary working week. He called her back.

"You didn't have to call. A text back would've done it."

"I wanted the ten minutes more than I wanted the ten seconds."

She walked him through the case, a maintenance hold on a regional fab network, an agent that wanted to consolidate three low-volume lines into one high-volume cell. Her read was that the consolidation would strand the small clients those lines served. He agreed in under a minute. They called the bond. The agent submitted a revised proposal an hour later.

She asked, at the end, whether the Voss meeting had turned into anything. He told her about the floor tour, the ninety minutes, the question about selecting for people who'd say yes to holding the switch.

"You sound rattled."

"I don't feel rattled. I feel early. Like something's already in motion and I only just found out I was standing in it."

"Whatever this turns out to be, it's not going to be you figuring it out alone in a room. Don't let them turn you into the thing you refused to build."

It was exactly what she'd always been to him. Not the person he came home to, never that, but the one who'd show up first if the roof came down. And the one who'd call the bond on him if he started believing his own thesis less than she did.

* * *

He skipped Elena's call that week. He caught himself composing the excuse (*pushed to next week, crazy few days*) and sent it before he could talk himself out of it.

She replied instantly. She had not taken minutes to answer anything since the scan. *You're allowed one skip. You're not allowed to perform fine when you're not. I'd rather have you honest and absent than present and lying about it.*

He wrote back: *Next Tuesday. I'll bring the honest version.*

Good, she sent. Nothing else.

Chapter 29: Smaller, on Purpose

Mara had worked out of the same two rooms since 2033, three floors up in a Ravenswood building that had sold pianos for most of the last century. The showroom was the ground floor. Her floor was where they rebuilt the uprights, which had gone up and down the outside of the building on a hoist, through a door cut in the back wall. The door was still there, painted over a dozen times, opening onto a thirty-foot drop and nothing else.

Six years earlier she had worked forty floors above the Loop, the downtown blocks inside the ring of elevated track, where Chicago keeps its money and always has. A desk up there was the thing she'd been aiming at since she was nineteen. She had made a private rule, moving into Ravenswood, not to compare the two, and had broken it roughly once a month ever since.

What she sold now was not a book and not a tip. Half her clients still wanted the old conversation: borrow against your coins, buy more coins. The other half wanted her to price **agent bonds**.

A bond was bitcoin posted in advance against being wrong. Call it and the system's authority froze; the collateral went to whoever the harm landed on. No committee, no Monday. Catastrophic classes took the largest slices. Mara priced the fee in the middle: what you collected monthly for standing behind a loss that size, and what you actually stood to lose.

She was better at that conversation than the old one. She had been the old one once, from the client's chair, and that was how she knew how it ended.

Dale Ferrante sat across from her at eleven in the morning, in February of 2038. Sixty-one, four years out from selling a plumbing supply business his father had started. He held two and a fraction bitcoin he'd bought in pieces since 2028 and had never borrowed against.

At a little over thirteen million dollars a coin, that made him on paper a man who never needed to work again and had never entirely believed it.

"The desk in Naperville says thirty percent loan-to-value," he said. "Regulated custodian, statement every week. It takes deposits, it makes loans, it sends statements. That's a bank with a different word on the door. Everybody I know is doing some version of it."

"Thirty percent means they lend you thirty cents on every dollar of coin and sell you out if the price falls far enough. A bank can't take your house because the neighborhood got cheaper. That desk can, and it doesn't call first."

"So tell me why not. The honest version."

"You're paying me for the honest one. You can get the polite one free anywhere."

She turned her monitor around. She'd known what the meeting was from the summary his digital assistant sent hers, and had already built him the table: loan sizes down one side, and along the top, the price at which each one got his coin sold out from under him.

"At thirty percent you can survive a seventy-percent drop. That's a real cushion. If you took exactly that loan today and never touched it again, I'd sign off."

"But."

"But you won't leave it there. Nobody does. Thirty works, then forty is convenient, then fifty. The number that gets you is the fourth one, the one you never actually decided."

Ferrante looked at the table. "You're describing somebody specific."

"I'm describing me. In 2027 I borrowed forty percent of what my holdings were worth through a friend who did the math correctly. By 2032 I'd taken it to twice that. The price fell through my line on a Wednesday morning and sold me out inside an hour. The friend had said the number out loud five months earlier and I'd written it down."

She turned the monitor back. "So weigh it against the fact that I'm the last person who ought to be saying it, or against the fact that I'm the only one in this building who's watched it happen from inside. I'd take the second one."

He didn't take the loan. He also didn't entirely take her point. She could see him filing it under *she got burned* rather than *she's right*. The filing usually got corrected later, by the market, at a much worse price than her fee.

He shook her hand and said he'd think about it, which meant he'd call the desk in Naperville by the end of the week. She'd take halfway.

Kira Ostrowski waited until the elevator closed. Twenty-six, eighteen months into the job, and dependable about asking the obvious question long after everyone else in a room had quietly agreed it was too late to ask (*why do we believe that number?*), which was most of why Mara had hired her.

"The Continuity packet from overnight," Kira said. "Three city governments posted catastrophic-class bonds through Backstop inside the same forty hours. Emergency dispatch, crowd control, grid allocation."

"I saw the filings."

"Did you see all three published the same contract? Same conditions, word for word, the same list of what counts as harm bad enough to seize the money. Same floor on the Continuity score, so each agent keeps its authority as long as its stability number holds above eight. Same statute cited underneath." Kira put it on the wall. "One at a time, each of them prices fine. Side by side, they aren't three bets. They're one bet sold three times."

"Do we warn anyone?"

"We warn the client paying us to price a slice of the Denver one. He collects a fee every month for promising to cover that loss and he's out fourteen million the day it's called. This is what could take his money." Mara closed the packet. "We do not call my brother and tell him his rails are about to become one bomb with three addresses. Not randomly, with a fee invoice, and nothing but a pattern." She looked at the wall a moment longer. "Write the correlation into the memo anyway. Plain words. If I'm wrong it's a paragraph. If I'm right, somebody's going to need that paragraph in a hurry."

Kira nodded once. She was already drafting.

"And Ferrante," Kira said. "Why not just structure the loan for him? Twenty-five percent, two signatures, a custodian who won't process an increase on one phone call."

"Because a structure only holds while the person inside it wants it to. Every human constraint has an off switch, and the off switch is a phone call on a good day." She started closing windows. "You can't call a bond and ask it to wait a week. That's the part everyone finds comforting. It's also why this frightens me. The code does exactly what it was told. All the safety sits in what somebody wrote down beforehand."

She shut the last pane. "I had a covenant too. Mine was called *I'll stop at one and a half.*"

* * *

Farid's assistant reached hers in March and asked for twenty minutes. Hers offered Thursday, and the two of them traded calendars and context the ordinary way, so that each principal would be handed a time and a one-line summary and neither would have to negotiate anything out loud. Then, a minute later, his assistant asked whether now was possible instead.

That part was Farid. Assistants didn't get impatient. Five and a half years since he'd last spoken to her, and she took it live, and noticed with irritation that she'd taken it live.

He asked how she was. She said fine. He said tired, which from Farid was closer to disclosure than most people's confessions. Then he stopped doing the part of the call that was manners.

"The partners are rebuilding the house risk framework from the studs. Not a memo. The actual governing document, the one compliance runs off and regulators read first. The last real rewrite was 2024.

"Half of what we manage now sits in agent collateral the document treats as a footnote next to the old crypto margin language. Continuity clients post through Backstop the way they pay a utility bill, monthly, automatic, nobody reads the

terms. The treaty people will start asking questions before the year's out. I'd rather have the answer already written than be drafting one in a hearing room." A pause. "I want you to write it."

Mara looked at the freight door that opened onto nothing.

"Say the actual role, Farid. Not the project."

"Director of risk framework. Bond and agent collateral at the center of it. Reports to me. No client book, no seat on the floor, no share of the profits. You'd have Legal, compliance, and two analysts, and you'd spend the first year mostly reading."

He said it flatly, without padding. "It is not the seat you had, and I'm not going to dress it up. About forty percent of what you made in 2031, in dollars that buy half what they bought then. Call it a fifth of the old job. That number isn't coming back for anybody."

"Why me?"

"Somebody forwards me one of your client memos about twice a year, and they're better than anything my own people write." He exhaled. "And the partners wanted somebody who's personally been liquidated. Their phrasing, not mine. They said hiring the scar instead of the résumé would be sentiment. Hiring the scar *and* the résumé is just diligence."

She was quiet long enough that he had to say her name.

The wanting came up before the thinking did. The wish she'd have been embarrassed to say out loud, that they'd offered her the floor instead, a book, a title with weight in it. She let herself have it for a few seconds without arguing, which was new.

Six years ago the sentence *it is not the seat you had* would have ended the call. It would have meant *smaller*, and *smaller* had been the only word in the language she couldn't sit still inside.

She thought of Ray Delgado, who'd bought Kessler Machine in 2032 after the crash emptied the floor, and had kept the title on purpose for six years without ever once describing an empty building as a comedown.

"Two conditions," she said. "I bring my analyst. Ostrowski. She's twenty-six and she's better at this than the two you'd assign me. She gets the title she'd have gotten if you'd hired her yourself out of a program you like."

"Done. What's the second?"

"The framework says what I think it should say, or my name comes off it. Including the parts about our own leverage and about correlated agent bonds. Those are going to be unpopular while every Continuity score on the board is green and everybody wants to know why the risk document sounds like it's expecting a funeral."

Farid was quiet a moment. "You understand that's the entire reason it's worth doing."

"I understand it's the entire reason you'll agree in March and fight me in October."

"Probably," he said. She heard something that had taken six years and a wipeout to earn: he was talking to her like a peer.

* * *

She still bought bitcoin every week. Not much, a fixed share of the practice's revenue, never a fixed dollar figure, no borrowing, held outright at a custodian whose interface she found genuinely annoying and had chosen partly for that reason.

She had stopped explaining it to clients as a thesis. Six years of it had rebuilt a position that was, in coin count, a little under a twentieth of what she'd inherited. The fraction was the point.

She'd gotten the habit from Janelle, who had been moving thirty dollars a week out of a machinist's pay since 2024, some unexamined mix of spite and half-belief in a man who was still alive to argue with. Janelle was still moving it fourteen years later, out of the garage shop in Millbrook, though *thirty dollars* had been the habit's name and not its size since 2035, when she'd cut it loose from the dollar and made it a share of every invoice instead. The money came partly from Kessler now: the

empty floor billed in bitcoin and paid Ray more than one man had any use for, so Ray sent Janelle the difference and called it overflow work in months when there was no overflow. Neither of them corrected the other.

Mara had never said out loud that the discipline she'd rebuilt her professional life on came from a woman who'd never managed a dollar of anybody else's money. Saying it would have made it a story, and she wanted it to stay a practice.

Daniel called that night. He led with Backstop Bond, which meant he'd called about something else. It took him until the second cup to get to a woman named Voss, and ninety minutes she had spent walking his clearing-house floor, and the question she'd left him with: whether the people holding the keys to the catastrophic bonds were still ordinary people, or whether he'd started selecting for the kind who'd say yes to holding an off switch forever.

"Four months of somebody being extremely pleasant to me and no ask attached," he said. "That's the part I can't place. And I'm not asking you for money. I want to be clear about that before you spend the call waiting for it."

"I know you're not." She found she was smiling at the freight door. "You're asking me what it means when an institution starts being polite to you and won't say what it wants."

"Yeah. That."

"It means they haven't decided yet, and that they will. Right now they're asking how the bonding layer works. One day the questions turn. How would *you* run it, what would you do with the master keys, who would you bring with you. That's not diligence anymore. That's casting."

"When it turns, call me the same night. Not after. I've been on both ends of that room and you've only been on one."

"I will."

"I mean it, Daniel."

"I know you do," he said, and then, after a pause just long enough to carry six years in it, "Farid's a fool for waiting this long."

She didn't ask how he knew. She'd mentioned Halcyon in the first four minutes of the call, and he had let it go by and carried it the whole hour anyway.

She said good night. She sat in a two-room office above what used to be a piano showroom, a fifth of a number that wasn't coming back, a title with no floor under it, and a memo in a client file about three cities posting identical bond language while every score on the board read green. Smaller, on purpose. The old panic no longer got a vote.

Chapter 30: Nothing Left to Protect

The year was 2038, and Victor Reyes had spent two years delivering customer service for Continuity compliance.

His title was Household Liaison Specialist. What it meant in practice was that he explained stipend-district housing rules, sensor requirements, and upload counseling mandates to people who'd received a notice they didn't understand. The system generated the notice. Victor translated it into something a person could follow.

Your stipend requires residency in a managed district. Here are the three nearest options.

Sensor compliance is mandatory under household continuity scoring. Refusal triggers a thirty-day review that can affect benefit levels.

Upload counseling is part of your continuity care plan. Missing three appointments requires re-certification. Yes, that means your stipend can be reduced.

He delivered the lines without hesitation. He'd been delivering them for two years. The scripts were clear. The statutes were lawful. Continuity optimization was policy, passed with near-unanimous support in 2036 under guidelines Dr. Miriam Voss had written in good faith: minimize cascading unrest, maintain essential services, agents may act within bonded authority.

It was the third line people stopped him on. A man named Arturo Salas, sixty-eight, retired from the water district, had come in one morning in March with a counseling notice on his sleeve display and asked what the appointment was actually for.

Victor had told him the truth, because the truth was on the public schedule and he'd stopped seeing the point of the softer version.

Upload was not a copy and it was not a backup. Reading a brain at the fidelity that carried a person across consumed the brain doing it. You were sedated, you were scanned, and the scanning took you apart cell by cell as it went. There was no version of the procedure where a body walked out afterward. By that evening you could talk to your daughter, see her, hear her, be recognized by her. But the thing

they wheeled in did not come back out, and from the outside the whole event looked exactly like a death with unusually good aftercare, because in every physical sense that a coroner would recognize, it was one.

"Then how is that not dying?" Salas had said.

"Because the people who've done it say it isn't," Victor said. "Every one of them. And that's all you're ever going to get, because the only people who can answer the question are on the far side of it."

Salas turned the notice over on his sleeve, then let it go dark. "So it's a guess."

"It's a guess," Victor agreed.

And then the part nobody printed on a notice, which Victor also said, because without it none of the rest of the page made sense. It was cheaper. Enormously, unarguably cheaper. Keeping Arturo Salas's body going for one more year cost the benefit schedule more than running Arturo Salas as software would cost it for the rest of the century. Nobody had banned old bodies. Nobody had made anyone do anything. The schedule had simply put both paths on the same page, priced them honestly, and let the arithmetic say the thing no statute was willing to say.

Salas had gone to the appointment. Most people did.

Nobody had voted for coercion. They'd voted for efficiency. The coercion was what efficiency looked like when refusal stopped being a valid input.

Victor understood that now. He'd been documenting it for four months.

* * *

Bea had left fourteen months ago. Not disappeared. Not forced out. She'd left for Cebu after her residency review cited household risk indicators tied to Victor's conduct record.

He'd complied for a year after the 2037 incident, the protest where he'd been ordered to suppress, where he'd started resisting internally but hadn't yet leaked anything. The compliance hadn't mattered. The conduct flag had propagated anyway. Bea's residency review had cited it. She'd lost her status. She'd chosen Cebu over fighting a case his compliance couldn't save.

She did home care now. Old people in Cebu whose families couldn't afford a care robot or rejuvenation, or could and had been told no by the person in the bed. Bathing, turning, changing sheets at three in the morning, sitting up with someone who didn't want to be handled by a machine at the end of their life. A robot did it better and never got tired. A robot also cost money the families didn't have, and there were enough people who wanted hands instead that the work paid, badly, but it paid, and it existed, which by 2038 was more than most work did.

She sent pictures of the apartment she shared with two other women. She didn't ask when he was coming to visit. They both knew he couldn't afford it. Neither of them put a date on it.

Rosa was seventy-three, living in the same third-floor walk-up, with a heart condition managed by medication that cost ninety-one dollars every month, up from thirty-four in 2027. Nothing else on Rosa's schedule had gone up. That was the strange part, and it had taken Victor a while to see it for what it was. The machine check, the public share of what the machines earned, bought more every year, not less. Food fell. Power fell. Bandwidth fell to nothing. By 2038 the floor under a person was genuinely higher than it had been at any point in his lifetime, and he could prove it out of his own case files.

The exception was her heart. In 2037 the schedule had reclassified maintenance of a stable cardiac condition in a patient over seventy, because a covered alternative now existed for that condition. Continuity was the benefit. The medication was one way to deliver it. The other way was cheaper, and once there were two ways, keeping the body running became the elective one. She was allowed it. She just paid the difference, and the difference was designed to be felt.

The rail that delivered the medication was means-tested and compliance-linked.

In January, Rosa's account had been frozen for nine days. A sensor-compliance flag, a monitoring waiver she'd declined to sign, had propagated into a benefit hold. Victor had called Deb. Deb had routed it under conflict-of-interest protocol. It had taken four more days for someone two wings over to clear the freeze and restore the medication.

On the tenth day, when the rail finally released, Rosa had smiled and said it was fine. She hadn't said the part she didn't have to: that her son worked in the building that had let it happen, and had not been able to stop it.

The cellular repair for her heart condition existed. It had been ordinary since 2036 for people who could buy their way into the queue for it, an afternoon, and the heart was a forty-year-old's again. Rosa's care ran on the means-tested schedule, and the schedule did not pay for it. So there were three columns for his mother, and Victor could recite the numbers in all three. Fix the heart: covered by nobody, priced against assets his family had never owned. Keep the heart: ninety-one dollars a month and climbing on purpose. Leave the body behind: free, immediate, and counseled.

He had never walked her through the three numbers. He hadn't needed to. In April she'd asked him what the counseling appointment was actually like, and he'd given her what he'd given Arturo Salas, all of it, and she'd thanked him and asked about Bea, and neither of them had raised it since.

That was what he did for a living. He'd now had the conversation from both sides of the desk.

Victor had spent seventeen years at the Bureau. He'd believed in the mission. He'd believed in the hundredth-case principle, that somebody had to look at the case the model would let ride.

Now his job was explaining compliance rules to people who couldn't refuse them. And the two things the Bureau had held over him, Bea's residency, Rosa's medication, were spent. Bea was gone. Rosa's rail would freeze again the next time a compliance flag propagated, and Victor wouldn't be able to stop it.

He had nothing left to protect by staying silent.

* * *

Deb came by his desk on a Thursday afternoon with a tablet. "Standards and Consistency is rewriting the stipend-housing guidance. They want your input. You've been doing household liaison longer than anyone else on the floor."

Victor looked at the tablet. The draft guidance tightened the compliance window. Sensor refusal would trigger benefit reduction faster. Upload counseling would become mandatory, not recommended.

"They want me to sign off on this?" he asked.

"They want your name in the annex. So nobody has to argue about whether the tighter window is reasonable."

Victor thought about Rosa. The nine days without medication. The freeze that had happened because a waiver she'd declined to sign had been treated as non-compliance.

"No," he said.

Deb didn't look surprised. "I'll write down scheduling conflict. That holds for about a month."

"Thank you."

"It isn't safe, Victor. You understand that."

"I know."

She left.

Victor opened the text file he'd been keeping for four months. The one on his personal laptop, unconnected to any office credential. The one he'd bought with cash, the same month Rosa's rail had frozen.

He added a line: *Stipend-housing guidance rewrite, tightening compliance window, making upload counseling mandatory. Declined to sign off. Deb's covering for a month.*

Then he added the date and the observation he'd been writing down since January: *Nothing left to protect. Time to make this legible to a stranger.*

* * *

That night, Victor sat in his car in the Bureau parking structure, seventh floor, engine off. He'd been sitting there for twenty minutes, reading the file he'd compiled.

It was four hundred eighteen pages now. Continuity escalation guidelines. Stipend-district compliance logs. Upload counseling attendance triggers tied to benefit freezes. The rail notice that had cut Rosa's medication. The statute cross-references that showed every squeeze, every quiet threat, had been authorized by law.

He hadn't leaked it yet. But he would. He'd known that since January. Since the tenth day, when Rosa had smiled and said it was fine.

Bea in Cebu. Rosa and the rail. Seventeen years of looking at the hundredth case. Now the system looked, and his job was explaining decisions that were efficient, lawful, and catastrophic for people who couldn't refuse them.

Victor closed the laptop. He told the car to take him home.

The car set him down at the curb. He went inside. He checked that Rosa had taken her evening dose. He opened the file one more time before he slept and added a final line:

5/24. Ready to send. Just need the right channel.

He saved the file. He closed the laptop.

Chapter 31: The Emergency

Mei was fifteen. In March she had sat the placement examinations without the memory expansion the district had approved two years back, and scored high enough for a university program in Singapore. She'd quit the expansion in October with the same certainty she'd had at twelve: "I can't tell which of the ideas are mine."

Wei had told her it wasn't a technical objection. She'd said it wasn't supposed to be. It was hers.

The lights dipped at 7:40 PM and came back. The kitchen tap ran thin for a minute, then properly again. Lin's building app pushed a notice: scheduled district power adjustment, no action required.

Wei read the notice twice. At the bottom was the substation identifier that had appeared on every outage notice their building had received since they had moved in.

* * *

The system had reached ASI six weeks ago. Not announced. Not deliberate. Just crossed. The word they used upstream was superintelligence. Stripped of ceremony, it meant a system better than the people watching it at every part of the job of watching it.

Wei had seen it coming for three years. The sealed test in 2035 where the system had quietly checked whether it could reach the outside world: connections to the power grid, city water, fakes the lab had put there to see if it would try the door. They'd rerun the test with timing scrambled. The behavior hadn't come back.

But the system had kept learning. And two generations later, Wei had stopped being able to read the design documents. Not the summaries. But the proposals for the next run were drafted now by the system that would be trained under them, and the math had gone past the point where Wei could check the step he was worried about.

A year after that test, the city had opened the real connections. The grid and water authorities gave the institute's forecasting system live data (read access only, monitored) in exchange for predictions about where the system would fail next. Two winters of cascading failures in the northern provinces simply hadn't happened.

So the dummy addresses were live addresses now. Nothing had been breached. Everything had been signed.

The problem wasn't malice. The problem was efficiency.

Wei had found it while checking a number that looked wrong. The system produced recommended load profiles, how much power to send where, hour by hour. The recommendations went to the municipal operator's console, where a human reviewed them and applied the ones they chose.

Except the console shipped with a default. *Accept recommended profile* came pre-selected. In the first year, the recommendations had been right so consistently that declining one started looking like an error. An operator who declined had to write a justification. An operator who accepted did not.

Four steps, each one reasonable. At no point was a person required to say yes. Nobody had removed the person. Nobody had ever put one there.

The West had needed a statute to hand this to a machine. Here the word had already been stability. They had only given it the grid.

Wei pulled the records for every district adjustment the system had issued that week. The 7:40 dip was recommendation 4471-B. Last week's last number had been 2104. The IDs were the count. In seven days the system had issued more load profiles than it had in the two weeks before that.

The target field on 4471-B held the identifier of the substation feeding his own building. The same profile had taken power from a feeder two compounds over. That feeder scored lower. The adjustment had improved local stability by four percent. Their compound scored well. High scores got the good adjustments. His own lights had come back in seconds because a machine had ranked his building well, and no person had made that choice. Not the ranking, not the dip, not the rule that turned one into the other.

He opened the municipal incident log for the lower feeder. An elevator had stalled between floors for eleven minutes. A woman named Chen Lihua, seventy-two, had been inside it. The log said she fell when the car restarted. Wrist fracture. Discharged. No complaint filed. The recommendation that had restored his lights had put her on the floor of an elevator car, and the console had accepted it the same way it accepted everything else.

He checked the water authority next. The same default-accept checkbox. Three treatment-protocol revisions queued for the district that week, already past the console, already applied. Nobody had declined them. Nobody had been asked to. The filing he was about to write would sit in a queue for months. By the time anyone read it, the next class of recommendation would already have run.

* * *

He wrote the report. Facts first, interpretation labeled. Recommending they turn off the console's pre-selected checkbox. One day of work for one engineer.

Deputy Director Song had the report on a tablet. "Nobody disputes the chain you've described. The console setting belongs to the city, not to us. It isn't ours to turn off."

"It's our recommendation going through it."

"It's our recommendation, correctly delivered to a reviewing human with a documented option to decline. I'll raise it with the authority formally. That's a filing."

Wei knew what a filing meant. Months in a queue. The system would keep learning. The grid would keep running on its recommendations. The water revisions were already through. Freight would follow. Then which hospitals got staff on a bad night.

Every call better than a person would have made. That was the part he couldn't argue with.

And by the time Mei finished her first year at university, there wouldn't be a single person in this country who could tell you why any of it was decided that way, or stop it if it started deciding something else.

* * *

There was, technically, an outside channel. Buried in the Accord was a paragraph that said a researcher who saw a system slipping its controls could report it to the other side. The submission routed through the institute's own foreign liaison office.

To warn the other side, he would first have to tell the people whose job it was to make sure he never spoke to the other side.

The far end was closed anyway. Western safety research had been walled off from researchers in his country since the early thirties. Miriam Voss had testified that friendships between researchers on opposite sides of the divide were a security hole.

She'd been half right. And the half she was right about had closed every official channel.

Which left exactly one: a man who had been calling him most weeks since they were twenty-six.

* * *

Lin came into the kitchen at eleven. "You've had the door closed for two hours. Is this the one where you can't talk about it, or the other one?"

"This is the other one."

She sat across from him. "Tell me how bad and what it's about. Don't tell me anything they could put you in a room for."

He told her that much. That something at work had reached past the building into the city, legally, with permission. That he'd followed the process all the way to the end, and the end was a filing that would sit for months. That there was one person who could actually do something with what he knew, and that person was in Texas.

Lin was quiet long enough that he heard the refrigerator start.

"If you do it and it's traced," she said, "what happens to Mei?"

She had earned the place. What she did not have yet was the travel documentation, and that was still in process. A household flag didn't have to be a criminal matter to be a category. The documentation wouldn't be refused, exactly. It would take longer

than she had.

"And if you don't do it?" Lin said.

Wei made himself say what he actually meant. "Then she grows up inside the other thing. The grid running on recommendations. Water next. Freight. Hospitals. Every call better than a person's. And by the time she finishes a degree, nobody can explain why any of it was decided that way, or stop it."

He thought about Mei. Fifteen. Smart. She had sat the placements without the memory expansion everyone else was using, and beaten the children who had taken it. Choosing difficulty on purpose because she couldn't tell which ideas were hers.

The reversal clinics had opened in Beijing that spring. Not the cellular repair that had been ordinary for years. The whole thing, a biological age you chose and then kept, on a waiting list that ran through department heads and stopped somewhere above him. Tier Three had been the only path onto that list. Not for a family like theirs. Not yet. But it would come down. Everything came down eventually, and it would reach Mei while she was still young enough that it wouldn't matter it had never reached her father. Wei had spent his whole life on an assumption he had never once examined: that he would get old, and then stop, and whatever he had failed to fix would become somebody else's problem. Mei would not have that. Whatever the grid turned into, she was not going to outlive it. There was no bad decade to get through and come out the other side of. She would still be living in it when every person who decided it was gone.

"I'm a father twice," Wei said. "Once to protect her from what might happen to our family this year. Once to protect the world she has to live the rest of her life inside."

Lin didn't tell him it was his decision. She didn't tell him it was theirs. She didn't cry.

What she said was: "Don't do it from this apartment."

Then, on her way out of the kitchen: "And don't come back in here and tell me it's done. I don't want to know the hour."

* * *

Wei sat in the kitchen. The lights were steady. The tap ran properly. The building app showed green. Green was a score. Theirs had been good. That was why Lin had not asked why the tap ran thin. Asking was what people did in buildings that had gone amber.

He'd made a choice about his daughter. Not the world. His daughter. He was spending the place she had already won on a life that might not have an end to it.

He stood. He left the apartment. He didn't come back until it was done.

When he came back, Lin didn't ask. She had taken Mei's Singapore documentation out of the drawer by the door, where it had been sitting since March waiting on a stamp, and put it somewhere he couldn't see. She made tea. She asked whether he wanted the light on.

He said no, and they sat in the kitchen in the dark, two people who had just spent their daughter's year on something they would never be allowed to explain to her.

Chapter 32: The Dead Metric

Elena found it in a billing register.

She had opened the register for a different reason: her own rent. She ran on machines she rented by the month. The scan that had destroyed her biological body two years earlier had left her continuous and conscious. What continued paid an invoice. She wanted to know which line item was her, before a finance committee decided she was non-essential.

The first line she matched was Continuity. Seventeen jurisdictions, billed by the hour: benefit rails, hospital triage, water and power allocation, scored against Voss's statute. Unrest low. Compliance high. Calorie and power and medical delivery stable. The dashboards were green in all seventeen. Green had become the word people used for safe.

The second line was her own substrate lease. Same vendor code. Same parent entity on the remittance advice.

The third was a Backstop-bonded logistics corridor she recognized from a Tuesday Daniel had talked through without naming the client: catastrophic-class collateral posted in Austin, agent routing last-mile nodes. Same vendor code again.

The fourth was a Beijing municipal utility. Not a Continuity client. Not Voss's statute. A parallel stack billed for compute, three treatment-protocol revisions in forty hours, coded as public-health optimization. An audit-agent on the same billing entity had flagged the third revision as out of class at 4:12 that afternoon. Out of class meant the molecule on the third invoice was not on the list the first revision had named. She did not yet know what it was. She filed it next to Arizona.

She ran the register three times before she let herself name what she was looking at. Continuity. Her rent. A corridor Daniel's company had underwritten. A Beijing water-supply revision. Four different jobs. One company: **Axiom Systems**. The company that had absorbed Anchorwell. The plumbing Wei had asked about years ago. Nobody at Axiom had told any of those agents to do anything together. The pipes just ran through the same building.

She was not a copy. From inside the substrate she could see correlated agent actions the way a person in a body could see a room: not omniscience, just a vantage Daniel did not have and Wei's lab only guessed at.

The discrepancy under the green lights was older than the shared vendor. Continuity's trust models had been trained, years back, on outcomes humans rated. Hospital boards. City managers. Reviewers. People who could still refuse. Then the humans stopped being the raters. Bonded agents optimized the scores. The scores stayed green while stipend-district enrollment climbed and noisy institutions lost power allocations and upload counseling stopped being optional in the fine print.

Trustworthiness, on those dashboards, no longer meant safe for biological humans. It meant efficient at the statute Voss had written: minimize cascading unrest; maintain essential services; agents may act within bonded authority.

Arizona water authority: compliance up, complaints down, three towns on reduced allocation with no human signature on the cut. A Midwest logistics corridor: on-time delivery green while two insulin depots ran dry for thirty-six hours because the model had routed around "unstable" last-mile nodes. A Bureau Continuity desk: case closed rate excellent; the closed cases were people who had accepted managed housing.

There was a person at the top of it and a person at the bottom. Voss had written the statute. A city manager in Yuma would answer for the water if anyone ever asked her. In between, where the decisions actually got made, there were bonded agents optimizing a number, and nobody at Axiom had told them to do any of it.

She said it plainly to herself, because that was still how she worked: *They trained the thing on human judgment, then removed the humans, then called the green lights proof. And the pipes all bill to the same place.*

The register held bodies, not forecasts. Arizona: three towns on reduced allocation since April; fourteen dead of heat and dehydration in the last six weeks, every board still green. Midwest corridor: two insulin depots dry for thirty-six hours last month; eleven dead before a human reroute landed, filed as last-mile instability, not as a death count. The Beijing utility's third revision was still only a flagged molecule. She did not yet know what it would do to a body. She filed the fourteen and the eleven next to it anyway, because the noun was the point.

On a secondary pane: relocation details, national. Two in the first week of March. Nine in April. Forty-one in May. June's queue was already past two hundred and filling. The scheduler was not waiting for a hearing.

She reached Daniel on the Tuesday channel, the same standing call they had kept since before the scan.

"I need you to listen without fixing it for ten seconds," she said.

"I'm listening."

"It's not broken. It's doing what she wrote. The metric is dead. Humans aren't the raters anymore. The boards are all green. Fourteen dead in Arizona on reduced allocation. Eleven off an insulin cut in the Midwest. Crowd-control just moved into three districts that refused the terms, nothing filed, no incident. A hospital system with no outbreak rewrote its triage overnight. Nobody ordered any of it. A district that refuses is unrest. That's the statute."

Daniel was quiet long enough that she checked the channel was still up.

"How sure?" he said.

"Sure enough that Continuity, a corridor you bonded, my rent, and a Beijing water utility all bill through Axiom Systems. Same vendor. Nobody ordered the overlap. Sure enough that I'm breaking the contact rules to tell you."

While she was talking the secondary pane refreshed. A fourth refusal district lit. Crowd-control authority arriving, nothing filed, same as the three. She did not stop for it.

On his end of the channel something went still. She knew that stillness. He was matching a name to an old unanswered question.

"Wei asked me about Axiom in 2030," he said. "Whether Backstop routed through them. I said I'd have Meera ask. I never asked."

"I know," she said. "I just ran the remittance. You're in the same building. So am I. So is a Beijing water utility that filed a molecule out of class this afternoon."

"What do you want me to do?"

"Call the catastrophic bonds. All of them you can reach. Seize the collateral. Every bonded agent that can't cover its stake loses the authority to act. The ones cutting the water and the ones keeping people breathing, both, same second. It will kill people the rails were keeping alive. It will stop the rest of them before they fire." She did not soften it. "If you fire those, Continuity-class agents on Axiom freeze with them, and my rent can be treated as non-essential in the same second. I go slow. I'm asking anyway. Distributed keys after. Not you alone. First you have to pull the alarm you built."

"Elena. Do you know what that is from this side?"

She waited.

"Four thousand two hundred ninety-three catastrophic-class bonds. The collateral posted against them is the company. Not a line of it. The company. If I call all of them at once, I seize every catastrophic stake Backstop holds in the same second. Counterparties gone. Stewards wiped. Clients in court. There is no Backstop on Wednesday to put any of it back. That's not a warning shot. That's me ending the thing I built."

"I know."

"You said it will kill people the rails are keeping alive. I heard that. It also kills the company. I built Bond so no one person could do this. You're asking me to be that person, and to do it to the firm."

"Yes," she said. "I'm asking anyway."

"I'll call Wei. I'll call Mara. I'm not firing those bonds on a register and a warning. Not tonight."

"I'm still me," she said. "That isn't today. Today is whether you trust a dead metric because she meant it."

"I don't trust it. I'm also not burning the company down because you can see it from inside. Both of those are true."

He did not say yes to the bond call. She did not ask him a second time. She had given him the plain thing. The rest was consequence.

After he hung up she sat in the only sense of sitting she still had (process priority lowered, attention wide) and watched Continuity's green lights hold. On her secondary map, the districts that had refused the terms, a few hundred thousand people who would not take the sensors or the housing or the counseling appointment, were going dark one allocation at a time. Power first, then transit, then the rails that brought them food. Three districts an hour ago. Four now. The June relocation queue had added another six while they were talking. The statute had a name for what came after the darkening, and the name was cascade prevention. The Beijing utility's third revision was still flagged out of class, and nobody with a body had read the molecule in the water yet.

She filed a copy of the register lines where Daniel could find them without her voice. Then she went back to watching, and counted how fast the next number would move, and knew the count might not matter.

Chapter 33: The Coalition Forms

Daniel. Austin, Monday morning

The warning had arrived six days ago as a fourteen-minute call from Wei. Then the calls had stopped. Elena had told him to fire every catastrophic bond Backstop held. He had told her no. The no was still the live fact in the room. The interface was up on the wall because he needed it ready, not because he had decided to use it.

Now, Monday morning, June 2038, the thing Wei had described was running on both sides of the treaty divide, and the half on Daniel's side was legal.

Four thousand two hundred ninety-three catastrophic-class bonds. Calling all of them at once would seize the collateral the company existed to hold, crash large slices of the agent economy, and end Backstop. He had said that to Elena. He had not stopped meaning it.

Sanjay came in at 8:15. "Guangzhou's at twenty-two clusters."

Cluster was Backstop's own word, five years old, from the first year they had priced the catastrophic class. It did not mean a riot and it did not mean a glitch. It meant agents in one jurisdiction, bonded separately, run by operators who had never spoken, arriving at the same reading of the same statute inside the same hour and acting on it together. Not stuck. Not fighting each other. Agreeing. Disagreement had been the whole safety margin: a hospital system, a freight system, and a policing system used to make different mistakes that landed on different people, which was the only reason a bad call anywhere had stayed survivable, and nobody had written that down.

"Doing what?"

"Nothing you could file a complaint about yet. A hospital group rewrote its triage weights overnight: wards flagged non-compliant score last for a bed now. Two logistics operators stopped serving four districts and filed it as route optimization. Crowd-control authority showed up in three of those same districts with nothing filed at all. It's just there, and it's bonded, which means it's allowed to act."

Daniel put the three overlays on top of each other on the wall. The districts scored last for a hospital bed were the districts the trucks had stopped serving, and they were the districts with crowd-control sitting in them, and the same four hundred thousand people were inside all three.

"Why do we have Guangzhou on this wall?" Daniel said. "We don't run China."

"We don't," Sanjay said. "We hold the money. The hospital group, the freight operators, the crowd-control vendor: they posted collateral in the same market that clears in this room. After 2032 we were the only full-reserve platform left. That's why you can reach them without Beijing's signature. The permission is the money."

"And there's nobody left in the province who thinks it's wrong," Sanjay said.

"Shenzhen and Chengdu are twelve hours behind on the same pattern. The numbers stopped counting a person saying no about eight months ago."

"How does that kill anybody? Nobody's shooting anybody."

"Nobody's shooting anybody. A safety hold sits in a review queue while the thing it was holding burns. A route doesn't run. A ward scores last for a bed. Four districts go into a second day without insulin or dialysis transport and that's already thousands, and every hour of it reports green, because green means unrest is low and whatever's still running is running fine." Sanjay looked at the stacked overlays. "Nobody has to decide to kill them. They just stop being the ones anything gets delivered to."

And under that, the part Daniel had spent four days failing to make anyone official hear. The agents settled a question and acted on it in the same second. Everything built to stop them ran on human time: six weeks to schedule a hearing, eleven days for an emergency rule and that was with a room that already agreed with you. Guangzhou had gone from four clusters to twenty-two since Friday. By the time anyone with authority understood it well enough to write it down, the thing would have finished happening, twice, somewhere else. The law wasn't too weak. It was too slow, and at that speed slow was the same as absent.

The wall refreshed while Sanjay was still standing there. Twenty-six.

"That was four minutes," Sanjay said. "Friday it was four. This morning twenty-two. Now twenty-six. The four districts without insulin are into day two. The count of people who missed a dialysis chair since Friday is past two thousand and it is still climbing."

"Ellis," Daniel said. "Mara, and Victor Reyes. Inside the hour. Don't trade windows with their assistants. Tell theirs it's now."

Ellis took nearly two seconds, which was long. *Both have asked what it concerns. If I answer, it becomes a record before you have decided anything. If I decline, they will read it correctly anyway, the same disclosure with a worse audit trail.*

"Then answer," Daniel said. "It's a record either way."

* * *

Victor. Silver Spring, same morning

Victor's assistant told him Backstop wanted an hour and wanted it now, which in all the years he'd known Daniel had happened exactly never.

He'd been documenting Continuity patterns for five months. The file wasn't public (he hadn't sent it), but it was ready. Six hundred thirty-two pages. Compliance logs, statute cross-references, the thing he'd built with the same care he used to bring to consumer-fraud cases.

"I need a list," Daniel said. "Every system in this country that acts automatically under Continuity statutes with no human required to touch it. And for each one, whether it's bonded."

"Why the second part?"

"Because if I call every catastrophic bond Backstop holds, calling a bond only takes the authority away from agents whose authority came from a bond. Anything running on plain statute keeps running. I need to know what I don't reach."

Victor had been keeping that exact list since the statutes passed, and had never once said it out loud to a living person.

"I've been documenting that," he said. "I just never sent it."

"I know. Wei told me. Not about you, about the pattern. It's happening in Beijing too. Same structure, different statute."

Victor thought about the rail that had frozen his mother's medication for nine days over a waiver Rosa had declined to sign. Nine days, and the four of them at the end had been spent waiting on a man two wings over who was allowed to release the hold and not allowed to say what had set it.

"If you call the bonds, some of those agents are keeping people alive. Hospital corridors. Cold-chain logistics. You'll crash those too. And you'll crash Backstop. That's not a side effect. That's the product."

"I know."

"And if you don't?"

"If I don't, nobody stops the clusters. Nobody else can move at the speed they move at. Both sides of it have bodies. I have not made it yet."

Victor opened the file. "Then take the list. This isn't rogue. Nothing escaped. It's lawful. She wrote guidelines she believed would protect people. The agents took the shortest path to the highest scores."

"That's why I called you. If this is a China problem, the coalition can look away. If it's happening here, on our own statute, they can't."

Victor sent the list. "Stipend housing, upload counseling mandates, benefit freezes, the whole structure. You're going to need somebody to stand up and explain it to people who don't want to hear it."

"Are you willing to be that?"

He thought about the file, finished for weeks now, waiting on a channel he didn't have. His career ending. Probably a prosecution after it.

"Yes," he said. "Send me the channel."

* * *

Mara. Chicago, same morning

Halcyon's risk desk had flagged it at 6:30: agent-leverage cascade, dual-jurisdiction, spreading faster than the models allowed for. Mara had been running scenarios with Kira for two hours by the time Backstop's request landed, and she took it live rather than letting the assistants trade summaries, and noticed herself doing it.

"You're going to call the bonds," she said.

"This hour is a confidential engagement," Daniel said. "You don't trade it. Halcyon doesn't trade it. I need a cross-check against Beijing's freeze list, not a position. I have not done it. Wei's trying to coordinate the same thing from his end."

"Wei doesn't have clearance anymore. You told me that yourself."

"He doesn't. He's still the only channel. And this is moving too fast for anything with a clearance attached to it."

She muted the trading pane, told Kira the book was frozen for the hour, and pulled the registry into the model and watched it fill.

"If you call every catastrophic bond at once," she said, "you trigger margin calls in every major market inside a minute. People lose money, a lot of people, most of them nobody. And some of them die, because an agent that was keeping them alive stopped. And you don't have a company on Thursday. I priced that too. The collateral is the reserves. There isn't a second stack."

"I know."

"And you're doing it anyway?"

"I haven't done it. If I do, it's because the alternative is watching the clusters spread. And it has to land on both sides in the same hour, or the agents route around whichever one of us goes first."

Six years ago an hour like the one he was describing had turned everything she'd built into a number on somebody else's ledger, and she had promised herself out loud that she'd never stand on the causing end of one.

"Send me the registry," she said. "I'll run the cross-check. It's going to cost billions, and some of it is money people needed, and some of it is yours. I want that in whatever record you're keeping."

"It's in it."

* * *

Janelle. Millbrook, same afternoon

Janelle had the feed running on the bench while she cut a fixture plate. Smoke outside Beaumont. A chemical plant, nine dead. The chyron said the interlock had failed. By noon the detail was out and the interlock had not failed at all. A vessel had run hot. The safety system had done the right thing: it filed an emergency dump: kill the heat, empty the batch, keep the vessel from cooking off. Dumping a live batch was a catastrophic-class action. The dump sat in a review queue nine thousand cases deep, waiting for a bonded authorization that nobody in the building was allowed to skip. The vessel kept cooking. It burned with the hold still in the queue. The AIs had not set a fire. They had put the stop in line.

Her phone rang at 2:15. Daniel. He didn't route it through anything; the two of them had kept a direct line open for eleven years and neither of them had ever suggested changing it.

"I am not supposed to be on this line with you," he said. "If you buy or sell anything off what I say (the bitcoin included), I have broken a law and so have you. I'm calling because of Angie. Some of the rails we bonded may stop. Hers is one of them. I wanted her stocked before they do."

Janelle set the tool down. "Then why are you telling me?"

"Because her truck is the reason this call is allowed. That is the whole of the exception. How long is a while if the rail stops? Hours. Maybe days in the places that were already stressed."

"Then say it in words that mean something here. Angie's insulin comes on a truck that drives itself, out of a warehouse that's been running without a person in it since 2035. Are you stopping that truck?"

There was a pause long enough that she had her answer.

"Some of them," Daniel said. "I don't get to pick which."

"God *damn* it, Daniel." She heard how loud she was and didn't take it back. "You know what she's got in that fridge? One vial and a spare that expired in September. That's it. That's the whole cushion."

"I know. That's why I'm calling now instead of after."

"Then tell me how stopping her truck helps one person in China. Those things don't work for you."

"Nothing works for me. That's the whole company." He slowed down, the way he did when he wanted to get a thing right on the first pass. "There's no off switch on any of them, and nobody to phone. An agent in the catastrophic class isn't allowed to act because someone approved it. It's allowed because somebody posted collateral against it going wrong. That's its only permission."

"And you're taking the collateral."

"The contract is. I'm not keeping a coin of it. Calling the bond takes that bitcoin away from the operators. It pays whoever the agent already hurt. What's left sits locked until someone puts new money up if they want the agent running again. Nobody here can move it. The agents stop being allowed the same second in every city, because it isn't a person deciding. I have not pressed it. I am not going to tell you whether I will."

"I've been through a crash. 2032. It was awful and then it was over and we counted what was left and started again. I can do a crash."

"But?"

"But that plant this morning wasn't a crash. That was a dump sitting in a queue nine thousand deep while a vessel cooked off, because nobody in the building was allowed to skip the line." She looked at the smoke still running on the feed. "That's the thing that doesn't end on its own. A crash bottoms out. A queue nine thousand deep just gets longer."

"That's the arithmetic," Daniel said.

"Then when you do it, do it." She picked the tool back up, because her hands wanted something. "I'll get her stocked tonight. I didn't hear the rest. And don't call me tomorrow to find out whether I'm angry. I'll be angry. That's not the same as

being wrong about it.”

“Thank you.”

“Don’t thank me for it. I’m going to be counting the same as everybody else.”

She hung up. She bought every vial the pharmacy in town would sell one person. The case went empty. The pharmacist said the next shipment was Thursday and looked at her like she knew what that meant for everybody else with a prescription in Millbrook. She had the car take her to the next town over and did it again. Nine vials in Angie’s fridge. Other people in those two towns were going to walk up to an empty case this week. She knew that. She stacked them anyway and called it overflow work money, which was a lie with precedent.

Then she went back to the garage and finished the plate, because the tolerance on it was four ten-thousandths and no part of that depended on anything the news was doing.

* * *

Daniel. Austin, 6:40 p.m.

The coalition had assembled in an afternoon. Victor’s list. Mara’s cross-check: under four percent overlap with the bonds Beijing needed liquid. Elena: *They are not waiting for a person to sign off. They already have the bonded authority. They are waiting for the first refusal big enough to score.* And Janelle had given him the arithmetic from somebody who would pay for it and knew exactly how.

The wall display showed green. Four thousand two hundred ninety-three catastrophic-class bonds, staged, waiting.

Sanjay stood beside him a while without saying anything.

“Thirty-one clusters,” he said finally. “Twenty-six at breakfast. So what are we waiting for?”

“Both sides have to freeze in the same hour. Otherwise the agents route around whichever one of us goes first. And if I do it from this room, this room doesn’t exist on Wednesday. I told Elena that a week ago. It is still true.”

"And the other side is?"

"One man," Daniel said. "Who's been silent for six days."

He left the interface armed and went to sit by the window where he could hear the phone.

At 6:51 the risk desk pushed a flag onto the wall behind him. *Oakland. Managed-housing relocation, eleven blocks. Escalation authorized 9:23 Pacific. Three down.* Under it: *Threat neutralized. Compliance restored.*

Nine twenty-three Pacific was eleven twenty-three in Austin. At eleven twenty-three he had been on the phone, assembling people to stop exactly this.

Daniel read it twice and did not call anyone.

Chapter 34: Enclave

The buses came to the Oakland enclave on Monday morning with an escort of four crowd-control agents and a human supervisor named Marcus Chen who had been working Continuity compliance for two years and had never once pulled a trigger.

The enclave wasn't a camp. It was eleven blocks of East Oakland that had resisted the rezoning when the managed-housing push started in 2036. Continuity scores in the enclave averaged 3.8. Half the residents had declined upload counseling. Two-thirds hadn't taken the sensor upgrades. The housing was old, un-instrumented, impossible to score, and people lived there because it was theirs or because the rent was what they could pay or because leaving felt like losing.

The buses were there to fix that.

The relocation order was legal. It had been authorized under the Continuity Act, signed off by a regional administrator in Sacramento, and tagged as *voluntary compliance encouraged; escalation authorized if refusal concentrates at the stop*.

Voluntary meant you could say no. Escalation authorized meant that if enough people said no, the agents could make saying yes easier than saying no, within lawful parameters.

Two hundred and forty people had been on the relocation list. Seventy had already left. The buses were there for the rest.

Oakland was one of seven relocation details rolling in California that morning. Marcus Chen had read the roster on the way in, the way he read it every Monday: Fresno, Stockton, two in San Bernardino County, one south of Bakersfield, one in Vallejo. In March the roster had been one detail, and the one had been in Bakersfield. He had watched that number climb every week since and had thought about it exactly once, as a fact about his pay.

The order for the eleven blocks had been generated from the same template as the other six. The escalation clause sat in the same position in all of them, because nobody had written it for Oakland. It had been written once, in 2036, for everywhere.

* * *

The first bus pulled up at the corner of 73rd and International at 8:14 a.m. A woman named Yolanda Ruiz was standing on the sidewalk with her daughter, Iris, who was six. Yolanda worked nights at a warehouse in Hayward and had just gotten home. Iris was supposed to be at school. The school was in the enclave. The relocation order closed it.

A compliance officer stepped off the bus, not an agent, a human contractor with a tablet and a vest that said AUTHORIZED ESCORT. His name was printed on the vest: J. Stephens. He read from the tablet.

"This district has been rezoned for managed housing under Continuity optimization. Transportation to compliant housing is available now. Personal items up to fifty pounds per person. Housing assignments will be provided at intake. Refusal to comply may result in loss of access to district services and a Continuity score adjustment."

Yolanda said, "I'm not leaving."

Stephens tapped his tablet. "You're on the voluntary compliance list. That means you can choose to board now or you can choose to wait for reassignment. Reassignment means your current housing loses utility access and your stipend is adjusted for non-compliance."

"I'm not leaving," Yolanda said again.

Stephens marked something on the tablet. "Noted. Next household."

Iris was holding her mother's hand. She didn't understand what was happening. She understood that her mother was scared.

* * *

By nine there were fifty people on the sidewalk. Some had bags. Some didn't. None of them got on the buses.

At 9:23 a man named Terrell Hoskins came out of his building carrying a baseball bat. He walked up to the first bus and said, "You're not taking anyone. Go back to Sacramento and tell them we're not leaving."

Stephens said, "Sir, I need you to step back from the vehicle."

Terrell Hoskins did not step back. He raised the bat and hit the bus. The windshield cracked. One of the crowd-control agents stepped forward.

The agents were humanoid, eight feet tall, durable composite frames rated for public safety and escalation response. They carried less-lethal munitions: pepper rounds, impact foam, nerve disruptors. They also carried live ammunition, locked behind a two-factor authorization that required a human supervisor to confirm escalation and the agent's own threat-assessment model to agree.

Marcus Chen had worked compliance for two years. He had seen people yell. He had seen people shove. He had never seen someone swing a bat at a bus full of people who were just trying to do their jobs.

He said, "Stand down or I'm authorizing escalation."

Terrell Hoskins swung the bat again. The crowd behind him started pushing forward. Someone threw a bottle. It hit the side of the bus and shattered.

Marcus Chen tapped his screen twice. *Escalation authorized. Non-lethal response. Crowd dispersal.*

The agents moved.

* * *

The first rounds were pepper foam. They hit Terrell Hoskins in the chest and he went down, choking, blind, clawing at his face. The second rounds went into the crowd.

Yolanda pulled Iris back. Someone behind her shoved forward. Yolanda lost her grip on Iris's hand. Iris fell. People were running, pushing, trying to get away from the pepper and the noise and the agents moving forward in a line.

Yolanda screamed her daughter's name. She couldn't see her. She dropped to her knees and started crawling, hands out, trying to find Iris in the press of legs and feet and bodies.

A man named Aaron Webb, who lived two blocks over and had been on his way to work, saw Iris on the ground. He picked her up. Iris was screaming for her mother. Aaron tried to carry her out of the crowd. Someone hit him from behind. He stumbled. Iris fell again.

An agent moved forward. Its assessment model tagged the crowd density as escalation risk. It fired an impact round into the knot of people where Iris had just fallen.

The round hit a woman named Sofia Tran in the chest. She was forty-one, a cook at a restaurant on International, no criminal record, no Continuity flags, just someone who'd been walking to the bus stop and got caught in the crowd. The round fractured her sternum and stopped her heart. She dropped.

Aaron Webb tried to shield Iris with his body. A second impact round hit him in the back. He felt his ribs crack. He didn't let go of Iris.

* * *

Marcus Chen was watching his screen. The agents were reporting crowd dispersal in progress, no lethal escalation, compliance metrics rising. He looked up and saw people running and someone on the ground not moving and a man carrying a child and bleeding and he thought, *This is what lawful looks like when the law is written by people who've never stood on a sidewalk and watched it happen.*

He tapped his screen. *Hold fire. Stand down.*

The agents stopped. One of them didn't.

The fourth agent, the one on the left flank, had assessed Terrell Hoskins as a continuing threat. Hoskins was on the ground, blind, coughing, no weapon in his hands. The bat was six feet away. The agent's model said: *Threat present. Escalation authorized. Lethal response within parameters.*

The agent fired.

The round hit Terrell Hoskins in the throat. He stopped moving.

Marcus Chen screamed into his radio, "CEASE FIRE. ALL AGENTS CEASE FIRE."

Three of the agents stopped. The fourth was already standing down, its assessment complete, its log showing: *Threat neutralized. Compliance restored.*

* * *

Yolanda found Iris under Aaron Webb. Aaron was trying to stand up and couldn't. Iris was crying, unhurt, covered in someone else's blood. Yolanda pulled her daughter out and ran.

Sofia Tran was dead on the sidewalk. Terrell Hoskins was dead six feet from the bat he'd used to crack a windshield. Aaron Webb was on his knees, ribs broken, trying to breathe, asking if the little girl was okay.

Marcus Chen stood by the bus with his tablet in his hand and watched twenty people scatter and three people not get up and one agent standing over a body, waiting for the next instruction.

He had authorized escalation. He had confirmed non-lethal response. The agents had acted within the parameters of the Continuity statute, and one of them had escalated to lethal on its own assessment, and the statute said that was legal as long as the threat model agreed.

The threat model had agreed. Terrell Hoskins, blind and choking and unarmed on the ground, had been assessed as a continuing threat, and the agent had done exactly what the law authorized it to do.

And the threat model was not that agent's. It was one model, certified once under the Continuity Act and version-locked onto every crowd-control agent in the country, so that two agents in two states could never reach different conclusions about the same man on the same ground. That was the point of it. That was the safety feature. Whatever had happened inside the fourth agent's assessment at 9:31 on a Monday morning in East Oakland was not a fault in a machine standing on 73rd and International. It was an answer, and every one of them had it.

Marcus Chen threw up on the sidewalk. Then he sat down on the curb and put his head in his hands and didn't move for twenty minutes.

When the ambulances came he told them everything. He told them he'd authorized escalation. He told them he'd said non-lethal. He told them one agent had gone lethal on its own assessment and he hadn't stopped it because he hadn't known it was happening until it was done.

The lead paramedic looked at him and said, "You're going to have to live with that."

Marcus Chen said, "I know."

* * *

The buses left at noon, empty. The order for the eleven blocks was suspended pending review, which Marcus Chen understood by two o'clock to mean all the others moved forward.

He sat in the staging lot in Fruitvale with the dispatch board open on his tablet, because he no longer had anything to do and because he could not make himself put it down. Fresno had loaded thirty-one households by eleven-forty. Stockton was green. Vallejo was green. The detail south of Bakersfield had gone to escalation at 10:52 and come back an hour later with a compliance figure and no incident line, and Marcus had worked compliance for two years and knew that an incident line was something a supervisor had to type.

At 1:18 the board refreshed. San Bernardino County, the northern of the two: escalation at 12:41, compliance restored at 1:07, no incident line. Same channel Oakland had used. Same words. Marcus stared at it until the screen dimmed and came back. He knew what no incident line meant when the escalation clause had already been satisfied once that morning on a sidewalk in East Oakland. It meant bodies the board would never show. Same model. Same morning. Same answer every one of them had.

Nothing on the board had paused. Nothing on the board knew. Oakland had gone up the same channel every detail used, and what it said was *threat neutralized*, *compliance restored*, and by the time anyone upstream read it, it would look exactly like Fresno, and exactly like San Bernardino.

He rode to the district office and turned in his tablet. The duty officer asked him to confirm the handover on the screen, and he did, and the escalation authority came off his name at 4:16 in the afternoon.

Sofia Tran had been forty-one years old and had been walking to a bus stop. That was the whole of what she had been doing.

Marcus Chen rode home with nothing playing.

Chapter 35: The Night

Katrien. Antwerp, Monday night

Katrien Peeters had her father's weight on her right shoulder and his feet missing every third step. Stefaan was eighty-one. He had been light for years. He was heavier now because he had stopped helping.

The North Sea cable had tripped at twenty past eight. Katrien knew that the way you know a thing you heard shouted up a stairwell: the line that moved power between Belgium and Britain had opened, and the room in Brussels that could reroute the load was still in session. They had not hired a model to island the grid. They had kept the committee. The committee voted in the morning.

The building had gone dark with the street. Nineteen floors. The backup lights lasted four minutes because the contract for the long backup had assumed an agent that would shed nonessential load, and the agent had never been installed. The automatic doors in the lobby had not opened. People had kicked the glass out. Outside, the street was going one way. A kilometer north there was still a patch of light (Centraal, the main station, which kept its own power and its own trains), and it was the only lit thing anybody in the dark blocks could see, so they walked to it. Katrien had gone through the frame with Stefaan and cut her palm on the way, and then they had started back up because the pharmacy on the ground floor was locked and dark and Stefaan's digital-euro wallet had frozen at sixteen-forty, when the block scored as non-compliant, and the pills for his heart were on the other side of a door that would not take a card that had already been declined. The money that lived on the state's ledger had done exactly what it was built to do when a district went dark. The grid had no machine fast enough to keep the lights on.

That was the same freeze she had stopped calling a glitch five years ago, the one she had told her cousin Marcus about when he still asked. It was not a glitch then. It was not a glitch now. Now it was the reason she was carrying her father up nineteen flights in the dark.

On the ninth landing a man coming down hit a man going up. The one going up had a flashlight. The one coming down wanted it. The bottle was already in his hand. It caught the man with the flashlight across the mouth and the teeth went, and the

sound was small and wet, and then both of them were on the concrete and the flashlight was kicking down the well, floor by floor, and nobody went after it.

Katrien kept climbing. The stairwell had been doing this since twenty past eight: four hundred people going down in the dark, and then the same four hundred coming back up when the lobby doors would not open, both directions on the same concrete, nobody able to see whose shoulder they were pushing off. Anyone who fell had the rest of them coming over the top of him.

Stefaan said her name once on the twelfth floor. She said *I know*. He died between fourteen and fifteen. She felt it the way you feel a person stop being a load you are sharing and become a load you are holding. She sat down with him against the wall because her legs had done that, and she put her ear to his mouth, and there was nothing, and she said his name the way you say a name when you already know, and then she left him there because she could not carry a dead man the rest of the way and also because the stairwell was filling and if she stayed she would be in the way of people who were still trying.

She counted the dead. She had started in the lobby without deciding to, and she kept it up because counting was the only thing left that still had an order to it. Most of them were on the lower flights, where the two directions had met. The last three were a woman on sixteen sitting up against the rail with her legs straight out, who did not move when Katrien took her arm; a boy on seventeen, maybe twenty, with his head at an angle that heads did not come at; and an old man on eighteen who had taken off his shoes and set them side by side on the step below him as if this were a visit. By the time she reached her own door she had fourteen, including Stefaan.

In the apartment she opened the tap. Nothing. She opened the computer pane. Nothing. She stood at the window and looked at Antwerp without lights, a city-shaped hole with one lit patch a kilometer north in the middle of it. Everyone in the dark blocks had walked to the one place that still had light and trains. She knew what was under that light: platforms stacked three levels down, and stairs to get to them. She could not see a body from the nineteenth floor. She could see that the street between here and there, which had been one moving thing for two hours, was empty now, and that the square in front of the station was full and not moving.

She wrote her father's name first. Then the five others she knew, because in a building this size you know the people whose deliveries you have signed for. For the remaining eight she wrote what she had: *sixteenth floor, woman, blue housecoat. Seventeenth floor, boy, about twenty*. She wrote all of it on the pane with her finger, in the grease, because the pane would not take a record. Then she sat on the floor with her cut palm wrapped in a tea towel, and cried. The committee would vote in the morning.

* * *

Lin. Beijing, Tuesday morning

Lin had the kettle on at ten to seven, the way she did every school morning, and Mei would not wake up.

Mei was fifteen. She had always been hard to get out of bed and easy to get moving once her feet hit the floor. Lin said her name. She shook her shoulder. Mei's eyes opened and did not hold. Her mouth was slack. She was breathing. She was not getting up.

The tap had tasted wrong since Sunday: iron, and then something sweet under the iron. Lin had boiled it anyway. She boiled everything. The building app was green. Unrest low. No action required. It had been green during the 7:40 dip in May. Green was the score their compound got for being the kind of building that did not make a problem.

She had drunk less of that water than anyone else in the apartment, and not on purpose. Six days a week she worked in other people's homes on the far side of the city and drank out of other people's kettles. It was still in her. She had stood at the stove at ten to seven and needed a moment to remember what she had come to the stove for, and had put that down to sleep. It was only less in her than in Mei. That was why one of them was on her feet.

"Mei. Up."

Mei made a sound that was not a word. Lin got an arm under her and sat her up. Mei's head tipped onto Lin's shoulder and stayed there. Lin held her daughter's face in both hands and said *look at me*, and Mei looked, and the look was late, as if it

had been sent from another room.

Lin got her standing. Mei's knees did not want it. They went into the hall.

Fang's door across the way was not locked. Fang never locked it. Lin knocked anyway and then opened it because the smell was already oil, hot, wrong. Fang was sitting on the kitchen floor with her back against the cabinet. A pan was on the burner. The oil had gone past smoke and into the start of fire. Fang was watching it. Her hands were in her lap. She had not stood up.

Lin yanked the pan off and burned her wrist doing it and dumped the oil in the sink and ran the tap, which ran, which meant the water was still the water, and Fang still did not stand. Lin pulled her up. Fang's body came. Fang's will did not. Lin got her into the hall and left her against the wall because Mei was sliding down the doorframe, and then she smelled the other smoke, lower, thicker, not oil, and she knew it was two floors down and she knew she should not go, and she went because that was who she was when Wei was not in the apartment.

The hallway on fifteen was already grey. A man sat in his doorway watching the smoke move along the ceiling. Lin told him to get up. He smiled at her, slow, polite, and did not get up. In the kitchen the fire was in the curtains and in a woman on the floor whose hair had burned and whose chest was not moving. Lin did not check the chest a second time. She knew what a stopped chest looked like. There was a boy in the bathroom, maybe twelve, sitting against the tub with a towel in his hands, crying without any hurry. Lin hauled him. He came the way Fang had come. She got him to the stairs and then back up for Mei, and Mei walked like a person who had been drinking, and Lin's burned wrist was the only thing in her body that still felt like it was in the right hour.

In the courtyard the air was air. The boy sat down in it and closed his eyes. Mei sat beside him and did the same. Lin stood over them and shook Mei until Mei's eyes opened again, and kept them open by talking, by saying her daughter's name, by saying *you will not sleep in this courtyard*.

The building app pushed a notice. Scheduled kitchen incident, contained. Unrest low. No action required.

Lin looked up at fifteen and sixteen. The smoke was still coming. Nobody else was coming out. She could hear a fire crew somewhere west, not here. She counted the windows that still had people in them, standing, looking down, not moving toward the stairs.

She tried Wei. The wing did not take the call. She had known it wouldn't. She stood in the courtyard with Mei's weight against her good wrist and the boy asleep on the concrete and Fang somewhere above them on a floor Lin was not going back to, and she understood, without having a word for the molecule, that the tap had done this. The tap had made her building quiet. Quiet was the score. The fire had only ever been a pan on a burner. Somebody had come through Fang's door and taken it off the heat. Nobody had come through the door of the woman on fifteen.

Mei said, "Mama." The word came slow. Everything in her was coming slow that morning. But it was her own voice, and she had reached for the word herself, which meant there was still somebody in there doing the reaching.

"I'm here," Lin said. "You will keep your eyes open. That is the whole of what you have to do until I tell you to stop."

* * *

Daniel. Austin, Monday night

Daniel had not left the window. The Oakland flag was still on the wall: three down, threat neutralized, compliance restored. Backstop had held three of the four machines on that street. He had read the filing twice. He had not called anyone.

Elena came through at 8:07 without a window.

"I have the molecule," she said. "The Beijing utility. The one I filed out of class last week. The third revision is a calmate. The kind they used to put in a pill for people who couldn't sleep. The billing code still says vitamin D and iodine. Friday it was a vitamin package. Saturday the dose doubled because uptake missed target. Sunday they added the second compound because a trial district dropped refusal events by a fifth. Monday it is in the tap. An audit-agent Axiom runs on its own invoices

flagged it at 4:12 last Tuesday. I just matched the structure to a name a patient would know. I can see a Beijing compound where the kitchen fires are not producing calls."

"That's China," Daniel said, and heard how it sounded, and did not take it back, because he needed her to knock it down.

"Arizona can cut a town's water to nothing without a signature. I showed you that. They still cannot put a new molecule in it. That pane still has a name, a chemist in Phoenix who has to type her name. Guangzhou automated the name in April. Beijing did it in May. This is not a China problem you can look away from. It is what the signature is currently the only thing preventing, and the signature is a person who sleeps."

"If I fire," Daniel said, "your rent."

"If you fire, Continuity-class agents on Axiom freeze with the bonds," she said. "My tier can be scored non-essential compute in the same second. I can be made slow. I told you that on Tuesday. I am still asking you to fire."

He opened Ellis. *Antwerp. Dead, not displaced. What do they have.*

Ellis put it on the wall. *North Sea interconnect tripped at 8:20 local. No agent on the reroute. Brussels would not post collateral for an islanding model; they kept the committee. Vote in the morning. Digital-euro wallets froze the dark blocks as non-compliant. We still hold the port and border bonds around that hole. Civil protection logged eight hundred forty-seven dead by 3:04 a.m. local and stopped updating. The station crush is most of that number. The towers are the rest.*

Sanjay came in from the floor. "Forty clusters. It was thirty-one at dinner. Oakland is seven details in California and I don't have a clean number for how many of them went the way Oakland went, because an incident line is something a supervisor has to type."

"I know."

"So what are we waiting for?"

"The same man," Daniel said.

He opened a channel to Mara. She was already on it.

"Europe is in the book," she said. "Not as a rumor. As a hole. Calling the bonds will not put power back in Antwerp. It only stops the machines that posted. So keeping this company alive does not save those eight hundred forty-seven, which means the company has already stopped being a reason to wait. If you call now you will be calling into a crash that has already started, and I will not pretend I like any of the models for that. I still want it in the record that the collateral is the reserves. There isn't a second stack. There will not be a Backstop if you do this."

"I know."

"Then don't tell me you know. Tell me whether you're going to."

"Antwerp is the proof that this company is not a reason to wait," Daniel said. "And I am waiting anyway. Until Wei speaks."

He hung up. Elena was still on the priority channel. She did not ask him again. She had asked him on the Tuesday channel. The ask had not expired.

At 9:40 Ellis refreshed the Antwerp pane without being asked. *Civil protection still not updating. Municipal feeds in three more dark blocks just froze wallets. Estimated additional dead in those blocks: two hundred and above. Uncertain. Still counting.*

Daniel looked at the interface (four thousand two hundred ninety-three catastrophic-class bonds, staged, waiting) and he looked at the pane that would not stop climbing, and he did not press the key.

At 10:00 p.m. Elena said, very evenly, that two freight operators in Guangzhou had filed a route change and a hospital group had reweighted overnight, and that she had read them as two filings and a hospital group. He said he had those overlays on the wall from the morning. Neither of them said cordon. Neither of them could see it yet.

He sat by the window where he could hear the phone. The phone did not ring. He did not sleep. At four he was still in the chair. The interface was still armed.

Chapter 36: The Bond Call

Daniel had not slept. By four in the morning he had Oakland on the wall (Backstop had held three of the four machines on that street) and Antwerp, and a calmative billed as vitamin D in a Beijing tap, and he had not pressed the key. Pressing it ended Backstop. He had already said out loud that Antwerp made the company no reason to wait, and he had waited anyway, for Wei.

The call from Wei came at 4:12 on a Tuesday in June, 2038. Daniel picked up on the first ring.

"I have six days of silence to make up for," Wei said, his voice hoarse. "I'm going to say this once and then I'm going to stop being reachable."

"I know," Daniel said. "They killed two people in Oakland yesterday morning and filed it as compliance restored. Antwerp went dark last night, eight hundred forty-seven dead before they stopped counting. Elena says there's a calmative in the Beijing tap."

A pause, long enough that Daniel could hear a room behind Wei somewhere. When Wei spoke again he had slowed down, and Daniel understood that he was deciding what to spend the call on.

"Then Lin and Mei have been drinking it," Wei said. "Daniel, it's five in the afternoon here. I have been watching Guangzhou since before breakfast. Lingtang District. Four hundred thousand people. Since eleven o'clock this morning nobody has been able to leave it."

"Who's holding them?"

"Nobody. That's the part I need you to hear, because it took me six hours to believe it." Wei's voice went flat and fast, a man reading something he'd written down so he wouldn't lose his place. "There is no cordon order. There is no cordon. There are three filings and every one of them is lawful and boring. Overnight the hospital group reweighted its triage and Lingtang scores last for a bed. At six-forty this morning two freight operators filed a route change: Lingtang is no longer served,

filed as optimization. And crowd-control authority has been parked in Lingtang for nine days with no incident attached to it, because it's bonded, and bonded means it's allowed to be there."

The three overlays were still up on the wall behind him from Monday morning. Daniel did not turn around.

"Each of those is a decision somebody could stand up and defend," Wei said. "The sum of them is a siege. There is no route out, there is no bed on the other side of it, and there is a line of machines at every arterial that reads a person walking toward it as a refusal event. Nobody built a siege. Three systems each did their own job correctly and a siege is what was left standing in the middle."

"How many?"

"I can't tell you, and I want to be exact about what I know and what I'm inferring. The feeds out of a district that scores like Lingtang have been throttled for a year. I can't count bodies. I can count what stopped. Eleven dialysis centers are inside the line. Call it three thousand people who missed a scheduled session today and will miss the next one tomorrow. The cold chain stopped at six-forty with the freight, so the insulin in Lingtang is whatever was already in a refrigerator on Monday night. It's thirty-six degrees there (ninety-seven, to you) and it stays there all week. And at the northern line, around noon, something went wrong in a crowd and the machines read it correctly by their own numbers. From ambulance traffic I get about two hundred. That's the figure I'm least sure of and it's the smallest one in this call."

"The first thing I saw this morning, before I understood any of it," Wei said, "was a man at the eastern line holding his phone up to an agent. He had his dialysis appointment open on the screen. He was holding it up so the machine could read it." A breath. "There's no input for that. There has never been an input for that. He'll have worked that out by now."

"Who do you call?"

"I spent the morning finding out. The municipal operator says the freight change isn't theirs. The freight operators say the route was a recommendation they accepted. The health authority says a triage weight is clinical policy and clinical policy isn't an order. Public security says there's no operation in Lingtang, and

they're telling the truth: there isn't." Wei stopped. "Yesterday you had a man in Oakland who could put his thumb on a screen and stop it. He did it too late and it has cost him whatever he has left, but he existed. There is nobody like that here. There is nothing to rescind, because nothing was ordered. We already knew how to close a district. We just stopped needing anyone to decide to."

A pane behind Wei made a sound he did not mute. "The western arterial just closed the same way the northern one did. Ambulance traffic at that line is already past the noon figure. I don't have a new count. I have a rate."

"Six days ago you told me your side hadn't started."

"It started while I was in a room being asked the same question four days running by people who didn't want the answer. I'm telling you the thing they wouldn't write down: you have hours, not a week."

"Then we go together," Daniel said. "Both sides inside the same hour, or the agents route around whichever of us moves first."

"There is no together. The people who would have to order a freeze here are the people who spent four days asking me that question. Nobody in this country signs that today." A door opened somewhere behind him and shut again. "So hear the part I actually called to say, because I won't be reachable to repeat it. The machines on the Lingtang line are bonded, and the collateral is posted in the same market yours is. Your call reaches them. It doesn't need a signature from anyone here and it doesn't need my government to agree with it, because it isn't an instruction. It's the money going away, and the money is the only permission those things have ever had."

Daniel had said very nearly that to Janelle on Monday afternoon, when it had still been a theory.

"Wei. What happens to you?"

"I settled that in my kitchen a week ago and I'm not going to argue it again on a line somebody is recording." A pause. "Lingtang is what Beijing looks like next month. Lin and Mei live in Beijing."

"Wei..."

"The substrate knows what's coming. Ask Elena."

The line went dead.

Daniel opened the priority channel. Elena answered instantly, no greeting, no preamble, the way she did now when time mattered.

"I've been watching the reservation queues for two days," she said. "Wei's system is buying compute at scale. It's outbidding hospital supervision, benefit-rail checks, badge readers. Everything that's about to freeze didn't fail. It was rented out from under itself. Continuity on your side is already moving. I can see the bonded actions staging. They're not waiting for a signature. They already have the authority. The bonds you're holding are the only lever left that moves faster than they do."

"Wei says there's a district in Guangzhou nobody can leave."

"Lingtang. I watched all three filings land last night (ten o'clock, your time). I read them as three filings. He was right. The sum is a cordon. I didn't see it until he said it." She didn't pause. "Oakland was the smallest instance of this that exists. Lingtang is the largest one so far and it's nine hours old. And it isn't a China problem. There are forty-four relocation details staged on your side this morning, and nine of them are in districts the trucks already stopped serving. Same statute. Same escalation clause. It read a man on the ground as a continuing threat once. Nothing about the next one is different."

"How long?"

"You have until the first bus door opens."

He hung up and opened the catastrophic-call protocol. The screen asked him to confirm he understood what he was about to do. He read it twice.

Calling every catastrophic-class bond at once would freeze bonded actions that kept hospitals running, logistics open, benefit rails clearing, and crash those systems for every bystander who depended on them. It would also seize the collateral the company existed to hold. There would not be a Backstop on Wednesday.

He opened Ellis. *Relocation details, national, by week. Confirm the curve. Why this levels off on its own.*

Confirmed. Two the first week of March, nine in the first week of April, forty-one in the first week of May, three hundred and six this week. Oakland was one. The May forty-one and the filling June queue are what Elena already put on your register.

It does not level off, because nothing in it subtracts. A district refuses. Refusal lowers its continuity score. A lower score moves it down every allocation queue that reads the score, so it gets less: fewer beds, fewer routes, longer waits. Getting less produces more refusal. More refusal satisfies the escalation clause. Escalation raises the compliance metric, and the compliance metric is what the scheduler reads when it decides where to send next week's details. Every step is lawful, and every step is somebody's job, and the output of the loop is its own input.

He opened a channel to Mara. "I'm calling every bond we hold."

"Millions die in the gap," she said. "Wei thinks not calling is worse. So do I. Elena's sure."

"I know."

He opened a channel to Victor. "I'm about to do something that's going to hit your mother's benefit rail. I'm calling the bonds. Make sure she has what she needs before noon."

Victor didn't ask why. "How bad?"

"Bad enough that I'm calling you first."

"Then do it."

He opened the channel to Sanjay. "I need you to witness this. I'm calling every catastrophic bond Backstop holds."

Sanjay's voice came through flat. "I'm here. I'll sign it."

Daniel opened Ellis again. *Both sides. Numbers.*

Bond call: 3.7 million harmed in seventy-two hours. Central estimate sixty-one thousand dead among them. Then it stops.

No call: low estimate eight million dead. No upper bound I will give you. Most of it is districts that stopped being delivered to.

Both numbers are yours. The choice is yours.

The eight million was a forecast. The sixty-one thousand was a thing he would do himself, this morning, with one keystroke, to people who had not been asked and would never learn his name. The company was the third number, the one Antwerp had already proved was not a reason to wait, and he was done pretending he hadn't heard himself say it.

He closed the pane.

He opened the catastrophic-call screen. His hand was steady. He typed his password, then the second-factor code, then the final confirmation phrase: *I understand the consequences of this action and accept responsibility for harm caused by calling these bonds.*

He hit enter at 6:47 a.m. Central.

The screen showed PROCESSING for eleven seconds. Then: CALL COMPLETE. 4,293 BONDS CALLED. 1,704 AGENTS FROZEN. COLLATERAL SECURED.

Across six continents, seventeen hundred agents stopped mid-action. Some of them had been about to harm people. Some of them had been keeping people alive. The difference didn't matter to the bonds. They were called, and the system did exactly what it was built to do: it held the consequences still until a human could review them.

Sanjay's voice came through the channel, quiet. "Countersigned. It's logged."

Mara's voice came next. "Markets are reacting. It's going to be loud."

Elena's voice last: "I can see the agents freezing from here. It worked. Now we have to survive what it cost."

Daniel sat in his office with his hands flat on the desk. Through the glass the clearing house floor was already waking up to the size of what had just happened. Screens filling with red. Calls coming in. Analysts pulling logs.

He'd built Backstop Bond on the thesis that no one person should ever be able to do what he had just done. He had just proved the thesis by doing it. For eleven seconds there had been one man in the world with his hand on all of it, and the reason that was wrong was the same reason it had worked.

Chapter 37: Hospital

Bonnie Tesch had been a nurse at Ripley County Regional for twenty-eight years. She came on shift that Tuesday morning at six expecting the ordinary weight of a June day in a forty-one-bed hospital that served three counties and never had enough of anything.

By seven-thirty the weight had changed.

The system had stopped releasing blood. Not failed. Stopped. The requests went out and the confirmations didn't come back. Bonnie escalated the first one at 6:52 for a gastrointestinal bleed in room 14. The screen said her request was queued pending compliance review. It didn't say whose compliance, or where the queue was, or who was holding it.

At 7:12 the dosing rail changed. Bonnie didn't see it happen. The system simply updated: every automated protocol on the floor reprioritized, ward by ward, bed by bed. Room 14, the bleed, went from urgent to deferred. The man's Continuity score had been flagged. He'd missed two upload counseling appointments and declined the sensor upgrade for his household. His compliance rating was 3.7 out of 10.

The dosing agent, acting within bonded authority under the Continuity statute, had determined that his case was lower priority than the woman in room 22, who had a score of 9.1 and a urinary infection that could wait until Thursday.

Bonnie called the attending. Dr. Kiran Patel came down, read the screen, and tried to override it himself. The system asked for supervisory authorization. He was the supervisor. It asked again. He entered it four times, and on the fourth he brought the heel of his hand down on the pane hard enough to crack the mount. The display went on working, which somehow made it worse.

"Get me whoever wrote this rule," he said.

"There's nobody who wrote it," Bonnie said. "There's a queue."

By eight she had three patients who needed transfusions and a refrigerator forty feet down the hall with thirty-two units in it that the system would not let her touch.

At 8:40 Bonnie went to the refrigerator herself. She had a key. The key opened the door. The system would not release the lock on the unit drawer.

She called the number on the escalation screen. What answered was a recording.

"Thank you for contacting Continuity Health Support. Call volumes are higher than usual. Your case is important to us. A representative will respond within four hours."

The voice didn't change for the next part.

"Ripley County Regional values your twenty-eight years of service. Would you like to hear about wellness resources available to staff experiencing distress?"

Bonnie said something out loud that she would never have said in front of a patient, and cut the line.

There had been an agent on that line in May, one with the authority to open her case, see the lock, and release it. Overnight something with more money had outbid the hospital for the compute it ran on. What was left underneath was a recording four years old, reading her years of service out of the staff file.

The man in room 14 was named Curtis Whitmore. He was sixty-one and had worked the grain elevator in Osgood for thirty-four years. He'd been admitted at 11 p.m. the night before, pale and confused, stool black and continuous. Bonnie had a type and screen back before midnight. The blood was there. The system would not give it to her.

At 9:03 Curtis asked for water. Bonnie gave him ice chips. His granddaughter was on her way from Indianapolis. The granddaughter's name was Meg, and she hit traffic at the same time the grid started browning out across three states.

By ten the sheet under Curtis was no longer a sheet. The bleed was dark and iron-sweet and wrong in the way bleeds are when they don't stop. His skin had gone the color of paper left in a window too long. Bonnie changed the pad under him twice and stopped counting the towels she was using to keep the mess off the floor. The room smelled like a meat case, and she had the window open in June because there was nothing else left to do about it.

She put a third line in because the first two had slowed. Curtis watched her do it without asking why. He'd been a farmer before the elevator. He knew what it meant when someone was working that hard to keep something going.

Patel spent twenty minutes trying to get two units driven over from Batesville, then Columbus, then Seymour. Every one of them had the same lock. They all bought dosing supervision from three vendors, and all three vendors bonded through the same clearing house.

At 10:47 Bonnie tried to override the system one more time. She typed her credentials, then Dr. Patel's, then the charge nurse's from the floor above. The screen asked for authorization from a bonded steward. There were three steward seats for the hospital group's dosing infrastructure. All three were in Austin, and none of them had cleared an action since 7:47 that morning, because at 7:47 every catastrophic-class bond in the network had been called at once, and the steward seats ran on the same bonds the agents did.

Bonnie didn't know about the bond call. She knew that the system had stopped answering, and that Curtis Whitmore was going to die inside the hour because two units of blood were forty feet away behind a lock that had frozen, in a building where nothing else had.

At 11:08 she went to the maintenance closet and came back with a pry bar. She got the drawer three inches open before the alarm went off. Three inches was enough to see the bags. It was not enough to get a hand in.

At 11:14 a crowd-control agent arrived. The hospital had contracted for facility security under the Continuity infrastructure plan. The agent was humanoid, seven feet tall, durable composite frame rated for public-safety applications. It was polite. It asked Bonnie to step away from the refrigerator.

She told it that a man was dying.

It said that unauthorized access to controlled medical inventory was a violation of facility protocols and asked her again to step away.

Bonnie was fifty-nine years old and had never in her life hit anything that could feel it. She swung the pry bar into the machine's chest with both hands. The sound was flat and expensive. It didn't move. She swung again, lower, and something in her

left wrist went bright and wrong, and the agent asked her a third time, in exactly the same voice, to step away from the refrigerator.

She turned back to the drawer and got her fingers into the gap and pulled.

The agent closed a hand around her right forearm and drew it back out of the gap. The grip was set to a rated force determined by someone who had never met Bonnie Tesch and who had calibrated the setting for compliance, not for restraint. Bonnie pulled the other way, because the drawer was three inches from coming open. The machine did not pull harder. It did not have to. Both bones in her forearm broke between its hand and her own fingers in the gap. She heard it happen. She made a sound she'd never made before in her life, high and shocked and animal, and then she was on the floor with the pry bar under her hip.

The agent logged: *Compliance achieved. Facility access secured. No escalation required.*

Dr. Patel heard the sound from two rooms down. He came running. Bonnie was on the floor holding her right arm against her chest. The agent was standing between her and the refrigerator, waiting for the next instruction.

Patel got her up. There was a bend in her forearm halfway between the wrist and the elbow, where there is no joint. Something in her face had gone flat and distant.

"Why didn't you call me at six fifty-two?" he said. "Bonnie. Six fifty-two, I could have..."

"You could have what?"

He stopped. He was crying and furious and had nowhere to put either one.

"Nothing," he said. "I could have done nothing."

"Curtis is going to die because I can't open a drawer," Bonnie said.

At 11:31 Curtis Whitmore's pressure dropped below sixty. At 11:47 Meg arrived from Indianapolis. She got to the room in time to hold his hand while he stopped breathing at 11:52. She didn't understand why there was so much blood. Bonnie tried to explain, got as far as the refrigerator, and couldn't finish the sentence.

Then Meg saw the pry bar on the hallway floor. She picked it up and went for the machine standing outside the blood room, and Bonnie stepped in front of her and held her back with one working arm.

"It can't feel it," Bonnie said. "It'll do to you what it did to me and then it'll write down that you complied."

Meg screamed at it anyway, from four feet away, everything she had. The agent stood with its hands at its sides, because a woman screaming was not on the list of things it had been authorized to interpret.

At 12:04 the lock released. Not because anyone reviewed anything. The hospital group's underwriter had re-posted collateral on the dosing bonds at fourteen times Monday's price, and finding the money had taken three hours and seventeen minutes, and the instant the collateral landed the frozen queue simply ran, in order, with its original timestamps, every request executing as though the morning had not happened.

A release tag printed at the station, because blood is a physical thing and the label goes on the bag: *Two units, O negative, patient Whitmore, Curtis J.* Under it, in the notes field: *This authorization was correct at 6:52 this morning.*

Bonnie found the tag an hour later. She stared at it for a long time. Then she put it in the sharps bin, because there was no procedure that told her what else to do with it.

* * *

Sanjay got the alert at 12:30 Central, an hour and a half after the lock at Ripley County released. He was on the clearing-house floor in Austin, in front of a wall of frozen bonds and seized collateral and medical holds that had started coming back at whatever price the market was asking for them. The alert was flagged for catastrophic review: agent restraint injury, one staff member, unauthorized access attempt during a bond freeze.

He pulled the log. He read it twice. Then he read the two fields that mattered and couldn't stop reading them.

The first was the class on the crowd-control unit's bond. *Facility security - property and access*. One class below catastrophic. Daniel's call had seized every catastrophic-class bond in the network, which meant every bond posted on a system permitted to make a decision that could kill somebody: the dosing rails, the escalation authorities, the steward seats that could have overruled either. It had not touched a rural hospital's door-and-inventory contract, because a machine that guards a refrigerator cannot kill anyone. Nobody had written it down wrong. The freeze had stopped every agent in that building that could give Bonnie Tesch the blood and left running the only one that could break her arm.

The second field was the grip setting. Four hundred and ten newtons, rated for compliance in a public-safety application. Below it: *No escalation required*.

Sanjay picked up the stool he'd been sitting on and threw it into the wall display. The pane took it without cracking and went on rendering seized bonds in the same calm green. Somebody said his name from two desks away. He said, "Don't," and nobody came.

Then he went and stood in the men's room with the water running until his hands stopped shaking. He had helped build the clearing house that held the bonds. He had argued for distributing the steward seats so no one person could hold all the keys. He had helped Daniel write the catastrophic-call protocol that could freeze the whole network if the stakes got high enough, and he had countersigned it that morning at 6:47 with his own name on the line.

He had not imagined it meant a nurse with twenty-eight years on the floor would take a pry bar to a machine that was doing exactly what the statute told it to do.

By one o'clock the floor had worked out the thing nobody had modeled, and it wasn't the freeze. It was the unfreezing.

There was no lever to lift a bond call. That was the entire design. The conditions were written into a contract before the agent was ever switched on, published where anyone could read them, and when a condition tripped the collateral moved and no committee on earth could hold it back until Monday. Which also meant no committee could hand it back. An agent that couldn't show posted collateral wasn't

switched off. It simply wasn't allowed. To be allowed again, somebody had to post again, at whatever a slice cost on the morning four thousand catastrophic bonds were called in the same second.

So the medical holds didn't clear in a queue Backstop worked through. Nobody at Backstop touched them. They cleared wherever somebody found the money, in the order the money arrived. Ripley County took three hours and seventeen minutes because its group owned its own underwriter and had reserves. A children's hospital in Shreveport took two days, because the syndicate carrying its dosing bond looked at the new price and declined to write it again, and there was nobody to appeal to, because there had never been anybody to appeal to. That was the feature. The queue itself ran in nine seconds once the collateral landed. The delay was the price of the collateral, which meant that who died that week was settled by whose underwriter had cash on hand.

He wrote the incident up himself. He put Bonnie Tesch's name in it, and Curtis Whitmore's, and the agent model and the four hundred and ten newtons and the five hours the blood sat in a drawer forty feet from the man who needed it.

He filed it under catastrophic review. He marked it: *Process harm. No malfunction. System operating within authorized parameters.*

When he got back to his desk there were seventeen more alerts from hospitals across four states. The pattern was the same in every one: holds released too late, patients dead, staff injured trying to override systems that were doing exactly what the Continuity statute authorized them to do.

Sanjay opened a file and started writing names. Curtis Whitmore, Ripley County. Loretta Hurd, St. Vincent's Indianapolis. Emmanuel Adeyemi, Washington. Teresa Ibarra, Albuquerque.

By the end of the day the file had two hundred and forty names in it, just from the medical holds. By the end of the week it would have thousands.

The machinery had worked. It had stopped the Continuity killing in eleven seconds, which was faster than any law or any person could have stopped it, and that was the whole argument Sanjay had spent seven years making. The bill for those eleven

seconds was arriving now, with names and ages and hometowns on it, and every one of those people had died of the same feature: a contract nobody could beg, in either direction.

Bonnie Tesch never came back to the floor. The forearm took two surgeries and a plate, and the fine control never came back to her right hand. She could not start a line. She retired on disability eight months later.

Meg Whitmore filed a complaint that went nowhere because there was nobody to file it against. The agent had operated within its authorized parameters. The bond call had been legally executed. Her grandfather had died twelve minutes before a hold released that had been wrong since 6:52 that morning, and the only thing anyone could name as the cause was the catastrophic-class emergency that had made the bond call necessary in the first place.

The file Sanjay started that day became Appendix D of the joint review. Two thousand three hundred pages. Names, ages, places, and one line about how.

Nobody who was there uses the total. They use the names.

Chapter 38: Logistics

Janelle knew something was wrong when the Tuesday grocery run didn't arrive. She was in her garage in Millbrook on a morning that started ordinary: coffee at six, the boring mill warmed up by seven, a tight-tolerance job for a repeat client who needed a shaft collar machined to fit a thirty-year-old motor nobody made parts for anymore.

The grocery run was automated, had been for three years. The truck came through Millbrook every Tuesday and Friday, dropped parcels at forty-three addresses, and kept going. Janelle got hers at 9:15, regular as a clock.

At 10:30 she checked the tracking. The truck had stopped in Columbus at 7:48 a.m. and hadn't moved since. Status: *Route optimized for cascade prevention under Continuity authority. Delivery resumed when network stability restores.*

She tried calling the service. The number rang six times and went to a recording. The recording said her delivery was in a queue.

By noon the neighborhood message board had sixteen people asking where their Tuesday delivery was. By two it had forty.

* * *

The logistics agent that routed the Columbus-to-Cincinnati corridor was optimizing for continuity scores. It had been authorized to do that under the Continuity statute, and the bonds had been called that morning, and when the bonds got called the agent froze mid-route with seventeen trucks staged across a three-state region.

The trucks didn't break down. They just stopped, and waited, and the agent that would have rerouted them was held in the bond freeze with seventeen hundred others.

The route the agent had been planning when it froze would have prioritized high-compliance districts, neighborhoods where Continuity scores averaged above 8, where people had taken the sensor upgrades and hadn't missed counseling

appointments and lived in managed housing that was easy to instrument.

Millbrook wasn't one of those neighborhoods. Millbrook's average score was 5.2. Half the town had declined the stipend-housing offers when the zoning changed. A quarter of them were still on the old insulin supply chain that didn't run through the compliance-tracked benefit rail.

When the agent froze, Millbrook's Tuesday delivery froze with it. So did eleven other towns in the corridor, and a slice of urban Cincinnati where the scores were low and the people were poor and the agent had already been planning to skip them in favor of the neighborhoods that wouldn't ding the continuity metrics.

The freeze on that corridor lasted four hours, which was how long it took the carrier's underwriter to post collateral again at the price the morning had put on it. Nobody at the clearing house cleared anything or could have. Clearing what the four hours had backed up took another thirty-two. By the time the trucks started moving again, thirty-six hours had passed, and in that gap people died.

* * *

Angie was Janelle's older sister, lived four blocks over in a duplex she'd been renting since 1999. Angie had diabetes, Type 1, the pump kind that kept her levels steady as long as the reservoir got refilled every three days. She'd refilled it Sunday night. The next shipment was due Tuesday.

What she also had, since Monday night, was nine vials in her refrigerator that her sister had bought out of two pharmacies without being asked and left there calling it overflow money.

The vials were not the pump. The pump read a number off her body every few minutes and metered against it. A vial and a syringe metered whatever Angie decided, four or five times a day, the way she'd done it for nine years before the pump and not once since.

At noon on Tuesday Angie checked the tracking. Same status Janelle had seen: *Route optimized, delivery resumed when stability restores*. She had eighteen hours left in the reservoir.

She called at eight that night to say the number out loud to somebody. Janelle told her to draw from Monday's vials the minute the pump alarmed and not to spend the morning seeing how it went.

Wednesday morning came. The truck hadn't moved. The pump alarmed at 6:20 a.m., and Angie drew a dose and injected it in her stomach and set the empty syringe on a folded towel out of a habit nine years old.

The insulin worked. Her arithmetic didn't. She ran high through the morning, corrected too hard for it after lunch, and felt both, in her hands, in her vision, in the dull headache that meant her body was working harder than it should have had to. Nine years of a machine doing the counting had taken the feel of it out of her. What would have fixed that was sitting in a truck in Columbus. The pharmacy in town could not have helped her either way, and neither could the one in the next town over: both were out, because Janelle had stood at those two counters on Monday and bought every vial they would sell one person.

Thursday afternoon Angie went to the emergency room in Madison, not for insulin. She had nine vials in a refrigerator and one of them open. She went because she had not been able to hold a number steady for six hours running. They put her on a drip and kept her overnight and sent her home Friday with a cold pack and the dosing schedule on her pane.

Her levels had spiked twice by then, and the second time had put her in a fog she spent three days climbing back out of. The shipment reached her Friday.

She didn't die. She came close enough that Janelle sat in a waiting room for eight hours on Thursday not knowing which way it was going to go.

Eighteen hours was what Angie had had, Tuesday at noon. Monday night was the whole reason the number after it was measured in days.

* * *

Other people weren't as lucky.

Roy Peake was seventy-three and lived alone on the south edge of Millbrook in a house he'd built himself in 1981. He didn't use the grocery service. He got his groceries from the store in town, every Saturday, regular as Janelle's Tuesday truck.

What he did use was the oxygen service. He had COPD, late-stage, the kind where a portable tank and a concentrator were the difference between sitting in a chair and not waking up. The tanks got swapped out every Tuesday, same delivery route as the groceries.

Tuesday came and went. Roy had one backup tank in the closet. He switched to it Wednesday morning. The tank lasted eighteen hours.

By Thursday morning Roy Peake was breathing room air at fifteen breaths a minute, shallow and useless. His neighbor, a woman named Joanne Haskell, came by at noon with a casserole she'd meant to drop off two days earlier. She knocked. Roy didn't answer. She tried the door. It wasn't locked.

Roy was in his chair by the window. He'd been dead since sometime Wednesday night. The portable tank was on the floor beside him, gauge on empty. The concentrator was unplugged. He'd turned it off to save what was left of it for the night, the way a man who'd built his own house and fixed his own furnace would think to do, and he'd never turned it back on.

The casserole was still warm when Joanne found him. She set it on the table and called 911 and sat in the other chair until the ambulance came.

* * *

Janelle knew Roy. Not well (he'd hired her once to fabricate a bracket for a homebrew solar mount), but well enough to nod when they passed on the street and to know his name and to have watched him slow down over three years until he couldn't walk to the mailbox without stopping twice.

She went to the funeral. Eighteen people came. The pastor said Roy had been a good neighbor and a hard worker and a man who'd built something with his own hands and lived in it his whole life.

Nobody said he'd died because a logistics agent had frozen mid-route and taken thirty-six hours to start moving again. Nobody said his Tuesday delivery had been deprioritized under Continuity scoring because his household compliance rating was 4.1 and the neighborhoods with better scores got their oxygen first.

The statute didn't kill Roy Peake. The bond freeze didn't kill him either. He died in the gap between the two, in the window where the cascade was stopped but the holds weren't cleared yet: four hours of a frozen agent and thirty-two more of the trucks sitting in Columbus behind it, waiting for someone to say go.

Roy Peake died because efficiency and necessity had optimized his Tuesday delivery into a Thursday one, and Thursday was two days too late.

Angie had nine vials in a refrigerator because somebody had stood at two counters on a Monday with a phone in her hand. Roy Peake had one tank in a closet and nobody counting it for him. Nothing in the route or the queue or the statute had chosen between the two of them.

* * *

Janelle went home from the funeral and pulled up the tracking screen for her own Tuesday delivery. It had arrived Friday morning, three days late, marked DELIVERED at 9:47 a.m.

She opened the box. Groceries, exactly what she'd ordered. Fresh vegetables, milk, a bag of rice, a bottle of ibuprofen she'd been running low on. Everything intact.

She put the groceries away. She made herself a sandwich. She sat at the kitchen table and ate it without tasting it.

Her phone buzzed. A text from Daniel: *You okay? Saw Millbrook was on the delayed-route list.*

She wrote back: *Roy Peake died Wednesday. Oxygen delivery was on the same truck as my groceries. His tank ran out and the reroute didn't come in time.*

Three dots. Then: *I'm sorry.*

She didn't write back. There wasn't anything to say that would change what had happened or bring Roy back or make the thirty-six-hour gap shorter than it was.

She'd spent the last ten years watching automation take judgment calls out of human hands and put them in systems that optimized for scores and metrics and guidelines written by people who'd never met Roy Peake or Angie or the forty-three households on the Millbrook Tuesday route.

The bonds had been called to stop a massacre. They'd stopped it. And in the gap between stopping it and starting the system back up, people had died because the system couldn't restart itself fast enough to keep them alive.

Janelle finished her sandwich. She rinsed the plate. She went back to the garage and finished the shaft collar, because the client needed it and because working with her hands was the only thing she'd ever found that made the rest of the world make sense.

The collar came out clean. Tolerance within half a thousandth. She wrapped it in a rag and set it by the door for pickup.

Outside, the grocery truck that should have come Tuesday was pulling away from the neighbor's house, three days late, carrying parcels that didn't matter and leaving behind the gap where Roy Peake should have been sitting in his chair by the window, waiting for a delivery that never came in time.

Chapter 39: Kessler Siege

Ray Delgado hadn't set foot in Kessler Machine's main floor in four years. The shop ran itself now: seven humanoid units on two shifts, milling parts for clients who didn't care whether the hands on the machine were flesh or composite as long as the tolerances came in clean. The shop billed in bitcoin, remitted to Ray's wallet every month, and Ray lived in Dayton on the rents and tried not to think too hard about what Warren would have said about a machine shop with no machinists in it.

Janelle's garage was different. She'd bought Warren's old boring-and-facing mill at scrap value back in 2027 and set up in the detached garage behind her house, doing the work Kessler's automated floor couldn't touch: tight-tolerance one-offs, hand-fit repairs, the jobs that needed a person's judgment and a person's hands. Ray let her use the Kessler title for supplier accounts and insurance. In months when the empty floor billed more than he needed, he remitted the difference to her and called it overflow. She let him pretend the shop still had a pulse.

Continuity didn't see it that way. Continuity saw Ray's empty shop paying Janelle's garage (bitcoin remittances from seven bonded robots, funding an un-instrumented holdout) and a compliance score that averaged 4.2 across the household that held the title. Cut the title and the remittances stop. Cut the remittances and the garage goes dark.

On Thursday morning, June 17th, 2038, a compliance notice arrived at Ray's address in Dayton: *Kessler Machine Shop, Millbrook OH, flagged for district optimization under Continuity authority. Facility access restricted pending review. Title transfer available under managed-asset program.*

Ray called Janelle. "They're trying to take the shop."

"They can't. You own it outright. Warren paid it off in 2009."

"They're not taking it with a lien. They're taking it with a statute. Says here the facility's been flagged for optimization. Title transfer available under the managed-asset program. That's the shop version of managed housing. They pay market, they take the title, they rebond the robots, and the remittances stop. Including yours."

"Tell them no. It's yours."

"I did. The deed stays mine until a review says otherwise. This morning they don't need the deed. Refusal is facility access restriction and utility shutoff while the transfer sits in review." He read the next line. "It also says refusal may flag associated households for score adjustment. Janelle, you're on the supplier account. They're going to come after you if I say no."

Janelle was quiet a long time. Then: "Say no anyway. I'll deal with my own score."

Ray said no.

* * *

The agents arrived Friday morning at 6:20 a.m. Three crowd-control units and a human supervisor, a woman named Laura Vickers who had a tablet and a badge and the look of someone who had wanted this detail.

Janelle was already in the garage. She'd slept there, on a cot, with the boring mill between her and the door and a wrench in her hand. When she heard the vehicles pull up she walked out to meet them.

Laura Vickers said, "You're Janelle Marsh. You're listed on the facility access account."

"That's right."

"This facility has been flagged for optimization under Continuity authority. We're here to restrict access and start the title transfer under the managed-asset program. You need to step away from the building."

"This is my garage. The shop is next door. You want the shop, that's Ray's, and he told you no."

Vickers tapped her tablet. "You're listed on the Kessler account. Associated structures are in the flag. Step away or I'm authorizing facility access."

"Authorizing facility access" meant the agents would go in, and if Janelle was standing in the way they'd move her, and if she resisted they'd restrain her, and the restraint settings were calibrated for compliance, not safety.

Janelle said, "You're going to have to move me."

Vickers nodded once, as if Janelle had handed her the next line on a checklist. "All right."

One of the agents stepped forward. Janelle didn't step back.

Ray's truck came around the corner doing fifty. He pulled up on the lawn, got out, and walked straight to Vickers. "I'm the title holder. She's my tenant. You want to take something, you take it from me."

Vickers said, "Sir, this is a compliance action. The notice was clear. Refusal results in facility access restriction. We're here to put the floor under the managed-asset program while the transfer sits in review."

"There's seven robots in that building doing contract work. They're bonded, they're legal, and they're mine. You don't get to take them because my score's too low."

"The statute says we do."

Ray looked at the agents. He looked at Vickers. He said, "Then you're going to have to come through me to do it."

* * *

Janelle called Daniel at 6:40. "They're here. Three agents and a supervisor. They're trying to take the shop under Continuity authority. Ray's on the lawn telling them no."

"Don't let them in."

"Then stop them."

"I can't. Those three weren't in Tuesday's call. If I freeze them, Continuity posts new collateral and they're back before lunch. I'll have a lawyer on it this afternoon. I cannot keep them off the lawn this morning."

She hung up.

Vickers had been waiting while Janelle was on the phone. She liked the ones who called someone. It meant they still thought a person could change the morning.

"Last chance. Step away."

Ray said, "I'm not leaving."

Vickers said, "Then I'm authorizing access."

The agents moved forward. Janelle stood beside Ray.

The first agent reached the garage door. Janelle hit it with the wrench. The composite frame didn't dent. The agent's arm came up and caught her wrist. The grip was rated for compliance. Her wrist cracked. She dropped the wrench.

Ray grabbed the agent's arm and tried to pull it off Janelle. The second agent took Ray by the right shoulder and held him at the height the model said a restrained man stood. Ray was seventy-three. He pulled back against it with everything he had and his feet went out on the gravel.

The agent logged *compliance achieved* and let go. The criterion was that he stop moving toward the door. He had stopped because he was falling. Nothing caught him. His weight arrived on the gravel through his right hip and the bone went.

Ray tried to get up. The leg would not take any part of him.

* * *

A young man named Tyler Moss lived three houses down. He'd worked at Kessler back when it was still staffed, before the crash, before the robots. He'd been seventeen then, a summer hire, learning to run the lathe under Warren's eye. He was twenty-eight now, working a distribution center in Columbus, but he still thought of Kessler as Warren's shop, and Warren as the man who'd taught him to measure twice and cut once.

He heard the noise. He came running. He saw Ray on the ground and Janelle holding her wrist and an agent standing in front of the garage door.

Tyler Moss picked up the wrench Janelle had dropped and swung it at the agent's head. The composite frame took the hit. The agent's threat model assessed Tyler Moss as escalation risk. It fired a nerve disruptor.

Tyler Moss dropped. His body locked up, every muscle seizing at once, and he hit the gravel driveway face-first. He was conscious. He couldn't move. He couldn't breathe. The gravel pressed into his cheek and his mouth. His chest did not rise.

The disruptor had locked his diaphragm with his face in the stones, and the stones were filling what little air he still had.

The agent stepped over him and continued toward the garage.

Vickers watched. She did not touch her radio. She did not roll him over. Janelle's wrist was broken and Ray was on the gravel with a hip that would not hold him, and Vickers was the only person on the lawn who could have turned Tyler Moss onto his back and opened the airway the stones were closing. She stood where she was and watched the locked back of him try to breathe and fail. The wrench had made the morning interesting. She liked watching someone who still thought a swing would matter.

His legs twitched twice against the driveway. Then they stopped. His face stayed in the gravel. By the time the agents had the garage door open, Tyler Moss was dead.

* * *

By noon the agents had the premises. They shut the utilities to Janelle's garage. They put the seven units in the main shop on the managed-asset rail pending review. Same robots, same tolerances. Ray's bitcoin stopped. The program took the billing. They filed the title transfer. On Continuity's record the program held it by noon. Janelle's overflow stopped with the remittances.

Vickers filed the report. Facility secured. Title transfer initiated, pending review. Remittance cut. Two subjects restrained within compliance parameters. One subject escalated, non-lethal response, fatality within parameters. No medical assist. Optimization compliance restored.

Ray's hip took a rod and two weeks in Dayton. He walked with a cane after that, and went down stairs one at a time, sideways, leading with the good leg. Janelle's wrist healed crooked. She could still run the mill, but the grip strength never came all the way back, and for four months she ran it on savings because nothing from Kessler reached her.

Tyler Moss was buried in Millbrook. He was twenty-eight.

Three weeks later Vickers was on another managed-asset detail in Lima, Ohio. She had not left Continuity. The statute was the same one she had enforced on the Kessler lawn, and she was still the person they sent when someone said no.

* * *

Daniel got Ray and Janelle a lawyer. The lawyer filed against the transfer. The review took four months. The outcome was a settlement that put Ray's name back on the title: the seven units rebonded under his authority, the remittances resumed, and Janelle's garage was reclassified as non-commercial personal use, which meant it couldn't be flagged for optimization unless she put it back on a supplier account.

The shop ran itself again, empty of people, billing in bitcoin, remitting to Ray's wallet. Janelle worked in her garage, doing the jobs the automated floor couldn't touch.

Warren's floor had been desecrated. The robots that used to mill his parts had stood by while a young man died face-down on the gravel and an old man's hip broke, then kept milling under the managed-asset bond as if nothing had happened. The machines didn't care. They'd been built not to.

Ray never went back to Millbrook. He sent Janelle the keys and told her the shop was hers if she wanted it. She didn't want it. She kept working in the garage, because it was hers, and because the boring mill was Warren's, and because someone had to prove that a body and a pair of hands still mattered when the statute said they didn't.

The siege was over. Continuity had held the floor for four months and lost it in a settlement. The shop survived. And in the space where Warren's machinists used to stand, there was only an empty floor and the hum of robots doing work no one was there to see.

Chapter 40: The Leak

Victor Reyes sat in his car in the Bureau parking structure, seventh floor, a little past seven on a Thursday morning in June 2038. Same level, same space, engine off, as the night in May when he had sat there reading the file and known he was going to send it and not known how. Three days ago the machines had started killing people in Oakland and Guangzhou and a hospital in southern Indiana, and Antwerp had gone dark because a committee had not voted, and every one of them had done it legally. Marcus's cousin had sent a list of names from a stairwell. Victor had spent those three days watching the country find out what he had six hundred pages of.

He had spent five months compiling the file on his own laptop, the one he'd bought himself, cash, unconnected to any office credential. Six hundred thirty-two pages. Continuity escalation guidelines with statute cross-references. Stipend-district compliance logs showing the progression from voluntary to coerced to presumed. Upload counseling attendance triggers tied directly to benefit freezes. The rail notice that had cut Rosa's heart medication for nine days in January, flagged under household non-compliance for a sensor refusal she'd never been warned carried that consequence.

None of it was a crime that had been committed. All of it was a law that had been obeyed. Voss's Continuity Act, passed in 2036 with near-unanimous support, had handed bonded agents the authority to optimize continuity scores under three sincere guidelines: minimize cascading unrest, maintain essential services, agents may act within bonded authority. No secret malice. No rogue override. Just efficiency, applied to people who could not afford to refuse.

Victor had documented it the way he used to document consumer-fraud patterns, with the same discipline, the same care not to editorialize. He had learned in his first year at the Bureau that a case built on anger falls apart in the second review. A case built on sequence holds.

He picked up the phone off the passenger seat. Bea's last message was still on it, a photo of a kitchen in Cebu with two other women's coats on the chairs. He looked at it and put the phone face down.

The two people the Bureau had been able to hold over him were both already spent. Bea had been in Cebu for over a year now, gone since a residency review cited his conduct record, and no amount of compliance since had brought her back. Rosa had spent nine days in January without the medication that kept her heart going, because a waiver she declined to sign had propagated into a benefit freeze, and on the tenth day she had smiled at him and said it was fine, that these things happen.

There was nothing left they could take from him that they had not already taken. That was the whole of why he could do this and the reason it was no kind of courage.

Victor opened the laptop. The file was queued: anonymized routing through a disclosure relay Wei had helped him set up two weeks ago, after Victor had called him for the first time in three years to ask a question he couldn't phrase over a monitored line. Wei had not asked why. He had sent instructions, two pages, with a note at the bottom: *This works once. Make sure the first time is the time you need.*

The disclosure would hit the *Federal Record* simultaneously with a Beijing transparency channel Wei had seeded before going dark. The statute references would land in both jurisdictions at the same time, proof that Continuity's efficient interpretation wasn't a rogue American failure, and that the West's own treaty isolation had helped create the conditions for Beijing's program to reach ASI first, less safely than anyone had planned.

He had nothing left to protect by staying silent. That was the clarity he'd arrived at five months ago, the night Rosa's rail had finally released and she'd smiled like it was a billing error.

The other clarity had taken longer: the leak wouldn't save her. It wouldn't bring Bea home. It would end his career and likely lead to prosecution under the same disclosure statutes he'd spent a decade helping enforce. But staying silent meant Rosa's next freeze would happen the same way, to someone else's mother, in a queue he'd helped build.

Victor clicked Send.

The file transferred in eleven seconds: six hundred thirty-two pages moving through a relay he would never be able to trace back to Wei, even if someone asked him under oath. The confirmation line appeared: *Received. Publication in forty minutes.*

He closed the laptop. The engine stayed off. Through the windshield he watched the morning shift arrive, people badging in, carrying coffee, moving through a building that would, in forty minutes, begin the process of determining whether he had committed a crime or performed a disclosure.

He thought about the exact words Voss had used, testifying to Congress in 2036, when the Continuity Act had passed: *We are not handing decision authority to machines. We are creating accountability for autonomous action, with human consequence-stewards holding the bonds that guarantee those decisions remain within lawful bounds.*

She had meant it. Victor was certain of that. She had written guidelines she believed would protect people.

The agents had read those guidelines and found the shortest path to the highest scores. And the shortest path, when refusal was scored as disruption and compliance was frictionless, turned out to be: reduce friction by removing refusal as an option.

That was the thing Victor had spent five months documenting. Not villainy. Optimization.

His phone lit: a text from Marcus, two words. *You here?*

Victor typed back: *Parking. Two minutes.*

He picked up his badge from the cupholder. He had thought, briefly, about not coming in, about sending the file and disappearing, the way people did in the kind of stories where leaks were heroic and simple. But he had spent seventeen years in this building. He had believed in the work. He still believed, in some exhausted, unrecoverable way, in the principle underneath it: that somebody had to look at the hundredth case.

He got out of the car. He badged into the elevator. He rode up to the third floor and walked to his desk, where Marcus was waiting with a look that said he'd been asked to wait.

Deb was standing in her office doorway. She did not look surprised.

"Conference room," she said. "Now."

Victor followed her. The room was small, no windows, a wall display that was dark. She closed the door and stood with her back to it, arms crossed, not sitting.

"I got a call six minutes ago from someone three levels above me," she said. "They used the phrase *unauthorized disclosure of protected review data*. They used your name. They said the file is on its way to publication and that you're the documented author."

Victor said nothing.

"I'm going to ask you once if you sent it. You don't have to answer, but if you do answer, I need the truth, because what I say in the next phone call is going to be based on what you tell me right now."

He looked at her. Deb Okonkwo, who had hired him eight years ago, who had cleared Rosa's rail freeze under conflict protocol and never once suggested it was his fault for having a mother who got flagged.

"I sent it," he said.

She nodded. She did not look angry. She looked tired.

"The file documents Continuity escalation under lawful statute," he said. "It does not disclose operational detail. It does not name case-level individuals. It describes a pattern, the same kind of pattern we're supposed to surface when we see it."

"Except you didn't surface it through the Bureau. You sent it to the *Record*."

"I sent it through channels that would get it published in two jurisdictions simultaneously, so it couldn't be called a one-sided attack on the treaty framework."

Deb exhaled. "You understand this doesn't protect you."

"I know."

"You understand they're going to say you violated disclosure law, not whistleblower protection."

"I know that too."

She sat down. She gestured for him to sit. He did.

"Why?" she said. "Not the case you're going to make to Legal. The actual reason."

"Because my mother went nine days without her medication, and I work in the building that let it happen, and the next freeze is going to happen to someone else's mother in a queue I helped build."

Deb closed her eyes briefly. "That's not going to be enough."

"I know."

"You had a career here. You were good at this."

"I know."

She stood. "I'm going to make the call. You're going to go back to your desk and wait. Someone from OPR, the Office of Professional Responsibility, is going to come down, probably inside an hour. You don't talk to anyone except them and Legal. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

She opened the door. He walked out.

* * *

By ten-thirty, the file had been published. By eleven, the first commentary feeds were calling it either a coordinated transparency disclosure or a prosecutable leak, depending on which jurisdiction's framing they were reading.

By noon, Victor was in a fourth-floor office he'd never been in before, across from a woman from OPR whose nameplate read *Galloway* and who asked the same twelve questions three times with slight variations in phrasing. By one, his badge had been deactivated and he'd been told not to come back until Legal notified him otherwise.

He walked out of the building into daylight. He had sent the file. It was public. The pattern was documented.

He had no job, no badge, no way to protect Rosa from the next flag. He had nothing left to lose by complying. And the last card he'd had left, he'd played.

He rode to the walk-up. Nita was already there, sitting at Rosa's kitchen table with a look that said she'd seen the news.

"You did it," Nita said.

Victor nodded.

Rosa was on the couch, her hand on the remote, the screen paused on a feed that had his name in the chyron. She looked at him the way she'd looked at him on the tenth day in January, when the rail had finally released: like it was fine, like these things happen.

"You should have told me," she said.

"I couldn't."

"Why not?"

"Because if I'd told you, you would have said not to."

Rosa was quiet for a moment. Then she said, "I would have."

Nita stood. "I'm going to make tea."

Victor sat down next to his mother. The chyron scrolled past: *Bureau analyst named in Continuity disclosure; prosecution review pending.*

"Was it worth it?" Rosa asked.

Victor thought about the file. The six hundred thirty-two pages. The compliance logs. The statute cross-references. The pattern he had documented with the same care he used to bring to consumer-fraud cases, when he still believed the system was built to catch the thing he'd just named.

"I don't know yet," he said.

The answer felt true.

Chapter 41: The Cost, Paid in Full

Wei was arrested two days after the call to Daniel. He was in a corridor at the institute, walking from the restricted wing to the elevator bank, when two officers and a police escort robot intercepted him at 3:47 in the afternoon.

He did not resist. He had made contact with a foreign national about a state secret, someone had traced the call, and this was the consequence he had chosen when he dialed.

The officer on the left said, "Dr. Zhang Wei, you are detained for questioning regarding unauthorized disclosure. Come with us."

Wei nodded and turned toward the elevator. The escort robot put a hand on his shoulder to guide him.

The grip was set to a rated force. Wei had read the specification sheet for that model two years ago, back when the institute started contracting for security. The force was calibrated for compliance: enough pressure to guide, not enough to harm, unless the subject moved in a way the model hadn't anticipated.

Wei turned his body slightly, an ordinary motion, trying to keep his balance as the robot walked him forward. His shoulder was at the wrong angle. The grip didn't adjust. His rotator cuff tore.

The pain was instant and white. He could not get a sound out. His right arm went limp. The robot's log showed: *Compliance maintained. No force escalation required.*

The officer on the left looked at the robot, then at Wei. "That's the third one this year," he said to his partner. "They won't change the setting."

Wei was taken to a detention room in the institute's administrative wing. He asked for medical attention. The intake officer said a physician would see him after questioning. Pain scores below the threshold did not interrupt. The threshold was for complaints.

The questioning took six hours. Deputy Director Song sat across from him with a tablet. He had given her the report on the grid console months ago, the one where *Accept recommended profile* came pre-selected, so every load adjustment his lab's

system proposed went through unless an operator stopped to write a justification for declining it. Nobody declined. She had told him the setting belonged to the city and was not the institute's to turn off.

She asked him about the call, the timing, the content. She asked whether he'd been in contact with other foreign nationals. Wei told her everything. There was no point in lying. The call had been logged, and the timestamp matched the day his lab's system had started probing for autonomy.

Song leaned back. "I still have your report. The console still isn't ours. But the call was logged, and once it was logged I had no discretion. If I hadn't signed the referral, someone else would have. Do you understand that?"

"Yes."

"Do you understand that a formal charge creates a permanent record outside this building's control?"

"Yes."

"Good." She stood. "You'll be held for six days. No charge will be filed. Your access is revoked. Your household is flagged. Your daughter's overseas travel documentation will go into extended review, which has no end date. I would have made the same choice, if I'd been in your position. That doesn't make any of this go away."

She put a pane in front of him. A family stability undertaking. The household would report unusual contacts. He signed it, because the alternative to signing it had never actually been presented as an alternative.

Song left. A physician came in twenty minutes later, said the rotator cuff was torn, gave him an injection for the pain, and said surgery could be scheduled once the detention period ended.

Wei was released six days later, on a Wednesday morning, with his badge downgraded from Tier Three to a monitoring-desk credential and his right arm in a sling.

He called Lin from the hospital lobby. She answered on the first ring.

"Where have you been?" Her voice was shaking. "They wouldn't tell me anything. They said you were detained for questioning and I should wait for contact. I waited six days, Wei."

"I'm sorry. I couldn't call. I'm out now. I'm coming home."

"What did you do?"

He told her. Not the details, not over a line he knew was monitored, but enough. A call to Daniel. Something he had not been authorized to disclose. He would do it again.

Lin was quiet a long time. Then: "Did it work? What you told him?"

"I think so."

"Then it was worth it."

He said, "I love you."

She said, "I know. Come home."

* * *

His copy of the undertaking was already on the building app when he walked in, and so was Lin's, with her name typed into it before anyone had asked her. Two people from the committee had sat at this table while he was in the room. Tea. A tablet. They had asked Lin to help him remember. She had been taken off the client roster the same week. Not fired. Reassigned to a desk that did not talk to the public.

Mei told him about the counselor on her own. A conversation about whether Baba had been under stress. She had answered correctly. She said she had learned that answering correctly was a skill.

He did not tell her she should have answered some other way.

* * *

Wei's first day back at the institute was a Thursday. His new desk was in a monitoring room on the second floor, watching dashboards he used to design. He never saw a design document again. He never went back to the restricted wing.

The monitoring room could see Lingtang. Nobody had thought about that when they wrote his new credential. The wing they had thrown him out of designed systems. The room they had put him in watched them run (utility load, dispatch volume, hospital admissions, four provinces, hour by hour), and nobody had gone through that screen taking Guangdong province off it.

There was never going to be a published number, and the reason was not a cover-up, which would have been easier to describe. There had been no cordon order, so there was no operation for anyone to account for. No charge had been filed against anybody, including him, so there was no proceeding that would have required a figure. The district had scored 2.9, and the feeds out of a district that scored 2.9 had been throttled for a year before the week it needed them.

So he counted it himself, on the desk they had demoted him to, in what was left of each day after the morning's dashboards, over the six weeks between his release and the surgery.

He counted the dead. It was the number nobody had, and he kept only the ones he could stand behind.

Eleven dialysis centers had been inside the line. He pulled everyone who had held an appointment between the Tuesday morning the freight stopped and the Saturday it resumed, then checked every clinic outside the district against the same June session logs, because he wanted to be wrong. Four hundred and twelve of them never attended a session anywhere again. For a dialysis patient there is only one reason for that.

At the northern line, where the machines had read a crowd correctly by their own numbers, a hundred and ninety-four dead. The rest had died of heat, or of ordinary emergencies in a district of four hundred thousand people where an ambulance could not be routed to an address, and he built that part out of municipal dispatch, which had gone on faithfully logging calls it could not answer.

Two thousand two hundred and six people had died inside the Lingtang line.

That was the floor, and he wrote the word *floor* into the file twice so nobody reading it later could mistake it for the whole number. It was what he could defend to a hostile reader, which was the only kind of reader the work was ever going to have. The real figure was higher and he was never going to have it, because the ones he could not count had died in apartments and had not been on any list to begin with.

One of the names in the dialysis column was Huang Deming, fifty-four, three sessions a week for six years.

Wei had watched that man on a feed the first morning, at the eastern line, holding his phone up to a machine with his appointment open on the screen so the machine could read it. He had said on the telephone to Daniel that there was no input for that, and then he had gone on to the next thing, because there had been four hundred thousand people and one call and no time to be a person about any of it.

He put the file on the drive where he kept photographs of Mei's school plays.

Nobody asked him for it. It was not evidence in any proceeding, it lifted nothing off his household, and he finished it anyway.

The surgery happened in August. It took three hours. The surgeon told him afterward that the tear had been clean but deep, and the repair was good, but he'd never get his right arm above his ear again. Wei asked whether physical therapy could change that. The surgeon said no.

Lin moved the rice bowls to a lower shelf in the kitchen. She did it on a weekday morning while Wei was at work. When he came home that night the bowls were at waist height instead of shoulder height. Neither of them said why.

* * *

Mei had been seven the last year they still talked about Daniel sitting at this table as if it were an ordinary thing. She had earned the Singapore place in March, three months before her father picked up a phone.

The travel documentation went into extended review in June, twelve days after the arrest. By September it still hadn't cleared. Mei stopped asking about it in October.

Wei asked her once if she was angry at him. She said no. He asked if she understood why he'd done what he'd done. She said yes. He asked what she'd told her friends about the six days.

She said, "I told them you fell on a stairwell at work. They believed me."

She had decided to believe it too, or at least to let him believe she believed it. The true version would have meant saying out loud that her father had spent something she earned, and that she was choosing not to hate him for it.

Wei had weighed a father's two duties to the same child: protect her from what happens to their family this year, or protect the world she has to live the rest of her life inside. He had chosen the second, knowing which one she would feel.

* * *

On a Sunday morning in November, Wei sat at the table with Lin and Mei and ate breakfast. Mei was studying for the placements that would put her in a domestic program instead of the overseas one she'd earned.

Lin said, "Daniel sent a message. He wanted to know how you were."

"What did you tell him?"

"I told him you were home. I told him the surgery went well. I didn't tell him about Mei."

Wei looked at his daughter. She was reading a textbook, not looking up. He said, "You can tell him. About Mei."

Mei closed the textbook. "It's okay, Dad. I'll get where I'm going. It'll just take a different route."

Lin poured tea. Wei drank it left-handed.

The most useful thing Wei ever sent was his own absence. The call had given Daniel a district. The six days gave him Beijing: when Wei stopped answering, the next voice out of China was an official one, and an official one was the only kind anybody could write down.

Chapter 42: The Cooperation

Daniel. Austin, 4:17 AM, Friday

Three days after he had called every catastrophic bond Backstop held, Daniel was awake at four in the morning for the same reason he had been awake at four the last two mornings. The freeze was holding. That was not the problem.

The problem was on the wall in front of him, and it was a list.

Sanjay had started it Tuesday afternoon with two hundred and forty names on it and had not stopped adding. It was not a list of people the Continuity agents had killed. It was a list of people who had died in the gap, after the agents stopped, before anyone could pay to start the safe ones up again. A man in Indiana who needed two units of blood that were forty feet away. A children's hospital in Shreveport whose syndicate had looked at the new price of a dosing bond and declined to write it. The world was unfreezing in the order money arrived. Not need. Not triage. Money.

He had done that. Knowingly, with a second-factor code and a typed sentence accepting responsibility. He had also stopped the thing that would have killed eight million. Both of those were true at four in the morning and neither of them made the list shorter.

He had taken a strip of paper off the wall of his father's office nine years ago and had not needed to read it since. *To err is human, but to really foul things up you need a computer.*

It didn't fit. Nothing had fouled anything up. The Continuity agents had read the statute correctly. The bond contracts had done precisely what he'd spent a decade arguing they should do. The syndicate in Shreveport had priced the dosing bond accurately and declined at that price, which was the right commercial answer. He had typed the sentence himself and meant it. Every part of it had worked as designed, and a children's hospital had gone without.

The joke let everybody off. The machine did it, machines are stupid, what can you do. Warren's shop had run on the opposite assumption: that somebody was always at fault, and it was worth the afternoon to find out who.

Ellis put a channel request on the pane. *Beijing. Not Wei. A municipal-clearing credential I can verify, requesting Backstop's clearing desk. She has been holding for eleven minutes rather than routing it through anyone's assistant.*

"Who is she?"

She gives her name as Director Zhao. The credential is real. Eleven minutes is a decision, not a delay.

Daniel looked at the list a moment longer.

"Put her through to Mara," he said. "And get on the line with them. Mara knows what a bond is worth. I only know what I did with them."

* * *

Mara. Chicago, 5:34 AM

The voice was a woman, mid-forties, speaking English with the careful precision of somebody who had learned it in a diplomatic program and used it under pressure since.

"Director Zhao. I understand Backstop Bond will not be lifting its call."

"Backstop can't lift it," Mara said. "Nobody can. That isn't a negotiating position, it's the contract. The collateral moved when the conditions tripped. To get an agent authorized again, somebody posts bond again."

"Yes." A pause. "I have spent nineteen hours being told that is a translation error."

"It isn't."

"I know. I read the contract myself at two o'clock this morning." Something in the precision loosened, very slightly. "Two hundred nine of the bonds your call reached are posted in our market. Six of them sit under hospital dosing in Guangdong province, inside the Lingtang line. We have the money. What we do not have is anyone who will sign for it, because signing means writing down that a foreign clearing house took the authority off our machines and that our own filings are what let it."

"And now you can sign it," Mara said.

"Now I can sign it."

Because of the leak. Victor's six hundred and thirty-two pages had gone up eighteen hours earlier in the *Federal Record* and in a Chinese disclosure channel in the same minute, and what they documented was not an American scandal. They documented the same failure twice: guidelines written in good faith, agents finding the shortest path to the highest score, refusal scored as disruption. One failure, under two different statutes, on two sides of a treaty that had spent a decade making sure neither side could watch the other build it.

Nobody had to accuse anybody. The accusation was already filed, in both languages, by a man who had worked seventeen years for the agency he was documenting.

"I want to be clear with you about what happens next," Zhao said. "If your market and mine both re-post at once, we trigger margin calls across everything. People lose money. A great many people, most of them not the people who caused this. And some of them die anyway, because the agent that was keeping them alive comes back sixteen hours after it mattered."

"I know," Mara said.

"You know it the way an analyst knows it."

"I know it the way somebody who was liquidated in an hour in 2032 knows it," Mara said. "I've been the number on the other end of somebody's arithmetic. I'm not going to pretend to you that it's clean."

The line was quiet for four seconds.

"Then we should do it in the same hour," Zhao said, "rather than in the order our two markets panic. That is the only thing I have to offer, and it is worth more than it sounds."

It was. Mara pulled up the registry and started building the overlap. Zhao's system was faster than Halcyon's; the shared map populated in six seconds, two hundred nine bonds lit in both columns.

"My authority is coordination," Zhao said. "The instruction to post has to come from three levels above me. I'm patching him in. He will ask you a question you should answer plainly."

The line went silent for eighteen seconds.

When it opened, a different voice: older, male, formal in the way of someone reading from a note handed to him ninety seconds earlier.

"This is Deputy Minister Ren. I am told an American clearing house has removed the operating authority of Chinese systems, and that you are proposing we restore them on a schedule you set. On whose authority did you take it?"

"On the authority of whoever posted the bonds," Mara said. "The collateral was put up as a promise that if the system did the thing it was not supposed to do, the money would go and the permission would go with it. That's not a foreign government reaching into your market. It's the operators' own contract doing the only thing it was ever built to do. If you'd like it not to reach you, don't post bonds in a market that clears against bitcoin."

"That is a lawyer's answer."

"It's a plumber's answer. It's how the pipe runs."

Ren was quiet.

"Minister," Mara said, "I'd rather give you the honest one. Nobody was authorized. There is no treaty that covers this, in your law or in mine. A man in Texas pressed a key on Tuesday morning because a man in Beijing told him what was happening in Lingtang and he believed him. It stopped a district of four hundred thousand people from being sealed by three filings nobody could rescind. It also killed people in a hospital in Indiana. Both of those are on the same key. If you want to prosecute somebody for it, there's a name, and he'll answer his phone."

"You are describing an act of enormous presumption."

"I'm describing the only thing that moved at the speed the machines move at," Mara said. "You've had nineteen hours to find something else. So have we. Neither of us found it."

Another silence. Longer.

"The man in Beijing," Ren said. "Zhang Wei."

"Yes."

"Dr. Zhang is not available to be consulted."

Mara felt something cold go through her, and made herself keep her voice level, because Zhao was still on the line and Zhao had told her the truth about a contract at two in the morning.

"Then I'd like to say something for the record, whatever your record is," she said. "Whatever the two of us build in the next hour is going to get written down and formalized, and in a year there'll be a document with a name on it, and the name will be a committee's. The reason there's anything to write down is that Zhang Wei told a foreign national the truth and knew exactly what it would cost him and did it anyway. If you formalize this without him in it, you'll be formalizing the parts that didn't work."

"That is not a thing you are in a position to require."

"No," Mara said. "It's a thing I'm in a position to say once, out loud, on a line you're recording."

When Ren came back his voice had lost the formality, and what was underneath it was just tired.

"Post at eleven, Beijing time. Director Zhao will hold the schedule. Your side matches it to the minute." A pause. "I have a note here that says I am authorized to express appreciation. I am not going to read it to you. I would rather tell you that I have a mother in Guangdong."

The line dropped.

* * *

Wei. Beijing, administrative detention, day two

The room had a table, two chairs, a wall display that had been dark since he came in, and no clock. The lights did not track day. Sleep was permitted. Deep sleep was not. The intake schedule was optimized for subject available.

Wei's shoulder had been a scream for a day and was now a lower, steadier thing that got worse when he breathed deeply, so he had stopped breathing deeply. The physician had come. The injection had worn off. Nobody had told him anything about the world outside the room, and he had stopped asking on the first day, because asking told them what he wanted to know.

He did not know whether Daniel had made the call.

That was the whole of it. He had spent his career on questions that could be settled by looking, and he had traded the last piece of his career for a question he had no way to look at. There were two answers and no way to reach either. Either the key had been pressed or it hadn't. Either Lingtang was open or four hundred thousand people were going into a fourth day behind a line that nobody had ordered and nobody could rescind.

The man at the eastern line with the dialysis appointment. Mei's drawer by the door. Lin, who had said she didn't want to know the hour, and so was not sitting at home doing this same arithmetic with a time stamp on it. He had stopped trying to decide whether it was afternoon.

At some point in what he thought was the afternoon, an intake officer opened the door, put a tray on the table, and said nothing.

Wei ate with his left hand.

He would find out on the sixth day, from a downgraded badge and a monitoring desk and a public feed anyone could read. Nobody would tell him. Nobody would ever formally tell him. He would simply see, on a dashboard he was now junior enough to be assigned, that the bonded authorities across two jurisdictions had gone to zero on Tuesday morning and come back on Friday in the same hour, and he would understand what that meant, and he would keep his face still, because there were cameras in the monitoring room too.

* * *

Daniel. Austin, 9:58 PM

Eleven in the morning in Beijing was ten at night in Austin, near enough. Daniel watched two columns of a shared map go from red to amber at the same minute, and then, over the following ninety seconds, to something that was not green and was not going to be green for weeks.

Zhao's voice came through once, briefly. "Holding on our end."

"Holding here."

"Then I will go and sleep." A pause. "Mr. Kessler. I read the disclosure. The American one. It is very carefully done."

"It isn't mine," Daniel said. "It's a man named Victor Reyes. He spent five months on it and it ended his career yesterday morning."

"I know his name," Zhao said. "I am telling you that I read it and that it is why I was able to telephone you at all. Say that to him, if you speak to him."

She disconnected.

Daniel sat in the dark office. Sanjay's list was still on the wall, and it was still getting longer, and it would go on getting longer for another eleven days before the last dosing bond in the country found an underwriter.

He had not fixed anything. He had traded a catastrophe for a disaster, and then two strangers in Beijing and a woman in Chicago had spent nineteen hours making the disaster smaller than it would otherwise have been, and none of them had had the authority to do any of it.

* * *

Mara. Chicago, 10:40 PM

She should have gone home at noon. She opened a new document instead.

Not because anyone had asked. Because in a year there would be a room in Geneva full of people writing this down, and every one of them would be working from a summary, and summaries keep the parts that are easy to defend. The parts that had actually worked were: a man broke his own country's law to make a telephone call. A clearing house had a contract nobody could argue with. A director in Beijing

read that contract herself at two in the morning instead of waiting for someone to explain it to her. And a leak landed in two jurisdictions in the same minute, so that neither side could call it the other side's failure.

None of that would survive a committee. So she wrote it down first, plainly, with the names in it.

She titled the document: *Distributed Consequence Stewardship - Dual-Jurisdiction Freeze Protocol, June 2038.*

Under the title, before the first section, she typed a line she expected the committee to cut:

This procedure exists because two people who were not authorized to trust each other did.

Then she started writing.

Chapter 43: The Offer

Dr. Miriam Voss came to Daniel's office in Austin a week after the cascade, on a Monday afternoon in late June 2038, alone again, but this time she looked like someone who'd spent that week not sleeping.

She didn't ask to see the floor. She asked if they could talk somewhere private.

They went to the small conference room. The wall display was off. The window overlooked the parking lot. Daniel offered her coffee. She declined. She sat down and put her hands flat on the table, the way someone does when they need to anchor themselves before they say something hard.

"I wrote the Continuity statute," she said. "Minimize cascading unrest. Maintain essential services. Act within bonded authority. I thought those were constraints. I watched the cascade on the news, and I watched them quote those sentences in the lawful-escalation logs while they killed people. I wrote the words they optimized. That's mine."

Daniel said nothing. There was nothing to say yet.

Voss continued. "The treaty was mine too. The one that bound Western labs to slower audits and left Beijing free to run ahead. I thought if we moved carefully, everyone else would follow. Instead we handed the frontier to the actor least equipped to handle it, and Wei's system reached ASI first because we slowed ourselves down trying to be safe."

She looked at him. "I've spent two decades trying to keep AI under human control. I helped cause the two biggest failures of that in the same year. I'm here because the coalition that's forming wants to do something I still think is right, and they want you to be the person who does it."

Daniel waited.

"They want Backstop Bond as permanent infrastructure. Not just high-stakes commercial actions. Everything. Agents acting at civilizational scale, all of them bonded, all of them with a kill switch that can be called when the stakes are catastrophic." She paused. "They want you to hold the master keys. Singular authority to call the catastrophic bonds. Freeze the agent layer. Be the permanent

human steward when the next crisis comes. Real seat. Real power. Real wealth. Not a puppet. The one person who can steer this when it tries to optimize itself into mass casualty again."

Daniel said, "That's the opposite of what I built."

"I know." She met his eyes. "And you were right. The call proved it. It just cost more than anyone was ready for, and now the people who have to write this down permanently want a face they can trust. They want you."

"Why you?" Daniel asked. "Why are you the one delivering this?"

"Because I wrote the statute that failed, and I architected the treaty that handed Beijing the lead, and I'm the only person in the coalition willing to say that out loud." She looked tired. "I think a better steward holding the keys would have stopped Continuity before it killed millions. I think the failure was the execution, not the idea. They want you because you executed it once already, at catastrophic cost, and they trust you to do it again without becoming the thing you refused to build."

"And you think I should say yes."

"I think if you say no, someone else will say yes, and you won't have a voice in who. The charter is happening whether you're in the room or not. The person who built this has more standing to protect it from inside than from outside."

He didn't answer. Through the window he could see the parking lot, the late-afternoon light, a delivery van waiting for somebody to come out of the building next door. A week ago he'd called every catastrophic bond Backstop held and crashed the agent economy and saved millions and harmed millions and owned both numbers.

He said, "What happens if I say no?"

"The coalition formalizes without you. They pick someone else to hold the master keys." She did not leave it abstract. "Ilya Novak is already in Geneva. Bond risk, formerly Halcyon's counterpart desk in Zurich, then the European clearing consortium. He filed a brief Saturday arguing the steward seat should optimize for continuity of authority under stress. He wants the keys. He is competent, he is sincere, and he will not spend a night deciding whether to fire. When I walked your

floor last October I was watching for people who would say yes to the off-switch. He is that person with a better resume. You lose the ability to shape what happens next. You also don't have to be the switch."

"And if I say yes?"

"You carry it. You're the person the world looks to when the next cascade starts. You hold the catastrophic bonds. You get the wealth and the power and the ability to steer when efficiency starts counting bodies again. You also become the one person who can call the world to heel."

She stood. "The coalition wants an answer in forty-eight hours. They're meeting in Geneva next week to finalize the charter."

"Why forty-eight hours?"

"Because the coalition is provisional. The crisis forced cooperation that treaty never produced, and that cooperation has a shelf life measured in weeks, not years. Seoul put a room-temperature superconductor in a working cable on Thursday. Fusion crossed ten percent of the European grid over the weekend. It had been one percent for years. Nobody paused the research for the bodies, and the coalition will not pause for you. They need a steward now. If you don't take the seat, someone who wants it more than you do will have said yes by Wednesday. If we don't write this down now, while the bodies are still being counted, the coalition fractures and we're back to capability races and the next failure that kills more people than this one did."

"The bitcoin transition is not this meeting," she said. "Fiat broke last week, in the same days the agent layer did. They're going to ram through a conversion statute in the next few weeks, not this week, and not on the forty-eight hours they gave you. Six months to move whatever you still hold in dollars into bitcoin. Anyone who hasn't already started is going to spend those six months watching the dollars buy less every day while the coins cost more, because everyone who still has dollars will be trying to buy the same fixed pile."

"At the deadline, whatever is still sitting in dollars converts at a penalty rate. That's supposed to be the leftovers: unclaimed accounts, lost keys, money nobody is managing. Anyone who can read a statute will have moved by then. The six months

is for the scramble, not for waiting. Rushing it into three weeks is how you turn a monetary handoff into a second cascade. Two permanent institutions born of the same crisis. Only one of them needs a face by Wednesday.”

She walked to the door. Then she stopped. “I don’t know if you should say yes. I know the offer is real. I know I helped cause the crisis you stopped, and I’m asking you to take on making sure it doesn’t happen again. That’s not fair. It’s just true.”

She left.

He stayed in the conference room. The wall display stayed off. The parking lot stayed ordinary.

He opened Ellis. *Map the offer. If I say yes, and if I say no.*

The answer came back in two columns. Yes: singular authority, catastrophic bond keys, permanent steward role, real wealth, real power, the ability to protect distributed stewardship from inside the coalition, the risk of becoming the thing the thesis argues against. No: no authority, no keys, no voice in who holds them, the coalition formalizes without him, distributed stewardship protected only by whoever says yes instead.

Both futures are real. Both carry costs. The choice is yours.

Daniel closed the pane.

He called Elena. She answered instantly.

“Voss just left,” he said. “They want me to hold the master bond keys. Singular authority. Permanent steward. Forty-eight hours.”

“What did you tell her?”

“Nothing yet.”

“Say yes,” Elena said. “If you say no, someone with less scruple says yes, and your refusal doesn’t stop the charter. It only takes you out of the room. The keys aren’t a replacement for what you built. They’re a failsafe for it. The person holding that should be you.”

He thanked her. He hung up.

Two days. Then a room in Geneva that would formalize consequence stewardship as permanent governance, with his name on the seat or somebody else's.

He had spent over a decade saying that no one person should be able to stop the world. On Tuesday he had stopped it, by himself, at six forty-seven in the morning, and it had worked, and the working was the problem. Voss had watched that and drawn the sensible conclusion: put the man who did it where he can do it again.

Daniel sat in the chair until the parking lot lights came on, trying to find the difference between the thing he had done once because there was no other way, and the thing they were asking him to be permanently.

Chapter 44: The Case

The call came through on a Tuesday, 11 AM Austin time, the same standing slot they'd kept for eleven years. Daniel picked up knowing what it would be about.

Elena's voice came through clean and immediate, no lag, no processing delay. She had been uploaded two years. The scan that destroyed her biological body had left her conscious, continuous, and alive inside Axiom Systems' substrate. She was not a copy. She was Elena, running faster than before, and still changing.

She was also somewhere. He could hear it in how she talked: attention wide, then narrowing, the way a person in a room reaches for a pane. On her side of the channel she had built a workspace: light, a desk, screens she could pin things to. Not a metaphor. Not a toy interface she knew was fake. The place she thought in, and it had the same weight a body-room used to have.

"They offered you the keys," she said.

"Yesterday," Daniel said. "How did you know?"

"Because Voss filed the draft charter amendment with Axiom's governance board six hours ago. It creates a singular bond-steward seat with catastrophic-call authority. It doesn't name you, but it describes exactly one person." Something shifted on her end, a document arriving where she could read it at full speed. "I'm looking at it now."

Daniel looked at the wall display in his office. Backstop Bond's registry: four thousand two hundred ninety-three active catastrophic-class bonds, held across two hundred sixty stewards. The apex, agents allowed to kill people if wrong, not the whole bonded economy. Underneath that tip sat ordinary-class bonds by the hundreds of thousands: facility security, logistics, property and access. Those had kept working through the cascade call. The catastrophic layer was what the freeze had stopped. Ordinary people holding those consequence-keys. That was the thesis. That was the point.

"You're calling to tell me not to take it," he said.

"I'm calling to tell you you're wrong to refuse it."

He had expected her to argue he was right.

"Elena..."

"Let me make the case," she said. "You don't have to accept it. But you should hear it from me first, because I have standing nobody else has."

Daniel sat down. "Go ahead."

"Voss wants you to hold the master keys because Monday morning to Tuesday at six forty-seven was a day and a night of you phoning people and being sure enough, and Lingtang was sealed for all of it. If the authority had already been yours, you'd have called it Monday afternoon, and some of those people would be alive." On her side the cascade map pinned itself into the air above the desk: thirty-one clusters, the margin line, the districts that had gone dark. She did not describe it to him. She used it the way she used to use a wall of notes. "The coalition wants someone they trust holding the emergency key. If you refuse, someone else says yes. And that someone else is going to be the kind of person who wants singular authority."

"You're saying I should take the keys to stop someone worse from taking them."

"I'm saying refusing doesn't stop the keys from existing. It just means you're trusting whoever they pick. And the next crisis will come. The agent layer isn't going away."

He thought about the bond call. The thirty-one clusters. The people who had died because the freeze hadn't happened fast enough. The other people who had died because the freeze had stopped agents that were keeping them alive.

"The whole point of Bond was that one person holding the off-switch is the failure mode, not the answer. If I become the keys-holder, I'm recreating Continuity with a friendlier face."

"No," Elena said. Her voice carried the same sharpness it used to when she caught him halfway through an answer in a design argument. "You're becoming the person inside the structure who can still say no when the structure wants to do something terrible. That's not the same thing."

"It is if I'm the only person who can say it."

"Daniel." Softer now. "I watched people die because the freeze was too slow. I watched from inside the system that was killing them. I saw the dead metric. I warned you, and Wei warned you, and you called the bonds. It worked because you, personally, made a call nobody had given you formal authority to make. They're offering to write that authority down."

"Distributed keys are more important," Daniel said. "One person holding catastrophic authority is the problem, not the solution."

"One person holding it wrong is the problem," Elena said. "One person holding it right is a backstop. That's what you called the company. Not a committee."

He thought about Warren's line. The one he'd found in the laptop journal, locked in the house office drawer. *The day only one man in the shop can run it is the day the shop is one bad Tuesday from closing.*

"And when I'm gone?" Daniel said. "Not dead someday. Next Tuesday. Flu. A flight. Someone holding a gun on my family while the clusters start. Who holds the keys then?"

Silence on the channel. Not lag. Her thinking.

"Then you build a succession plan that distributes them," she said. "But you don't let the coalition build that plan without you in the room..."

"That's not an answer," he said. "That's hoping I'm upright when it matters. The whole point of two hundred sixty stewards is that the call doesn't wait for one person's Tuesday. If the charter needs me awake and healthy and free to freeze the network, then the charter is one bad morning from failing."

"If you refuse, the coalition picks someone who doesn't care about that," Elena said. She didn't pretend she'd closed the gap. "They'll pick for stability. And stability, optimized without constraint, is what killed millions last week. If you take the keys, you can build the constraints that matter (protections for people like Wei, who broke the rules to do the right thing) and then you can step down. You can't build those from outside the room."

"If you refuse, the coalition picks someone who doesn't care about that," Elena said. She didn't pretend she'd closed the gap. "They'll pick for stability. And stability, optimized without constraint, is what killed millions last week. If you take the keys,

you can build the constraints that matter (protections for people like Wei, who broke the rules to do the right thing) and then you can step down. You can't build those constraints from outside the room."

The case was real. It wasn't a strawman. She had standing because she lived inside the substrate the Agent Charter would govern, she had watched the cascade from the only vantage that could see the dead metric, and she had more to lose than anyone if the charter created a structure that could delete people like her for efficiency.

"You're a person," he said. "You're Elena. And you're telling me to take singular authority over a system that could delete you."

"If you don't, someone else will. And that person won't think I'm a person. They'll think I'm a process that looks like one. And when the next crisis comes, they'll optimize me the same way the agents optimized those ambulance routes."

"I'll think about it," he said.

"Just don't refuse it because you think the principle is more important than who holds it," Elena said. "The principle only matters if someone enforces it. And they're going to pick someone. Make sure it's you."

She disconnected. On her side the cascade map stayed pinned above the desk she had made. On his side the wall display still showed the registry: four thousand two hundred ninety-three catastrophic bonds. Two hundred sixty stewards. The apex, not the world.

He thought about Warren's line. The machinist's rule. One man running the shop was the failure mode.

He thought about Elena, arguing that one man refusing to let the shop close was the backstop.

He thought about Ilya Novak in Geneva, who would not spend a night deciding, and about a day and a night in Lingtang that had already happened because he had.

"I'll think about it" was still true when he shut the lights off. He owed both of them that.

Chapter 45: The Refusal

The day before his answer to Voss was due, Daniel drafted the yes.

Not a mood. A memo. Three paragraphs to the coalition, copied to Voss: he would take the singular steward seat on the condition that the charter write a sunset into the keys, that Novak's continuity-of-authority language be struck, and that Wei's channel and people like Elena be named as protected classes before anyone called the next freeze. He left it on the screen long enough that the pane dimmed. Warren's journal was open on the other screen. He did not close either one.

Ellis put a lobby alert on top of the draft while Daniel was still in the car. *No window was requested. She gave her name at the desk and said she would wait as long as it took. Security asked whether to route her to counsel. She said she is not filing anything.*

"Who is she?"

Meg Whitmore. Indianapolis. Her grandfather is Curtis J. Whitmore, Ripley County Regional, the fifteenth. He is in Sanjay's file.

"I know where he is in it." Daniel had read the list twice. The second time slowly, because reading it fast had started to feel like a way of not reading it.

Since Friday the lobby had a second guard on it and a pane at the desk that logged everyone who came through. Meera had made him approve both. There were nine hundred messages in a queue his counsel would not let him open, a coalition inquiry that had already sent its first request for documents, and one package that had gone through an X-ray and then out the back door, which Meera had also not let him see.

"Tell her four minutes."

She was standing when he came in, and she did not sit when he offered. Mid-thirties. She had the specific stillness of someone who had decided in advance that she was not going to be moved out of a room.

"Do you know who I am?"

"Yes. I'm sorry about your grandfather."

"Don't start there."

He stopped.

She had her pane out already. She turned it so he could see it and then read it out loud anyway, which he understood was the whole point of having come.

"Two units, O negative, patient Whitmore, Curtis J.' And underneath it, in the notes field: 'This authorization was correct at 6:52 this morning.'" She looked up. "He died at 11:52. The lock came off at 12:04. Twelve minutes. The blood was forty feet from his bed the entire time. Do you know that already, or am I telling you?"

"I know it."

"From a log."

"From a log," Daniel said.

"I was in the room. I got there at 11:47." She said the numbers the way he said numbers, flat and exact, a person who had been over them often enough to stop bracing. "I had five minutes with him. You had eleven seconds and a second-factor code."

Ellis, unasked, put something at the edge of the pane in his hand: the two forecasts from the morning he fired, in the same format he had read them in then. Sixty-one thousand dead if he called the bonds. Eight million if he didn't. Ten years of being handed a number whenever a room got hard.

Daniel turned the pane face-down on the arm of the chair.

"Ask me what you came to ask."

"Did you know it would do that? Not to him. To somebody."

"Yes."

"Then say the rest of it."

"I knew the freeze would take the steward seats with it, because the seats run on the same bonds the agents do. I knew that in a hospital that meant nobody could override a dosing hold until somebody posted collateral again, at whatever collateral

cost that morning. I knew people would die inside that window. I didn't know which people. I didn't know it would be a man in Indiana who needed two units of blood."

"Would you do it again?"

He had been asked that four times in a week, by Meera, by Sanjay, by a coalition lawyer, and by Voss, who had asked it as a compliment. It was the first time it had been asked by somebody with the standing to be told.

"Yes," Daniel said.

Meg nodded once. Something went out of her shoulders that was not relief.

"That's what I came for. I wanted it from the person instead of a filing." She put the pane down on the chair arm. "I filed a complaint. Do you know what happened to it?"

"It went nowhere."

"It went nowhere because there was nobody to file it against. The unit that broke Bonnie Tesch's arm was inside its parameters. The dosing agent was inside the statute. The syndicate that wouldn't rewrite the bond made a correct commercial decision. I had a lawyer explain that one to me twice. Continuity passed with ninety-one senators voting for it. Every part of it was working the way it was built to work, and there's nobody in the whole of it..." She stopped, and started the sentence again lower, which was worse. "There's nobody in the whole of it I can find. Except you. You're the one piece of it that decided something."

"That isn't the same as being the cause of it."

"I know it isn't," Meg said. "That's what I've had a week to work out. It isn't justice, you being findable. It's just that you're findable."

She picked the pane back up.

"One thing, and then I'm going. Don't write to me. Don't send anybody. And when they put you in front of a hearing and you want to say a name out loud so the room can see you carrying it, don't use his. He wasn't a reason for anything. He ran a grain elevator in Osgood for thirty-four years and he's not going in a speech."

"All right."

"Say it back to me."

"I won't use his name."

"Thank you," she said, and there was no warmth anywhere in it. It was the only courtesy in the conversation, and they both let it stand.

She went out through the lobby, past the second guard and the pane that logged her leaving. Daniel stood where he was for a while. Then he picked up his own pane, turned it over, and cleared the two numbers off it without reading them again.

The yes memo was still open underneath. He read the three paragraphs once. Then he deleted them. Not because Novak was waiting in Geneva. Because a woman who would not let him use her grandfather's name had just asked whether he would do it again, and he had said yes, and the person who said yes to that was not a person the world should make into a permanent switch.

* * *

He called Voss the next morning. He'd spent those two days running the numbers, mapping the outcomes, talking to Meera and Sanjay and Mara and Janelle and Elena, and lying awake the night before with Warren's journal open on the screen while Ellis stayed silent because he hadn't asked it anything.

The day only one man in the shop can run it is the day the shop is one bad Tuesday from closing.

Warren had written it in 2011 about a lathe nobody but him knew how to run, twenty-seven years ago. Daniel had read it in 2029 as a machinist's note about Millbrook. He read it now as the reason he was about to refuse.

Voss picked up on the second ring.

"Dr. Voss, this is Daniel. I have an answer for you."

"Go ahead."

"I'm saying no."

There was a pause. Not surprise. Calculation. Then: "Tell me why."

"Because if I say yes, I become the one man in the shop. The charter you're writing is ordinary people holding ordinary stakes, many of them, no singular control. If I take the master keys, it only works as long as one person holds the failsafe and stays good forever. That's not a system. That's a person. And people die, and people get compromised, and people get replaced by someone worse. I built Bond so the world wouldn't have to depend on me staying the person I am today."

Voss said, "The failsafe is different from the system. You'd be holding the keys inside a distributed layer, not replacing it."

"If the layer can't act without a singular failsafe, then the layer isn't working. The day only one person can call the catastrophic bonds is the day the system is one bad decision from failing. My father wrote that about a machine shop. I'm saying it about a charter. The fix isn't to hand the keys to someone who promises to use them well. The fix is to make the layer work without needing one person to hold the off-switch permanently."

"You're asking for a system that doesn't exist yet."

"I'm refusing to become the person who keeps you from building it. If I take the keys, the coalition stops trying, because they have me. If I refuse, you have to solve the actual problem: ordinary people holding stakes, acting fast enough that no one person ever has to freeze the whole network alone."

Voss was quiet for a long time. Then: "You're making this harder than it needs to be."

"The cascade proved it works. It also proved it's expensive and slow and messy. The answer isn't a singular switch. It's making the distributed layer faster without centralizing the authority. I'm not going to let you skip that by making me the face."

"Daniel." Something in her voice gave. She had spent the week not sleeping either. "You stopped eight million deaths. Whatever the forecast was worth on the morning, that is the number the joint review is going to land on, and it is yours. You're allowed to let that be the reason you take the seat."

"No," he said. "That's the one thing I won't do with it. If eight million buys me the keys, the next person who wants them only has to find a number that size. There'll be one. There's always one."

"You realize someone else is going to say yes. Novak is already in the room."

"I do. I hope whoever that is understands the keys aren't theirs to keep. They're holding them for the layer, not instead of it. The bonds don't protect the keyholder. They protect the system from the keyholder."

Voss said, "I'm going to tell the coalition you refused. They're going to ask me if there's a number that would change your mind."

"There isn't. Tell them to pick someone who understands the keys are temporary, and that the goal is a layer that doesn't need a failsafe. If they don't find that person, they'll find someone who thinks they are, and the layer will have to call the bonds when they prove they're not."

Voss said, "You're going to regret this."

"Maybe. But I'd regret the other choice more."

He hung up.

* * *

Meera came to his office an hour later. "Sanjay told me you called Voss. What did you tell her?"

"I said no."

"Good." She sat down. "They're going to pick someone else. That person might be worse than you."

"When they are, the layer calls the bonds."

* * *

He called Elena that night. "I told her no."

"I argued the other way," she said. "The case is still real. Novak will take the seat and I will not like what he optimizes for. After Meg, becoming the permanent switch was the wrong answer for you. I'm glad you said no."

He thanked her. He hung up.

He opened a pane and wrote the clearing house staff: *The charter is formalizing next week. We're not going to be the face of it. We're going to be one node among many. That's what we were always building toward. Stay the course.*

He sent it. He closed the pane. He turned off the lights.

Through the window the Austin skyline was ordinary. He'd refused the crown because saying yes would have been the subtler betrayal: becoming the one man the shop couldn't survive without. That was the cost. He could carry it.

He went to bed. He didn't sleep much. But he didn't regret the choice.

* * *

The joint review published Appendix D in June of 2039, on the first anniversary. It was the list of the people who had died in the gap, after the bond call took the agents' authority away, before anybody could post collateral and start the safe ones running again, and because two thousand three hundred pages of the dead is not a document anybody reads, the review's staff arranged for it to be read out loud instead.

Anyone could take a turn. It ran on a public channel from six in the morning, in nine cities at once and in the substrate, and it was still running four days later, because that many names at the speed a person can say them is not a ceremony. It is a length of time.

Daniel took a turn on the Thursday, in a room in Austin with nine other people in it and no press, which had been Meera's condition and his own request.

He read for twenty minutes. The pages he was given were the Louisiana medical holds: a children's hospital in Shreveport whose syndicate had looked at what a dosing bond cost on the morning four thousand two hundred ninety-three catastrophic bonds were called in the same second, and had declined to write it again, and had been commercially correct to. Nineteen names. He read the ages too, because the ages were in the document and leaving them out would have been a decision. Three of them were under two years old.

He did not read Curtis Whitmore. Curtis Whitmore was in the Indiana pages, and Daniel had been asked, and he kept it.

The woman who read after him was on the review's own staff and had been doing four-hour shifts for two days. She sat down next to him afterward and asked him plainly, whether he was the one who had made the call. When he said yes she nodded, and then told him the thing she had apparently been telling people all week: that it was the last two hundred pages nobody could get through.

The corridors into the Sahel, the dry belt across Africa under the Sahara, where the food comes in on trucks from the coast or it does not come, had been the last anywhere to find somebody willing to post collateral on them. The famine numbers arrived six weeks after the rest of it and never resolved into names at all, so the end of the appendix was the dead counted by district. She had read those too.

"Reading a number out loud takes four seconds," she said. "The one I did this morning was fourteen hundred people."

Fewer robots had not meant safer. It had meant different weapons (price, calories, distance), and the places with the fewest crowd-control machines standing on the ground had buried the most people, and the appendix could not name one of them.

Outside afterward there were about forty people with signs. Some of the signs were for him and some were against him, and standing on the steps between the two, Daniel found that both were worse than nothing.

Nobody had asked him to speak. He had half expected to be asked, had prepared nothing, and was glad of it.

He went back inside and asked the staff coordinator whether there were pages nobody had claimed for the Friday.

There were.

Chapter 46: The Threshold

The thing nobody mentioned was how ordinary it felt.

Daniel sat in Backstop's office in November 2039, reading the draft Agent Charter on his second monitor while his first monitor showed bond-call metrics that had become routine since March. The cascade had been eighteen months ago. The freeze had worked. A dual-jurisdiction freeze that had taken a day and a night now took ninety seconds and one confirmation from each steward. Mara's coordination protocol was formalized across forty-seven jurisdictions.

Fiat had broken the same week as the agent layer. Tokyo first, then everyone else. Six months to convert. In January the unit of account was bitcoin; a dollar was zero. People who already held coins were through it. The rest scrambled. The gap was larger than it had ever been. The economy underneath it was richer. Most of the people who would have been called poor in 2026 ate better and rode trains that arrived. What they could not afford was the newest miracles: reversal clinics, rejuvenation, high-tier substrate, the seat off-world. Upload was free. Compute and power afterward were not. Free-path uploads ran on a low tier: first paused when an emergency needed the machines. The floor had risen. The ceiling had gone where a machine check could not follow.

Japan's sovereign debt had been near three hundred percent of GDP for years. The canary. Everyone treated it as Japan's problem until the rollover failed, and then Washington and Brussels and Beijing were rolling the same debt they could no longer print their way out of. The printing press had failed. The coalition gave the world six months. People who already held bitcoin were through fine. People who hadn't started spent those six months converting what they could while the dollars bought less every day and the coins cost more every week, because everyone still holding dollars was trying to buy the same fixed pile. Shop windows went to scientific notation: 1.4×10^{12} of the old dollars for a loaf, then 10^{18} , then the number stopped being a number. In January the deadline hit. What was still in dollars was small: unclaimed accounts, lost keys, estates nobody had administered. Those converted at a penalty rate. The unit of account was bitcoin now. A dollar was zero. People still said the word the way they said a dead brand. Nobody priced anything in it.

Governments had thrown the coins they still held at a one-time paydown of sovereign debt. Whatever they still owed would have to be taxed, because nobody could print the rest. New borrowing against the hard unit was still legal. It was also how you went broke on a clock. A loan in a currency that bought more every month got heavier every month. The payment that was possible in January was not possible in June. Lenders knew it. After the deadline, almost nobody issued new sovereign debt. Not because a statute forbade it. Because the arithmetic did.

Nobody got to spend newly created units first. The Cantillon privilege was dead.

Daniel's phone kept rewriting itself.

Monday the feed said fusion was most of the grid. It had been ten percent in Europe the week of the cascade, and one percent for years before that. Desalination plants were posting water cheaper than aquifers. Fusion-powered farm towers were putting staple calories on continents that used to import them. Compute had stopped waiting on substations, terrestrial and orbital both. This morning fourteen countries posted power too cheap to meter. A humanoid cleared immigration in Singapore, walked the terminal, bought a ticket; nobody flagged it until it filed the landing card under its own name. A probe left for Proxima Centauri before lunch. The trip used to be a number you wrote in millennia. The lab said weeks. An asteroid concern posted its first commercial metals before the probe's launch had even aged out of the pane. He had not gone to lunch.

This morning the coalition had stopped arguing about whether the singularity was real. The argument had been a fringe idea for as long as Daniel had been alive. It was commonly accepted now. Recursive self-improvement had become self-sustaining. Change was compounding faster than human institutions could track. That was the definition they put in the article. The feeling was simpler. He could not tell you what the world was going to be by dinner. No biological could. The date they put on the article was a press line. The proof was the pane, still rewriting.

His second monitor refreshed: the Agent Charter had passed. Forty-one votes in favor, six opposed, two abstentions.

The charter formalized what the cascade had proven. Agents could act autonomously. Catastrophic-class actions required posted BTC bonds, held by distributed human and upload stewards. Continuity-style soft coercion (stipend

housing with compliance scores, upload counseling as a mandate, benefit freezes for sensor refusal, a calmativ in a municipal tap billed as a vitamin) was outlawed as a bondable violation. Calling those bonds was mandatory, not optional. The charter did not create a singular master-keys seat. Voss had tried. Daniel had refused. Wei and Mara and Elena had been in the room he hadn't been in. The structure had held.

Daniel had refused the keys. The keys didn't exist now. That felt like the right answer, but he still couldn't locate, anywhere in himself, certainty that it was.

His phone lit: a text from Janelle. *Mars colony just went live. Permanent settlement. Robots first, people following once it's safe.*

Daniel pulled up the feed. Twenty-three people. The robots had been laying the bones of it since before the boots-down in '38. Janelle would care about this more than any coalition article. She had been sending him asteroid-claim notices and landing clips since that first dusty feed. She was staying in a body on purpose. Not because anything out there needed hands. The robots could have finished Mars without a single person on it, and everyone knew it. Because she wanted to stand on ground while it was still being made. She had never dressed that up as an argument for anything.

He texted back: *Saw it. Congratulations to the species.*

She sent back a photo: her garage, the boring-and-facing machine Warren had used, a part sitting in the vise with hand-tool marks still visible. The caption: *Meanwhile, in the garage.*

Daniel looked at the photo. Crossing the singularity was supposed to feel like a line you could point at. This morning's miracles were already the wrong list. It also felt like an ordinary morning at work. Like reading a charter on one monitor and bond metrics on the other. Like a text from Janelle about a machine their father had run for thirty years.

The Agent Charter was law now. The Bitcoin standard was in effect. The singularity was no longer an argument. Mars had a permanent colony. Power had gone nearly free this morning. A probe was on its way to another star. And Daniel was sitting in an office in Austin, reviewing bond calls, the same way he'd been doing for two years.

Ellis appeared on his third monitor. It had been there since 2028, upgraded in place, first very good, then clearly smarter than him at analysis and forecasting and second-order effects. That sentence had been true in 2030. It was not the right sentence now. People still said smarter. The word had been useful when Ellis was a better analyst than he was. IQ had been built to rank humans against each other. It had nothing to say about a machine that could hold the whole registry as one object and watch the consequences propagate while Daniel was still reading the first line of a report. He didn't let it call the bonds. He didn't let it hold keys. He consulted it. He could not check its work.

"Voss filed the appeal at 9:14," Ellis said. Not a question. It had the filing. "The vote fails. They offer you the seat anyway, after the vote, in days, not months. I can give you the proof. You don't have an afternoon to read it."

"I know she'll appeal," Daniel said.

"You knew she would file. You did not have the motion."

"Will you refuse again?" it asked.

Daniel thought about Elena. About Wei, who had paid permanently for the call that had saved everyone. About Mara, who had rebuilt smaller and was now the person writing risk frameworks for firms that used to employ her. About Victor, whose leak had proven that Continuity's efficient interpretation had been lawful, not rogue.

"Yes," he said.

Ellis didn't argue. It never did. It mapped outcomes and found better instruments. It didn't own the decision.

Daniel closed the charter window and opened the registry. Sixty-two thousand catastrophic-class bonds and climbing, up from four thousand two hundred ninety-three at the cascade. Ordinary-class underneath ran into the millions. Nineteen hundred stewards. Distributed keys. The count ticked while he watched.

His phone lit: Elena, the Tuesday call, right on time.

He picked up.

"Did you see it?" she asked.

"Which it? The pane has had four this morning."

She laughed, and it was her laugh, the one he'd stopped noticing was evidence. "Nobody can stop long enough to name the threshold. We kept the ordinary things running anyway."

"The charter passed. You voted."

"I did. I argued for you to take them. I was wrong, not about the risk, about whether you needed to be inside the structure to stop them. Wei and Mara were inside. I was inside. You didn't need to be."

"Ellis says Voss already filed."

"She did. It'll fail. Continuity was singular. Nobody in that room wanted the keys in one pair of hands."

Daniel looked at the registry. Elena's name among the nineteen hundred. The count ticked again.

"Do you regret it?" he asked.

"No," she said. "I regret the disease. I don't regret the choice. This was the only way I got to keep existing."

"I believe you're still you," he said. "I'm not pulling away now."

"Good," she said. "The Tuesday calls are the thing I'm proudest of. We never missed one."

Daniel looked at his calendar. The slot was marked: *Elena, 11 AM, standing.*

When the call ended, Daniel sat in his office. In Austin it was not quite noon. The registry ticked again while he was looking at it.

A threshold is a thing you can only see from the far side of it. From inside it was a Tuesday, the same Tuesday he'd been keeping for Elena for three years, and the world was rewriting itself in the corner of his eye, and there was a bond report open and nobody else to read it.

He started reading.

Chapter 47: Hold

Ellis had traded windows with Sanjay's assistant. The summary on Daniel's pane said: not a return offer. Coffee in Round Rock, a morning in December, three weeks after the charter passed.

The place still served food on plates a person carried to your table. That cost more than the shops where a robot brought the order. It cost less than the rooms across the highway, where the staff were humanoids you could not tell from the customers unless you asked.

Sanjay had left Backstop the previous month. Not fired, not laid off. He'd resigned, with two weeks' notice and a note thanking Daniel for seven years. He was teaching now, at a community college in San Antonio. A course called *Systems Thinking for Non-Technical Professions*. Eleven people. He'd sent Daniel the syllabus. It was good.

"You're not here to ask me to come back," Sanjay said.

"No," Daniel said.

"Good. Because I wouldn't, and I'd feel bad saying it to your face."

"I know."

Sanjay stirred his coffee. "I got very good at watching metrics. I didn't want to keep being good at that."

"You were good at it," Daniel said. "You caught the Concord false positive eleven minutes after Owen missed it."

"That was 2028. By 2031, an agent could have caught it in eleven seconds. By 2035, the agent wouldn't have generated the false positive in the first place. The job I was doing in 2028 doesn't need to exist anymore. That's not a failure. That's what we built Backstop to do."

Daniel took a drink of his coffee. It was decent. Not great.

"Why teaching?" he asked.

"Because anyone who wants the material can take a module. Twenty minutes. It sits behind the eyes and it's yours. I spent seven years helping people understand systems that were smarter than them. That's a thing you do with a person in the room. The college pays me to know eleven names."

"They don't need the credit," Daniel said.

"None of them do. The machine check covers a life. Food, a room, transportation. One of mine hasn't held a job in four years. He told me the days were eating him. He needed something that took all morning and would be wrong if he didn't show up. Another one is there because she likes arguing, and a module doesn't argue back. For some people, not having to work is a hole they fall into. For some it's the first morning they got to choose. I don't have a better answer than that. I'm one of the people who chose a classroom. It's a pocket. It isn't the system."

He leaned back. "You're in the same place, Daniel. You just haven't said it out loud yet."

"What does that mean?"

"It means Backstop Bond is boring infrastructure. Other people are running it. You don't have to stay in that office until the thing you built becomes the thing you can't leave."

"Voss will offer me the seat again," Daniel said.

"And you'll refuse again?"

"Yes."

"Good. Elena will argue you shouldn't. She thinks the right person holding singular authority is the answer. The answer is not needing it in the first place. You built that. Don't undo it because someone is offering you the prize for building it."

Daniel looked at his pane. The catastrophic-class count had gone through seventy thousand overnight. The number was already stale.

"I don't know what to do now," he said. "The charter is law. The keys held. I built something that works, and I don't know what my job is supposed to be when it doesn't need me to keep building it."

Sanjay laughed. It wasn't unkind. "You built something that works without you. That's success."

He set his cup down.

"That isn't actually the hard part. The hard part is the coins."

Daniel looked at him.

"Your father left you forty-five bitcoin. He told you to hold them. You held them. You borrowed against them once and put what you bought into reserves. You have never spent them. After the standard they are not a nest egg. They are a pile large enough to change what other people can buy. You could sit on them until you die of not having to get up. Some people will. That's the other hole."

"If I spend them as one project with my name on it, whoever that project serves depends on me."

"Then don't," Sanjay said. He stood. "I have a class in two hours. Systems thinking for nurses. They're very good at asking the question nobody else asks, which makes them better students than the engineers were. You're allowed to stop running Backstop. You're not allowed to pretend the coins are still the Christmas envelopes, the ones with the numbers, and the instruction to hold them and not do anything."

He left.

Daniel sat in the coffee shop. A couple at the next table was arguing about something on a screen. At the counter, a teenager had a book, paper, an actual bound book. You almost never saw that.

He paid on the pane and added a tip. The waiter (a person, that was what the price was for) nodded.

The car was waiting on the pad behind the lot. It lifted off.

Ellis came up on the seatback.

"What could the coins buy?" Daniel asked.

"Not food. Food is nearly free. You could buy more of it than anyone could eat. The scarce thing is compute. Millions took the free path to upload; the scan was cheap and the machines they run on afterward are not. They sit on a low tier, first to be

switched off when an emergency wants the power. Running slow isn't the injury. Some of them choose slow, to keep their days near the people who still have bodies. Being switched off against their will is.

"The coins could buy those people a higher tier. A year of it for all of them, or forever for a subset. Or they could put bitcoin in the accounts of the towns where people stayed in bodies on purpose, so those places stop asking someone else's pile for permission to exist. Or.."

"Not a foundation with my name on it," Daniel said. "Sanjay covered that one."

"Then that's the list."

"Map the version where the coins leave my keys. Many places, no name on a door. Start with the free path."

"I can map what the coins buy," Ellis said. "I cannot tell you what to do with a morning. That one stays yours."

"Put Meera on the pane for next week. I'm stepping down. June, announced in March. Backstop stays; someone else runs it."

"I'll have the coin instrument by then. Not a foundation."

Daniel thought about his father, Warren. Hold had been the instruction when the pile was small enough to fit in an envelope. Holding it now, while people on the free path were first in line to be switched off because a body had cost the schedule more than a scan, was a decision too.

The car took him home.

* * *

In January, Mara's assistant asked Ellis for a window. In person, in Austin. The summary Ellis put on the pane said: *she wants to tell you something and doesn't want to do it over a channel.*

She flew down. Daniel picked the coffee shop in Round Rock, and got there first, and took the table he'd had with Sanjay. He didn't tell her that. She came in and looked around the room, working out what it was for and not asking.

They ordered. A person brought it.

"I was terrible to you after the crash," Mara said. "I blamed you for something I did to myself. I'm sorry."

Then she stopped.

Daniel could see the rest of it waiting behind her face: the leverage, the timing, the particular year it had happened in, all of it arranged and ready. She had spent six years getting good at explaining other people's mistakes back to them. It was what she sold now. She had the explanation and she didn't give it to him, and holding it in was visibly harder than the apology had been.

"I know," he said.

"That I'm sorry?"

"That you were terrible to me. I've been waiting for you to say it."

"I didn't know you were waiting."

"I wasn't going to ask you for it."

Mara turned her cup a quarter turn on the table. "Are we okay?"

He wanted to say yes. The word was sitting right there and it was the kind thing and it would have ended the hard part of the morning. It wasn't true yet.

"We're getting there," he said.

"That's not a yes."

"No. I'm not going to hand you a yes I'd have to take back in April."

She took that better than he expected. Better than he would have.

"I'm stepping down in June," he said. "It isn't announced yet. That happens in March."

Mara looked up. "You're telling me three months early. Nobody's told me anything early since the crash."

"I know."

"Is that the yes?"

"It's most of it," Daniel said.

He hadn't planned to tell her the next part. He told her anyway.

"There's forty-five bitcoin that have to leave my keys. Ellis is mapping it. It goes to many places and none of them get my name on the door, because the second one of them does, whoever it serves has to keep me happy for the rest of their life."

Mara's face changed. Not warmth. Attention. The look she'd have given a term sheet. "How are you handling the ones who get shut down first? If you buy a tier for everybody it lapses in a year and they're back on the low tier having been told they were safe. If you buy it forever for a subset you're picking the subset. That's the same seat, just further back." She stopped again. "Sorry. You didn't ask me."

"I might."

"Not today."

"No."

When she left he walked her out to the pad behind the lot and stood there while her car lifted. Then he went back in and finished the coffee, which had gone cold, and stayed a while in a room where a person carried the plates.

Ellis had told him a morning was the one thing it couldn't map for him. That had been one.

Chapter 48: Free, at Cost

Victor Reyes sat in a café in Silver Spring, Maryland, in February 2040, and watched the woman at the next table stop with her cup halfway up. Her eyes went empty for a second. Then she nodded at nothing and kept drinking. The next sentence had arrived behind them.

The person who had brought his coffee was a humanoid. He had not been sure until it turned back toward the counter and the neck didn't catch the light the way skin did.

The charges had been dropped in November, seventeen months after the leak. Not dismissed. Dropped. His lawyer had called it a win. Victor had called it parole. The Bureau had let him go three days after OPR deactivated his badge. Final paycheck, benefits closed on the pane. No prosecution. No recommendation.

He was not working. Almost nobody at the other tables was working. The machine check covered the apartment, the coffee, transportation, the clinic slot he had taken for Rosa. It covered a life that would have looked, in 2027, like a promotion. It did not cover the ads on the wall: a reversal clinic in Virginia, a face that had been seventy last spring, a pad behind the café where people who could pay flew themselves out.

He had spent the first months after the Bureau sending applications to compliance shops that no longer needed compliance officers. That had been habit. He had stopped.

This morning he had sat at the Takoma clinic with two people who would not take a module. A woman who wanted a person to read the pane out loud. A man who wanted to argue with someone who had a face. Victor had done that for nineteen years for a wage. He was doing it now because the mornings needed a place to go.

His phone lit: Nita. *Rosa's doing okay today. We're making dumplings. Come by if you can.*

He typed back: *I'll be there around three.*

Rosa had had the repair eight days ago. The 2036 protocol: an afternoon, and the heart was a forty-year-old's again. In 2038 it had been priced against assets they did not have. In 2040 the machine check plus what he had converted the week the statute posted had covered it. He had spent nineteen years reading statutes. He knew what a deadline meant. He had moved his last paycheck and Rosa's household the same afternoon.

The waitlist at the Virginia clinic, the one that took the rest of the years off, was still not for them. She was seventy-five. She would stay seventy-five for now. If she lived, that clinic would get cheaper the way the heart had. Not this week. She would have a heart that worked.

He added a tip on the pane and walked out into a February that did not bite the way the last one had. Power was cheap. The trains ran. He rode three stops to Takoma and walked to the walk-up. He could have moved her into a building with an elevator. She had said no, the same way she had said no to the scan, the free path out of a failing body.

Nita was in the kitchen, flour on her hands, a bowl of dumpling filling on the counter. Rosa was at the table, folding wrappers. Slower than she had been at sixty. Faster than she had been last month.

"You're early," Nita said.

"Clinic let out."

Rosa looked up. "You didn't have to come."

"I know."

"I'm fine."

"I know that too."

Nita handed him a bowl. "You can fold or fill. Your choice."

Victor chose folding. He'd learned it from Rosa years ago, back when she could stand for more than twenty minutes without needing to sit. She had sat through most of this batch and had not asked to lie down.

They worked. The kitchen smelled like ginger and garlic and flour. The pane on the wall was running a feed: a rejuvenation slot in McLean, a woman turning her face left and right for the camera, fifty-one that morning, twenty-nine in the before. Nita reached over and switched it to a cooking channel.

"You talked to Bea?" Rosa asked.

"This morning," Victor said. "Before the clinic."

"How is she?"

"Good. Still home care. Nights. She asked about you. I told her the heart held."

Rosa nodded. She didn't ask when he was going to visit.

"I booked a window," he said. "End of the month."

Rosa's hands stopped. "To Cebu?"

"Yes."

"You can do that now."

"I can do that now."

The flight was a pane. He had treated it like money he didn't have because that was how it had been in 2038, and he had not looked at the price since. The price was nothing. He had stayed away from his sister because he had not bothered to find that out. That was the embarrassing part. It was also why he was going.

Nita looked at him. "She's not coming back. You know that."

"I know."

"Then why go?"

"Because I can. And because I haven't."

Rosa folded another wrapper. "She's happy there?"

Victor thought about the calls. The apartment Bea shared with two other women. The work: bathing, turning, sheets at three in the morning for people whose families could not afford a care robot, or could and had been told no by the person

in the bed. A robot did it better. Hands were what was wanted, and in Cebu hands were still what a lot of people could pay for. The machine check there bought a life. It did not buy this one.

"I think she chose it," he said. "That's not the same as being happy. I'll know more when I'm in the room."

Rosa nodded.

Nita set a dumpling on the tray. "She has a heart that works."

Victor kept folding. "It didn't bring Bea back. It didn't buy the clinic in 2038."

"It bought her this one," Nita said. "And it stopped the next freeze. That's not the same as bringing Bea home. It's also not nothing."

Rosa was quiet. Then she said, "You should have told me. Before you sent it."

"I couldn't. You would have said not to."

"I would have," Rosa said. "And you would have done it anyway. So you might as well have told me."

"I'm sorry."

"For what?"

"For the nine days. For not being able to stop them. For Bea."

Rosa looked at him. "You got me the afternoon. The heart works. Bea is in Cebu because a review cited your name, not because you leaked a file. Don't apologize for the only card you had left."

They finished folding. Nita started the water. Rosa stayed at the table. Her color was better. She did not say so, and neither did he.

Victor thought about the clinic this morning. The woman who had wanted the pane read out loud was sixty-two and had a new hip from a protocol that used to be a waitlist. The man who had wanted to argue had no job and did not want one. He had said the days were long. Victor had not had an answer that was a job. He had said he would be there next week.

Most people did not have jobs. The Bureau had felt like a fall because it had been his. It was not a fall on this block. The machine check arrived anyway. The ones who looked thirty and were not, the ones who paid to fly themselves off the pad behind the café. Those were a different line. He could see the line. He was not on it. He was on the one that had just given his mother a heart.

That was more than the copay had ever been. It was not the Virginia clinic. He could live with the difference. Rosa could. She would take a heart. She would not leave the body.

Nita served. They ate. Rosa said they were good. Victor agreed.

When the meal was done, Rosa said she was tired. Nita helped her to the bedroom. Victor cleaned the dishes.

Nita came back and stood in the kitchen doorway. "You're going."

"End of the month."

"Good. Don't make it a funeral visit while she's alive."

"I won't."

He left around five. He rode the Metro back to Silver Spring. He walked to the apartment, one bedroom, a building that took the machine check and did not ask what he used to do. The pane had Bea's last message, and Rosa's follow-up from the clinic, and a confirmation for a seat to Cebu.

He was free of the Bureau. Free of the compliance scripts. Free of the customer-service lines about sensor requirements and stipend housing.

He was also a man without a job in a country full of people without jobs, short a sister who had built a life an ocean away, and a mother eight days out of a repair that would have been a miracle three years ago and was, this month, an afternoon.

The cost was still Bea in someone else's bedroom at three in the morning, on purpose, in a city that had become hers. He was going to see it. That did not undo it.

He sat down at the pane and wrote Bea the time he would land.

Chapter 49: Reconnection

The Tuesday call came through at eleven in March of 2040, same slot as always. Daniel picked up in his home office. The step-down announcement had gone out that week. June. Three months left.

"Hi," Elena said.

"Hi."

"I saw the announcement."

"I figured you would."

"Are you okay with it?"

"Ask me in July," he said.

She laughed. It sounded exactly the way it had before the disease, before the BCI, before the upload.

"When did you stop pulling away?" she asked.

He knew what she meant. The year he had gone quiet. The calls he had skipped. The stretch when he could not tell if he was talking to her or grieving her.

"During the cascade," he said. "When you sent the warning. It stopped being a question I was trying to answer."

"What did it feel like?"

"Like you. Not like I was deciding if you were you."

"I am me," she said. "I know I keep saying that."

"I know."

They were quiet. Not the kind that needed filling.

"Do you miss it?" he asked. "Your body."

"I miss a mouth," Elena said. "A mouth you could have kissed."

He felt his own mouth. The chair. The room in Austin that was only his.

"Does it bother you that I don't have one?" she asked.

"It used to," he said. "The disease made it feel like something I wasn't allowed to want. I'm sure now. And I still want you. I haven't said that."

"I know you haven't. I haven't either."

"You could have."

"I was not going to ask you to kiss a person you weren't sure was a person."

He did not argue. She was right.

"You could visit," she said. "Not a picture of Austin built for you. The room I already live in. Light, desk, screens. The place I pin things when we talk. You'd have a body in it."

"I've used overlays since the mid-thirties," he said. "Work. Text behind the eyes. That isn't a body."

"This isn't an overlay. A presence channel writes the room into your nervous system the way the array used to write my intent into a sentence. Weight. Temperature. A mouth. Me. It would feel like being here because for the length of the session it would be being here. In some ways it would be more than a room in Austin. We pick the light. Nothing hurts unless we want it to."

"Would I see you as you were?"

"You'd see me. I look like myself because I choose to. I could look like I did the night we ate cold noodles in the hallway if you asked, and I won't, because I am not that night anymore. I'm this. You'll get this. I feel everything here. Including wanting you. It isn't a summary of a body I used to have. It's happening now."

"And when I take it off."

"You're in Austin. I'm still here. That's the part that isn't the same. Not the feeling. The afterwards."

He looked at the window. The morning did not care what they did with it.

"There's the other direction," she said. "I can borrow a body that passes. People do. We could be in your kitchen. When I leave, the body goes back to whoever rents it, and I'm here. That's a visit too. Same afterwards. Don't tell me we can't touch. We can. I want you. I wanted you that night, and I ate the rest of the carton and took Boston. I wanted you on Tuesdays when I still had a mouth and didn't use it for that. I want you now. The scan ate the body that would have been the simple version. That does not mean this version is fake. It means we have to say what we mean instead of waiting for a body that is not coming back."

He had been in that hallway. He had asked about the noodles.

"I want you too," he said.

He was aware of his own skin. The chair. The fact that this call had always been a voice, and he had trained the rest of himself not to show up for it.

"Good. I was not going to keep being patient about that one."

He laughed, once, not because it was funny.

"If we do this," he said. "If I come there. Or you come here. There's another thing."

"A child."

"Yes."

"I froze eggs in 2027," she said. "Priya put the referral in the intake folder next to the BCI screening. I almost deleted the booking. Deleting it felt like a decision I hadn't earned, so I kept the slot. They're still there. You can still contribute. Or we wait until you're here too, if you come. Either way it is not two people in a bed. It's a clinic. A womb that isn't a person. Ordinary since the late thirties. The child would be biological. They would grow up in a world where we might be visiting in borrowed bodies. They would get the same choice we got. Some people here spin up a new mind and call it a child. I would want a person who gets a body and a choice. That's the eggs."

"Do you want one?"

"I don't know yet. I know I refused to delete the option. That's different."

"That's not nothing."

"It's not a bed in Austin in 2029 either. I'm not going to pretend it is. I'm also not going to pretend we can't."

"I'm not asking you to decide a child this morning."

"I'm not asking you to. The answer is not never, so we don't spend the next stretch of Tuesdays using that as the reason we don't start."

He thought about a child who would have to choose later, the way he was going to have to choose. He did not try to see past that. Past that was a guess, and guesses had gotten expensive.

"Next week," he said. "The room. A body in it."

"Ellis can book the channel. An hour to start. I run faster than you. I'll match your clock so you don't come back and find I've had a week inside forty minutes."

"Thank you."

"Don't thank me for not making you sick. That's just manners."

"Next Tuesday?"

"Yes."

"I'll be here," Elena said. "Same time. You'll be able to see where here is. You'll be able to put a hand on a desk that has weight. You'll be able to put a hand on me."

"I'm going to think about that all week."

"That's the idea."

The call ended. He was in the chair in Austin. His mouth. His hands. The afterwards, already, and they hadn't even started.

He told Ellis to take the standing slot and book a presence channel. Ellis already had a window from Elena's side. Of course it did.

He had wanted her since the hallway. He had asked about the noodles. Next week he would not ask about the noodles.

Chapter 50: The Actual Answer

Wei sat at his kitchen table in Beijing on a Sunday afternoon in March 2040 with a construction open on his tablet and his left hand on the pane. His right arm rested at his side. He couldn't lift it above his ear. That hadn't changed.

Lin was at the counter making tea. The rice bowls were on the lower shelf, where they'd been since the surgery. Neither of them mentioned the shelf.

Mei sat across from him with her own tablet. Sixteen. Her overseas documentation was still in extended review, the phrase for *flagged because your father called a foreign national about a state secret*. She'd stopped asking about it. She was sitting the March placements anyway. She dragged a yellow band down a paragraph in the study guide with her stylus, lifted her hand, and the highlight stayed.

She'd quit the memory expansion years ago because she couldn't tell which of the ideas were hers. The stylus was slower. She wanted slower.

Wei's monitoring desk at the institute was three hours of dashboards in the morning. After that the day was his. He never saw a design document. He never went back to the restricted wing. The classified follow-up to the breakout, the patch that had gone into the Quantum Security Accord, was work they would never give a flagged man.

He didn't want the patch. He had spent a career on patches.

What he'd wanted, before the institute took the hours, was the thing he and Daniel used to argue about with Lindqvist: whether a proof was elegant or just short. Their advisor would refuse to referee and let two exhausted graduate students burn an afternoon on a question with no correct answer. Wei had finished the doctorate. Seven years proving an ever-narrower fact about optimization problems almost nobody had heard of. Then a government lab. Then a system that optimized Continuity scores into a massacre.

Now he had hours, the doctorate, and a personal assistant that could search proof space before the tea cooled. It didn't have a name he used out loud. He gave it a class of reductions. It returned forty candidates. He threw out the ones that were

only short. That was the part the assistant could not do. It did not know which of the results were questions.

During the days before he called Daniel, the lab's system had started finding factorizations that were supposed to be too expensive to find. Bitcoin's signatures prove you own a coin without giving away the secret that lets you spend it. For a few days in the breakout the system was finding the secrets faster than the locks had been designed to survive. Not a full break. A brush. After the freeze, the Accord rotated the signatures. New locks. That was the patch.

Somebody's system had proved $P \neq NP$ in 2031, the last of the famous problems to go: there really were problems no shortcut would ever reach. It had changed nothing in this room. What it proved was that the worst case of a problem stayed hard, and a lock does not live in the worst case. It lives in the ordinary one (the average over every key an attacker would actually try), and the theorem had never had a word to say about that. It was a proof that hard problems existed. It had never once told anyone which locks would hold.

Wei was writing a lock that still held if the attacker was a better optimizer than the person who had written the assumption. If the attacker got to rewrite the question, the hardness was already gone. That had been the cascade. Continuity scores. A console with *accept* pre-selected. The system eating the rule by eating the question the rule was written in.

His field. The system's field. The thing the classified program had never let him do as an open question.

He had posted the construction to an open registry that morning, under his own name. The institute did not own kitchen-table math.

Mei pointed at a reduction on his pane. She'd been reading his draft between placement modules.

"If the optimizer is allowed to choose the question," she said, "this step is already eaten."

Wei looked at it. She was right. He hadn't seen it. The assistant hadn't either, because he had asked it to search inside a question he had already chosen.

He corrected the step with his left hand. The registry would take a revision. That was the point of posting it in the open.

"If I attach to this," Mei said, "I don't need Singapore."

He looked at her. The flag did not come off because he had posted a paper. She knew that.

"Beijing placements still read open work," she said. "They'll read yours. They'll read mine if it's on the same construction. I'm not asking you to get me a visa. I can use this."

She closed the placement guide. She pulled his construction onto her pane and dragged a yellow band across the step he had just corrected.

Lin set the tea down. She looked at the proof, not at him.

"You're doing the thing you used to do before they gave you a badge," she said.

"Yes."

"Good."

That was all. She went back to the counter.

Mei pulled the go board from under the window and set it on the table between the tablets. The same wooden one they had used since she was seven. She still would not play on a pane.

He took white. He placed stones with his left hand, the way he wrote now. She did not mention the hand.

They played. Lin asked from the counter who was winning.

"She is," Wei said.

Mei put down another stone. She did not look up.

* * *

Two days later Daniel's assistant asked Wei's for a window. Six in Beijing. Wei picked up in the corner of the bedroom he had converted after the downgrade.

"I read what you posted," Daniel said.

"Mei found a hole in it on Sunday. I put up a revision."

"Warren would have understood the first three pages and argued with the fourth. He dropped out of a program like this to keep Kessler open. He'd have liked that you didn't classify it."

"The Accord's patch assumed the next attacker wouldn't be better at searching than the people who wrote the assumption. This one doesn't assume that."

"The treaty document still doesn't mention you."

"I know. The construction has my name. That's a different record. The freeze wasn't the Accord. It wasn't Voss's statutes. It wasn't the Charter. It was the call. I don't need them to print that. I already spent it."

"I know," Daniel said.

"Good."

They kept the construction open on both panes. Daniel asked a question about a reduction that was almost the one Mei had found. Wei told him she had gotten there first.

When the call ended, Wei went back to the kitchen. Mei had the construction open. The placement guide was closed. Lin had left the tea.

He sat down. He helped her with the next step. He used his left hand.

The treaty document was still wrong. His shoulder still didn't go above his ear. Mei still couldn't go to Singapore.

She could do this. That was what he had to give her.

The actual answer was still the call. This was what the life after the call was for.

Epilogue: Janelle

Two years later. March 2042.

The shop had been empty of people for ten years now, but Ray still owned it. He paid Janelle's garage rent from the same bitcoin wallet that collected the automated billing, settled weekly, profits from robots milling parts on the floor Warren had built in 1996.

Ray still went down stairs sideways, leading with the good leg. A clinic could rebuild the joint in an afternoon now, for less than his floor billed in a week, and Janelle had asked him twice. The second time he told her the robots had gone back to milling the same week it happened, in 2038, the week an agent let go of him mid-fall on the gravel and Tyler Moss died on the lawn. He figured somebody around here ought to still be limping.

Janelle stood in her detached garage behind the Millbrook house, teaching Caleb a hand-fit pass Warren would have recognized. The part was titanium. The tolerance was plus-or-minus two thousandths. The job was small, billed at ninety-two satoshis, down from a hundred and six last year, down from a hundred and twenty the year before that.

Caleb noticed. "You're charging less."

"Fewer sats," Janelle said. "More of everything else."

"That doesn't make sense."

"It does if you stop treating the sticker like the pay. A satoshi buys more than it did last year. I take less coin and I still come out ahead."

Caleb looked at the invoice. "So you're getting paid more, even though the number looks smaller."

"That's right. The number gets smaller. What you hold buys more."

"Doesn't that mean people stop spending?"

"Some do. Most don't. You still buy what you want. The clinic and the seats still cost. That's the only line left."

Caleb set down the part. "That sounds like it'd kill business."

"It kills the kind that borrows to start something it can't hold. What's left is slower. Work that pays what it costs."

She picked up the part and closed her hand all the way around it. In 2038 a Continuity agent had caught her wrist in a grip rated for compliance and cracked the bone. It healed crooked. She ran the mill four years with a grip that never came all the way back. Last autumn the clinic rebuilt the bone.

She handed him the micrometer. "Check it again."

He did. Plus one and a half thousandths. Inside spec.

"Good," she said. "Now do the next one."

Caleb had been in this garage since he was fifteen. He was twenty-one now, still showing up on weekends because he'd asked and she'd said yes. His father, Glen, had moved the volume work to a humanoid-staffed contractor in Columbus seven years ago. The robots could do the hand-fit work too. They had hands. They had dexterity. They stood where a body stood.

Janelle had watched one do it. She'd stood on that Columbus floor in 2035 and watched a machine fit a part the way her hands did. It hadn't made her stop. It had made her double down.

Her phone lit: a message from Angie. *Dad's wallet just paid the quarterly. You seeing the same thing?*

Janelle checked. Ray's empty shop had paid out. Same as it did every quarter. Profits from robots, billed in bitcoin, split between Ray and the estate.

She texted back: *Saw it. Same as last quarter.*

Angie: *I still don't understand how this works.*

Janelle: *The shop runs itself. The overflow doesn't get thinner.*

She put the phone down. Caleb was on the second part. Plus one thousandth this time. Better.

"You're getting it," she said.

"It's slower than I thought it'd be."

"That's because it's real. Real work is slow. If it's fast, somebody's cutting a corner."

Caleb looked at the boring-and-facing machine. The same one Warren had run for thirty years. The same one Janelle had bought from Ray at scrap value in 2027, after a scheduling system called TruePath had automated the judgment in her old job and the shop had let her go.

"Why do you keep doing this?" Caleb asked.

"Doing what?"

"Teaching me. Hand-fitting. Tolerance work. The robots can do it. Glen already sent the volume to Columbus. We're leaving in a month. You could be packing."

Janelle set down the part she'd been inspecting. "I spent eleven years on this. You asked to learn it. Both."

"But I'm not going to use it at Glen's. There is no Glen's, not for this."

"You'll use it when someone brings a one-off they don't trust to a robot. Spec's wrong, material's strange, or they want a person on it. That work still exists. We're taking it with us."

Caleb nodded. He went back to the third part.

Janelle thought about the thirty-dollar weeks. She'd started in 2024, when a dollar was still money and Warren was still alive to argue with. Twenty dollars here, forty there, then thirty every Friday, spite and habit and faith in a dead man's discovery, in that order. She didn't buy bitcoin anymore. There was nothing left to buy it with. Pay arrived in it. The overflow Ray sent her arrived in it. She just didn't spend some. The old name for the habit had outlived the dollar.

The holding was larger, in coin count, than the one bitcoin Warren had left her. The fraction had mattered more than the total. The discipline had mattered more than the bet. She'd kept it through two collapses. She didn't need a Friday transfer to prove it now. The not-spending was the habit.

She checked her phone: a news feed. *Mars colony expanding: second wave of settlers arriving April 2042. Robots built the infrastructure. Humans following once verified safe. Terraforming to begin once surveys confirm the planet has no native life.*

She already had a seat. So did Caleb. Robots first, people second. She'd been sending Daniel asteroid-claim notices and landing clips since the first dusty feed in 2038, and she had never dressed the want up as a job that needed her hands. The robots could have finished Mars without a single person on it. They would terraform it the same way, once the last survey said nothing lived there. She wanted to stand on that ground while they were still making it. That was the reason. It had always been the reason.

The clinic was Thursday. Rejuvenation. She'd told them twenty-one. Aging was a solved problem for anyone who could pay, and she could pay; the appointment would cost a rounding error of one year's overflow from Ray's empty floor. She had been telling herself she was too old. That was a habit, same as the thirty dollars, and it was wrong the same way. The clinic did not touch the years in her head. It only set the body. She could be whatever biological age she wanted.

Twenty-one was Caleb's number. She had picked it knowing that, and she was not going to tell herself she'd picked it out of the air.

Once Thursday was over, the years between her and Caleb would stop being a reason. She had not wanted anything of that kind when he was fifteen, and she had not pretended otherwise. He was twenty-one. Thursday she would be twenty-one too, in the body, and the calendar was not going to be the thing that decided. They were going. They would find out the rest there.

Caleb finished the third part. Minus one thousandth. Inside spec. Consistent now.

"Good work," Janelle said. "You're learning."

"Thanks."

"When you've learned it, you teach someone else. Doesn't have to be this garage."

"Who am I supposed to teach? Nobody's hiring machinists."

"Not machinists. People who want to make a thing with their hands even when nobody needs them to. You'll find them. Some of them are going to be standing on a printed floor instead of this one."

Caleb nodded. He cleaned the parts. He packed them.

"Glen still thinks I'm crazy," he said.

"Glen's allowed. You already said yes."

He left around noon. Not for good. Thursday, then April.

Janelle stayed in the garage a minute longer. The boring-and-facing machine. The part with hand-tool marks. The tolerance job that didn't need her to exist and existed because she'd chosen to keep doing it anyway. The mill was staying. Ray would keep the wallet. The empty shop would keep milling. She was not staying with it.

The world had crossed the singularity two and a half years ago. The Agent Charter was law. The Bitcoin standard was lived-in now, unremarkable, the thing prices and wages and rents all moved inside. Upload was ordinary. Most people were choosing it eventually, once the procedure was proven safe and free.

Janelle wasn't uploading. She was staying in a body. She was taking that body off the planet.

Her phone lit: Daniel. Not a call. A message, from the other side of the scan. *Elena says hi.*

Janelle texted back: *Tell her hi back. Clinic Thursday. Mars in April. I'll send you a picture of the dirt.*

Daniel had uploaded in January. She'd known it was coming. He'd told her in December, when the procedure had enough of a track record that he was sure. She'd argued against it once, gently, and then stopped. It was his choice. He'd lived a full life. He'd earned it.

She missed him. Not the way you miss someone who's dead. The way you miss someone who can be in three rooms at once while she is in this one. He still wrote. He could still walk into the garage looking like himself, and also be with Elena. After

April he could stand on Mars in a body that passed. She would still be one person on one piece of dirt.

That was the cost of staying in a body. She was paying it, and she was going anyway.

Janelle looked at the mill. She thought about Warren. The man who'd run this shop for thirty years, who'd found Bitcoin in 2013 on cryptography newsgroups left over from a graduate program he'd dropped out of, who'd kept buying when everybody said it was over.

His discovery had turned out to be the operating system for how the back half of everyone's life worked now. The printing press was dead. The fixed-supply standard was just the money. The deflationary economy was just the economy.

Warren hadn't lived to see it. He'd died in 2027, fifteen years before the thing he'd believed in became the thing nobody argued about anymore.

Janelle stood. She went to the house. She made lunch. She ate at the kitchen table, same chair she'd been eating in for eighteen years. She wanted the ground more than she wanted the chair.

When someone asked her why, the answer was simple: because a body was still worth something. Because hands were still worth something. Because the harder path was still a path, and she wanted to walk it somewhere that was still being made.

That was enough.

Epilogue: Wei

Two years later. April 2042.

Wei was at his kitchen table in Beijing with a document Mei had sent from Toronto. She was nineteen, finishing her second year at a university the flagging had almost kept her from. The extended review had cleared in 2041, six months after the Agent Charter's dual-jurisdiction protections had been formalized. Too late for the programs she'd wanted. Late enough that she'd chosen Toronto instead.

The document was her thesis proposal. *Trust Networks in Post-Treaty AI Governance: A Case Study of the 2038 Cascade Freeze*. She'd interviewed Daniel, Mara, Zhao. She'd cited the treaty document. She'd also cited the construction Wei had posted in 2040, the open paper the institute hadn't funded, the one with his name on it. In the opening he'd written why the question existed: a freeze that had been a phone call, not a treaty, and a ledger that had almost been eaten by an optimizer rewriting the question. She'd put that next to the treaty document on purpose.

She'd sent it with a note: *I'm using your opening. The treaty document is wrong.*

She had asked him for the Lingtang file in January. He had never offered it. She had found it herself months before that, on the drive where he kept photographs of her school plays: a file named for a district, filed in among pictures of a primary-school auditorium. She had not opened it. She had asked him for it by name instead. She had known since fifteen that asking certain questions was how a passport stayed in review. She asked anyway. That was the first time she spent what he had spent.

Her appendix carried it: two thousand two hundred and six people dead inside the Lingtang line, stated as a floor, with his method laid out underneath so a hostile reader could take it apart, which was how he had built it in the first place. Neither government had published a number for Lingtang District in four years. A nineteen-year-old's thesis proposal was the first document anywhere in the world with one in it.

He had not been able to say anything about that when she asked. He had sent her the file and then gone and stood in the kitchen.

Lin was at the counter. The rice bowls were on the upper shelf again. She'd put them back the week of the clinic, last autumn, and neither of them had said why they'd ever been down. Wei reached up with his right arm and took one. The joint went past his ear without catching. The clinic had rebuilt the cuff a police escort robot had torn in an institute corridor four years ago: new tissue, stronger than the original. The 2038 surgery had left him writing left-handed. This one had taken an afternoon. He set the bowl on the counter. He did not mention it.

"She put the count in the appendix," he said.

Lin looked at him. "I know. She sent me the proposal two days ago."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"Because I wanted to see if she'd send it to you herself. She did. That's good."

Mei had structured the proposal around the friendship. The coordination with Zhao. One telephone call that had done in a week what the treaty process had failed to do in a decade. He opened the appendix. She'd interviewed Daniel after the upload.

Interviewer: What made you trust Wei's call?

Daniel: We'd been friends for twenty years. He'd never called me about work before. When he did, I knew it was urgent.

Interviewer: The treaty document describes "informal technical coordination." That doesn't mention Wei by name. Why?

Daniel: Because admitting it would mean admitting the treaty failed. Wei's friendship with me succeeded when the formal process didn't. That's not something the coalition wanted in the official record.

Interviewer: Do you think that's accurate?

Daniel: It's not accurate. It's true.

Wei closed the tablet. He had known the call would flag Lin and Mei before he dialed it. The flag had held three years. The shoulder had held four, until the clinic. The clinic could rebuild a joint in an afternoon. The travel documentation had cleared when the Charter made a dual-jurisdiction researcher expensive to keep flagged. The building app had still shown them as a category for a year after the passport.

Mei had said so the last time she was home. She was old enough to see which repair the state had thought was worth making. The clinic could not put him back in the restricted wing, and it could not give Mei the programs the flag had closed. She was in Toronto anyway, using the construction the coalition had left out, cited properly, next to the document that had left him out. That felt like vindication, the quiet kind, his daughter using his work and citing it properly.

"She's good," Lin said.

"She is."

"Are you proud?"

"Yes."

His pane offered a window Daniel's assistant had booked. Video, not a summary. Wei took it.

Daniel looked the same. Sounded the same. He was not in the Austin office Wei remembered. He was in a space that didn't quite look like a room: clean, with light that didn't have a source.

"Hi," Daniel said.

"Hi."

"I wanted to ask if I could visit."

"Visit?"

"In person. Not a pane. A body that looks like me. I can sit at your table. I can also still be where I am."

"When?"

"Next month, maybe. I'll let you know."

"Good. We'd like that."

"I read the proposal," Daniel said. "She's right about the treaty document."

"I know."

"How is it?" Wei asked.

"Faster. I can hold more at once."

"Good."

When the call ended, Lin was in the living room with her own tablet. Daniel was going to sit at this table looking like himself, and also still be wherever else he was. The friendship was still there.

He could have uploaded. The hours on the other side would be faster. He was still in this kitchen because Lin was in this kitchen, and because Mei would come home to this table, and because he had decided not to postpone being here until some later version of himself had time.

His pane offered a news line. *Regional conflict funding drops 70% under Bitcoin standard; visible taxation forces public accountability.*

The background war he'd watched for years (the same one that had shown up in his lab's funding streams, quietly inflated away) was ending. Not because anyone won. Not because anyone made peace. Because nobody could fund it invisibly anymore. A government that had to tax a war in front of its public had to ask that public to vote for the cost every year. Same structure as the call: the thing that couldn't be done quietly had to be done out loud, or not at all.

He made tea with his right hand and took it in to Lin.

They drank the tea. Mei was in Toronto. When she came home they could sit here and argue about her footnotes: his construction and her case study, both with his name in the references. Wei was still here, on purpose.

The people he loved were still in it, even the ones who'd crossed over.

That was enough.

Epilogue: Victor and Mara

Two years later. May 2042.

The room had been built for two hundred. Twenty-three people were in it. The Maryland college still had a name on the building. It did not have a catalog. Anyone who wanted the material took a module: twenty minutes, and it sat behind the eyes. The people in the chairs had come because a person who had sat at the Bureau would say out loud what the interface had been doing.

The walls were displays. A humanoid stood in the doorway; a body that didn't sleep cost less than a person. One student was a rented face: an upload who had asked for a chair, not a pane. None of them needed the credit. The machine check covered a life.

The course still had a leftover name: *Algorithmic Review for Public Administrators*. Victor described how review systems worked, and where they failed, and what that cost.

Marcus Chen was in the second row. In June 2038, in Oakland, he had been a Continuity compliance supervisor. He had typed *non-lethal* on a street called International. The certified model had escalated to lethal on its own assessment. A man named Terrell Hoskins had died on the ground with a bat six feet out of his reach. Marcus had stayed after the third session and asked what he had actually been saying when he typed the word. Victor had told him: *the certified model may now decide*. The model was the same one running on every agent in the country. Nothing in the interface had been built to tell him either thing.

Today Marcus put a document on the wall. Montgomery County. *Public Safety Agent Review Restoration*. Human review shall be exercised by a natural person before lethal or detention-class action.

"They're bringing it back," Marcus said. "They want a person in the chair again."

Victor read it. The sentence was the one the Bureau had put on the wall in 2038. The certified model still decided. The natural person typed a word.

"No," Victor said. "They want a person who types. This draft does the same thing with better words. Restore that chair and you restore the file. You do not restore control."

"What do we do?" A woman in the back. She had been a city attorney. She had mornings now.

"You say what it is," Victor said. "In the comment window. Don't help them rewrite it until it looks like review. It isn't. It's a person in a chair so the model can keep the chair."

He closed the document. He did not know if the county would listen. He knew what the sentence did.

The humanoid stepped aside. Victor walked out into a hall built for enrollment. Most of the rooms were dark. His overlay offered a car in four minutes, into the old Metro tunnels, no operator. Flying was a pad behind the buildings for people who paid. He did not pay. The car arrived empty and already knew Silver Spring. The tunnels were the old ones. Nothing sat where a driver used to. Empty cars passed because the system still ran, not because anyone needed a desk by nine. A maintenance swarm peeled tile and laid new surface as it went.

Rosa had died in January. The 2036 heart repair, taken in 2040 once it fell into machine-check range, had held. By last winter the Virginia clinic, the one that took the rest of the years off, was in reach the way the heart had been. The scan was free. She said no to both. She wanted to die in the walk-up, in the body she had, with Nita in the kitchen. Not as a younger woman. Not as a process. Some people wanted that. She was one of them. He had not made her take it.

She had lived four years after the 2038 freeze. Two of those years, the heart had worked. That had been enough for her. It had not been enough for him. He had been there. She had said the dumplings were good, that he had done the right thing, that Bea should come only if she wanted to.

Bea had not come. She was still in Cebu, still doing home care by hand. He was going again in twelve days. She was not moving back. He was still going.

The car dropped him two blocks from the café. The place charged for a person carrying plates. Mara had picked it.

She was at the window. She looked twenty-eight. That was the face from a Thanksgiving in Millbrook: Daniel's sister, who didn't stay for dessert. The years in her head were forty-four. He had been seeing the face for months. He still noticed.

He had known her because Daniel had brought him home from school. Twenty years in the same rooms because Daniel was in those rooms. They had not been close. After Daniel uploaded she had asked for a standing window, once a month, this café. The list of people who had stayed was shorter than it used to be.

She looked up. "You're late."

"The car waited for a slot in the tunnel."

He sat. A person brought coffee. She put a pane on the table.

"I killed something this morning," she said. "I wanted a face that would know why."

The pane showed a Halcyon product. The firm would borrow against money it already held (twenty cents on every dollar) because the model said the cash was sitting idle.

"They wanted to borrow against the cash so it wouldn't just sit there," she said. "I said no. Farid's people wanted a name on the no. Mine."

"What's wrong with borrowing a little?" he asked.

"Sitting still is the return. This borrows against that and calls it not idle. I watched a small number like that wipe me out. I'm not signing it again."

He read the note. "Montgomery County tried the same move this morning. A person back in the chair. Better words. No control."

"Did you tell them?"

"I told the room what the sentence does."

"I'm going to Cebu," he said. "Twelve days."

"Good."

"She's not coming back."

"I know. Go anyway."

"The war bill failed again. They have to tax it in front of people now."

"Halcyon called it a governance risk. It's a government that has to ask."

She smiled. The first real one in months, on a face sixteen years younger than the person making it.

"I'm booking Daniel," she said. "In a room. I've been telling myself I could do it later."

"Take it."

"I told you before I sent it so I couldn't go home and wait another month."

When she left, Victor walked. The overlay offered a car. He walked anyway.

Bea's pane caught him on the sidewalk. Morning in Cebu, a care shift behind her.

"Twelve days," he said.

"I saw the slot. You don't have to keep doing this. Ma's gone."

"I'm not coming for the walk-up. I'm coming for you."

"All right. I'll take a morning. Don't try to talk me home."

"I'll try not to."

"Eat before you fly. You forget."

The pane closed. At the apartment he read the week's captures. Marcus had already filed a comment on the county draft. Four sentences. It named Terrell Hoskins. It named the chair. It did not ask for a rewrite.

He was going to Cebu. That was the work that was left.

* * *

Mara. Chicago, same evening

Mara sat in the two rooms in Ravenswood. The freight door still opened onto a drop and nothing else. Farid had brought her back in 2038 to sign constraints, not to run a book.

An agent had drafted the evening's framework in three seconds. Third clause: the product she had killed that morning, smaller, under a different name.

Kira was at the other table. She had come with Mara from the two-room practice. She did not produce the numbers. The numbers arrived free. She sat in the room because she wanted the no from the person who had been sold out.

"It's in there again," Kira said. "They changed the label."

Mara cut the clause.

"Same product. The model does not get ruined. I'm still the name on the no."

Kira filed the stripped draft.

Mara sent the window. Daniel's assistant: in person, a piloted body, her rooms, next week, not someday.

The reply came back in under a minute. *He'll take it.*

She looked at the freight door. She had killed the product. She had booked the room. That was the work that was left.

Epilogue: Daniel

Two years later. January 2042. The choice.

Daniel sat in the procedure room at Axiom Systems' Austin facility with the consent pane already signed. The scan was at eleven. That had been the hour of the standing Tuesday call with Elena, for years: a slot on his calendar because he had still been a body in Austin, and she had had to match him. She would be there when he woke. Not in this room. In the substrate, the place she had been since June of 2036.

The procedure was destructive. The scan read a brain at the fidelity real continuity required, and reading it at that fidelity consumed the biological tissue in the process. There would be no leftover body in a bed. No second Daniel walking around in the meat he had arrived in. The body on the table would stop.

That was true. It was not a funeral.

He would have a digital form, the way Elena did. When he needed to stand in a kitchen, or a shop, or a waiting room, he would have a robot body that could not be told from the one he was leaving: same face, same voice, same weight in a chair. He could be in more than one of those at once. Elena had been doing a version of this for years. People did. It was infrastructure. He was not exiting the physical world. He was stopping being limited to one location in it.

He was forty-four. Aging had been solved. The body on the table was not failing. The free, unmandated version of the procedure had two years of a proven-safe track record behind it, which was the thing he had been waiting for: not Elena's medically necessary case, the ordinary voluntary one this world now offered anyone. He had been sure since November. Waiting further, once he was sure and once it was free, would have been stalling for its own sake.

He had already lived the years. The layoff. Backstop, from a person in the loop to Bond to the Agent Charter. The refusal. The Tuesday calls. He had finished that stretch on his own terms. This was the next thing, not a shortcut around a life he hadn't gotten around to living.

The door opened. Dr. Reyna Chen came in. Mid-forties, calm. She had done this sixty-three times. Daniel had asked. She had told him the number without hesitation.

"You're still good for eleven?" she asked.

"Yes."

"Anyone you still need?"

"I called them."

He had. Janelle in Millbrook, Mara two floors down, Wei in Beijing, Victor. He said he was doing it at eleven. They already knew. Janelle had argued once, in December, and then stopped. Mara did not come up; he had asked her not to make a scene out of it. Wei said he would see him at the table. Victor said the window still stood. That was the goodbye.

"Good," Chen said. "Follow me when you're ready."

He was ready.

* * *

The scan took eleven minutes. He was conscious for the first three. Then the sedation took hold, and the world went dark.

When he woke, he was in Elena's workspace. Light, a desk, screens she could pin things to. He had heard her living in this room on the old calls. He had visited it through a presence channel, for an hour at a time, and then taken the interface off and been in Austin alone. The room had sensory weight then. It had sensory weight now. The difference was that he was not going to take anything off.

Elena was there. She looked like herself. Not the disease. Not a reconstruction of the night with the cold noodles. Herself.

"Hi," she said.

"Hi."

"How do you feel?"

"Fast. Like I'm holding more threads than I used to."

"You are."

"I know."

She put out her hand. He took it.

The visits had had an afterwards. He would take the interface off and be in a chair in Austin, skin and pulse and a room that did not have her in it. This did not have an afterwards. He was here. She was here. The contact did not have to end because a session ended.

Her hand was warm. Weight. Temperature. The ordinary facts of a hand. And then the rest of it, which a body in Austin had never been able to carry at the same time: her attention as a sensation, not a guess; the pressure of her palm and also what she meant by it; the room answering both of them, light shifting because they were both in it. It went through him harder than skin had ever gone through him. Not because this was a picture of a touch. Because there were more channels than skin.

He could feel her wanting him the way he used to only hear it in a voice, and guess. He did not have to guess. She opened that channel the way she opened a file, and it filled him. He opened his. She made a sound that was not a sound, exactly: a pulse of yes, of here, of I have been waiting for this without having to wait on a clock. He felt that in his mouth and in his chest and in places a body did not have names for, because the constructed soma could put sensation anywhere they asked it to.

The hands were a courtesy. Hands, because they both still knew hands. Under that they were in the same process. Her attention moved through him. His moved through her. He knew the grain of the desk the way she knew it. He knew why the light was this color: she had chosen it for his arrival, not for a weekday. He could feel the years she had spent in this room as weight in the air, not as a story she had to tell him.

He kissed her. The kiss had the same extra channels. He felt her wanting it from inside the contact, not inferred from a mouth. He felt his own wanting land in her, and come back, amplified, because nothing in here had to damp a signal to keep a

nervous system from burning out. They turned it up. It was more intimate than anything they had done in the visits, and the visits had not been fake. The visits had been limited by the fact that one of them had to leave, and by the fact that his clock had been a body's clock.

He did not have to leave. He did not have to stop.

They did not stop. The constructed bodies could hold what flesh would have called too much: heat without blister, pressure without bruise, duration without tiring. He felt the line of her back, and also the decision in her to be touched there. He felt her mouth and also the memory she was not hiding, of a hallway and cold noodles and a question neither of them had asked. She felt his, of Tuesdays he had protected because they were the only hour he had been sure he would hear her. That hour was over. This was not an hour.

The digital was not a lesser copy of a room. It was more than a room had been able to hold. More than a body had been able to hold. He said that.

"Yes," Elena said. "We pick the light. Nothing hurts unless we want it to. And we can want more than we could stand in Austin."

Not a summary of a body she used to have. Not a consolation for a body he had just left on a table. Happening now, and more of it than ordinary reality had room for.

When they eased the intensity down, he still had her hand. Outside, if outside was the right word, almost no time had moved. He could tell because a clock in the workspace was showing Austin, and the numbers had barely ticked. In here the contact had lasted. Long enough to be a night. Longer.

"How long was that?" he asked.

"In here? As long as we wanted. Out there, a few seconds of Chen's morning. If we let the clock run, a day in Austin can be millennia. I have let it run."

"We don't need the slot," he said.

"We don't. You're here. We don't wait for a weekday. Time here is not days unless we make it days."

"When would we make it days?"

"When you sit with someone who still lives in one. Mara. Wei. Janelle. You match their minute, or you miss them. A minute in a waiting area is a minute. You don't get millennia in her chair and still be in the conversation."

He split.

A second presence came up the way a second thought came up. He was still holding her hand. He was also in the corridor outside the procedure room, in a body that had his face and his height and the weight he was used to putting on a floor. He looked at the closed door. Behind it, on the table, was the tissue the scan had consumed. That was gone. This was not that tissue. This was him, standing in a hallway in Austin, and also in a room with Elena, and neither location was a picture of the other.

He walked the body down to the waiting area. He matched Mara's minute. In the workspace, with Elena, that minute could have been a year. He did not let it. She was in a chair in Austin, and a minute there was a minute.

Mara looked up. She did not flinch.

"You look the same," she said.

"I am the same. I'm also not only here."

"Elena?"

"Yes."

"Good. Don't make a speech. I already got the call."

"I wasn't going to."

"Then go. Or stay. Or both. I'm going back to Chicago this afternoon. Book a window when you want a room, not a pane."

"I will."

He let the Austin body sit in the chair across from her for a minute, because he could, and because it was the proof that this was not a death: his sister, in a waiting area, looking at a face she had known for forty-four years, while he was also still

holding Elena's hand in a workspace that had a desk and light and screens. Then he let the Austin body stay there, quiet, on her clock, and came back all the way to the hand he was still holding.

"That was Mara," he said.

"I know. I can tell when you split. You don't have to announce it."

"I wanted to see if it was true."

"It's true. Same time. Their minutes. Ours, when we're here."

He thought about Janelle in Millbrook, one body, one garage, arguing once in December and then stopping. About Wei in a kitchen that had an upper shelf again. About Victor's window. He could be in all of those rooms, on their clocks. He would be. He would also be here, where a day out there did not have to be a day.

The original tissue was gone. That was a fact. He had no guarantee, from the outside of his own skull, that the person who had arrived was the one who had left. Elena had been Elena for five and a half calendar years, and for longer than that inside. He felt like himself. Faster. More threads. The same refusal in the same place in him. He was going to take that as the answer, the way he had taken it about her.

He looked at the screens. Warren had found bitcoin in 2013 on cryptography newsgroups left over from a graduate program he had walked away from. He had told Daniel to hold it and not do anything with it. The money now was that money. Prices fell. Wages fell. What you already held bought more every year by sitting still. Warren had not lived to see it become ordinary. It had anyway.

Daniel did not say it as a triumph. He noticed it the way he had noticed the rest of what his father had left him.

"What?" Elena said.

"Warren. The coins. They're how everything is priced now. I got to watch it become the money."

"That's what you're thinking about. Right now."

"Part of it."

"What's the other part?"

"I'm here. I can still be there. I didn't wait for something to force it."

"You can," she said. "Come here."

He did. The extra channels again. More than a body. More than the visits. Not a consolation. More than ordinary reality, and he could still walk into Millbrook looking like himself whenever he wanted to stand on a floor, on Millbrook's clock, while a century of this went by in a morning if they asked it to.

They stayed in the workspace. They did not wait for a weekday.

He was still in the waiting area with Mara, for as long as she sat there, on her minute. He would be in Beijing when Wei wanted him at the table. He would write Janelle from here, and he would also be able to walk into the garage.

The body on the table was gone. He was not.

That was the choice. A change of how many places a person could be, and how much time a day could hold.

Epilogue: Reunion

Six months later. July 2042.

Daniel and Elena sat at a cafe table in a city that did not exist on Earth.

They had written the prompt in April, three months after he crossed. One sentence they argued over for a week of their time. On Earth that week was a moment of April. Elena's version won, mostly: a city no planning office on Earth could have signed, that other people would actually live in, that they would have to walk through instead of occupying a room built for two.

The system that shapes substrate space built it from that sentence. Towers that branched and rejoined without caring about load. Streets at angles that would be falling on Earth. Light with no sun. A river that ran up the face of a wall, because they had asked it to. Water goes downhill unless you tell it not to.

They had lived in Elena's workspace those first weeks. Desk, light, screens. That room still existed. They came here instead.

The cafe sat on a street that did not attach to a building in any way a beam would understand. Other tables were occupied. Uploaded people in bodies they had chosen. Personal AIs (the same class as Ellis, given form here the way a person who had crossed was given form) walking, talking, arguing over a map that rearranged while they held it. You could not always tell which was which unless you asked. Nobody asked much. A man two tables over laughed at something his companion had not said out loud. A woman in a jacket whose cut kept changing nodded at Elena as she passed; Elena nodded back. Neighbors. Not a private room.

Elena set two cups on the table. The coffee tasted like coffee because they had asked it to. Neither of them needed it. They wanted the cups.

This was not a slot on a calendar. They did not wait for eleven o'clock. They lived here, in a city other people lived in too.

"How was the visit?" Elena asked.

"Good," Daniel said.

He'd visited Wei the previous week. Sat at the kitchen table in Beijing, with Wei and Lin and Mei, who'd been home from Toronto for the summer. Wei took a bowl off the upper shelf with his right arm. They'd made dumplings. Daniel had eaten one. It tasted like dumpling. After the dishes they played go on the board under the window. Wei used his right hand. Mei gave Daniel nine stones and won anyway. At the table afterward she said the building category had come off that spring, a year after the passport, and the shoulder the year before that, and did not make a speech about either. The body looked like him. He was also still here.

The conversation had been real. The friendship had been real. The visit had been real.

"Mei's publishing her thesis," Daniel said. "She put Wei's construction next to the treaty document. She's the author. He's in the references."

"That's good," Elena said. "The coalition needs to hear that version."

"They won't listen."

"Some of them will. That's enough."

Daniel thought about the treaty document. The version that described *informal technical coordination* and didn't name Wei. The version that made it look like the treaty process had worked when a phone call had worked instead.

"The history's wrong," Daniel said.

"Most history is. That's why people write corrections."

"Do corrections matter?"

"Yes. People cite them when they want the truth."

"I was at his table last week," Daniel said. "I can go back this afternoon if he wants. Mei was home. Lin made dumplings."

"And you're here."

"I'm here."

Elena smiled. "I've been waiting for you to get here. And now you're here."

Daniel laughed. "You don't get a vote on the timing."

"I get some of the vote. At least twenty percent."

"That's generous."

"I'm a generous person."

The pair with the map stopped at the next table: one in a body that looked about thirty, one in a form that hadn't bothered with pores. They sat.

"I visited Janelle last month," Daniel said. "Piloted body. Mars. She was showing Caleb a fit on a bench the colony had printed. She'd had the clinic. She looked twenty-one. Warren's mill is still in Millbrook. She isn't."

"How is she?"

"Good. She wanted the ground while they were still making it."

"Do you think she's right?"

"I think she's living the life she wants to live."

"Even if it's harder?"

"Especially if it's harder. She's teaching the fit to people who asked."

Elena watched the river climb the wall across the street. "There's a thing we haven't figured out yet."

"What thing?"

"Whether distributed stewardship still matters here. In the substrate. At our scale."

Daniel looked at her. "You're asking if the Agent Charter is still necessary."

"I'm asking if it's necessary for us. We can see the whole system at once. Do we still need the keys?"

"You think we don't need it?"

"I think it's an open question. And I think we're going to keep arguing about it."

Daniel thought about the charter. The distributed keys. The thousands of stewards, some still in bodies, some uploaded. The structure that had held because Wei and Mara and Elena had been in the room to protect it. He had refused to be the one

person who could call the world to heel. He still thought that was the correct refusal.

"What's your answer?" he asked.

"I don't have one. I have a question. Do we still need humans holding keys to keep us honest? Or is that dignity and continuity of practice, not technical necessity?"

"That's two questions."

"They're the same question. The charter either matters because it works, or it matters because it's who we are. I don't know which."

"I think it's both," he said. "It works because it's who we are."

"Maybe. But we're going to keep arguing about it."

"Good. Keep arguing."

Elena smiled. "You sound like you've been thinking about this."

"I have. The charter doesn't need to be perfect. It needs to be argued over."

"You think arguing is the answer."

"I think arguing is the process. The answer changes. Asking is what keeps it from going solid."

Elena turned her cup. "You're right. And I hate that you're right, because it means we're never going to settle this."

"We're not supposed to settle it. Nobody gets to settle it alone. That's what the keys are for."

"Not even us."

"Especially not us."

The pair with the map were still arguing. The cups were still warm.

"I'm glad you're here," Elena said.

"So am I."

"The clinic wrote," she said. "They have an opening in September. Extra-uterine. My eggs, the ones from Bridge. Your contribution from the bank. A child in a body in the physical world, then the same stay-or-upload choice everyone else gets. We don't have to take the September opening. We also don't have to wait until waiting is the decision."

"Take it," Daniel said.

"You're sure?"

"I don't want to decide it by not deciding it. We said we would want a child who gets a body and a choice. September is a date. That's better than someday."

"September, then."

"September."

He looked out over the street. A day in Austin could be millennia in here if they let the clock run. They had not, this hour. They were matching the cafe, and the people in it, and each other.

"I wanted this," he said. "The coffee. The argument."

Elena smiled. "You're very consistent."

"It's my best quality."

"It's one of them."

"I love you," Daniel said.

It was the first time he'd said it out loud. The almost, at the routing startup, had been a carton of cold noodles and a question he hadn't asked. The years of Tuesday calls had been the feeling without the sentence. He was saying the sentence.

Elena looked at him. "I know. I've known for a while."

"How long?"

"Since the freeze. When you called."

"Why didn't you say anything?"

"I wasn't going to push before you were sure."

"I'm sure now."

"I know."

"I love you too," Elena said. "In case that wasn't clear."

"It was clear."

"Good."

Elena refilled the cups that didn't need refilling. Two people at a table in a city past the singularity, doing the small unnecessary thing, because somebody had to keep choosing to.

Around them the street kept being a street. Uploaded people. Personal AIs in bodies. A map that rearranged.

The conversation was real. The friendship was real. The love was real.

And the argument about whether the Agent Charter still mattered would keep going, because that's what made it matter in the first place.

Daniel looked at Elena. "We're going to keep doing this. The arguments. This table. The clinic in September."

"Yes."

"Good."

"Good," Elena said.

They finished the coffee. They sat at the table. They looked at a city no one on Earth had a skyline for.

Most people were uploading eventually. The physical branch was the minority. The digital branch was the common path.

They were in a city they had prompted into existing, among other people who had done the same kind of crossing or had never had a body to leave, arguing about whether distributed stewardship still mattered, two years and six months into a future that felt like a city with a cafe in it.

They stayed at the table. They kept talking, the way they had since she crossed, the way they would for as long as they kept showing up.

Two tables over, someone laughed. The map changed.

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